



THE CONFLICT THESAURUS:

*A Writer's Guide to Obstacles,
Adversaries, and Inner Struggles*

VOLUME 2

ANGELA ACKERMAN
& BECCA PUGLISI

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OceanofPDF.com

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CONFLICT'S ROLE IN STORYTELLING: SHAPING THE PLOT

We're all familiar with the fish story. You know, the one where an uncle, neighbor, cousin...*someone* sets out to catch a fish. And then he does.

Presented like this, it sounds straightforward and—dare we say it—a touch boring. And if the story was nothing more than someone reeling in their dinner, it would be pretty yawn-worthy. But what makes a fish story special is that it's always more than it seems. In fact, it might not contain a carp, trout, or catfish at all and instead be a tale of how someone negotiated a great deal on their car, pulled out an engagement ring and got a yes, or something else entirely. But it's still a fish story, trust us. And for it to work, it needs the same vital thing all great stories do: *conflict*.

Let's look at a classic fish story for a moment, one where the storyteller is your neighbor. He's on his porch, enjoying the cooling air as dusk sends fingers of pink and orange across the sky. He spots you mowing your lawn and waves you over. The pitcher of iced tea at his elbow seems pretty inviting, so you climb the steps, sit, and thank him for the hospitality.

Once you're settled, he nudges an ice chest with his foot. "Went fishing this morning. Boy, what a day."

Good neighbor that you are, you lean in with an expected, "Oh?"—the universal signal to tell you all about it.

Our fisherman begins his tale with the setup: he rose with the sun, gathered his rod and tackle, and headed out the door. The early hour meant less traffic, and he made it to the lake in record time. Not a cloud in the sky, just him, the birds, and the gentle buzz of dragonflies. A great day to be on the water.

Then, an early upset: his blasted boat motor refused to start. It took him a good half-hour of pulling to fire it up, and by then, other fishermen had arrived. The whole point of getting there early was to claim *his* spot, so he had to hustle to keep his lead.

Finally, he reached his secret fishing location and cast a line over the side. The sun warmed the back of his neck and the water was mirror-calm. And somewhere below, a certain plump trout was scouting for a free meal.

But the minutes ticked by. And by.

Not a bite, not one nibble.

Your neighbor starts to grouse about how his back ached and the hot sun was crisping his skin like chicken in a fryer. To make matters worse, because he was in a rush, he'd left his lunch kit and water bottle in the truck. He was so thirsty, the saliva in his mouth had turned to glue.

His impatience grew. The fish had abandoned his secret spot. His thumb hurt like a bugger because he'd accidentally poked it when baiting the hook, and overhead, dark clouds were brewing. The day had become a total dud. Maybe it was time to pack it in.

But then, the line jerked. And then again.

From his chair, your neighbor re-enacts this moment. His arms are extended, an invisible twitching rod in his grip. He pulls back, testing the resistance. Aha, a solid bite!

He cranks the handle of a non-existent reel, pulling and releasing in turn, but sweet whiskey, wouldn't you know it, this fish had the strength of an alligator. No, two! The kind that grew up in the runoff of a nuclear power plant.

Pulling with a fierceness that seems superhuman, your neighbor grunts and relays the rest of the battle in spurts.

Thunder rumbled overhead. The sky was black. The wind had picked up and waves slapped his boat, threatening to capsize him! He held on, fighting the monster for a good hour.

You cock an eyebrow.

"Well, maybe half an hour." He pauses. "Five minutes, at least."

This detail clarified, he returns to the tale. At last, the trout broke the surface, thrashing like a demon. Your neighbor stands and begins to grunt and swear as he grapples with the invisible fish. Finally, he wrestles it into the boat and collapses in his chair. Victory!

He slugs back a gulp of iced tea. Then he taps the red lid of the fish cooler. "Took everything I had, but, well, the rest is history!"

And that's a fish story—an epic tale of highs and lows, of being outmatched and outwitted until personal will and strength tip the scales in the teller's favor. Sure, it wanders away from the truth and comes with a

good dose of embellishment, but the teller knows something important: having a need (**motivation**) and setting a **goal** to fill that need doesn't make a great story. But achieving a goal that fulfills that need when everything is against you (**conflict**) *does*.

This is a key takeaway for us writers because when we sit down at the keyboard, our imaginations can come up with event after event to write about, but without certain conflicts, the story's plot will wander, taking the reader's attention with it. That's what a fish story teaches us: for a story to draw in the audience, we need a goal, a motivation, and conflict.

GOAL, MOTIVATION, AND CONFLICT WALK INTO A BAR

For most writers, dreaming up exciting ideas, characters, locations, and situations isn't a problem. But if we blindly run with these, instead of writing a story, we may end up with just a series of things that happen (and a long, annoying revision road). And unfortunately, the longer it takes to get a tale into fighting shape, the more chance there is we'll grow frustrated, become distracted by a new idea, and move on to something else. Burying another manuscript in the hard drive graveyard is never the goal. Finishing and getting the story into the hands of eager readers is.

Thankfully, there's an easy way to find the bones of your novel right at the start. The Goal, Motivation, and Conflict (GMC) formula is explored in Debra Dixon's book of the same name and is based on three key story elements:

Goal: What your character wants

Motivation: Why your character wants it

Conflict: What stands in your character's way

This trio is the foundation for a story—in fact, without them, there is no story. So, when you're unsure if you have a solid premise for a novel or just a collection of ideas about murderers in the woods, a secret affair, and things blowing up, use the GMC formula as a test.

GMC Formula: A character wants something (the goal), because of a reason (motivation), but something stands in the way (conflict).

Here are a few GMC statements you might recognize from fiction and film.

Mary wants to reach the coast (goal) because she needs safety and security (motivation), but a forest of undead blocks her path (conflict). ~*The Forest of Hands and Teeth*

The Grinch wants to ruin Christmas (goal) because he needs peace and quiet (motivation), but the spirit of the season makes the people of Whoville tough to break (conflict). ~*The Grinch that Stole Christmas*

Seong Gi-Hun wants to win money (goal) because he needs to take care of his family and pay off a huge debt (motivation), but the game he agrees to play turns into a sadistic series of challenges where losing means death (conflict). ~*Squid Games*

You can see how the GMC formula distills these stories to their most basic elements. It can do the same for yours ([Appendix A](#) can help you track these important features). It also allows you to experiment with different ideas about what your protagonist may want, why they want it, or which story-level problem presents the biggest obstacle.

There are other ways to examine a potential premise, but GMC is one of the most effective, serving as a strong reminder that conflict plays a big role in every story, no matter what it ends up being about.

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FOUR LEVELS OF CONFLICT

A cardinal sin of storytelling is to skimp on conflict, and no wonder. Those problems, challenges, obstacles, and inner struggles are what keep readers engaged, casting doubt on the character's ability to achieve their goal.

Because readers are focused on what's happening from one scene to the next, it can appear that conflict is only occurring moment to moment. In actuality, it's present at different levels, and maximizing how the various obstacles and challenges interact is key to building a rich, powerful story. Let's take a look.

Central Conflict

Every story has an overarching conflict that should be resolved by the end of the book. Whether your protagonist is trying to prevent evil creatures from entering their world (*Stranger Things*), stop the terrorists who have taken over Nakatomi Tower (*Die Hard*), or find the groom and get him to his wedding on time (*The Hangover*), they must address that problem. The central conflict for any story will take one of six forms:

Character vs. Character: The protagonist goes up against another character in a battle of wits, will, and strength.

Character vs. Society: The protagonist takes on society or an agency within it to bring about necessary change.

Character vs. Nature: The protagonist battles a form of nature, such as the weather, a challenging landscape, or its animal inhabitants.

Character vs. Technology: The protagonist faces a manufactured foe, such as a computer or machine.

Character vs. Supernatural: The protagonist confronts a force that exists outside their full understanding. This may involve an encounter

with fate, a god, or some other magical or spiritual foe.

Character vs. Self: The protagonist experiences a large-scale internal battle of clashing beliefs, hopes, needs, or fears.

The central conflict locks the wheels of your story's rollercoaster onto a specific track so the macro and micro challenges you add will support plot and character development.

Story-Level (Macro) Conflict

Some conflicts present bigger problems that your character doesn't have the means or ability to solve. These threats loom over much of the story, and the protagonist will have to work through them while handling other immediate, scene-level dangers and challenges.

For example, in *Die Hard*, John McClane is one man against an organized, armed group who have taken over Nakatomi Tower. His central conflict (character vs. character) is to stop the terrorists and save everyone in the building, especially his wife. That on its own seems impossible, but it's complicated by a few other problems he also has to deal with: keeping Holly's identity as his wife a secret so the terrorists can't use her as leverage, figuring out Hans Gruber's real motive for taking over the tower, and doing it all despite the bungling interference of a grossly inept FBI.

And in the back of his mind is the most challenging problem of all, the one that brought him to California in the first place: how to fix his crumbling marriage and reconcile with Holly before it's too late.

Large-scale conflicts like these will need to be addressed by your protagonist, but they won't be ironed out immediately. Very often, the character will have to work on these issues in stages as they dodge danger and achieve smaller goals from scene to scene.

Scene-Level (Micro) Conflict

Conflict at the scene level comes in the form of as-it-happens clashes, threats, obstacles, and challenges that get between your character and their goal. The character is trying to handle what's right in front of them, deal with inner struggles, and above all else, prevent disaster. Sometimes they succeed and sometimes they fail—and failure is part of the process, by the way. Setbacks are necessary to increase the pressure, introduce complications, raise the stakes, and force your character to examine why

things went wrong. This last one is especially important for characters on a change arc since internal growth is crucial for them to successfully achieve their story goal.

In *Die Hard*, John McClane pulls the fire alarm so first responders will arrive and discover what's going on in the tower. This fails when the terrorists convince the fire department it was a false alarm. Worse, it places a target on John's back because now Hans Gruber and his mercenaries know that someone in the building is working against them. A manhunt results with John, unarmed and barefoot, fighting to stay a step ahead in each scene by outwitting, overpowering, and killing those sent to eliminate him.

Internal Conflict

Another form of conflict takes place within the character. At the macro level, it's the main internal struggle the protagonist must address to achieve their story goal.

John McClane's marriage is a breath away from breaking because he's self-absorbed and unaccommodating, believing his needs and career should come first. Holly, rather than become a minimized puzzle piece in John's world, moves herself and their children across the country to follow her own professional dream. John visits her with the goal of reconciling, but he's really hoping that her choices have shown her she's better off in New York with him. Instead, he finds her happy, thriving in her career, and independent—so independent, she's using her maiden name.

This ego hit makes John realize that getting her back won't be easy, and if he wants to make it work, he might have to make some sacrifices. This sets the stage for his inner conflict—putting himself or others first. With Holly in mortal danger, he realizes how selfish and unsupportive he's been and wants the chance to tell her so. This awakening is John's first step toward resolving his inner conflict, which he achieves when he does everything within his power to stop Hans and protect Holly, no matter what the personal cost.

Internal conflict also happens at the micro level with conflicts arising in individual scenes. Faced with the crushing force of painful circumstances, pressure, and opposition, characters often struggle with what to do, knowing right from wrong, and even what they should feel. Conflicting emotions and competing desires, needs, and fears can paralyze

a character, cloud their judgment, and make decisions and choices that much harder.

External or internal, macro or micro, conflict powers your story. It pushes and pressures the character, stands in the way of his greatest desire, and strains him to his limits, making him want to quit. Then he'll have to show his strength and prove his worthiness by fighting, making sacrifices, and being willing to change to achieve his goal.

ENCOURAGE UNEVEN MATCHUPS TO HEIGHTEN CONFLICT

As you're strategizing ways to use the four levels of conflict in your story, look for opportunities to highlight inequities. When we engineer story elements to be unbalanced, it generates immediate friction by putting the protagonist at a disadvantage. Let's examine some of the purposeful disparities built into *Die Hard*, starting with the characters.

At first glance, John's experience as a seasoned New York police officer has surely given him the skills to deal with a threat like Hans Gruber. Only...Hans isn't alone, and John is unarmed and in an unfamiliar place. Worse, when the building is taken over, he's trapped with no leverage or resources—not even a pair of shoes. Hans, on the other hand, has a team of skilled and well-armed mercenaries with full building access and plenty of hostages, including John's wife.

This imbalance makes stopping Hans and protecting Holly seem futile, and for much of the movie, John's goal is out of reach. But how he handles conflict at the scene level—taking out his enemies one by one, dropping a dead body on a car to draw a policeman's attention, getting his hands on a weapon, and stealing Hans' detonators—allows him to balance the scales until winning becomes possible. His responses to conflict also give readers a chance to see who he really is. His inventiveness and relentlessness are key to getting the audience to buy into the idea that one man can disrupt a highly organized plot to steal 650 million dollars in bonds.

Die Hard is a great example of how each level of conflict adds to the whole, creating a dynamic plot and arc. On the outside, it seems like your typical shoot 'em up cop movie, one you don't have to think too hard about and can just enjoy. And while that's true to some degree, inner conflict gives it depth. At the end of the day, if John wants to achieve all his goals

(including saving his marriage), he must stop being self-absorbed and put the needs of others before his own.

HOW TO CONNECT THE LEVELS OF CONFLICT

Hopefully you can see how different levels of conflict work together to build a sustainable series of challenges that will strain a character mentally, physically, and emotionally. So how do we apply this in our own stories?

If we can borrow from *Die Hard* one last time, imagine Nakatomi Tower as your story's landscape, with each floor representing a scene. Your character's goal may be to get to the roof because someone up there needs help (stakes). A family member is being held captive by the character's nemesis, who's waiting with a bomb (macro conflict) and is more than willing to blow the building to ash rather than lose.

The protagonist has injured their leg and the elevators are out, so climbing thirty-five floors will be no easy feat, and to make things worse, each floor has been booby trapped (micro conflict). But your character moves from floor to floor, facing enemies, problems, and dangers. Everything they encounter has the potential to derail their progress, bury them in complications, and get them to turn around. And they're tempted because, deep down, they really don't think they're up to the job (inner conflict). Each close call makes them wonder if this is an impossible mission that will only get them killed.

But as your character moves up, they're getting better at avoiding traps. Maybe they find a weapon and a bag of tools to help them. They're growing stronger and are feeling more capable, though self-doubt still digs at them. But they've come too far and endured too much, so they keep pushing upward.

Finally, they reach the roof and their nemesis. If they don't win here, the bomb will bring down the building, their loved one, and themselves. In this fight, they refuse to let self-doubt grab hold as it did so many times before. With their determined mindset and tools acquired along the way, they defuse the bomb, defeat the enemy, and save their loved one. The central conflict is resolved, and they've achieved their goal.

While every story is unique, the primary role of conflict is to take someone who is not capable of achieving their goal and, over the course of a story, reshape them into someone who is. As you choose obstacles, challenges, and antagonistic forces to oppose the character and create

friction, ask yourself if they contribute to this evolution. While you will have some minor inconveniences and hassles at the scene level, most conflict should be chosen to help the character learn what they need to about themselves and the world, and prepare them for the battles ahead so they become someone capable of winning.

CONFLICT CATEGORIES

While the inclusion of different conflict levels will provide depth, you'll also need a variety of challenges to keep your scenes fresh. If a character encounters the same stressors over and over, readers will grow impatient, and that's a one-way ticket to Skim City—or worse, Close-the-Book-Ville.

The story's genre, central conflict, and protagonist's arc will determine some of the conflict scenarios, but you'll need many more to round things out. With so many to choose from, where should you start? Don't worry, we've got you. The scenarios in this book are grouped by the types of challenges they present. Each category has certain superpowers, so dive in and discover what they are, and then head to that section of the thesaurus to dream up the perfect mix of macro and micro problems for your story.

Dangers and Threats

This is one of the most obvious and versatile forms of conflict: a hazard or menace that represents direct harm to the character or the people they care about (and may be responsible for).

According to Maslow's Hierarchy of Human Needs, *Safety and Security* is one of the most important needs a person can have—meaning, in the real world, we typically seek ways to avoid situations that put us at risk. Psychologically speaking, characters should mirror flesh-and-blood people, so they too will be wary of situations that could harm them. Of course, that won't stop us from making sure their car hits a patch of black ice or ensuring a predator crosses their path in the woods, will it?

Danger can originate from other people, the environment, a location, or even from within the character themselves. For someone struggling with an addiction, an inability to gauge risk or seek help could lead to a hospitalization or death. A person consumed with guilt over past mistakes might become self-destructive, taking on an adversary or challenge far beyond their abilities because they believe that only self-punishment or self-sacrifice can balance the scales.

When you're looking for a hit of organic danger, look no further than your character's location. Every story setting will contain inherent perils. Perhaps a hired detective is staking out your unfaithful character's house, or the rain-soaked ground where your adventurers are hiding is about to give way. Locational dangers can be small (a poisonous centipede skittering into a character's sleeping bag) or large (a hurricane about to make landfall). Depending on what you need for the story, these threats can cause an inconvenience, create delays, ruin carefully laid plans, or worse.

This category is also a great choice when you want to make your character responsible for the fallout. They can underestimate the danger or overestimate their abilities, and then the consequences will really sting because the pain they're experiencing could have been avoided. Another benefit of the character ignoring or not seeing the danger is that they'll learn a hard life lesson, one they won't want to repeat.

Ego-Related Conflicts

Just as dangers and threats attack the character's safety and security, ego-related conflicts undermine their esteem and recognition. This human need is all about personal worth, both the value others place on someone and how that person sees and values themselves.

In the real world, people tend to shy away from situations where they could be embarrassed because they worry about what others think and don't like to be judged. Insecurities magnify mistakes in their minds, especially if their egos have been hurt by criticism or similar blunders in the past.

Because well-built characters will have similar psychological drivers, they'll struggle with insecurity connected to a personal negative experience, especially if it left an emotional scar. Being excluded, discredited, lied to, or minimized will hurt them, even if they strive not to show it.

Ego-related challenges stir up internal conflict and trigger sensitivities that are hard to hide, so the character may respond by pulling back and isolating themselves, exploding with anger, or replying with barbed honesty that only makes things worse. Even in cases where the character has done nothing wrong, these conflicts can cut deep simply because there's a witness.

Consider Fiona, our protagonist who has not visited her hometown in quite a while. Things are becoming serious with her boyfriend, however, so she books a flight. She's nervous, because her parents have some odd ideas

about the world, but she knows Drew is the one, and it's time to introduce him to her family.

Fiona and Drew arrive as her parents are having an after-dinner glass of port. At first, everything goes as expected. They're overjoyed at the surprise visit and they fawn over Drew, asking about his job, family, interests—basically ticking all the boxes. But as one glass of port turns into several, Fiona's dad begins to rant a bit about world events until, in a pin-drop moment, he floats a full-on, dark net alien conspiracy theory.

Imagine Fiona's embarrassment and how she might try to salvage the evening. Maybe she laughs it off, pretending it's a joke. Or she tells Drew that her dad's teasing him to see how he'll react. But the more Fiona tries to minimize the damage, the louder and more verbal her father gets. Soon he's targeting Fiona, criticizing her for being naive, living in a dream world, and not acknowledging the undisputable evidence that an alien force is pulling the puppet strings of the human race. As her father rages, humiliation washes over her. The love of her life is bearing witness to this lunacy. What must Drew think of her parents...and her?

Ego-related conflict, such as suffering a humiliation, strikes deep. It's an attack on one of the character's most important basic needs. In response, the character may lash out (fight), go silent (freeze), or cut her visit short (flight)—whatever response fits her personality, emotional range, and way of coping with being made vulnerable. Regardless of her reaction, readers will connect to the pain she feels because no one is immune to ego-based hurts.

It's also common for someone experiencing this kind of conflict to internalize it through self-blame. In this case, Fiona may fault herself for bringing Drew to meet her parents or for not warning him about what he might be walking into. It will take time for her to see that she isn't to blame for her father's ravings and that her own worth has nothing whatsoever to do with his ideas or habits.

Because ego-related conflicts tend to give birth to internal struggles, they can be a good option for a character traversing a change arc.

Loss of Control

In the real world, control is important for us to maintain, as can be seen in the dozens of big and small decisions we make every day. We may invest in a university degree if it gives us financially secure job options. We might

buy a house in a school district that will ensure a quality education for our children. We put fuel in the car so we don't run out, clean scraped knees so they don't get infected, and choose politeness over honesty to avoid drama. In other words, we live according to the rules of cause and effect.

But does life give two crab apples about cause and effect? Nope. While we're playing the odds, it stands up and says, "Hold my beer." It's indisputable and somewhat horrifying: control is only an illusion. At any moment, something unexpected can happen that undoes all our careful planning.

A loss of control in the real world can be devastating because we think we should have seen what was coming—anticipated it and had an escape plan ready. As with ego-related conflict, we categorize our inability to control every aspect of life as a personal failure and falsely believe there's something wrong with us.

This kind of event can happen to anyone, so when we hit a character with a complication they can't stop or prevent, it messes them up. It also sends readers reeling in a queasy-yet-familiar way. As things spin out of control, they empathize with the character's feelings of self-blame and anguish.

Conflicts that dispel the myth of control can also reveal characterization in the protagonist's lowest moment. Imagine a character whose spouse succumbs to a heart attack while camping. In the days that follow, does our grieving character angrily push people away, causing cracks to surface in those relationships? Does he sink into the quicksand of denial and refuse to acknowledge what happened? Or will he set aside his pain to help his children and other family members cope with their heartbreaking loss?

How fast a character works through a loss of control is up to you, but they shouldn't get over it too quickly. Keep in mind that it will take even longer if the conflict results in difficult fallout or an emotional trauma that must then be navigated.

Losing an Advantage

One of the worst things we can do to a character is cause them to lose hope. After all, conflict's sharp sword has already jabbed them relentlessly throughout the story. They've fought, sacrificed, and clawed their way forward, and then finally, their hard work starts to pay off. They gain

something they need, the world starts to support them, or they pull ahead of the competition.

So naturally, because we're evil, we take their hard-won advantage away.

Losing an advantage is a versatile type of conflict that can be especially helpful at specific times, so it should be wielded strategically. For example, not every character rushes out the door when the trumpet call of adventure sounds. Instead, they cling to their favorite saggy, cat-clawed chair, because even if the living room of life isn't great right now, it's what they know, and that makes it safe. It's in their comfort zone.

But if we let our characters stay where they are, the story is as good as dead. Taking away something they deem vital, like a position of authority, a trusted ally, or cherished relationship, can convince them to stumble through that first story door.

This type of conflict can also test a character's commitment. What happens when they lose the one thing that's been motivating them to continue? If their lead witness in a trial is murdered, or their benefactor withdraws support, or an adoption falls through, will they forge ahead or throw in the towel?

In a similar way, the loss of an advantage can offer enlightenment to a character who's been chasing a false goal. Characters don't always have their priorities straight at the start of the story and can end up pursuing the wrong dream—or chasing goals for the wrong reasons. Maybe they're trying to be the best son or daughter possible, so they give in to parental pressure and abandon their big-city dreams to help with the farm. Or they continue trying to become a blacksmith because they've apprenticed for so long already and don't want to waste all that work and sacrifice.

Part of the arc for these characters is about discovering what they truly want. The removal of an advantage creates a crossroads moment where a decision must be made. Will they try to regain the loss so they can keep moving toward their objective? Or do they recognize that, without the advantage, the goal has lost its allure?

The right goal is one that a character is fully committed to, and even if they lose an advantage, it won't stop them.

Power Struggles

If there's one thing we know about our characters, it's that at some point, they're going to clash. And *why* is no mystery. Each member of our story's cast has their own goals, agendas, needs, and beliefs, and those don't always play nicely with the goals, agendas, needs, and beliefs of others. When there's too much friction, a power struggle ensues.

This often happens in relationships where characters don't have equal status, such as a police officer and suspect, boss and employee, or teacher and student. It can occur when the person with less power tries to level the playing field or unseat the other party. Conflict will also arise when it's perceived that one person is using their position unfairly. If your character is on the receiving end of a power play—say, they've been frivolously sued by a disgruntled customer, falsely accused by a rival, or passed over for promotion because of nepotism—it will trigger their moral sense of right and wrong, leading to a battle royale.

These tussles can also happen in positive relationships and may be harder to deal with because the character is being pressured by someone they love or respect. A father who pushes his son to follow in his footsteps and enter the military might have a fight on his hands if the son perceives it as an attempt to control him. This may not have been the father's intention; he merely believed the structure and discipline would do his son good. But disagreements often come down to perspective. And if the situation isn't handled carefully, a valued relationship could be damaged.

When the people involved are very different—say, an upright and honorable person vs. a bullying, manipulative character—power struggles can be used to contrast personality. To create some popcorn-worthy showdowns, think about what might put your players at odds. Do they both want the same goal, or are their goals so far apart that, for one to win, the other must lose? Is there an intense animosity between them over something that happened in the past? How might that play out on the stage of your story?

One of the best places to highlight a power struggle is within a dialogue exchange between characters with different goals. If one party wants information the other doesn't want to share, a beautiful tug-of-war can unfold, complete with verbal jabs, veiled threats, and insults.

Power struggles can also exist as macro conflicts that last for much of the story. These overarching standoffs usually have higher stakes and can

become personal quickly, with one character vowing to beat the other at any cost.

And on that note, don't be afraid of letting things get personal, because escalating emotions can override a character's common sense and possibly their morality. Their determination to win may encourage them to justify deplorable behavior, such as purposely causing trouble for their enemy, making false accusations, sabotaging them, and more.

Whether it's your protagonist, antagonist, or someone in between who's behaving badly, the motivation behind their actions should be clear, or this conflict will feel contrived. And if your protagonist is the one slinging mud, don't go so far that they become unlikeable. A way to avoid this is to show what's at stake and build in a moment of shame when they realize they've lost their way. Readers can forgive bad behavior if the character takes responsibility for it and changes their response in the future.

Miscellaneous Challenges

Conflict is multifaceted, and like most things in life, not every scenario can be filed neatly into a particular box. If you're searching for conflict that provides a unique challenge for your character or complicates their situation in ways you might not have considered, look through the ideas in this category. Maybe your character is in the wrong place at the wrong time, they have been mistaken for someone else, or a dire circumstance forces them to blindly trust a stranger. Oh, the possibilities!

To explore additional categories and conflict options, check out Volume One of *The Conflict Thesaurus: A Writer's Guide to Obstacles, Adversaries, and Inner Struggles*. There, you'll find options for relationship friction, failures and mistakes, moral dilemmas and temptations, duty and responsibility, increased pressure and ticking clocks, and no-win scenarios. To view a list of Volume One entries, see the [MORE CONFLICT SCENARIOS](#) page.

KEEPING THE CENTRAL CONFLICT CENTER STAGE

At this point, you should be getting an inkling of the vast number of conflict scenarios your character could face over the course of a story. As things progress and the protagonist's difficulties compound, there's always a risk of the central conflict getting muted or lost in the noise. Too much conflict, or certain problems getting a disproportionate chunk of airtime, can lead to pacing issues or confused readers who don't know what the character is working toward. Keeping the core plot and central conflict as your main focus is the best way to ensure that everything you put in place is building toward that eventual climax.

So, which of the six central conflicts is your story built around? In the *Harry Potter* books, the core struggle involves character vs. character conflicts because the primary forces of opposition are Voldemort and his agents. Katniss' battle with the Capitol in *The Hunger Games* is part of a character vs. society dynamic. And Sarah Connor's adversary in *The Terminator* is a robot, creating a character vs. technology showdown.

If you're at the start of your plotting journey and are still figuring this out, the Goal, Motivation, Conflict formula can help you zero in on the main force of opposition. Or if you're drafting and want to ensure your core conflict aligns with what you're writing, GMC works for that, too.

It's also a great option for helping you see what a central character vs. X conflict will look like in your story. Then you can start choosing the problems and friction-inducing situations that will test your character's commitment, reveal characterization, and force them to reflect on how to become stronger so they can achieve their goal.

But unless you pick the right conflict and introduce it at the right time, certain story problems can become larger-than-life and derail your main plotline. There are two areas in particular where this can become a problem.

CHARACTER ARC

When a character resolves their main internal struggle, their heart and mind become aligned, which is usually necessary for them to achieve their goal. It's no surprise then that inner conflict tied to the character arc will be prominent. However, just because it's crucial to your story doesn't mean internal tug-of-wars should overwhelm everything else, including your plot.

In this case, balancing internal and external conflict is all about proportion: including enough internal struggle to show the character's gradual journey toward change without bogging down the external plot and related conflict. This is handled quite well in the first book of the *Harry Potter* series.

As Rowling introduces readers to Harry and his world in the opening pages, she focuses largely on external conflict: he's mistreated by the Dursleys, belittled, and ignored. They lock him in a cupboard, withhold his mail, and motor him off to an isolated island to keep him from getting his Hogwarts letter. Then Hagrid appears and turns his world upside down.

Here's where we see the first bit of internal conflict from Harry. It's fitting, because one thing he's learned from living with the Dursleys is to keep his head down and avoid attention. So he rolls with the punches, taking whatever's thrown at him. But when Harry learns that he's a powerful non-Muggle who defeated the most formidable wizard that ever lived, he's shell-shocked and struggles to fit this new information into what he's always believed to be true.

This pattern of blending external and internal conflict continues throughout the book, with Harry's moments of personal struggle coming intermittently: he has a moment with the sorting hat, shows conflicted emotions about the Mirror of Erised, doubts his Quidditch abilities, etc. And this is the right balance, considering Harry's story. While he does experience some internal changes in book one, they're secondary to the story goal: beating Voldemort. Achieving that objective is not only vital for book one but also sets up the main conflict for the rest of the series. A lot of external conflict is required to prepare Harry to keep Voldemort from acquiring the sorcerer's stone and coming back to power, so that's what Rowling gives us.

For stories with less action, you may have to experiment to find the right balance between internal and external conflict. Some characters may have more internal hurdles than others, and of course, if you have a character vs. self plotline, the internal struggle is the core story, so it will

require more focus. In *A Beautiful Mind*, for instance, John Nash's battle is with his mental illness, so a lot of airtime is given to him fighting his schizophrenia and the personalities it conjures.

Another way to balance internal and external conflict is to pay attention to the pacing. Too much internal weighing and measuring will interrupt the action. And those outer obstacles, adversaries, and threats don't take coffee breaks; they need to be dealt with. Maintaining the right balance will keep the pace moving and ensure that readers are clear on exactly what the character needs to accomplish.

SUBPLOTS

While a good portion of conflict happens in the main plotline, some macro conflicts will need time to resolve. For clarity, let's talk a bit about subplots and the best way to resolve them without overpowering the core conflict.

A **subplot** is a subordinate story that relates to the main plotline and typically involves the protagonist or someone close to them. Continuing with our Harry Potter theme, in *Harry Potter and the Sorcerer's Stone*, the main plot and conflict are as follows:

Story Goal: Keep Voldemort from finding the stone and returning to power

Central Conflict: Harry vs. Voldemort (character vs. character)

And while there are many subplots, here are a few of the more obvious ones.

Subplot 1: Harry, Ron, and Hermione becoming friends

Subplot 2: Harry's growing adversarial relationship with Malfoy

Subplot 3: Snape as an antagonist for Harry

Each subplot should have its own story arc, and while it will be simpler and shorter than a main plotline, it will have a clear beginning, middle, and end with its own ups and downs. Each one should also push the story forward and, in some way, influence the main plot. For example, Harry's friendship with Ron and Hermione is key to him defeating Voldemort in the first book. In the climax alone, Hermione's knowledge about Devil's Snare and Ron's experience and self-sacrifice in the game of Wizard's Chess make it possible for Harry to get to that final confrontation. So while it's great for

Harry to have friends, this subplot is integral to him achieving his main goal (while also providing valuable opportunities for characterization).

The Malfoy subplot is important because Voldemort doesn't make a physical appearance until the third act, so Malfoy acts as a stand-in, providing a physical antagonist for Harry to battle. He also plays a part in many scene-level conflict scenarios that draw Harry closer to fulfilling the overall goal.

The third subplot, though, is the most interesting—as anything to do with Snape tends to be. Like Malfoy, Snape is a sparring partner for Harry. And the scenes with Snape often have to do with the race for the sorcerer's stone, so they support the main plotline, as required. The fascinating thing about this subplot is that we realize at the end of the book that most of those scenes with Snape involved red herrings, meant to throw Harry and the readers off. Snape wasn't working with Voldemort to get the stone; everything he did was to keep it out of Voldemort's hands and protect Harry. And as anyone who has read the rest of the books knows, Snape as a red herring is an ongoing theme. So not only does his subplot contribute to the first book's storyline, it also is foundational to the series as a whole.

The conflicts in these subplots have a lot of wow factor, and they could have easily run away with the story. But they didn't because they were built to do what they needed to do: provide Harry and his friends with the knowledge and experience they needed to face bigger battles. As a result, his fight to prevent Voldemort from returning to power remained center stage.

HOW CONFLICT'S GOLDEN THREAD POWERS THE STORY

Conflict has a unique superpower: it impacts both plot and arc, and in doing so, becomes the golden thread that weaves the two together. You'll find it all throughout story structure; for example, without conflict, there's no *Inciting Incident* to push the character to leave behind their ordinary world for the new one. And unless he's relentlessly pummeled and buffeted by adversaries and problems, he wouldn't hit rock bottom and there would be no *All is Lost* moment. *The Dark Night of the Soul* is where he reflects on his journey through conflict's fire, and then doubles down to make a push for change. And the *Climax*, well, that's the ultimate point of friction—an outer clash where he wins or loses based on how well he's resolved any inner struggles.

Conflict's imprint is found everywhere—throughout the plot, arc, and beyond. Let's look at some of the ways meaningful opposition and challenges can improve your story.

CONFLICT AIDS IN CHARACTER DEVELOPMENT

On page one, a character should not be able to achieve their goal—meaning, if the climax occurred at this point in the story, they would fail miserably. Conflict, for all the pain it causes, becomes their training ground. As they face smaller hazards and opponents, the character gains the knowledge, skills, internal understanding, and resiliency needed to face bigger, scarier problems.

Not every match up ends in success, either, but failures are just as important to character development. A misstep can lead to complications and generate uncomfortable emotions like powerlessness, insecurity, and disappointment. These emotions are unpleasant, so the character becomes motivated to avoid them. To understand what went wrong, they'll take a hard look at their strengths and weaknesses, and analyze any beliefs, needs, fears, or biases that might have impaired their decision-making. If they

identify something holding them back, they'll make changes so future outcomes are more favorable.

This willingness to evolve becomes especially important as conflicts escalate, stakes rise, and there's less room for failure. Only by finding their best selves can they maneuver past harder challenges and adversaries. Fears and flaws that hamper them are discarded in favor of attributes, skills, and knowledge. As they change, they see more successes, and this helps them do the harder internal work needed to grow. Once they fully reconcile any inner conflict, they'll become the person they need to be, the one strong enough to handle whatever they encounter.

Now, while this is the typical path of development for characters on a change arc, conflict can lead down a darker path, too. Despite ample opportunities, the protagonist may be unable to let go of past pain, biases, and dysfunctional thinking, and if fear takes hold and failures pile up, they'll wander farther away from who they must become to win. In this case, their attitude and perspective can become increasingly negative, and desperation may cause their moral lines to shift or disappear.

CONFLICT BUILDS UP (OR TEARS DOWN) SELF-ESTEEM

A character who is actively working through difficult situations will be bolstered by the knowledge that they're making decisions and forging ahead, not sitting on the sidelines waiting for something to happen. Even if they are outmatched and experience failure, they can look in the mirror and know they're doing what's right. It takes courage and grit to take on seemingly insurmountable problems—especially when there are no easy wins. Sometimes, just showing up can prove a character's worth to others and themselves.

On the flip side, conflict can sow doubt about their aptitude and abilities. Too many mistakes in high-risk situations can eat away at them—especially when others seem to be losing faith, too. If the strain of back-to-back challenges beats them up mentally and they're unable to push through self-doubt, the possibility of them giving up is high. Instead of persevering, they may revert to old behaviors and emotional shielding that will erase the progress they had made toward becoming someone stronger and more centered.

CONFLICT HIGHLIGHTS THE CHARACTER'S VALUES AND BELIEFS

Every character has a **belief system** that steers their decisions and actions. Their morals, values, core beliefs, and emotional attachments set their worldview and become the foundation for how they live their life—what they do, think, and embrace.

A belief system can evolve (or devolve) over time, but early experiences lay the groundwork. Important moments in life, people the character bonded with and learned from, and how the world has treated them will all contribute to what the character values most.

Because life experiences are individual, each character will end up with a unique set of ideals, morals, and opinions about the world. For example, a character who grew up in an environment of support, stability, and unconditional love is likely to place a high value on trust, relationships, and belonging. But someone who was shuttled through the foster care system until they finally aged out may value self-sufficiency and independence, because in their experience, unconditional love and external support are myths.

If this pair ever met, think of how they might approach a relationship together. Character B may avoid intimacy because they've learned that relationships are temporary and people always leave when things get tough. Character A may seek to build closeness quickly because they understand the value of such bonds, but when they encounter resistance, it will confuse them. After all, they've never been hurt by love and they won't understand the other person's pushback.

One of the most magical aspects of story is the landscape it provides for readers to explore and experience a variety of belief systems. Conflict makes this possible. When a character's values and ideals generate friction, it puts their morals in the hot seat and highlights who they really are. Scenes with this kind of **moral conflict** add depth and increased investment because the character's goal is tied to the values and truths they live by.

CONFLICT CAN PROVIDE A WINDOW INTO THE PAST

When a situation or person challenges the character's belief system or perspective, their response will naturally provide insight into their values or morality. Likewise, if a stressful situation stirs up a character's past hurts and fears, they may say or do something that's loaded with subtext, making

readers want to know more. Conflict can provide a way to share a bit of the past without slowing the story.

Consider Rocket from *Guardians of the Galaxy*, a cybernetically and genetically enhanced raccoon who was abused, altered, and remade by scientists. This treatment left him with heavy levels of distrust, anger at the world, and a me-first mentality that makes him morally flexible. He's opportunistic, antagonistic, and willing to steal or engage in violence to get what he needs. The audience views him as a deeply damaged character, and he is. But is it any wonder, considering his history of mistreatment?

After a botched attempt to capture Quinn (Star-Lord) for a bounty, Rocket is sent to prison with him, Groot, and Gamora. There, he is belittled and insulted by other inmates, and anger pushes him to reveal a vulnerable truth: he didn't ask to be made into a monster. This moment, along with a few key others, are all that's needed to explain why he is the way he is.

Conflict between characters tends to reveal individual biases, skewed viewpoints, and misconceptions. This friction can allow the writer to drop hints about negative past events—especially emotional wounds that shaped the character's worldview and beliefs.

CONFLICT CAN REVEAL A CHARACTER'S MISBELIEFS

Part of a character's belief system are misbeliefs: toxic and destructive lies the character embraces about himself and the world around him. If your character is on a journey of growth, this misbelief will skew his perceptions and must be addressed for him to complete his journey of growth (and achieve his goal).

Returning to *Guardians of the Galaxy*, Rocket agrees to help Quinn and Gamora break out of the prison and transport a powerful orb in exchange for a big financial reward. The group bonds through conflict—first, during their escape, and later as they take out steadily more challenging foes. But then the orb is stolen and Rocket's anticipated payday dissolves. The group's mission shifts to an altruistic one: prevent Ronan from using the infinity stone to destroy a world. Considering Rocket's loyalty was secured through a promise of payment, we might assume he'd break from the group. Instead, he stays.

Why would someone who is largely motivated by financial gain do this? Well, despite his prickly exterior, he's an outcast who longs to be accepted. The problem is the lie he believes, that he's not worthy of

inclusion. The world sees him as a monster, so he sees himself that way, too. He acts the part of the chaotic, unlovable thing that people believe him to be—until Quinn came along, that is, and their band of rowdy misfits became a family.

For the first time, Rocket sees the world differently. He belongs to a group that protects and cares about each other. And maybe with a new, more altruistic mission, he can do the thing that no monster would do... become a protector of others.

When Rocket lets go of his misbelief and acknowledges his self-worth, he allows the group's values to be incorporated into his own belief system. He changes from being self-serving to serving others—well, mostly. Rocket wouldn't be Rocket without a dose of opportunism and profiteering.

Various elements come together in a character's arc to make the story work, but the constant is the golden thread of conflict. Without it, Rocket wouldn't have been thrown together with Quinn and the others nor pulled into the larger-scale battle over the infinity stone. Without conflict, he wouldn't have lost his temper and revealed his inner truth of hating himself, which changed the way Quinn treated him. And finally, without conflict, he wouldn't have realized he cared about the people he was with, and in them, found a family to belong to.

CONFLICT CAN GIVE READERS AN OPPORTUNITY TO REFLECT

Stories enable readers to experience the lives of others, and while conflict makes events more gripping and entertaining, it also can introduce deeper life questions that may push them to examine how they see the world.

Moral conflict is rarely black and white. By nature, it exposes readers to different viewpoints, even ones that don't match their own. As the story unfolds, each character's values and what they're fighting for can spark philosophical questions about what's right and wrong in certain situations, how a person should live their life, and which beliefs are worth fighting for.

Depending on the story's topic and theme, a reader might find certain personal assumptions challenged. For instance, the idea that a good man with strong morals would never torture another person (*Prisoners*). Or how a value can be twisted, such as the idea that you should do anything for love (*Pet Sematary*). Readers may also be forced to think more deeply if they realize a belief they share with one of the characters has a dark side.

Not every story needs conflict that will cause readers to question their own beliefs or create an epiphany. But scenarios that make readers think tend to stay with them for some time after the book closes.

CONFLICT ADDS TENSION

It's common to confuse conflict and tension because they're often used together to deliver a one-two punch. The difference between them is subtle, but important:

Conflict is a force that stands between your characters and what they want most.

Tension is the feeling of anticipation surrounding *what will happen next*.

Imagine a character who is dating two women, Alice and Shai. Neither is aware of the other, which is just how Logan wants to keep it. But in an epic goof, he asks them both to meet him for dinner at the same restaurant on the same night.

When the women arrive (at the same time, of course), that's conflict. When they both cross the room, unaware they're meeting the same man, that's tension.

Tension draws readers in and causes them to mentally ask questions:

Will the women find out Logan's dating them both?

Will he worm his way out of it?

What will the women do?

Will there be a big blowout?

Strong tension follows a pattern of pull-and-release—meaning, you let the tension build until it reaches its peak then resolve it by answering some of those unspoken questions.

We'll imagine that Logan sees the two women. Doom is approaching on stilettos, and he has no idea what to do. One thing is certain, though: when they reach his table, it's over.

If we wanted to continue building tension, we could add an event that delays the inevitable. Maybe Shai drops a glove halfway to the table and Alice notices. She retrieves it and stops Shai to return it.

Tension builds as they trade a few words. Logan watches this horror unfold: *Will one of them mention me? Point? Will they turn on me with death in their eyes?*

Readers know Logan is dead meat...unless we cut him some slack by flipping his tension from negative anticipation to positive. We can do that by introducing another event.

Perhaps after accepting the glove, Shai glances toward the restroom. Logan's mind is ablaze, hoping she takes a detour so when Alice reaches his table, he can tell her he's sick and they need to leave. Then he can text Shai with a similar explanation for his absence.

Readers watch this new development and think, *Will she go to the restroom? Is this his way out?*

Anticipation builds and again we achieve pull-and-release by answering internal questions. Shai doesn't hit the restroom, and both women arrive at his table at the same time. Sorry, Logan, you jerk. No easy out for you.

After a moment of confusion, the blowout Logan and the reader have anticipated happens. Shai and Alice start shouting at him, and every diner stops eating to watch the show. Embarrassed, he pleads for them to calm down, which only fires them up. Finally, Alice snatches a bowl of soup from a passing waiter's tray and dumps it over Logan's head. Tension is again released.

Shai asks Alice if she wants to get a drink, and the two leave. Logan, dripping chowder, signals for the bill, relieved that the restaurant is far from home and no one he knows will have witnessed this.

This last line provides a classic opportunity to use another tool in our tension belt: **foreshadowing**.

As Logan picks clams off his face, he catches someone filming him with their phone. His guts tighten like a noose because he knows nothing good can come of this. And the reader does too.

More internal questions arise:

Will that video show up online?

Will someone see it and recognize him?

As you can see, tension affects both readers and characters. A new situation, threat, or obstacle appears, and provided something's at stake, an

unasked question hangs in the air: *what comes next?*

Tension can result from all kinds of conflict scenarios, such as when the character

Is wrestling with competing goals, needs, or desires.

Must make a decision without all the facts.

Is unable to resolve a problem.

Is waiting on an outcome.

Has no good options.

Doesn't know how bad the fallout will be.

Doesn't know who will pay the price for their actions.

Doesn't know who to trust.

Can't predict how someone will react.

Notice the repeated theme here: *something is unknown*. Exploit that ignorance or uncertainty and let the tension build.

Tension can also be found consistently in the character's relationships, arising from power struggles, a sense of entitlement, a lack of boundaries, jealousy, misplaced loyalty, and more. When a disagreement unfolds, even between people in a loving situation, characters will react in a variety of ways, such as avoiding one another, ghosting each other's calls and texts, holding back information, becoming passive aggressive, or saying things that are hurtful. Responses like these will increase tension as the likelihood of a resolution declines while also deepening the rift in the relationship.

When characters are rivals or enemies with no goodwill between them, each must try to anticipate what the other will do: *How far will they go to get what they want? Do they have leverage over me? Will they stoop to low blows or try to cheat, manipulate, or sabotage my efforts?*

This fear of the unknown can unnerve your character and become so unbearable that they act impulsively and make things worse. Imagine that your protagonist is embroiled in a tight political race. Waiting for her rival to slander her has become too much for our politician, so she launches a proactive strike and releases old video footage of her opponent's drinking and debauchery.

This creates the hoped-for media storm, but it also awakens something in her rival, who had every intention of running a clean campaign: a desire for revenge. Our character took action because the tension became

intolerable. But the short-term release won't be worth the consequence of her opponent digging up old scandals and secrets in retaliation.

While tension can be quite effective in its negative form, positive tension has its place, too. In romance, it manifests as excitement or yearning as the partners grow closer. The story may start with small-scale friction (disagreements, opposing ideas or goals, etc.), but eventually the two will resolve their differences, lower their emotional shields, and let each other in, causing readers to rejoice. And let's not forget sexual tension, where desires collide and the tension of not touching becomes unbearable...*rawr!*

Other examples might be when characters separated by circumstances make plans to come back together, or a protagonist closes in on their goal. Tension in these situations come in the form of positive and hopeful anticipation.

At the story level, tension exists as long as the stakes are high and macro conflicts are unresolved. At the scene level, micro conflict must be dealt with, but uncertainty should be present until the scene's end, when the conflict has been neutralized, deferred, or diminished. Sometimes a scene can end with a new problem, cooking up a new batch of tension for readers to devour.

In general, tension will be present in good storytelling right up to the final page, when the details are finally tied up and the characters are safely in their new (and better) world.

CONFLICT GENERATES EMOTION

Well-crafted conflict should produce an emotional reaction from your character because they're in a situation that isn't ideal. Whether it originates from a person, event, or the environment, conflict can trigger a fight-flight-or-freeze response that puts the character on high alert.

Say they hear a strange noise in their house. You can imagine them going on the offensive, listening intently, assessing the threat level. Tension causes internal questions to form:

Do I recognize that noise?

Is it a sound that makes sense for right now? (Day or night, when they're alone, etc.)

Are the doors locked and is the alarm on?

The state of not knowing will be uncomfortable, making the character seek answers so they'll know what to feel—curiosity, anxiety, fear, or something else. Depending on what emotions are brewing, they might get up to investigate, call the police, or shrug and go back to sleep. If they get up, what they find (or don't find) will cause their emotions to escalate, shift, or downgrade.

When it comes to producing emotion, we tend to think that bigger is better, but this isn't always the case. Strings of smaller upsets can sometimes produce more emotion than one explosive event.

Imagine a scenario that's heart-stopping, like a hungry boa constrictor slithering down the hall toward you. You'll go from *Huh?* to terror pretty fast. Then fight-flight-or-freeze will kick in and you won't experience a range of emotions because you're too focused on survival.

Don't get us wrong: a dramatic conflict scenario can produce extreme feelings. But employing a chain of conflicts allows you to gradually turn up the heat on characters, drawing out different intensities and kinds of emotion.

Imagine Susan being called to school because her daughter collapsed during a soccer practice. As she drives there, her mind is running wild, imagining what could have happened, if Nedra is hurt, etc. She arrives to find out it's not too bad—just a bump and cut on the head caused by the fall. Nedra needs stitches but is otherwise in good spirits.

Susan takes her to Urgent Care, and Nedra explains to the doctor how she'd felt dizzy on the soccer pitch, maybe because it was so hot out. As the doctor sutures, Susan teases Nedra for not drinking enough water and then softens it with a joke about the *Harry Potter* scar she'll have.

Nedra asks who that is.

Susan and the doctor exchange a look; there's not a kid alive who doesn't know that name. She smiles at Nedra as if it doesn't matter, but her insides have seized. The doctor orders a few tests, stressing that it's just a precaution, nothing to worry about.

On the way home, Susan is careful to be upbeat with Nedra, but frantic mental questions are piling up. *Is this normal? Can a concussion cause temporary memory loss?*

Then the test results come back. Nedra has a brain bleed...and a tumor. It's big. She needs to be admitted to the hospital immediately.

As Susan sits by her daughter's bed and holds her hand, she says all the right things – that everything will be fine, this hospital has the best doctors, it's good they found it now. She lets the words pour out so nothing else does, like her fear or the guilt she feels over ignoring little things, teenage things, like Nedra turning on the shower but forgetting to get in, or denying she asked for toast for breakfast when she absolutely did. All Susan can think is that if she hadn't dismissed the signs and had gotten Nedra tested, maybe the tumor wouldn't be so bad.

As you can see here, a slower delivery of small-seeming conflicts gives characters more room to experience a range of emotions, such as worry, relief, fear, anxiety, devastation, and guilt. Layered conflict causes feelings to shift, grow, and morph into something else. It's like a plate of hot wings—the heat grows gradually, getting worse the more you eat. Sudden big conflicts, on the other hand, are like a ghost pepper that can be swallowed in one gulp, producing an instant, extreme reaction. Deciding which to use will depend on the result you're aiming for.

CONFLICT PUSHES THE STORY FORWARD

When conflict is missing, tension goes along with it, because nothing is standing between the character and their objective; the path to the goal is straight and easy, with no obstacles or competition to worry about. That means there's no real urgency to reach their destination, either, so maybe they'll take their time. You know...stop at the mall, visit with friends, book a cruise.

There's a saying among writing experts: Happy Characters in a Happy Land is a story killer. And boy, is this true. But conflict (and stakes that provide a high cost of failure) will set a protagonist's heels on fire and push them to run. And as complications and escalations pile up, they have less room to maneuver. This doesn't just make them move faster, it forces them to improve their responses so they make fewer missteps. In other words, your character will be growing. With each internal change, they'll become more invested in the skills they're learning and the person they're becoming and less invested in who they once were. This ensures that as the plot moves forward, the arc will, too.

WAYS TO AMP UP YOUR CONFLICT

By now, your mind is probably brimming with ways to use the golden thread of conflict. Here are a few ideas on how to bind your character a little tighter.

Make the Outcome Uncertain. To keep readers from easily predicting the result of a conflict scenario, sow some doubt—a.k.a., don't go easy on your protagonist. Put them at a disadvantage—or, if you're feeling evil, give them an easy win that isn't a true victory. Maybe a character with friends in high places gets a big promotion, only she doesn't realize her "friends" are setting her up as a scapegoat for their criminal behavior. Winning can also trigger unforeseen consequences. If your character doesn't pay now, make her pay later.

Withhold Something the Character Needs. When a character has everything—information, financial backing, a mentor, the support of others—it's an easier skate to the finish line, and what's the fun in that? Think about what your character needs most to succeed, and take it from her. If she needs medicine, put it in a glass vial that, at a critical point, will shatter. When she needs a map to navigate, let it be ruined by a dunk in the river. Knowledge, a way to communicate, a weapon... characters who are forced to act when they don't have what they need often screw up, leading to more conflict.

Make the Stakes Personal. Every story should have high stakes, where something is at risk if the character fails. But when the stakes are personal, winning becomes more crucial because of what they could lose. Get to know your character and the people, places, and things they hold dear. Then endanger them: a child's life, the character's job, their reputation, or their marriage. Most characters will walk through fire to protect the people and things they cherish.

Consider a No-Win Situation. The most heart-wrenching times for your character are when they have to make a decision in which someone will pay regardless of their choice. These story moments take courage because the character must decide between two equally bad outcomes. Do they save their daughter if doing so means abandoning their son? Do they stay and risk capture, or run and risk death by exposure? No-win scenarios create obvious tension for characters but also for readers, who recognize an impossible situation when they see it and wonder what choice will be made.

Keep Your Character Moving. Did you know that if sharks stop swimming, they'll die? This is a lesson we can apply to storytelling because when a character settles down for too long, the tension flatlines. So, keep them moving. If they find a haven, fill it with hidden dangers that compel them to leave. If a romantic relationship is becoming routine, introduce a disruptor—a secret being exposed, a hopeful ex-lover showing up, or a complication that forces a physical separation.

This goes for inner movement, too. If the character isn't moving forward and resolving their internal conflict, create a crisis that jeopardizes everything they've worked for. Remind them that they need to keep evolving to get what they want, even if this means facing hard truths or examining old wounds.

Shake Up the Team. If your character is relying on others, find a way to introduce dysfunction and friction. Disagreements, misunderstandings, egos, rivalries, or a sense of entitlement can shake the foundation of a relationship, create a power struggle, and leave your character without their much-needed backup.

Tighten the Timeline. There's nothing like a ticking clock to pile on the pressure, so think about how you can shorten a window of opportunity, move up a deadline, force the character to wait, or give them an ultimatum. Characters who rush can get sloppy and make mistakes, compounding the conflict.

Pull the Trigger. All characters carry some baggage from the past. If they're navigating a change arc, they'll have an unresolved wound, and

chances are, they've buried it deep. The problem is, for them to move forward, they need to deal with whatever is holding them back. A well-placed trigger can cause that wound to resurface.

Maybe your character has been avoiding her cousin, who was driving the night her sister died in a crash. But now she must work side by side with him to save their family's business. Or your character must perform a wellness check on someone who lives in the building where her abusive parents raised her. Exposing your character to fears and painful memories can awaken them to the realization that the past is holding them prisoner.

Include a Sacrifice. A character facing a challenge that's beyond her must make some hard choices if she wants to avoid losing everything. Maybe she must abandon one goal to put more energy into another, or give up on a passion to stand by a friend. Sacrifices are meaningful and will cause readers to care, so don't be afraid to use them.

Turn to Your Genre. Every genre will have specific opportunities to ramp up conflict. Does your character live in a historical time when certain illnesses were prevalent or their rights were restricted because of their race, gender, or religion? Is there a specific technology that is hampering your character's ability to move undetected in a future world? Pull organic conflict from the very bedrock of your genre by considering the character's reality and the challenges they might face.

Don't Make Violence Your Go-To. As you seek ways to power up conflict, it can be tempting to use violence to hammer home a threat. Sometimes this is warranted and fits the scenario, but other times it's used as an easy way out. Before going to this extreme, pause to see what's best for the story. If you decide to use it, don't make it the only tool in your bag of tricks. Writers should also think twice about using gratuitous violence to characterize, especially in situations that directly target women or children.

HARNESS THE POWER OF QUIET CONFLICT

We know that smaller conflicts layered together can sometimes have the biggest impact. It works the same way with subtle conflict. History is filled with powerful moments of quiet resistance—ordinary people who spied

during a war, hid Jewish people from the Nazis, or sewed hidden messages into clothing to draw attention to unfair working conditions in second-and third-world countries.

When you need conflict that's subdued yet satisfying, give these a try:

Subversion. Have a character use persuasion or manipulation to "turn" people inside a rival or enemy's inner circle.

Collusion. A character pursuing a goal that will disrupt the status quo and make enemies of powerful people—what can be better than that? Adding someone else who is like-minded, of course. Two characters, maybe even rivals, joining forces to conspire against an influential person or agency is the ultimate rebellion.

Interference. Quiet conflict can always come in the form of disruptions and obstructions, such as an unforeseen delay, bureaucracy slowing things down, losing a resource, an opponent purposefully passing along wrong information, or someone causing small problems to hinder the character's agenda.

Informing. No one likes having their private matters made public—often because it causes a loss of leverage. This is why information being leaked to the character's competitor or enemy can be so detrimental. Not only could this sabotage a character's goals, having an informant in their camp will cause them to view everyone around them with suspicion, creating deeply embedded trust issues.

Influencing. Influencers, by nature, win trust and favor and use their position to persuade others. A benevolent influencer can help a character make better decisions, but a malevolent one could use their resources to derail the character's confidence, make them dependent, and lead them to choices and actions that will weaken them in the long run.

Intimidation. This is the big bad brother of influencing—the threat of violence or unpleasant consequences being used to pressure a character into making certain decisions. Intimidation can come in the form of a physical attack, someone's unwanted presence, or even a meaningful

look. It can be mental, too, especially if the person doing the intimidating has information that can be leveraged if their target doesn't fall in line.

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THE VILLAIN IN THE ROOM: CREATING POWERFUL CLASHES

Your protagonist will face a lot of conflict throughout their story, and much of it will come from various **antagonists**. Clashes with a romantic rival, well-meaning meddler, frenemy, or invader can provide valuable opportunities for the hero to learn how to respond to attacks, figure out what works and what doesn't, and practice the skills they're learning. Confrontations like these are especially important if your story includes a **villain**, because they'll train and prepare the hero for that final showdown in the climax. These nefarious characters figure into many stories, so let's take some time to discuss the ins and outs of writing them well.

A villain is a person, entity, or force who is cruel, evil, or malicious enough to wish the protagonist harm. Rather than simply blocking a goal or interfering with the hero's plan, a villain causes suffering, making it vital for them to be conquered by the protagonist. Clarice must find and defeat Buffalo Bill if she wants to rise above her past and become a great FBI agent (*The Silence of the Lambs*); Chief Brody must defeat the man-eating shark to preserve his town (*Jaws*).

Regardless of the form your villain takes, there are certain details and qualities that will make them formidable and credible. Let's explore these qualifications through a case study of Dr. Lawrence Myrick, played by Gene Hackman in the movie *Extreme Measures*.

VILLAINS LIVE BY A MORAL CODE

It's been said that the best villains don't know they're villains; they think they're the hero of the story. And this is true because a well-crafted baddie has his own moral code. Compared to the protagonist's, it's twisted and corrupt, but it still provides guardrails that guide him through the story.

Dr. Myrick is a renowned and brilliant neurosurgeon who has dedicated his life's work to curing paralysis. It's a noble cause that he believes in more than anything—not so much for himself but for all the

paralyzed people in the world. This cause is so important that when he develops a treatment, he can't wait decades for it to crawl through the testing process and eventually be approved. So he bypasses the animal testing phase and goes right to human trials. It's kind of hard to find healthy subjects who are willing to take such a risk, so he kidnaps homeless people and confines them to his secret medical facility, then severs their spinal cords so he can test his treatment on them.

To the rest of the world, this is unconscionable. It's cruel, inhumane, and horrifying. But to Myrick, the end justifies the means. He's perfectly okay stealing people, taking away their freedom and mobility, and subjecting them to countless medical cruelties. And if they reach a point of no longer being useful in his studies, he's fine doing away with them because they're people no one will miss. He actually views them as heroes, sacrificing themselves for the greater good. His morals are deranged, but they're absolute, guiding his choices and actions. And when you know his code, while you don't agree with it, you at least understand what's driving him, and his actions make sense.

When you're planning your villain, don't assume that if they're evil they have no values. Explore their beliefs about right and wrong. Figure out their worldview and ideals. Specifically, see how the villain's beliefs differ from the protagonist's. This will show you the framework the villain is willing to work within, steer the conflict they generate, and will provide a stark contrast to the hero.

THEY HAVE A STORY GOAL, TOO

Like the hero, the villain has an overall objective, and they're willing to do anything within their moral code to achieve it. When their goal is diametrically opposed to the hero's, the two become enemies in a situation where only one can succeed.

We know Myrick's goal: to cure paralysis. And things are progressing nicely until an ER doctor in his hospital discovers homeless patients disappearing from the facility. Dr. Lathan starts nosing around, and when he realizes someone is up to no good, it becomes his mission to stop them. So the two are pitted against each other. If one succeeds, the other must fail. To quote *Highlander*: there can only be one.

As the author who has spirited the villain out of your own (dare we say *twisted*?) imagination, you need to know their goal. It should be as clear-cut

and obvious as the hero's objective. Does it put them in opposition to the protagonist? Ideally, both characters' goals should block each other from getting what they want and need.

THAT GOAL IS DRIVEN BY HIGH STAKES

Whatever your hero's objective is, there is something vital at stake. If Harry Potter doesn't defeat Voldemort, the world will be plunged into a living nightmare worse than the first time He Who Must Not Be Named came into power. Jean Valjean must become a better man and hide his criminal past if he's to make a life for himself and his child.

The villain's goal should involve equally high stakes. Voldemort needs to kill Harry to neutralize the prophecy so he can regain the power he once had. Javert must capture Jean Valjean and return him to prison because doing so supports Javert's prejudicial ideals; if a criminal like Valjean can redeem himself and escape justice, then everything Javert believes and has built his life on is a lie. If Dr. Myrick fails, people will have to live with the difficulties and indignities of paralysis forever.

Know your villain's objective, but also know what's at stake should they fail. Make that clear to readers so they'll understand why this villain is driven to do what they do.

VILLAINS ARE WELL-ROUNDED

Because villains are typically evil, it's easy to fill them up with flaws and forget the positive traits. But good guys aren't all good and bad guys aren't all bad, and characters written this way have as much substance as the flimsy cardboard they're made of. Myrick is cruel, unfeeling, and devious. But he's also intelligent, generous, and absolutely dedicated to curing a devastating malady that afflicts the lives of many.

Positive traits add authenticity for the villain while making them intimidating and harder to defeat. An added bonus is when their strength counters the hero's.

The villain of *Watership Down* is General Woundwort, a nasty rabbit whose positive attributes are brute strength and sheer force of will, making him more man than animal. In contrast, hero Hazel embodies what it means to be a rabbit. He's swift and clever. He knows who he is and embraces what makes him *him*. In the end, Hazel and his rabbits overcome a seemingly undefeatable enemy by being true to their nature.

When your villain is conceived and begins to grow in the amniotic fluid of your imagination, be sure to give him some positive traits along with the negative ones. Not only will you make him an enemy worthy of your hero, he'll also be one readers will remember.

THEY HAVE A BACKSTORY (AND YOU KNOW WHAT IT IS)

One of the biggest mistakes authors make with their villains is not giving them their own origin story. A character who is evil with no real reason behind their actions or motivations isn't realistic, making them stereotypical and a bit...meh.

To avoid this trap, know your villain's beginnings. Why are they the way they are? What trauma, genetics, or negative influencers have molded them into their current state? Why are they pursuing their goal—what basic human need is lacking that achieving the goal will satisfy? The planning and research for this kind of character is significant, but it will pay off in the form of a memorable and one-of-a-kind villain who will give your hero a run for his money and intrigue readers.

VILLAINS ARE FORMIDABLE

The story is often about the protagonist's journey, we know, but it's also about the protagonist defeating a dangerous enemy. One reason many stories fall flat is that the villain isn't strong enough. If the hero can easily defeat their nemesis, is that story-worthy? Are they really a hero? Are they worthy of the reader's time, adoration, and support?

No, no, and no. For your protagonist to become a hero, they must overcome insurmountable odds.

Make this happen by giving your villain strengths the hero lacks. Provide them with allies and resources the protagonist would kill for. Their drive to win needs to be impressive and terrifying, making them persistent, relentless, and willing to do just about anything to get what they want. And their goal itself should be a huge threat; just the idea of the villain having a chance of getting what they want should scare the potpourri out of your protagonist.

And speaking of fear, don't underestimate its potency. The ability to inspire fear in their underlings, victims, the hero, and even readers is the key to your villain's power. So figure out what makes them intimidating, unnerving, disturbing, or downright scary, and play that up.

THEY SHARE A CONNECTION WITH THE PROTAGONIST

In real life, we have many adversaries. Some of them are distant—the offensive driver on the highway or that self-serving, flip-flopping politician you foolishly voted for. Those adversaries can create problems for us, but the ones that do the most damage—the ones we find hardest to confront—are those we share a connection with. Parents, siblings, exes, neighbors we see every day, competitors we both admire and envy, people we don't like who are similar to us in some way...conflicts with these people are complicated because of the emotions they stir up.

The same is true for our protagonists. The most meaningful clashes will be with the people they know. Use this to your advantage. Bring the villain in close and make things personal by engineering a connection between them and the protagonist. Here are a few options for you to work with.

Give Them a Shared History. The more history the two have, the more emotion will be involved. Guilt, rage, grief, fear, jealousy, regret, desire—strong feelings like these will add sparks to their interactions. They'll cloud the protagonist's judgment and increase the chances their villain will gain an edge.

Make Them Reflections of Each Other. What happens when the protagonist sees him or herself in the villain? A seed of empathy forms. The hero feels a connection with the person they have to destroy, which complicates things immensely. Personality traits, flaws, vulnerabilities, wounding events, needs and desires—all of these (and more) can be used to forge a bond that will add complexity and depth to this important relationship.

Give Them a Shared Goal. When your hero and your villain are pursuing the same objective, it accomplishes a number of good things. First, it ensures that only one of them can be the victor, pitting them against each other. But they're also more likely to understand one another. They'll have different reasons and methods of chasing the dream, but the shared goal can create an emotional connection.

VILLAINS AREN'T NECESSARILY BEYOND REDEMPTION

So, this one isn't a requirement, but it's something to keep in mind because of the interest it garners for readers. Most villains are never going to change their ways. What's more, they're strong *because* they're so entrenched in their own goals and skewed morality. The fact that the hero can't turn the villain makes the enemy more daunting.

But a redeemable villain has an element of vulnerability; if they're going to do a one-eighty, they must recognize their failings and decide to change. Vulnerability is appealing to readers, as is the unpredictability that comes with a villain who could go either way. We also like the idea that people can change, that even the baddest of baddies can be redeemed, because it means anyone can be saved. Darth Vader, Walter White, Beauty's Beast—redeemed villains like these give us hope for ourselves and the world, so providing the possibility of redemption can be a good thing.

As you can see, a lot goes into creating an enemy that is realistic, properly worrisome, and worthy of holding the title of villain in your story. When you're drawing this character, give them the same thought and effort you'd put into your hero, and you'll end up with a villain that will enhance your story, intrigue readers, and give the hero a run for their money.

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THE CLIMAX: THE PINNACLE OF STRUGGLE

Escalation is an important element of successful story structures. The beginning is usually quiet as key players are introduced, the setting is established, and readers are given a glimpse of what's wrong in the protagonist's world. The catalyst then provides a choice, where the heroine leaves her ordinary world and steps into a new one. In the next half of the story, she works her way toward the goal that will fulfill her, facing many conflict scenarios that challenge her methods and way of thinking. In those story moments, the stakes get higher, the consequences more drastic, and the clashes more incendiary until everything culminates in a final confrontation that will determine if she achieves the goal or not.

This is the climax of the story. The reader has known from the beginning that this battle would occur; it's what they've been looking forward to, why they've stuck with it for so many pages. A successful climax will help determine how satisfied the reader is with the story, so it's vital that we get it right.

WHAT IS THE CLIMAX?

The climax is the final showdown between the heroine and her nemesis. They may have clashed already in the story—multiple times, possibly—or it might be the long-awaited confrontation the story's been building toward. Different story structure models place this pillar at various places, but it's generally agreed that it works best in the last half of Act Three. This allows for the proper build-up to the climax while leaving enough time for events to resolve afterward.

The purpose of the climax is to give the heroine a final chance to succeed and achieve her goal. Numerous conflict scenarios have tested her resolve and abilities so far. She hasn't always succeeded, but as the struggles have gotten bigger and the stakes have grown, she has moved steadily toward her outer (and inner, if she's working a change arc) goals.

And now comes the biggest test of all: the final meet-up with her nemesis. It's her last chance to prove herself. If she fails here, she fails for good. As a result, the climax should definitively determine who wins.

It also allows the heroine to display what she has learned on her journey. Whether she's acquired skills, identified a strength she thought was a weakness, rejected a long-believed lie, or adopted a new mindset, what she's learned should tip the scales in her favor during the climax. This is often where the inner and outer journeys merge, because the changes she's undergone and the lessons she has learned about herself are exactly what she needs to achieve the outer goal. When it's done artfully, that synchronicity creates a satisfying resolution for readers as the pieces click into place.

Lastly, the climax should mirror the catalyst. As Michael Hauge says in *Writing Screenplays That Sell*:¹

Just as the aftermath contrasts with the setup at the beginning of a screenplay, the climax of the story mirrors the opportunity (catalyst). While the opportunity *begins* the forward movement of the story—begins the hero's visible journey by taking him to a new situation—the climax *ends* that journey by resolving the hero's outer motivation (story goal).

In a story with a three-act structure, there's an invisible hinge at the midpoint that divides the story into two halves. James Scott Bell likens the midpoint to a mirror because the events on one side reflect the other. In this way, the climax relates back to the beginning, closing out the journey that began in your first pages.

So, to recap, the elements of a successful climax are as follows:

1. It's the final showdown between the heroine and the antagonist in which there is a definitive winner.
2. It mirrors the catalyst (opportunity).
3. The heroine uses what she's learned.
4. The victor (whomever it may be) achieves their goal.

To illustrate, here are a few popular climax scenes and what they accomplish.

Gladiator: Maximus kills Commodus in the arena, thereby avenging his family and returning to them in the afterlife.

Cold Mountain: Ada, Inman, and Ruby defeat Teague and the Home Guard so the two women can live in peace and build a life for themselves at Black Cove farm.

Star Wars: A New Hope: Luke Skywalker uses his Jedi training to destroy the Death Star, crippling the Empire and sending the enemy (Darth Vader included) packing. Peace and safety are restored to the galaxy.

There are many ways to craft this important scene—as many methods as there are writers. But keeping the elements of a successful climax in mind will enable you to write one that will satisfy most readers. Of course, there are always exceptions—stories that don't quite follow the rules or do so unexpectedly.

QUIET CLIMAXES

We tend to think of the climax as a gargantuan clash or noisy confrontation. And this is often true in thrillers, sports stories, and courtroom dramas. But an epic battle isn't always needed to round things out. The climax of *Pride and Prejudice*, for example, happens with Lizzy and Mr. Darcy going for a simple walk. They don't even argue at this point. Instead, they admit their past failings, express their love for each other, and decide to get married.

It's a quiet climax that still achieves its purpose. It is their final confrontation as antagonists and happens at the right point in the third act. Lizzy's recognition of pride as her fatal flaw allows her to overcome it and find true happiness with Mr. Darcy. And her choosing him for a husband mirrors the catalyst—her determination when she first met him to have nothing to do with him.

The climax of many romance plotlines is simply when the couple finally stop fighting and get together. It might happen through a conversation, an embrace, or a kiss. It might involve the character's race to catch their love interest before they leave forever, culminating in a shared, meaningful glance when they find each other. Of course, it can be a monumental moment, such as a fight that resolves with the two becoming a

couple or, well, the truest romantic sense of the word *climax*. But very often, this event is quiet. And that's fine, as long as it achieves its purpose.

THE HERO WINS BUT DOESN'T ACHIEVE THEIR GOAL

It's always interesting to see a story where the character defeats her nemesis but fails to get what she wanted. This bittersweet climax provides complexity for readers as they experience multiple emotions and must mull over the final events to sort out their feelings.

But how does this work? What does it mean if the heroine beats the antagonist but doesn't achieve her goal during the climax scene? Most of the time, it means that her goal was a false one, with the character realizing her objective wasn't what she actually needed or wanted.

The protagonist of *While You Were Sleeping* is Lucy, a lonely young woman who is disappointed with her life and longs for a family. Through a wacky series of events, she finds herself engaged to Peter, a man she has long admired from afar. As she gets to know his family and slowly falls in love with them, she sees her engagement as a way to achieve her goal—until she meets his brother. Over time, her feelings shift for both men, but she takes no action because Peter is her ticket to a better life. It isn't until the wedding ceremony that she rejects her original goal and announces her love for Jack, laying claim to her new, rightful objective.

In a storyline with a false goal, a moment of revelation is required to set everything straight. In Lucy's case, it happens during the climax, and her story goal isn't achieved until the denouement, when she and Jack get engaged.

In many cases, the character's realization happens earlier in the story; at that point, the character shifts the focus of their goal, and things continue toward the climax as usual. Elle Woods' (*Legally Blonde*) objective is to win her ex-fiancé back by getting into Harvard and becoming a lawyer. But when she realizes in Act Two that she'll never live up to Warner's pretentious standards, she stops pursuing him and devotes all her attention to navigating law school and winning an important court case.

Despite the time spent pursuing a false goal, both of these heroines end up getting what they want. But for other characters, the result isn't so neat and tidy. Sometimes, the character decides on a new objective without having time to start pursuing it, and the final scene shows them setting out on the path toward that goal. Other times, the character's realization is that

their pursuit is the wrong one, and they end the story not yet knowing what the right path is. Regardless, while the goal may not have been reached, the character will have discovered a particular truth about themselves and find peace. In this way, they achieve their inner goal, which will center them and give readers confidence that the character is going to figure things out and be okay.

STORIES WITH AN ANTAGONISTIC FORCE

While character vs. character conflicts are the most common, many stories feature a protagonist who is pitted against an antagonistic force. In scenarios where a character is fighting society or technology, nature, the supernatural, or even him or herself, the enemy doesn't always take a human form: Jo March vs. change and growing up (*Little Women*); John Nash vs. his schizophrenia (*A Beautiful Mind*); Oskar Schindler vs. the Nazis (*Schindler's List*). So how do you write a climax scene where the character is fighting an intangible?

The solution is to provide a physical antagonist for the hero to fight who represents the enemy. John Nash spends much of his story mentally and verbally fighting with Parcher, Charles, and Marcee—the personalities other people can't see but are real to him. Because Schindler can't take on the entire German army, Amon Goeth becomes the face of the Nazis and the one he battles.

If you're writing a story without a tangible antagonist, appoint a nemesis—an underling or someone else who represents the idea of the enemy. They become the person the hero will confront, clash with, and eventually overcome.

This can also work if you're writing a series where the hero and the overarching antagonist won't duke it out until the final installment. Introduce a lesser antagonist in each book who will serve as a sparring partner and someone for the hero to confront in the climax.

WHAT ABOUT SUBPLOT CLIMAXES?

Each subplot has a beginning, middle, and end structure like the main plotline, but on a smaller scale, with less airtime. This means that each subplot needs its own (smaller) climax. When should that important mini-event occur?

Let's see how it's done in *The Silence of the Lambs*.

Main Plot: Clarice Starling seeks to overcome her past by becoming an exceptional FBI agent.

Subplot #1: Hannibal Lecter wants to be free.

Subplot #2: Buffalo Bill wants to live with a new identity.

The climax of the story has to focus on the resolution of the main conflict, so it's usually best for your subplot's climax to happen separately. In *The Silence of the Lambs*, the climax of the main plotline is the in-the-dark basement fight between Clarice and Buffalo Bill, where she kills him and succeeds in her goal of becoming a top-notch agent. The climax for Lecter's subplot occurs prior to this scene, with a bloody and unsettling massacre that ends with a victorious Lecter going free.

It's possible, though, for the story climax to simultaneously resolve the main conflict and a subplot, negating the need for two separate scenes. We see this when Clarice kills Buffalo Bill; she snuffs out his ability to live in his new identity while catapulting herself to exceptionality, and both plotlines are settled in one climactic moment.

Hopefully you've got a handle now on what the climax is and what it should accomplish. As the last big moment of your character's story, it's a memorable one, so it's vital that you make it as strong and compelling as possible. To help you accomplish this, let's discuss not only what to do, but what to avoid. You can also reference [Appendix B](#), which contains a handy checklist of common problems in the climax and how to address them.

RESOLVING TOO SOON

This important moment is what readers have been waiting for. They've seen this showdown coming since the antagonist first came on the scene, and they want it to be everything they've imagined. A climax that wraps up too quickly will rob them of the satisfaction they're looking for, they won't thank you for it.

If you're concerned this scene might be resolving too quickly, ask beta readers or critique partners for their thoughts on this, and see what feedback you get. If it needs to be fleshed out, try removing an advantage, inflicting an injury, or introducing information that emotionally devastates the protagonist. In essence, make things worse for them and better for the antagonist. If the hero has to work harder for their win, the confrontation

will last longer and provide more satisfaction for readers when success is achieved.

THE SCENE THAT NEVER ENDS

Hear that sound? The sound of pages impatiently being flipped? That's what you get when the climax scene seems to last forever. It's easy as the author to get nostalgic at this point because the reader isn't the only one who's been looking forward to this moment. It's the last big step in your beloved character's evolution, and you want to make it everything it should be. And this is fine, as long as the length of the scene doesn't kill the pace and leave your readers disappointed.

The best way to ensure the climax is the right length is to do what you're hopefully doing with every other scene: plan it out carefully. Decide what needs to be said, what needs to happen and in what order, and get writing. And again, let beta feedback inform you about potential trouble in this area. If advance readers complain that your epic battle scene is dragging, crank up your chainsaw and start trimming. Cut out any play-by-play, unnecessary conflict, excessive introspection, and other filler, leaving only what's necessary to fulfill the scene's purpose while keeping up the pace and tension.

IT'S TOO PREDICTABLE

As the author, you know how the climax is going to end: the protagonist is going to either win or lose. And by this point in the story, readers will also have an idea about how things will turn out. But success or failure shouldn't be certain. Why? Because regardless of how dire the situation is, if the reader knows what's going to happen, there will be no tension. And this is something a satisfying climax should be chock full of.

The truth is, your character should have spent the majority of their story growing and changing into a hero who is a match for their foe. If they're navigating a change arc, they will have identified their fatal flaw and dealt with it appropriately. But they still have weaknesses and misgivings. Their fears may have been subdued but not eradicated. Keep the tension up and cast some doubt for readers by making sure those insecurities and weaknesses are evident as the hero marches into the final battle. Think about how the location can be used to benefit the antagonist, or what psychological warfare they can wage. You can also increase a protagonist's

vulnerability once the battle is underway in the form of a lost ally, a ticking clock, increased stakes, and so forth.

If success in the climax is a no-brainer, it's also possible that your antagonist is simply too weak. They should be imposing and menacing. Terrifying. While the protagonist has learned some things along the way that have made them stronger, those advantages should bring them up to the antagonist's level (rather than eclipsing it completely). If your hero can waltz into the climax and easily dispatch their enemy, then the enemy is likely the problem and needs reworking.

AN AMBIGUOUS OUTCOME

Remember one of the requirements of a successful climax: the protagonist emerges as the winner or loser. If it's not clear who won, this scene hasn't served its purpose. The same is true if the climax ends and readers aren't sure if the protagonist achieved their story objective. It's imperative that these two things are clear, so don't fall short in this area.

IT'S NOT SIGNIFICANT ENOUGH

One definition of the word *climax* is "the highest point." That is true in a literary context because the conflicts, setbacks, and confrontations have been escalating throughout the story, leading to this pinnacle moment. The climax *has* to be more significant than any other confrontation in the story.

Now, this doesn't mean it's the most explosive. Lizzy and Mr. Darcy's moment of confessing their love and declaring their desire to marry isn't as combative as many of their former interactions, but it is the most powerful because of its significance. Had the two stated that they kind of liked each other and might consider getting together, it wouldn't have worked. But Austen pulled out all the stops to make it the most meaningful scene in the story.

DEUS EX MACHINA

In our zeal to make things difficult for our heroes, it's easy to unintentionally paint them into a corner with no way out. And when they can't save themselves, we may be tempted to employ the ol' **deus ex machina** plot device: the arrival of a powerful someone or something from an unexpected quarter. A time machine, giant eagles, a freak weather phenomenon, or God himself can certainly get the job done, but in doing so,

they rob the character of his agency. Readers don't want to root for a slacker protagonist who can't clean up his own mess. Give them what they want, and resist the temptation to rescue your hero in the climax.

¹ Hauge, M. (2011). Structure. In *Writing Screenplays That Sell: The Complete Guide to Turning Story Concepts into Movie and Television Deals* (pp. 109). HarperCollins.

RESOLVING RELATIONSHIP CONFLICT: NOT SO FAST

Human beings are notoriously uncomfortable with conflict. We go to great strides to avoid it, and when we must face it, our discomfort will often push us to resolve it quickly so we can move on. Your character might prefer to work this way, but while they're (probably) not trying to ruin your story, allowing them to leap past conflict too quickly will accomplish just that.

KEEPING CONFLICT UNRESOLVED

We've discussed the importance of maintaining tension throughout the story and how conflict keeps that fun train rolling. One of the quickest ways to kill the tension is to have your characters deal with their people problems directly and effectively. Not that they shouldn't try ... it's just best for the story if they fail. When your character is being annoyingly mature and facing their issues with others before you want them to, here are a few ways to disrupt their progress.

Misunderstandings

How many times have you gotten to the other side of a problem with a friend or loved one before realizing that a simple misunderstanding was to blame? And how much easier would it have been if both parties had been concise and clear to begin with? Misunderstandings and imprecise communication are the cause of a lot of conflict. So if your character attempts to work through an issue with an opponent, manufacture a misunderstanding. Ambiguous language could result in one person interpreting the meaning of something differently than it was intended, and assumptions can take your character down the wrong track.

Unwillingness to Accept Responsibility

When conflict arises, a character will often focus on how it impacted them and how they were wronged. But each party will typically bear some

responsibility for the situation. Even when one person carries more guilt than the other, for a breach to be mended, both parties need to take a breath and acknowledge how they could have responded differently, been more considerate, or tried harder. If either person is unwilling to go that far, peace talks can stall.

Confronting While Emotional

We've all been in this situation: we know there's a problem and we have to do something about it, but we're hurt, or confused, or just pissed off. Instead of waiting for our emotions to settle, we confront the offender in the middle of those feelings, and it doesn't go well.

When your character initiates a conversation, craft the exchange in a way that inflames the hurt feelings. Have them react impulsively and make things worse, thereby creating the need for another difficult confrontation to deal with the new conflict.

A New Issue Cropping Up

Perhaps your characters are doing everything right to fix their issue. They're being clear in their communication, have analyzed and admitted responsibility for the part they played, and have set aside their own emotions. Things are going swimmingly—until something happens that creates a new issue.

This is done beautifully in a scene from *A Few Good Men*. Daniel Kaffee and his legal team go to Guantanamo Bay to meet with some high-level, high-ego officers. These are powerful men who aren't happy with the case, but their cooperation is vital, so Kaffee needs to smooth things over. Lunch goes well and Kaffee's getting ready to leave when he asks Colonel Jessup for a document Jessup doesn't want to provide. And it all hits the fan. They're right back to where they started.

One benefit of this technique is that it allows your character to *almost* defuse the original conflict. The tension, which was high, starts shifting downward, and then—bam! It's elevated again. Give your character a win, then hit them from an unexpected quarter to heighten the stress and keep readers guessing.

Personality Conflicts

People are unique, with their own styles of communicating, behaving, and interacting. But not all personalities get along. One person's teasing to lighten the mood might cause another's prickly nature to emerge, or a reserved character's quiet response may come across as passive or uncooperative. When opposites don't attract, they're likely to rub each other wrong—which may be where the conflict began in the first place.

No Common Ground

Sometimes characters join forces to solve a problem only to find they're so far apart in their ideas or methods that they can't work together. Imagine two characters looking to shake things up in the kingdom because a segment of society is being mistreated and no one seems to care. At first, the enthusiasm and mutual desire for change align them—until the question of “how” comes up. The protagonist may want to gather like-minded people and appeal to the king. But the other person scoffs and declares that it's time to sharpen swords and lead a revolt. When the values and ideals of the involved parties are too far apart, a shared goal may not be enough for them to overcome their differences.

Biases and Personal History

The more history your character has with the other person, the more complicated the situation will get. They have this recent snag to work through, but past experiences and their own feelings about that person will cloud the issue.

Encourage this scenario by setting the stage for readers. Make them aware of a significant blow-up in the past or that conflict with this person is an ongoing thing. Use your character's internal dialogue to show their judgment or bias about this person. Then, when the two run into each other and attempt to make up, their preconceptions and past history will tank the effort before it gets off the ground.

Half-Hearted Attempts

A realistic response to conflict is the half-hearted one because, honestly, characters don't always want to fix things. Maybe they're being manipulated or bullied into reconciliation by a third party, or they have another reason not to fully commit to a resolution. In these situations, they'll make a

perfunctory attempt that's sure to fail—prolonging the tension but also providing a confrontation that will generate added conflict.

Avoidance

When it comes to dragging out conflict, we've saved the most obvious and realistic technique for last. Most people hate confrontation and seek ways to avoid it. And we know what happens when problems aren't dealt with: they fester, and complications multiply, making things even harder to fix.

The act of avoidance itself can generate conflict as the character goes to great lengths to keep from facing the issue. This technique gets high points for both authenticity and its tendency to create more problems, so if avoidance fits your character's personality, be sure to take advantage of it.

RESOLVING CONFLICT TEMPORARILY

Another way to delay a reconciliation is to only let your protagonist partially resolve the problem. It hasn't been solved, just put off for another day. In the meantime, bad feelings are growing, people are taking sides, and objectives are stagnating. All of this is good for your story, so if your character is likely to procrastinate, consider a course of action that will allow him to do that.

Be the Comic Relief

Humor is effective in soothing minor tensions and bringing people together. This makes it a natural go-to response for a character seeking to end an uncomfortable moment—especially if humor and charm have served them well in the past. But it's a short-term solution, because while it might encourage the other party to dismiss the friction temporarily, the problem is still there and will have to be dealt with eventually.

Play for Time

This strategy enables a character to request more time before agreeing to a sit-down. In a legal drama, the protagonist would ask for a continuance or a brief recess so they can gather evidence or give a witness time to arrive. In other stories, the character will seek a postponement, either to try and fix the situation on their own or put off an uncomfortable conversation.

This strategy keeps the conflict going while also adding another tension-building element: a ticking clock. The showdown is still coming, but now a deadline has been set. If the character is flying by the seat of their

pants, the pressure will be on and they'll have to come up with a plan before things go from bad to worse.

Create a Distraction

A staple of thrillers and action stories, distractions are very effective at turning attention away from the hero to a more immediate threat, thereby buying some much-needed time.

In season three of *Breaking Bad*, Walter White is (again) on the ropes—this time, with his DEA brother-in-law getting close to discovering Walt in a compromising situation. So Walt arranges a phone call from someone claiming to be a hospital employee who tells Hank that his wife has been in a terrible accident. Hank tears off, sirens blazing, allowing Walt to escape and put off their confrontation for another day.

Distractions come in all shapes and sizes. It may be a situation manufactured by the hero or a naturally occurring event they use to their benefit. Either way, if it's credible, it will keep the tension alive.

Lie, Lie, and Lie Some More

When in doubt, a character can always fib their way out of a situation. Maybe they cut a corner, gambled away the office's petty cash, or spilled a friend's secret. Rather than own up to it and face the consequences, they'll lie. The other person will be mollified—maybe even taking the blame themselves—and everything is fine for a while. But when the web of lies unravels, conflict will return with a vengeance, dropping the character into a pot of trouble.

CHARACTER AGENCY: PUT YOUR HERO IN THE DRIVER'S SEAT

Consider, if you will, a story about a woman who wants to gain esteem by winning an important legal case. Things are going along fine until she gets fired from the firm for her unusual fact-finding practices. She ends up being forgiven and rehired, but then her babysitter bails, leaving her with no one to watch her kids. Then, at a critical point in the case, she gets so sick, she's unable to keep working.

It could be an interesting plotline. Obstacles are blocking her from her goal, which is a good thing. But it falls flat because the character isn't driving the story; the events are. Instead of making things happen, she's just reacting to what is thrown at her. She doesn't seem to have any control over her destiny.

But look what happens when we put her in charge:

To make ends meet, Erin pesters a local lawyer to hire her as a secretary. In the scope of her work, she discovers information in a seemingly innocuous file that doesn't make sense. She secures permission to do a little digging, but there's a miscommunication with the boss, who doesn't expect her to spend a full week off-site doing research. He fires her, but soon realizes that her fact-gathering revealed a huge violation of human rights—something Erin discovered when she took the initiative to investigate. So she's reinstated. But then she loses her babysitter. This doesn't set her back for long because she quickly finds a replacement in the guy next door (taking a step toward an important romantic relationship in her story). The case progresses to a critical point, at which time, she falls deathly ill. But she soldiers on and goes to the office anyway, where she learns that decisions about her case have been made expressly behind her back.

Both summaries tell Erin Brockovich's story, but the second one puts her behind the wheel. Each time she's hit with a problem or roadblock, she

makes a choice or acts in a way that pushes the story forward and inches her closer to her goal. This is the essence of character agency.

It's not a simple element to define, but at its most basic, **character agency** is the character driving story events through choices. When conflict happens, she doesn't just respond; she takes action. She chooses, and by doing so, determines what comes next.

Agency is important because, without it, it's not really the character's story. She may be in it, but if she's not making things happen, accelerating events, and actively working toward her goal, what's the point? If nothing the character does changes the outcome of the story, why is she in it?

There's an ongoing internet argument about Indiana Jones and character agency. The theory is that the climax of *Raiders of the Lost Ark* and the subsequent disappearance of the religious artifact would have happened whether Indy was there or not. None of his decisions impacted the plotline whatsoever; he made lots of choices, but in the grand scheme, none of them mattered.

We mean no disrespect here. This is an incredible movie with one of the most memorable and iconic heroes of the last century. But there's a reason you don't see many successful tales about protagonists with no character agency; most of the time, they just don't resonate with readers because the character is a bystander in their own story. It's not compelling or inspirational. So unless you've come up with the next *Raiders* or *Hunger Games*, you must put your protagonist in the driver's seat so they can navigate the roadblocks and turns in a way that will get them to the finish line.

How do we do that, exactly?

USE CHOICES

In the first volume of *The Conflict Thesaurus*, we discussed the 3C cycle of conflict, choices, and consequences. In a nutshell, when conflict is introduced for a character, a choice must be made, and consequences will follow. This cycle is repeated many times throughout a story. Sometimes the character makes a choice that propels them toward their goal. Other times, their decision pulls them in the wrong direction. Either way, they have a say in what's happening to them.

The conflict scenarios you introduce, and the choices that stem from them, are key to giving your character agency in their story. Plan with this

in mind and use conflict with purpose to encourage (or discourage) decisions that will get the character where they need to go.

INCLUDE A GOAL IN EVERY SCENE

Change doesn't happen overnight. Success for your protagonist consists of many baby steps that get them to that final objective. This is why a story has scenes, and every scene needs a goal of its own.

Let's say your protagonist is a cop with questionable methods whose overall objective is to rescue someone from a captor. At the start, he won't know much, but every scene will include a goal that will get him closer to finding the captive. The objective of one scene might be to speak to the neighbor who last saw the victim. Another goal could be to interview a key suspect. He might need to win over a supervisor who doesn't think he can handle the case.

If your character lacks agency, it could be because your scene-level goals aren't defined enough; if he doesn't know what he's working toward, then his choices won't matter. He might make decisions, but they're going to be all over the map because he lacks direction. And a protagonist who wanders aimlessly doesn't have agency. So know your character's goal in each scene.

EVERY SCENE NEEDS CONFLICT

Once you know your character's scene goal and you're sure it belongs on the roadmap to their overall objective, add conflict that makes it harder for them to get there. Conflict makes things interesting, yes, but it also requires a response.

In our scene where the cop needs to interview a suspect, maybe the guy asks for a lawyer, which will make it difficult to get answers. How does the protagonist react—does he try to convince the suspect that he doesn't need legal representation? Use force to coerce him? Bug the guy's briefcase so he can get the information (illegally) without an interview?

Every scene needs conflict because it provides opportunities for the character to go one direction or another. The decision to use physical force or blackmail could get the cop his answers, but if he's trying to turn over a new leaf and act ethically, it could push him farther from that internal objective—something he'll have to address in later scenes. However he responds, he's choosing, and those choices will help determine his fate.

YOUR CHARACTER MUST DO THE CHOOSING

Conflict alone won't give your character agency. If the events in their life don't give them a choice—if they are forced to adopt a certain way of thinking or comply to a course of action—then someone else is running the show. If our cop is essentially a puppet who was given the case because it's political and his supervisors want things to go a certain way, they will be dictating his actions. Whatever conflict comes along will already be decided because he's going to do what his boss says. “Yes” men and followers don't typically make the best protagonists, so create a way for a pinned-down character to resist and go rogue.

You can get the same problem in stories with supernatural elements. Monsters, magic-wielders, demigods, and the like will have an edge over mere mortals. Or consider Mother Nature—how can the protagonist overpower an earthquake or tsunami? They can't.

Basically, any antagonist with an inordinate amount of power or leverage has the potential to steal your character's agency. Keep that in mind and find ways to make your protagonist the decision-maker.

A good example of this is found in the first *Lord of the Rings* book. On their trip to destroy Sauron's ring, the fellowship has to get over a mountain. But Saruman sends a supernatural storm that makes it impossible for them to cross. Instead of shrugging their shoulders and plodding back down to safe ground, they call a meeting in the middle of the blizzard. Caradhras is a no-go, so what route will they take next? Only after Frodo has made the decision to go through Moria do they leave the mountain.

This could easily have been a situation where the characters allowed story events to displace them and move them around. But Tolkien didn't let that happen. He gave them the opportunity to choose. That choice had consequences, as we see in later chapters, but it also allowed the characters to set their own course.

USE YOUR STORY'S THEME

Most stories have a theme—an idea the protagonist is wrestling with. Conflict scenarios that touch on that theme can put your character in the driver's seat because he'll have to think carefully about the options.

The movie *Wall Street* does a great job of this through its exploration of greed. Is greed good, as fledgling stockbroker and wannabe mogul Bud

Fox is told? Or is it bad, with the power to utterly corrupt? The screenplay writers allow Bud to figure this out by introducing scenarios and choices where greed plays a part. Can he break the law to gain information that will benefit him? Is it ok to share insider information with the boss he idolizes and trusts? Does he have any responsibility for what Gordon Gekko does with that information?

Using your theme to craft conflict and choice scenarios keeps the decisions personal because they touch on something the character is already sensitive about. Questions will be raised that make him think—questions with a moral or ethical basis that will determine who the character is deep down. As such, he can't afford to let others make those decisions for him—at least, not for long.

MAKE SURE YOUR CHARACTER IS FULLY FORMED

One of the benefits of character agency is that it allows your reader to get to know your protagonist. With every decision he makes, the reader sees his values, fears, goals, and motivations. Through his reactions, they learn about his personality and emotional range. The more intimately the reader knows your character, the stronger the bond will be and the more they'll want to see the character succeed.

But it only works if the character is consistent. He may have all the agency in the world, but if his decisions are sporadic or random, he's not going to get where he wants to go, and readers won't connect with him. This is another reason it's so vital that you know your character inside and out. Character building can be tough, but the hard work pays off when you end up with a protagonist whose choices and actions propel them forward and endear them to readers.

COMMON CONFLICT CONUNDRUMS

As we wind down our study of conflict, it's a good idea to discuss the problems authors often run into with this storytelling element. Some of these have been covered in depth already, so let this serve as a checklist for avoiding common pitfalls.

HO-HUM CONFLICT

Is your conflict falling flat? Unrealistic or boring? Not resonating with readers? Consider these common causes.

No Stakes or Low Stakes. If each conflict scenario includes choices that will drive the character toward (or farther from) their story goal, we have to motivate the protagonist to make the right decision. We do this through stakes—a cost incurred if they don't navigate the scenario successfully. But it's easy to set the bar too low. When the stakes aren't high enough, don't impact the character, or are absent altogether, the protagonist won't be motivated to move forward, rendering the conflict meaningless. Avoid this issue by making sure something is at risk that the protagonist cares about.

Contrived Conflict. We can easily fall into this trap by thinking that exciting conflict scenarios will make the story cooler and better. But the circumstances may not call for an unexpected pregnancy, a fistfight, or a terrorist attack. And if you include one, it's going to feel forced because it doesn't fit. Only add conflict scenarios that make sense and dovetail into the overall conflict thread. If a big moment does need to happen, set it up properly so it doesn't come out of nowhere and startle readers.

CONFLICT-INDUCED PACING ISSUES

Is your story dragging and putting readers to sleep? There are many causes for pacing issues, and misused conflict just might be the culprit.

Too Much Conflict. We all love (fictional) conflict, and as the authors yanking the puppet strings, the conflict doesn't hurt *us*, right? Wrong. There

is such a thing as too much conflict, and it can lead to episodic writing—a series of scenarios that don't necessarily lead one to the other. The result is a story that wanders hither and yon instead of heading in a definitive direction. It also overloads readers, who become exhausted by the nonstop tension and constant highs. Give them a break by choosing only conflict scenarios that will serve the central conflict or subplots. This litmus test will help you weed out unnecessary events that are muddling your story and burning out readers.

Navel-Gazing. On the flip side, you can also have an excess of introspection, with the protagonist spending too much time thinking. Maybe their internal reflection is about important things: problems they're facing, decisions to make, or figuring out what they want. But when your character is thinking, they're not doing. Thinking is passive, and too much of it will kill the story's pace.

This is another area where it's important to get the proportion right. There is no textbook answer for how much introspection is necessary but try shooting for an 80/20 balance: 80% action, 20% thinking. Carefully examine passages where the character is spending a lot of time in their own head, and trim as needed.

Another tip for solving this problem is to give your characters something to do during reflective moments. Instead of having them ponder life as they're lying in bed, sitting at a table, or staring out a window, get them moving. It doesn't have to be anything monumental; they can just as easily think as they're walking into work or sweeping up the kids' breakfast mess. Everyday tasks like these will put the character in motion and make an introspective scene more active, giving it a less passive feel for readers.

MELODRAMA

Soap operas are known for being big on drama. Affairs, murders, betrayals, amnesiacs. A dead person showing up very much alive, with a love child. Melodrama works in soap operas because it's part of the genre. It's what the audience expects. But novels are a different animal. Readers want characters who feel realistic with stories they can relate to, and while some theatrics are good, too much over-the-top conflict will create unwanted melodrama.

The first step toward avoiding this trap is to make sure the conflicts you've chosen—particularly the sensational ones—fit your story. Have you picked a scenario because it's exciting or something you're personally interested in? Because it's "now" or current? For shock value? Remember that conflict should always serve the character or story: to test the protagonist's resolve or moral fiber, provide a chance to practice their skills, push them to make a decision that will take the story a certain direction, etc. If the big conflicts you've chosen don't support character development or the main plotline, it's time to revise those scenes.

If the conflict itself isn't the problem, the issue could be with your character's reactions to it. Big conflicts call for big responses, and some characters are more emotional and reactive than others—meaning, big responses from them will make sense. So, first and foremost, know your character to get a feel for their emotional range, and make sure their reactions fit their personality.

Then look at the progression of their feelings throughout the scene. Their emotional state shouldn't stay the same; what they feel at the beginning of a scene should modulate at some point to another emotion, from happiness toward shock, frustration toward excitement, anger toward resignation, etc. This keeps the pace moving because change is happening, and highs and lows are being navigated.

But when genius burns and the words are flowing, it's easy to forget this. We get so caught up in writing the story events that we don't put enough effort into our characters' responses to them. The result is someone who doesn't respond to much of anything, then jumps to high emotion in the scene's climax. To avoid this, familiarize yourself with the normal continuum for human emotions. Irritation leads to frustration, to anger, and then to rage. Knowing how feelings naturally progress will help you write your character's reactions in a realistic manner and avoid the dreaded melodrama trap.

OVERCOMPLICATED PLOT

When it comes to layering conflict carefully and deliberately into a story, there's a lot to remember. In our zeal to get it right, it's easy to go overboard, throwing too much into the stew and ruining the whole meal. If your story feels muddled and crowded—if it's hard for you to keep track of the main conflict and subplots—you may have overcomplicated it. And if

you, as the author, can't keep it all straight, your readers won't have a chance. It's time to simplify.

First, take an honest and objective look at your subplots and remove any that do not support or relate to the main storyline. Those are taking up space and muddying the waters. This step alone will greatly reduce the unnecessary complication of your story.

Then, do the same thing with your scenes. Are any of them not pushing the character toward their overall goal or driving a subplot forward? If so, they're dead weight that should be cut or revised.

These checks are simple, but they're far from easy. Separating the filler from what's important is a challenge. And once you've identified the unnecessary bits, it's even more difficult to chop them out of your story. But the hardest work often produces the most satisfying results, so be ruthless in this process and don't be afraid to kill your darlings.

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FINAL WORDS FROM THE AUTHORS

Conflict wears many hats in your story. It aids in personal development by providing choices and consequences for your character, nudging them along the path to growth and evolution. It also is a foundational part of story structure, providing an ebb and flow of tension that undergirds and supports the whole thing.

As a result, it's important to choose conflict scenarios deliberately. Go with the ones that are the right intensity level for your overall story and for each scene. Ensure that only scenarios connected to the core conflict make the cut. And add variety by including different kinds of conflict to your scenes.

The categories in this book can narrow down your options to a short list of possibilities, making it easier for you to identify the perfect challenge for your scene or story. If you can't find what you're looking for, try the first volume of *The Conflict Thesaurus*. [A full list of the entries from that publication](#) can be found at the back of this book.

And leave room for the unexpected. What could happen in a scene that the hero doesn't see coming? An ally turning on them? A sudden handicap? A competitor arriving who is far more skilled than the protagonist? Weave those unanticipated surprises into your story to keep your character on their toes and readers on the edge of their seats.

While we'd love for this book and its companion to answer all your questions about conflict, that's just not possible, because the writing journey and its learning curve never end. So keep reading, asking questions, challenging yourself, and writing better and better stories. We're cheering you on!

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THE CONFLICT THESAURUS

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Loss of Control

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A BREAK-IN

EXAMPLES

- A residence being burglarized
- The character's vehicle being broken into
- The character's workplace being broken into
- A storage unit or outbuilding being burglarized

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

- Losing valuables
- Feeling unsafe and violated
- Repairing break-in damage (to a door, a window, a lockbox, etc.)
- Cleaning up any mess left behind (broken glass, smashed furniture, graffiti, etc.)
- Having to reevaluate and adjust security measures
- Filing a police report or filling out insurance forms
- Relocating until the site of the break-in is restored and secure
- Needing to purchase new items to replace stolen ones
- Children needing to be comforted
- Putting on a brave front with family members so they don't experience long-term worry or stress
- Dealing with well-meaning neighbors who weigh in on how this could have been avoided
- Difficulty sleeping

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

- Incurring a severe injury (if the character was present during the break-in)
- An irreplaceable or invaluable item being stolen
- Becoming so safety-obsessed that the character's (and their family's) ability to enjoy life is hindered
- Having to file for bankruptcy
- Losing a business
- Becoming targeted as a witness to the crime

Personal information being stolen that puts the character or their loved ones in danger

The thieves discovering a secret they leverage in the form of blackmail

The character learning they were specifically targeted (because of personal information the perpetrators wanted, as an act of vengeance, etc.) by someone who remains at large

Discovering evidence that a relative may have been responsible

A family member or roommate being killed

Killing the perpetrator in self-defense

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anxiety, Apprehension, Betrayed, Devastation, Disbelief, Disillusionment, Dread, Emasculated, Fear, Guilt, Hatred, Insecurity, Overwhelmed, Panic, Paranoia, Powerlessness, Regret, Reluctance, Resentment, Shock, Terror, Vengeful, Vulnerability, Worry

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Being unable to trust others

Feeling shame for choices that may have led to the break-in (hanging around criminals, owing money to the wrong sort of people, not fixing flimsy locks or broken latches, etc.)

Being unable to forgive someone for a lapse that made the break-in possible

Experiencing guilt for being away during the break-in

Struggling with post-traumatic stress

Being easily triggered so the memories continue to surface

Questioning whether they should have done more to make sure the building was secured

Knowing the perpetrator, and struggling with whether or not to press charges

Wanting unlawful justice or revenge

The character questioning whether their actions during the break-in could have been different

Irrational fear or paranoia that it will happen again

Making a choice during the break-in that results in someone's serious injury or death

Empathy for the perpetrator (because they were starving and needed food, were suffering from a mental health issue, etc.) warring with their own need

for justice or personal safety
Being told to move past it, but being unable to

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Compulsive, Confrontational, Extravagant, Forgetful, Gullible, Inattentive, Irresponsible, Macho, Materialistic, Melodramatic, Paranoid, Uncooperative, Vindictive, Violent, Volatile, Withdrawn, Worrywart

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: If the character's identity is tied to being a parent, leader, or protector, a break-in happening on their watch may cause them to question their fitness in this role.

Esteem and Recognition: A character who has been victimized may find their confidence shaken, especially if their actions contributed to the break-in or led to endangering their loved ones.

Love and Belonging: If the character knew the perpetrator, the shock of realizing they trusted the wrong person may cause them to doubt their ability to let the right people into their lives. This may prevent them from seeking out other meaningful relationships.

Safety and Security: Having their personal space violated will disrupt a character's level of security.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Cautious, Cooperative, Courageous, Independent, Just, Mature, Merciful, Meticulous, Objective, Observant, Patient, Proactive, Protective, Resourceful, Responsible, Sensible

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Becoming more situationally aware

Learning to plan for undesirable outcomes

The character using their experience to help others avoid the same thing happening to them

Transitioning to a safer residence or place of work

Supporting a loved one through a difficult time and growing closer to them through the experience

Gaining a healthier perspective about material things

Learning to receive care for trauma

The perpetrator being caught and brought to justice

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A FAMILY MEMBER DYING

EXAMPLES

Losing a family member to a serious injury or accident

A loved one committing suicide

A family member being murdered

A parent or sibling dying from natural causes

Losing a child to an illness or disease

A wife or sister dying in childbirth

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having to raise a child alone

Needing to arrange a funeral, cremation, or burial

Having to notify others of the loss

Incurring unexpected medical bills and debts

Having to handle the deceased person's obligations (properties, social security, insurance, etc.)

Discovering the deceased did not leave a will or trust

Arguing with loved ones over decisions

Needing to support others through the loss

Being hounded by the media (if the family member was well-known)

The character having to execute a will they don't agree with

Dealing with gossip, awkward conversations, and questions

The character discovering they were left out of the will

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Having to file for bankruptcy

Ignoring the genetic nature of the fatal disease or illness that took the family member

Being so mired in grief that the character is unable to help their children deal properly with the death

Being blamed by others for the loved one's death

Being found legally liable

Discovering devastating, life-changing information about the family member after their death

The character losing their spiritual moorings

Losing faith in an important establishment (the police force, the medical system, etc.)

Greedy relatives fighting over the deceased's assets

The relative being posthumously linked to a heinous crime, turning family members into pariahs

The death being ruled as suspicious (if the character was involved)

Turning to drugs, alcohol, or other self-destructive behaviors to cope with the loss

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anguish, Confusion, Denial, Depressed, Devastation, Disbelief, Doubt, Fear, Grief, Guilt, Loneliness, Overwhelmed, Powerlessness, Regret, Relief, Remorse, Self-Pity, Shame, Shock, Somberness, Surprise, Suspicion, Sympathy, Uncertainty

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Feeling unsure about what to tell others (children, sensitive family members, etc.)

Experiencing disbelief or refusing to accept the loss

Struggling with depression and grief

Resenting the deceased for leaving behind a difficult situation

Regret over what was said or not said

The character doubting their ability to handle the loss

The death bringing the character's own mortality into focus

Experiencing doubt or a crisis of faith, especially if the death seemed unfair or unjust

Struggling with self-blame for not doing more for the deceased

The character regretting their actions toward the deceased

Feeling shame for experiencing a sense of relief

Struggling to forgive someone who was involved

Knowing a difficult secret about the family member and being unsure if it should be shared or not

Feeling nothing for the person who passed, but having to hide it to keep up appearances

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Addictive, Antisocial, Controlling, Disorganized, Disrespectful, Greedy, Irresponsible, Jealous, Martyr, Melodramatic, Morbid, Needy, Pessimistic, Resentful, Self-Destructive, Superstitious, Suspicious

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: Those mired in grief or struggling with newfound responsibilities will have less time and energy for pursuing personal goals and passions, which may need to be shelved for a time.

Esteem and Recognition: A character who feels responsible for the loved one's death (whether they are or not) will question their own self-worth.

Love and Belonging: Losing a loved one when the character has very few people to count on can result in them being cast adrift with no support system.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Centered, Empathetic, Funny, Independent, Inspirational, Mature, Nurturing, Objective, Optimistic, Organized, Patient, Resourceful, Responsible, Spiritual, Supportive, Trusting, Unselfish

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Receiving support from friends, family, and members of the community

Accepting that death is part of life

The character becoming more independent and gaining confidence in their resiliency

Satisfaction arising from carrying out the deceased family member's wishes

The character reaffirming their faith or spiritual beliefs

A necessary change (a relocation, new relationship, job, etc.) turning into an advantage

Strengthening existing relationships

Seizing opportunities and loving more openly due to a newfound outlook on life

Embarking on a journey to raise awareness or funding so others won't suffer the same fate

Being responsible in some way and escaping culpability

Gaining a sense of closure (if there was difficult history between the character and their family member)

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A PARTNER RACKING UP DEBT

EXAMPLES

Taking out student loans

Maxing out a personal line of credit

Buying a rental property that turns into a money pit

Investing in a relative's business venture that goes under

The partner owing money to a loan shark

A spouse needing a lawyer to get out of legal trouble

A partner overextending their finances to prop up a failing business

A partner spending money they don't have to rescue an adult child from poor life choices

A partner charging expensive surgeries or treatments for his new dog to the family credit card

Having to remortgage a home to pay for the partner's stay at an addiction center

A partner being blackmailed for a personal lapse that could ruin the family name

Learning that a business partner has mismanaged company cashflow

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

A card being unexpectedly declined during a purchase

Embarrassment at being unable to complete a purchase

Arguments with a partner over their poor financial decisions

Having to call the bank to see how bad the situation really is

Going through past bills to look for other inconsistencies

Sleuthing online or in the filing cabinet to see if there are other hidden pockets of debt

Readjusting the budget

Cutting up credit cards

Canceling subscriptions and memberships to cut costs

Delaying a procedure, such as updating a prescription for glasses, because of the expense

Having to see a credit counselor to find a way out of the mess

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Being the last to know, which increases relationship friction and trust issues

A secondary betrayal that makes the debt worse—e.g., discovering the partner was catfished while having an online emotional affair

Illegal financial deals leading to legal troubles

Discovering that retirement savings or college funds have also been drained

The partner having an addiction (to drugs, gambling, risk, etc.) that must be addressed

The character's assets being repossessed

Having to sell a home and rent instead

The character having to change their plans for early retirement

A marriage falling apart

Being threatened by a loan shark

Having to go to family for a loan, compounding personal humiliation

Discovering that family members have already lent money and are part of the debt problem

Losing everything and having to start over

Shutting down a business and filing for bankruptcy

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Appalled, Betrayed, Bitterness, Confusion, Contempt, Devastation, Disbelief, Fear, Grief, Guilt, Humiliation, Hurt, Overwhelmed, Panic, Rage, Reluctance, Resentment, Resignation, Scorn, Self-Loathing, Self-Pity, Shame, Shock, Unappreciated, Vulnerability, Worry

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character replaying past conversations to see what they missed (self-blame)

Feeling humiliated

The character feeling like they don't know the person they're with

Wondering who knows about the situation and what they must think

Feeling like all the sacrifices and hard work to get to a place of stability were a waste

Directing anger inward for trusting so blindly and not being on top of things

Wanting to ask for help but not knowing who to go to

Wanting to go back in time and feeling weak for wanting this
Harboring resentment and being unsure if it will be possible to move past
this betrayal

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Addictive, Callous, Confrontational, Controlling, Disloyal, Disorganized,
Frivolous, Greedy, Hypocritical, Inflexible, Irresponsible, Judgmental,
Materialistic, Perfectionist, Self-Indulgent, Selfish, Spoiled, Vain, Violent

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: Financial instability will require the redistribution of all funds toward key survival needs. If the character's more meaningful goals require time and money, they may not be available until the situation can be resolved.

Esteem and Recognition: If the partner's debt problem becomes common knowledge, the character will feel judged, damaging their sense of esteem.

Love and Belonging: A hidden debt can destabilize even the strongest of relationships because it indicates a lack of trust between the two parties.

Safety and Security: A debt, especially one that takes time to clear, will strain the couple's funds and leave them financially vulnerable.

Physiological Needs: If the hole of debt is too deep to climb out of, the character could lose everything, including their home.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Ambitious, Cautious, Disciplined, Industrious, Loyal, Merciful, Optimistic, Organized, Persistent, Proactive, Thrifty, Unselfish

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Being able to cut back and get on top of the debt situation quickly

Seeking help for an addiction

A credit counselor helping to consolidate the debt into manageable payments

Receiving an inheritance that offsets most of what was owed

Changing habits and strengthening communication so the situation doesn't occur again

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A RECESSION OR ECONOMY CRASH

EXAMPLES

Tourism in a tourist-heavy region halting due to an unstable political environment or unsafe conditions, such as a natural disaster or local disease outbreak

A global pandemic causing a recession

A stock market crash devastating the investments of its country's citizens

Widespread war causing financial instability

A local workforce being decimated—such as a large car factory or fishing industry—putting many out of work and forcing them to move away to look for jobs

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Being out of work with limited job prospects

Having to learn new skills to adapt to a new job or life circumstance

Taking on a second job, leaving less time for family and personal interests

Frequent arguments with loved ones over the character's financial situation

Having to ask for a loan from a friend or family member

The supply chain of non-essential goods being interrupted, causing a shortage of luxuries such as electronics, popular toys, or other consumer goods

Reviewing the budget and cutting out things that can no longer be afforded (a child's singing lessons, a promised vacation, etc.)

Having to rely on friends or family to help the character through hard times

The character being forced to change their life plans or expectations for the future

The character fearing for the health or safety of themselves or their family

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

An extra expense coming at the worst possible time (a hospitalization, a car accident, etc.)

The character's home losing value to the point where they owe more to the bank on their mortgage than the property's market value

A shortage of essential goods, such as clean water, food, or fuel

Inflation rates outpacing the character's spendable income

Local businesses closing

The character experiencing bankruptcy when all of their savings are depleted

Becoming responsible for other family members who are even worse off

The character's business folding after years of work and sacrifice

Needing medicine or health care for a loved one and not being able to afford it

Public desperation leading to the character being mugged or robbed

The character's health declining

The changed circumstances and a sense of helplessness leading to depression

Being taken advantage of by those who benefit from the desperation of others (human traffickers, con artists, etc.)

The character contemplating taking their own life to escape the financial pressure

Widespread violence escalating to war

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anxiety, Apprehension, Bitterness, Concern, Desperation, Disbelief, Discouragement, Disillusionment, Fear, Indignation, Overwhelmed, Powerlessness, Resignation, Self-Pity, Shock, Uncertainty, Unease, Worry

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES (INNER CONFLICT)

The character struggling to accept that the world has changed

Dealing with feelings of shame (if a character can't provide for their family due to a job loss)

Becoming overwhelmed and struggling to cope with day-to-day responsibilities

Being tempted to participate in illegal activity or take a job that violates their moral code to improve their financial circumstances

The character having to hide feelings of powerlessness and hopelessness from others

Feeling guilty for focusing on their own situation when others have suffered more

Wanting to escape certain responsibility burdens and feeling cowardly for thinking that way

Resenting people whose connections, wealth, or luck have made the situation easier

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Addictive, Extravagant, Frivolous, Impulsive, Irresponsible, Materialistic, Pessimistic, Self-Indulgent, Spoiled, Worrywart

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A character in this situation may be forced to take a job they aren't passionate about to make ends meet, sacrificing personal fulfillment.

Esteem and Recognition: If a character's sense of esteem is tightly connected to a job or position they end up losing, they may think less of themselves and fear that others will, too.

Love and Belonging: Forced lifestyle changes may create friction in the family, which will negatively affect the character's sense of love and belonging.

Safety and Security: A shortage of necessary goods or civil unrest can lead to generalized violence, which would negatively impact the character's sense of safety and security.

Physiological Needs: If a character or their loved one is unable to obtain something essential for survival (food, medicine, a surgery, clean drinking water, etc.), death could result.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Adventurous, Calm, Disciplined, Efficient, Meticulous, Optimistic, Organized, Resourceful, Talented, Thrifty

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

The character learning personal lessons from hard times, helping them live a more fulfilled life when the economy stabilizes

The character's business providing essential goods during the recession and experiencing success

The character leveraging a talent or skill that becomes especially useful,

placing them in high demand or allowing them to weather the instability in a way others cannot

The character simplifying their lifestyle and finding pleasure in doing so

A savvy investment paying off when the economy recovers, making the character wealthy

Finding fulfillment through helping families impacted by the recession

The downturn showing the character that a pivot is necessary—to a new career or place to live—so they won't be exposed like this again

Shifting to a more sustainable lifestyle that will be less impacted by downturns in the economy

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AN UNEXPECTED PREGNANCY

NOTES

Becoming a parent is a huge responsibility that profoundly changes a person's life. It's even more of a disruption when the pregnancy isn't planned or wanted, causing all kinds of trouble for the mother, the father, grandparents—realistically, for many different members of your cast. If you're thinking of adding this kind of conflict to your story, consider an unexpected pregnancy for one of the following:

EXAMPLES

A teenager

An empty-nester

A sexual abuse survivor

The parent of an already-large family

A family living in poverty

A businesswoman who has just gotten her dream job

A woman whose husband has just been laid off

A woman who doesn't know who the father is

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Uncomfortable symptoms

Having to hide the pregnancy until a decision is made about what to do

Having to tell people about the pregnancy and becoming the subject of gossip

Having to postpone important plans (graduating from high school, traveling, etc.)

The character having to move back in with her parents

Passing up a promising opportunity, such as a promotion, because of uncertainty about the future

Being judged or criticized by friends and acquaintances

Considering termination when it goes against the family's beliefs

Considering termination but not having anyone to talk to about it

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Having no support system

Extreme symptoms that cause the mother to go on bed rest, be hospitalized, or lose her job

The character being rejected by their parents or partner

Having to stop taking a necessary medication to keep the baby safe

Being diagnosed with cancer and being unable to start treatment until the baby is born

Needing counseling as a pregnant sexual assault survivor and not receiving it

A well-known character choosing to terminate the pregnancy and suffering public backlash

The character being shunned from their family or church for choosing to end the pregnancy

An abortion leading to sepsis or another life-threatening condition

Health complications that endanger the child's or the mother's life

Terminating the pregnancy and suffering lifelong regret

The character being forced to keep the baby against their will

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anxiety, Apprehension, Denial, Depressed, Desperation, Determination, Devastation, Dread, Embarrassment, Fear, Guilt, Humiliation, Loneliness, Moodiness, Overwhelmed, Panic, Regret, Reluctance, Sadness, Self-Pity, Shame, Shock, Vulnerability, Worry

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Moral quandaries over what to do (terminate the pregnancy, keep the baby, give it up for adoption, etc.)

Worrying over finances

Worrying about what other people will say or think when they find out

Struggling with increased anxiety and panic attacks

Struggling with hormonal mood swings

Needing to hide the pregnancy but wanting to come clean

Not telling anyone and having to bear the burden alone

The character being pressured to do something they feel is morally wrong or don't want to do

Difficult circumstances creating mixed feelings toward the baby

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Apathetic, Childish, Evasive, Frivolous, Ignorant, Impulsive, Indecisive, Irresponsible, Melodramatic, Needy, Nervous, Pessimistic, Spoiled, Temperamental, Uncooperative, Vindictive, Weak-Willed

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A character with big dreams who unexpectedly becomes pregnant may have to put their plans on hold—perhaps indefinitely. The resulting lack of professional or creative fulfillment could lead to an overall sense of discontent.

Esteem and Recognition: This need could easily be impacted when others shame the character or express disapproval for their choices.

Love and Belonging: If the character's partner, parents, or other important loved ones abandon or pull away from them, they may become isolated at a time when support is desperately needed.

Safety and Security: There are many situations that could threaten a pregnant mother's sense of safety, such as severe symptoms that require hospitalization or bed rest, a complication that threatens the health of the baby, being kicked out of her home, losing her job, or even the baby's father having powerful enemies that endanger the mother and child.

Physiological Needs: While childbirth is no longer the danger it once was, it can still be risky in certain situations—if the mother has a specific mental or physical health issue, she lives in certain parts of the world, or she develops a severe complication and healthcare is unavailable.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE:

Ambitious, Calm, Independent, Loyal, Nurturing, Pensive

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Maturing and growing through the crucible of parenthood

Learning to become self-reliant

The character standing up for what they believe

Learning to put the needs of another first

The character discovering they're more capable than they realized

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BAD WEATHER

EXAMPLES

The character being caught in an unexpected storm without shelter

Poor weather conditions the day of an important event, such as the character's wedding day

A mudslide washing out a road

Non-stop rain swelling a river and making it dangerous to cross

Fog obscuring a hazard on the highway

Being caught in a tornado or tropical storm

Running out of fuel or food as a snowstorm hits

Icy conditions making travel impossible

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having to quickly cover up or relocate items outside to prevent damage

Having to prepare a home (shuttering windows, stockpiling wood for fuel, gathering candles or lanterns, etc.)

Experiencing frustration, anxiety, and worry

Being uncomfortable (being wet with no way to get dry, lacking food, etc.)

Traffic and travel delays slowing the character's progress

Losing an advantage—e.g., the head start in a race

Traveling by car or boat and hitting an obstacle obscured by the weather

Having to cancel plans or reschedule

The weather making travel more dangerous

Needing to adjust the start time for an event—say, for a political rally or sporting event

Stopping in an isolated place to wait out the weather

Not having access to a radio or the internet and being unable to track the weather event

Being unable to fulfill a commitment or promise because the weather makes doing so impossible

Having to pay for food and lodging until travel can resume

Having to shelter with strangers in an unfamiliar place

A wedding being postponed

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Suffering an injury far from help

Being lost in a storm

Taking shelter close to danger (a tornado, a forest fire, an eruption, etc.)

Having a car accident because of poor road conditions

Being snowed in without enough resources

Being trapped in a precarious situation (being caught in a flood zone, running out of fuel on a bridge that could be washed away, being caught in a forest fire, etc.)

Being separated from loved ones while escaping a crisis situation

Damage to property or assets—a windstorm dropping a tree on the character's car, for example

Storm damage delaying an important project, such as a new orphanage being built in a community

Discovering a loved one is missing after the weather event passes

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Agitation, Apprehension, Defeat, Desperation, Determination, Disappointment, Frustration, Homesickness, Hopefulness, Impatience, Nervousness, Overwhelmed, Panic, Powerlessness, Resignation, Self-Pity, Uncertainty, Unease, Worry

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Craving control but being powerless

Hiding pessimism and fear to keep others calm

Trying to read the weather and make decisions in the moment

Weighing the risks of failing forward vs. staying put

Being tempted to act despite the danger to maintain a lead or advantage

Wanting to flee a danger but also needing to save others

Self-preservation warring with doing the right thing and helping others

The character wanting to secure an advantage for themselves while knowing others need it, too

Knowing a sacrifice needs to be made, yet struggling to make it—giving up on fighting a fire that will destroy a home so the character can flee to safety, for example

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Controlling, Cowardly, Impatient, Impulsive, Materialistic, Melodramatic, Needy, Nervous, Perfectionist, Pessimistic, Reckless, Worrywart

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Love and Belonging: If something tragic happened during a dangerous weather event, remaining family members could blame the character for not safeguarding their loved ones better. This could create an even deeper emotional wound for the character and increase the pain from being alone.

Safety and Security: Extreme weather can destroy the things that make a character feel secure: their home, place of work, family business, their vehicles and assets, etc. This can not only remove their sense of safety but will also create a financial hardship when they must be replaced.

Physiological Needs: The dangerous nature of certain weather events can put your character in mortal danger or destroy the resources they need to live.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Calm, Cautious, Decisive, Disciplined, Easygoing, Hospitable, Industrious, Inspirational, Intelligent, Introverted, Nurturing, Persistent, Persuasive, Philosophical, Proactive, Protective, Resourceful, Responsible, Sensible, Thrifty

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Becoming more proactive and prepared in the future

A delay saving the character from danger or a disaster—e.g., a flash flood keeping the character from a battle, saving his life

The character being able to heal a rift, create closeness, or find common ground with someone they sheltered with

Taking advantage of a weather event that wreaks havoc with an enemy's agenda

The delay buying the character time to change someone's mind about something important

The character being able to contribute in a specific way and being recognized for their abilities

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BEING CAPTURED

EXAMPLES

Being kidnapped

The character getting caught in a hostage situation

Enemy forces taking the character prisoner

Being apprehended by law enforcement

Escaping from someone only to be caught again

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Missing family, friends, and daily comforts

Not having a way to alert loved ones about the situation

Sustaining physical, mental, and emotional injuries

The character not knowing where they are

Not being able to sleep

Loved ones not knowing where the character is or what happened to them

Needing to develop rapport with a captor

Trying to identify the captors and their motivations

Needing to protect information the captors are trying to obtain

Having to find a way out of captivity

Being forced to create propaganda that will demoralize others

Needing to pay the captors to secure release

Learning intel about the captors but being unable to pass it on to people who can use it

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Fighting back and being injured

Lacking the resources needed to obtain freedom (ransom, influence, etc.)

Discovering that a friend or loved one has also been captured

Giving up sensitive information to secure escape or protect a loved one

Being moved to a secure location that is beyond reach of rescuers

Being denied critical medical care

Developing PTSD (post-traumatic stress disorder)

Attempting an escape when the chance of success is slight
Basic resources being withheld, such as food, water, clothing, or shelter
Being tortured for information
Being experimented on
Being sexually assaulted
Being murdered

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anxiety, Betrayed, Bitterness, Conflicted, Confusion, Defeat, Defensiveness, Defiant, Depressed, Despair, Desperation, Doubt, Fear, Homesick, Impatience, Intimidated, Loneliness, Panic, Powerlessness, Tormented, Uncertainty, Vulnerability, Wariness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The toll of trying to hide fear from one's captors
Wrestling with feelings of isolation
Experiencing the deterioration or collapse of the character's mental health
Struggling as hope falters
Questioning whether to compromise their morals or safety to obtain resources or freedom
Feeling guilty about having to compromise a moral code to survive
Feeling powerless but having to hide it to keep other captives' spirits up
The character being torn about a sacrifice being made to secure their release (paying a ransom, releasing a nefarious political prisoner, etc.)
Not knowing if the information the character is being told (about loved ones, the state of their home country, etc.) is correct
Wanting to give in to despair
Wanting to lie during questioning but not knowing how much the captors already know
Having to ride out PTSD symptoms alone
Wanting to befriend another captive but not wanting to grow close to someone who could be killed or taken away

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Confrontational, Controlling, Cowardly, Disloyal, Foolish, Gullible, Hostile, Impulsive, Inattentive, Paranoid, Pessimistic, Pushy, Rebellious, Reckless, Selfish, Unethical, Verbose, Volatile, Weak-Willed

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Esteem and Recognition: Self-confidence and the way the character perceives their value can be negatively impacted if they are restricted and objectified.

Love and Belonging: If fellow captives are killed, the character might avoid building new relationships that will result in the trauma of losing people they care about.

Safety and Security: Being captured can lead to the loss of a safe, predictable environment for the character. Their mental health may also suffer in a high-stress, high-stakes situation.

Physiological Needs: Basic needs may go unmet when food, water, and shelter are withheld to coerce cooperation.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Alert, Cautious, Centered, Charming, Cooperative, Courageous, Diplomatic, Disciplined, Discreet, Focused, Honorable, Observant, Patient, Patriotic, Perceptive, Persistent, Persuasive, Resourceful, Spiritual, Unselfish

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Managing to escape

Being rescued

The character renewing or finding their faith

Finding friendships in a highly stressful environment

Discovering their strengths

Avoiding future situations that might lead to a similar outcome

Developing empathy for people who are overlooked or forgotten

Inspiring and helping others who experience trauma

Finding unknown reserves and resiliency

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BEING EVICTED

EXAMPLES

Losing a personal place of residence
Being evicted from a place of business

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Embarrassment arising from a public eviction
Needing to stay with a friend or family member
The character's credit being damaged
Having to file paperwork and seek legal counsel to stop the eviction
Incurring unexpected expenses (hiring a lawyer, paying for a storage unit, etc.)
The character not having access to their things because they're being kept at a friend's house or in a storage facility
Having to hunt for a new place to live
The character losing their security deposit
The character's belongings being seized
Their reputation or the reputation of their business being damaged
Needing to find another job (if the new living arrangement is far from a previous workplace)
The character's child having to change schools
The character losing proximity to neighbors and their place within a community
Having to find a way to move their belongings
Needing to give away a pet to move into a new residence
Having to adjust to a new residence that is inferior to the previous one
Struggling to find a new business location

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Getting into a physical altercation with a landlord or management company
Being turned away by family
Discovering that the eviction is part of someone's underhanded agenda

Having to lay off employees
The character's business failing
Having to file bankruptcy
Being sued
Moving to a new neighborhood that is dangerous for the character and their family
The character having to live out of their car
An anxiety or panic disorder being triggered
An addiction becoming worse
The character losing guardianship of their children because a safe living space cannot be arranged
Becoming homeless
Experiencing severe injury, illness, or death from unsafe conditions at the old residence or business

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Bitterness, Defensiveness, Defiant, Denial, Depressed, Embarrassment, Frustration, Guilt, Hatred, Humiliation, Insecurity, Intimidated, Overwhelmed, Powerlessness, Regret, Resentment, Uncertainty, Vengeful, Vulnerability, Worry, Worthlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character feeling shame for not being able to provide housing for their family
Regretting financial choices that may have led to the eviction
Fearing the unknown
Feeling resentment over circumstances that led to the eviction
Wanting revenge on the responsible person or organization
Becoming fixated on how to convince a landlord to overturn the eviction
Struggling to forgive whoever is to blame
The character obsessing over what they could have done differently
Feeling helpless or hopeless in an unjust situation
Being tempted to surrender and give in to despair (if this is the final straw in a series of blows)

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Addictive, Dishonest, Disorganized, Frivolous, Hostile, Ignorant, Inflexible,

Insecure, Irrational, Irresponsible, Resentful, Uncommunicative,
Uncooperative, Unethical, Vindictive, Violent, Volatile

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: When a character loses their home or financial stability, regaining those will become top priority—meaning, their dreams and passions will take a back seat.

Esteem and Recognition: Losing a home or business can negatively impact a character's reputation, self-esteem, and status within their community.

Love and Belonging: If someone is obviously to blame for the eviction, the character's relationship with that person will suffer. Needing to reside with a friend or family member in the aftermath can also lead to trouble.

Safety and Security: Without a residence, the character will experience physical vulnerabilities and insecurity. Their financial well-being will most likely take a hit, as well.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Centered, Confident, Cooperative, Courageous, Creative, Diplomatic, Easygoing, Industrious, Optimistic, Organized, Persistent, Persuasive, Proactive, Resourceful, Responsible, Sensible, Thrifty

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Finding a better residence or business location

Learning to follow contractual agreements more carefully

The character becoming more responsible with their finances or actions

Feeling supported by friends, family, or the community in a time of need

Bringing an unethical landlord to justice

Finding a new job that brings greater satisfaction

The character's child receiving better care or schooling in the new location

Having a shorter commute to work

Saving money by staying with loved ones or paying less rent

Seeking help for an addiction or mental health need

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BEING FRAMED

EXAMPLES

A civilian being set up for a crime they didn't commit

Being accused by employers for someone else's wrongdoing

A politician being framed by a rival

Being used as a scapegoat by an employer who is guilty of breaching a code of conduct, ethics violations, or fraudulent dealings

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Being investigated

An employer forcing the character to take a leave of absence

Having to pay for legal representation

Having to come up with bail money

Missing work to attend meetings (with lawyers, detectives, employers, etc.)

The character having to find evidence to prove their innocence

Needing to convince friends or family of their innocence

Having to pay a fine

Having no alibi

An existing criminal record making it harder to convince people of the character's innocence

Being arrested

Being found guilty and incurring an unnecessary or embarrassing consequence, such as having to attend anger management classes

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The character electing to defend themselves in court despite not having the necessary skills or experience

The character giving a false confession to lighten their sentence

Running from law enforcement or failing to appear in court

Being represented by an inept lawyer

Being fired or kicked out of school

Not being believed by friends and family
The character's reputation being destroyed
The situation becoming the final straw in a troubled marriage, ending it
Having to file for bankruptcy
Not being able to pursue a particular career
The character having to relocate or change their identity to avoid prejudicial treatment
Seeking revenge on the person responsible
Being sent to jail
The character's family and friends becoming targets

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anxiety, Betrayed, Confusion, Defensiveness, Denial, Depressed, Desperation, Disbelief, Fear, Humiliation, Impatience, Intimidated, Paranoia, Powerlessness, Resentment, Shock, Suspicion, Tormented, Uncertainty, Vengeful, Vulnerability

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character worrying about whether or not they'll be exonerated
Regretting choices that made the character a target for this frame-up
A misbelief forming that they were targeted because deep down they are weak
Experiencing guilt over what friends or family are being subjected to
Debating whether to trust the system or take matters into their own hands
Struggling to accept what might have been
Being tempted to suck up to or bribe the person deciding the character's fate
Feeling vulnerable and powerless that it was so easy for someone to ruin their life
Struggling with rage and resentment when the character sees the person who framed them
Feeling bereft after losing their faith in the goodness of humanity

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Antisocial, Apathetic, Cocky, Compulsive, Controlling, Dishonest, Gullible, Impulsive, Manipulative, Pessimistic, Uncommunicative, Uncooperative, Unethical, Unintelligent, Vindictive, Volatile, Weak-Willed

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: The character's plans to pursue their dreams would likely be derailed by false accusations.

Esteem and Recognition: This situation will directly impact the perceptions of others, creating problems with the character's self-image and reputation. Even if they are exonerated, it's likely that some damage cannot be undone.

Love and Belonging: If loved ones and family members don't believe the character's innocence, those important relationships will be weakened.

Safety and Security: Being threatened with the loss of their freedom (should they be found guilty) can cause the character to worry for their safety.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Calm, Centered, Cooperative, Empathetic, Focused, Honest, Honorable, Industrious, Inspirational, Just, Obedient, Optimistic, Patient, Persistent, Persuasive, Proactive, Resourceful, Responsible, Socially Aware, Spiritual, Wise

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Becoming an advocate for falsely-accused or wrongly-convicted people

Learning to think critically and not accept information at face value

The character's belief in the justice system being renewed when they are exonerated

Strengthening relationships with the people who stood by their side

Winning damages

Becoming more socially and situationally aware

Gaining job opportunities that would not have otherwise been available

Learning valuable lessons on who to trust and how to avoid being taken advantage of

Learning to recognize certain red flags about people

The character developing new protections for their email accounts, personal information, filing system, or anything else that someone could access to use against them

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BEING GIVEN BAD NEWS

EXAMPLES

Being told that a loved one was in an accident
That the character has cancer or another disease
A promotion went to someone else
The character's bid on a contract was too high
An anticipated trip has been canceled
That important paperwork was submitted too late
The sale of their home fell through
Vital funding couldn't be secured
The company the character works for is laying everyone off
That a pitch (for a new design, project, book, etc.) was rejected
A medicine or treatment isn't working
A child wasn't accepted into a university
That a loved one was victimized
That a family member or close friend has been killed

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

The character having to rearrange their schedule
Dropping what they're doing to reprioritize
Canceling plans
Losing time to sadness
Regret over trusting someone, not paying closer attention, not doing something sooner, etc.
Losing out on an opportunity
Missing a deadline or appointment
Poor decision-making due to stress and anxiety
Lost time because the character can't focus
Having to compartmentalize feelings until it's safe to process them
Saying or doing something in the stress of the moment that makes things worse—expressing anger inappropriately or sharing the news without thinking how it might impact others, for example

Not being sure how to share the bad news with others who are impacted

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Choosing to lie to others and live in denial, making everything worse

A money shortage that causes the character to default on a mortgage or loan

This being the final setback or problem that ends a marriage

Rage-quitting at work and then regretting it

Being unable to cope without what's missing (a loved one, steady employment, a place to live, a life-saving surgery, etc.)

Giving up on a direction in life because the news was such a setback or disappointment

Jumping into the wrong opportunity out of fear or a need for security without considering the possible repercussions

Pushing people away and becoming isolated or depressed

Self-destructing in the aftermath of receiving the news

Over-medicating and ending up in the hospital

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Agitation, Betrayed, Bitterness, Confusion, Denial, Depressed, Despair, Disappointment, Disbelief, Disillusionment, Grief, Guilt, Humiliation, Hurt, Inadequacy, Overwhelmed, Regret, Remorse, Resentment, Resignation, Sadness, Self-Pity, Shame, Shock, Unappreciated, Worry

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Suffering disillusionment after being so loyal or sacrificing so much

Internal struggles with guilt, regret, and feelings of failure

Struggling with bouts of depression or anxiety

Feeling irrationally responsible (for not preventing a catastrophe, death, victimization, etc.)

Wanting to give in to grief or sadness but having to be strong for others

Being tired of carrying such burdens (if this is the latest in a series of upsets)

Worrying about protecting dependents, a spouse, or the people the character leads

Trying to decide whether keeping the truth quiet is better than sharing the news and causing others pain

Fearing the future and what it may bring

Becoming obsessed with regaining control through any means necessary
Struggling with questions of faith in a situation that seems
disproportionately unfair or unjust

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Addictive, Antisocial, Defensive, Disrespectful, Impulsive,
Melodramatic, Morbid, Oversensitive, Pessimistic, Possessive, Reckless,
Resentful, Self-Destructive, Tactless, Ungrateful, Vain, Vindictive, Violent,
Withdrawn

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: If the news leads to the loss of an important opportunity that would have opened a door to the character's dreams, they'll have to rethink their life's path.

Esteem and Recognition: If a character has been passed over for a promotion or award, they may be viewed as incompetent or less skilled than others.

Love and Belonging: If the bad news relates to the death of a loved one, the loss of that relationship will cause a void in the character's life.

Safety and Security: Any news that compromises the character's safety will remove that sense of security, making them vulnerable.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Calm, Diplomatic, Gentle, Kind, Nurturing, Objective, Proactive, Protective, Sentimental, Wise

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Gaining perspective about what's really important in life

Feeling heartened that the outcome wasn't worse

The character realizing they need an emergency plan, then creating one

The character making changes to be less vulnerable (saving money in an emergency account, buying stronger health insurance, moving to a more secure field of work, etc.)

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BEING INJURED

EXAMPLES

Slipping on a wet floor
Falling down a flight of stairs
Misusing a tool and sustaining an injury
Overexerting while working out
Being injured while playing a sport
Being attacked by an animal or another person
Getting hurt while under the influence
Sustaining an injury because a safety protocol wasn't followed
Being hurt in a car accident

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Feeling foolish (if the character is at fault)
Attending multiple doctor or physical therapist appointments
Missing work or school while healing
Having to file medical insurance or legal documentation
Having to rely on others while recuperating
Complications resulting in a longer than usual recovery time
Needing to learn about the injury and the options for treating it
Having to arrange for childcare
Finding affordable medical care
Being questioned by police (if foul play was involved) or safety inspectors and human resources (if the injury happened at work)
Missing out on previously made plans
Not being able to care for family while recovering
Having to go to the hospital

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Being blamed despite someone else being at fault
Facing legal charges for criminal activity related to the injury
Needing care and having no one to help

Becoming injured in an isolated location
Needing to relocate closer to loved ones or medical care
The character being unable to continue their job because of the injury
Not having access to adequate medical care
Incurring insurmountable medical bills
Becoming disfigured or disabled in a life-altering way
The injury leading to life-threatening medical complications
Miscarrying a baby
Suffering chronic pain
Becoming addicted to pain pills
A family member being injured or killed in the same situation that wounded the character

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anxiety, Bitterness, Defeat, Denial, Depressed, Devastation, Disbelief, Emasculated, Embarrassment, Fear, Frustration, Grief, Guilt, Humbled, Impatience, Inadequate, Insecurity, Powerlessness, Regret, Self-Pity, Shock, Uncertainty, Worthlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Experiencing guilt for having to depend on others
Struggling with trauma associated with the circumstances of the injury
Feeling shame for choices that led to the situation
Struggling with the loss of independence and self-reliance
The character questioning their self-worth
Hating that people treat them differently after the injury
Accident-related anxiety affecting the character's performance
Developing a fear or phobia around being injured
Having difficulty accepting the injury's impact on their life
Experiencing survivor's guilt

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Addictive, Controlling, Cowardly, Impatient, Impulsive, Inflexible, Insecure, Macho, Melodramatic, Morbid, Needy, Perfectionist, Pessimistic, Reckless, Resentful, Self-Destructive, Vain, Weak-Willed, Withdrawn

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: An injury will likely move the character's focus away from higher-level needs, especially if it directly impairs an activity

they previously enjoyed. They may also become pessimistic and bitter if the injury forces them to give up a dream.

Esteem and Recognition: A character's self-image will suffer if an injury lessens their ability to function as they once did.

Safety and Security: A character's injury and an inability to care for themselves or loved ones can threaten their sense of security.

Physiological Needs: Under specific circumstances, an injury in an isolated location could become life-threatening.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Ambitious, Analytical, Appreciative, Centered, Courageous, Disciplined, Industrious, Inspirational, Objective, Optimistic, Patient, Persistent, Proactive, Resourceful, Responsible, Sensible, Spiritual

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Learning to persevere and overcome obstacles

Finding a better career path because of the injury

Becoming inspired to help others or taking up a philanthropic cause

Educating others about the injury or circumstances surrounding it

Learning to accept help from others

Becoming more cautious and responsible

Finding faith in life's difficult circumstances

Discovering a community of survivors

Acquiring a renewed perspective on life

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BEING ORPHANED

EXAMPLES

The character's parent or guardian dying

Being abandoned by a parent

The character's parent or guardian disappearing inexplicably

A parent or guardian being sent to jail and surrendering the child to the state

The child being pushed into refugee status

The state taking control of the child

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

The character having no family members who can or will take them in

Being placed in foster care

Having to move to a new home, neighborhood, and/or school

Discovering a painful or harmful truth about a parent or guardian

Having to adjust to a different socioeconomic status

Having to learn the rules of a new household

Not being treated nicely by foster siblings

Having to give up passions or hobbies in the new situation

Losing contact with friends

Having to learn a new language

Having to adapt to new rules and expectations

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

A character born into wealth or power being used as a chess piece by others

Refraining from making new relationships

Having no one to turn to or talk to

Trusting the wrong person

Being saddled with debt, lawsuits, or family shame (as a teen)

The child losing their cultural identity

The character being separated from their siblings

The character entering an abusive household

Relying on drugs, alcohol, or other toxic behaviors to cope

Being targeted (by traffickers, gang members, etc.) because the character is vulnerable

Running away and becoming homeless

Being cast out because orphans are viewed as bad luck or a nuisance

Contemplating suicide

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anxiety, Bitterness, Confusion, Denial, Depressed, Disbelief, Fear, Grief, Homesick, Insecurity, Loneliness, Neglected, Overwhelmed, Paranoia, Powerlessness, Resentment, Self-Pity, Shame, Shock, Uncertainty, Vulnerability, Worthlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Fearing loss or abandonment in other relationships

Having difficulty trusting others

Feeling compelled to lie to others to conceal the truth

Believing that relationships are transactional

The character obsessing over proving their worth to others

Struggling with shame and self-blame

Believing that being abandoned is normal

Needing lots of reassurance in new relationships

Struggling with having no control

Wanting to set healthy boundaries but craving the acceptance of others

Experiencing anger toward their parent or guardian

Dealing with survivor's guilt

Avoiding risks to minimize possible rejections

Fearing commitment or responsibility

Not handling the shock, pain, or grief of the situation well

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Addictive, Antisocial, Cynical, Gullible, Insecure, Martyr, Morbid, Needy,

Nervous, Paranoid, Pessimistic, Resentful, Self-Destructive, Spoiled,

Violent, Volatile, Weak-Willed, Withdrawn, Worrywart

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Esteem and Recognition: A character who views themselves as defective or worthless may be driven to earn the love of others in unhealthy ways.

Love and Belonging: Building and maintaining relationships may be difficult due to the fear of being left again. And if the character is surrounded by toxic people in the aftermath, shutting down and keeping others at a distance may become their go-to coping strategy.

Safety and Security: The character's world will change drastically as an orphan, which will shake their sense of security and safety.

Physiological Needs: Without intervention, losing their caregiver may leave the character without food, water, or shelter. Their life may also be endangered if they're given into the custody of an abusive or unstable person.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Alert, Centered, Courageous, Empathetic, Independent, Mature, Merciful, Observant, Optimistic, Protective, Proactive, Resourceful, Responsible, Sensible, Socially Aware, Spiritual

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Finding and reuniting with a missing parent

Discovering what happened to a missing parent and being given some closure

Becoming a loyal friend or family member to others

Finding a meaningful and rewarding relationship within a foster family

Reuniting with siblings (being placed in the same home, being adopted together, etc.)

Giving up unwarranted guilt; the character recognizing they aren't to blame

Becoming independent and self-reliant

Recognizing the value in positive relationships

Not repeating the mistakes of their parent or guardian

As an adult, becoming a mentor, foster parent, or advocate for those without parents

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BEING PUSHED TOWARD A SPECIFIC DESTINY

EXAMPLES

Being expected to take over a family business
Parental pressure to go to a particular school or take a certain career path
Being born into a line of rulers
Others pushing the character to marry a specific person
Being expected to fulfill a prophecy

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

The character having to give up their own wants
Being micromanaged and having decisions made for them
Being watched and monitored
Having to stand up to those who expect the character to embrace a set destiny
The character refusing to fall into line and losing the support (emotional, financial, etc.) of others
The character fighting and arguing with loved ones over their future
Dealing with guilt trips
A significant other being blamed for the character's decision to choose their own path
Receiving public scorn or criticism
Offending stakeholders
Having to pass the destiny onto someone else

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Not having control over personal relationship choices
Complying with a parent's demands and being unhappy in a chosen romantic relationship
A relational rift occurring when the character refuses to cave to pressure
Being cut off financially as punishment

Danger arising when the character publicly denounces or renounces the destiny they're expected to embrace
Being smeared by stakeholders
The family losing its business or lineage
Being estranged from or abandoned by loved ones
Being physically threatened or harmed
The character leaving home and braving homelessness rather than give in
The character engaging in purposeful self-destruction to prove they're unfit
Feeling trapped and developing depression
Turning to toxic behaviors to cope with the pressure
Committing suicide

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anxiety, Bitterness, Conflicted, Defiant, Denial, Depressed, Despair, Dissatisfaction, Emasculated, Fear, Frustration, Guilt, Loneliness, Overwhelmed, Powerlessness, Reluctance, Resentment, Resignation, Self-Loathing, Shame, Tormented

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Wanting the freedom to choose and worrying it's selfish to feel that way
The character feeling torn between what they want and what others want
Not seeing a way out of the situation
Struggling with being conditionally loved
The character wanting to be free but feeling the need to justify their decision to others
Feeling voiceless and powerless
Wrestling with questions about duty and how much it should steer a person's choices
Experiencing bitterness over diminished self-worth and objectification
The character wanting to be true to themselves but needing to hide their real feelings or ideas
Resenting the responsible people or force, whether it is a lineage, prophecy, or something else
Not wanting to have children or a significant other for fear of bringing them into the situation

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Controlling, Dishonest, Disloyal, Gullible, Hostile, Hypocritical, Impulsive,

Indecisive, Lazy, Martyr, Rebellious, Resentful, Stubborn, Subservient, Timid, Uncommunicative, Unethical, Weak-Willed

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: As long as the character is forced down a path they don't want, realizing their own desires for achievement may be impossible.

Esteem and Recognition: A character who is unable to break free of a required destiny may feel weak and easily-led, as if they will never be strong enough to forge their own path.

Love and Belonging: A character in this situation might struggle to maintain close relationships with people, afraid of dooming them to the same dismal or dangerous future. Likewise, the pressure to conform may spawn unhealthy ideas of loving relationships, making it harder for the character to see that love isn't something that must be earned.

Safety and Security: Others may target or harm the character if they choose to stray from their destiny.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Adventurous, Centered, Confident, Courageous, Creative, Decisive, Diplomatic, Honest, Independent, Industrious, Inspirational, Optimistic, Pensive, Persuasive, Private, Proactive, Resourceful

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Inspiring others to stand up for themselves

The character finding more success in their chosen path than they would have if they'd followed their destiny

Breaking a cycle of expectations

Protecting others from the same pressures

Finding a true passion and excelling at it

Shining a light on systems that limit personal freedoms

The character's self-advocacy helping their parent see they've become too controlling so the relationship can be salvaged before it breaks

Embracing the destiny because of personal choice, not external pressure

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BEING SCAMMED

NOTES

A scam is any deliberate attempt to defraud someone. It usually involves cheating people out of their money, but other valuable commodities can be stolen as well. Below are some scams your character could fall victim to.

EXAMPLES

Replying to an email that requests login or bank account information

Investing in an opportunity where the money spent goes to the person running the scam

Fake census workers gathering personal information over the phone

Being promised government grant money for a high-cost expense, such as college tuition

Pyramid and Ponzi schemes

Being sold a fake ticket to an event

Giving money to a non-existent charity

Shelling out money for promised services that shouldn't have to be paid for—e.g., paying to have a book published through a vanity publisher

Sending money to someone pretending to be a relative in distress

Spending money for services or products the character never receives—e.g., paying for headshots, then finding out the company has “gone out of business” before they come in

“Winning” a sweepstakes and having to provide bank account information to access the funds

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

The hassle of having to get new credit cards, bank accounts, etc.

Having to change passwords and close email accounts

Embarrassment arising from telling people what happened

Having to cut back on personal expenses to make up for the loss

Delaying certain purchases or a vacation

Reliving the humiliation when reporting the scam or pressing charges
Having to cash in an investment early to offset the loss
The character repeatedly having to prove their identity (because identify theft was involved)

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Becoming jaded with the system (if justice isn't served)
Losing prestige or a respected position when people discover the character was scammed
The character's credit rating being ruined
Relationship friction with loved ones who have to rescue the character financially
The character losing their life savings
Losing money earmarked for something specific, such as school tuition or a wedding
The character's personal information being sold to nefarious people, compounding the problem
Having to make drastic changes because of a precarious financial situation (taking on a second job, children leaving their school and friends, having to move, etc.)
The character rejecting technology so they won't be scammed again
Having to quit retirement and go back to work
Their view of the world and the goodness of people shifting to the negative
Becoming miserly and suspicious of other people's motives—even loved ones who need help
Giving up on a dream because someone along the way took advantage
Moving off-grid to avoid being scammed again
Becoming depressed and being unable to move on

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anguish, Anxiety, Betrayed, Bitterness, Confusion, Defeat, Defensiveness, Defiant, Depressed, Despair, Desperation, Devastation, Disbelief, Hatred, Horror, Humiliation, Overwhelmed, Panic, Powerlessness, Rage, Regret, Self-Loathing, Self-Pity

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Struggling to trust people
Worrying about the future and feeling the shortness of time in a way they

didn't before

Being overwhelmed by defeat and shame as the scam plays on a mental loop

The character losing faith in their ability to make good decisions

Becoming bitter or cynical

Being plagued with uncertainty and indecision

Over-analyzing everything, looking for hidden motives or agendas

Becoming risk-averse; playing everything safe

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Addictive, Gullible, Impulsive, Inattentive, Irresponsible, Know-It-All, Materialistic, Paranoid, Pessimistic, Self-Destructive, Self-Indulgent, Selfish, Spoiled, Timid, Vain, Violent, Volatile, Weak-Willed, Whiny

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS:

Self-Actualization: If the character turns inward, becomes fearful, and is reluctant to take risks, they may miss out on opportunities that would make them happier and satisfied.

Esteem and Recognition: The character's esteem will likely take a hit as they wonder how they could have been so gullible and missed the signs others would have caught.

Love and Belonging: If the scam destroyed the character's finances, resentment from loved ones who have to step in and support them financially could reshape the relationship.

Safety and Security: Not only can a scam deplete the character's finances and put their future security in question, they may feel less secure in the present, reading deception and dishonesty into harmless situations.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Cautious, Disciplined, Industrious, Patient, Protective, Resourceful, Responsible, Sensible, Thrifty

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Recognizing the signs and avoiding being scammed in the future

Educating others and saving them from the same fate

Using the court system to bring the parties to justice

Employing a specific skillset (such as software design) to create tools and resources to deter scammers and increase detection

Choosing to move past regret and self-blame and focus on life's positives

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BEING STRANDED

EXAMPLES

The character's car breaking down in an outlying area

Needing to get somewhere without any transportation or money

Being stuck in an airport when a flight is canceled

The character being abandoned by their escort while trying to escape hostile territory

Getting stranded in another country because of incomplete or expired paperwork

The character being left behind by their group in an unfamiliar place

Being far from home during a catastrophic event that shuts down formerly reliable infrastructures

A young character being unable to get home (because their designated driver is drunk, their ride left them, their phone died and they can't call home, etc.)

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Being a nervous traveler and not knowing what to do

Having to entertain young children while waiting

Having to rely on the kindness of strangers

Inconveniences arising from having to make new arrangements

Having to wait for new transportation to arrive

Dealing with frustration over time lost to the delay

Being physically uncomfortable (due to heat, cold, hunger, being crowded, etc.)

The character being stranded with people they don't get along with

Not knowing the language or customs of the locale

Having to secure needed resources (a passport, sufficient cash, weather-appropriate clothing, etc.)

Having to pay exorbitant costs to secure new arrangements

Being stuck with the person who created the problem

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Missing an important work meeting or family event

Being stranded in a dangerous area

The character being stranded while they're especially vulnerable (wounded, ill, inebriated, pregnant, etc.)

Being unable to secure a way out; having to stay indefinitely

Running out of food, water, money, medicine, or another vital resource during the wait

Being stranded with friends or family, then being separated from them

Getting stranded in an area of unrest and being targeted due to race, religion, skin color, etc.

Unintentionally doing something that draws unwanted attention, making the character a target

Being overwhelmed to the point of paralysis

Trusting the wrong people for help

Getting robbed or scammed—losing not only transportation but money, a phone, etc.

Taking drastic measures (stealing provisions, etc.) and being caught

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Agitation, Anger, Anxiety, Apprehension, Betrayed, Desperation, Determination, Disappointment, Disbelief, Discouraged, Doubt, Dread, Fear, Flustered, Guilt, Homesick, Impatience, Loneliness, Longing, Overwhelmed, Panic, Powerlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Struggling with impatience

The character blaming themselves for being caught unprepared (whether they are responsible or not)

Worrying about being separated from loved ones

Trying to beat back low self-confidence to cope better

The character being tempted to alter their moral compass to get by

Being consumed with anger or hatred toward whoever caused the situation

Difficulty trusting others despite desperately needing help

Anxiety over what will happen

Trying to limit negative thoughts and stay optimistic

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Childish, Cynical, Disloyal, Disorganized, Disrespectful, Foolish, Gullible, Ignorant, Impatient, Impulsive, Obsessive, Subservient, Timid, Uncooperative, Whiny, Worrywart

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: Being stranded means the character is away from home, family, and their livelihood. Getting back home will require them to temporarily sacrifice self-actualization to make it happen.

Esteem and Recognition: A character who is at fault for being stranded will experience self-doubt and a lack of confidence. Others caught in the situation because of the character's poor planning or lack of organization may also lose respect for them.

Love and Belonging: A character who is far from loved ones for an extended period of time may yearn for home and family.

Safety and Security: Safety and security can easily go out the window for a character who is stuck in a dangerous situation.

Physiological Needs: If the character is injured, sick, or doesn't have what they need to survive, the situation could deteriorate to a critical point.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Adventurous, Alert, Calm, Cooperative, Diplomatic, Industrious, Observant, Optimistic, Patient, Persistent, Persuasive, Protective, Resourceful, Socially Aware, Uninhibited

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Making the most of downtime with the people the character is stuck with

Learning something valuable from those who have taken the character in

Learning about the culture of the place where the character is stranded

Being changed by the kindness of strangers

Having a new appreciation for home

Learning how to get by with less

Gaining new survival skills

Developing a helpful character trait (patience, tolerance, tactfulness, etc.)

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BEING TAKEN IN FOR QUESTIONING

EXAMPLES

The character witnessing an accident or crime and having to make a report

Being questioned about the final days of a murdered friend or relative

The character being questioned about their proximity to the scene of a crime

A routine traffic stop giving police officers probable cause to question the character

The character being brought in to clarify information provided in a former statement

Being questioned about a crime that was committed by close friends or a business partner

Answering questions about a potential crime—e.g., because the character's professor is being investigated for sexual abuse

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Being late for work

Having to arrange and pay for childcare during the questioning

Missing an appointment or scheduled outing with a friend

Having to provide incriminating evidence about a friend or loved one

Losing trust in law enforcement

The character having to explain to others that they're involved in a criminal investigation

Becoming the subject of gossip

Nervousness making the character look guilty or uncertain about their testimony

Being triggered (if the character has had bad experiences with the police in the past)

Transportation issues that cause the character to miss their appointment

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Fatigue and constant browbeating causing the character to mix up details, raising suspicions

The character being caught lying about what they witnessed

An innocent character accidentally letting something slip about another illegal activity

Investigators building a story that isn't true, using the character's words against them

Becoming a lead witness in a dangerous trial and being pressured to testify

Dealing with investigators who have already made up their minds about the character

The character or their family being threatened by someone involved in the case

Having an incompetent or unethical lawyer

The character's past being exposed by the media in an effort to discredit them

Loved ones assuming the worst about the character's involvement because of their past actions

The character exhibiting poor judgment and making the situation worse (showing up high at police headquarters, trying to bribe an officer, etc.)

Being arrested and charged

The character getting away with a crime and being encouraged to continue their criminal behavior

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Agitation, Anger, Anxiety, Confusion, Defiant, Desperation, Dread, Embarrassment, Fear, Flustered, Guilt, Intimidated, Nervousness, Powerlessness, Resentment, Scorn, Smugness, Stunned, Uncertainty, Unease, Vulnerability, Worry

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Being scared despite not having done anything wrong

The character doubting their recall of what happened

Regretting their decisions or involvement

Feeling guilty about not being able to prevent the crime from happening

Wanting to ask for a lawyer but being afraid it will make the character look guilty

The character worrying over the effect the questioning will have on their reputation

Struggling to figure out why they're being questioned
Wanting to tell the truth but needing to protect certain information
The character being tempted to give in to a threat or demand to change their testimony
Becoming paranoid; feeling as if they're always being watched
The character needing to lie about what they witnessed and struggling to do so convincingly
A guilty character wondering if they covered their tracks well enough
The character questioning their own integrity
The character carrying the weight of knowing their testimony will ruin another's life

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Apathetic, Confrontational, Controlling, Dishonest, Disrespectful, Evasive, Forgetful, Impulsive, Inattentive, Melodramatic, Prejudiced, Tactless, Uncommunicative, Uncooperative, Violent

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A character who follows their moral code in this situation, but justice isn't served, may begin to question their values and belief system.

Esteem and Recognition: If friends or loved ones are quick to rush to judgment about the character's guilt, they'll begin to think less of the character. Proximity to other guilty parties (working for a company being investigated for fraud, for example) may also damage the character's reputation.

Love and Belonging: Relationships with friends or family can become strained if they disagree with the character's course of action or want the character to keep certain information secret.

Safety and Security: If the case involves a violent or desperate perpetrator who will go to great lengths to protect the truth, the character and their family could become endangered.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Analytical, Calm, Cautious, Confident, Cooperative, Courteous, Diplomatic, Humble, Obedient, Observant, Optimistic, Perceptive, Persistent, Persuasive, Responsible, Wise

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Being cleared of all charges

Providing information that leads to the guilty party's arrest

The character's input stopping further harm from being done

Experiencing a renewed respect for the police force and their dedication to justice

Seeing inequity or injustice in the system and pursuing change

Taking steps to protect themselves from dangers related to the crime they witnessed

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DISCOVERING ONE HAS A CHILD

NOTES

This entry refers to a situation in which the character becomes aware of a child they unknowingly conceived years prior. To explore the scenario where someone discovers that an unborn child is on the way, check out [AN UNEXPECTED PREGNANCY](#).

EXAMPLES

Being informed by an ex that a child was conceived in the final days of the relationship

An unexpected visitor showing up who identifies as the character's son or daughter

Discovering an unknown descendant through a genealogy study

Being asked to take a paternity test and getting a positive result

The character learning that the child they were told died at birth is actually alive

A lover getting in touch years later because they need help (to get the character's medical history, to ask for financial assistance, etc.)

Authorities contacting the father after the mother has died

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having to investigate the circumstances around the event to make sure it's true

Losing sleep over worries about the future

Difficulty focusing at work or school

Experiencing minor stress-related ailments (stomachaches, weight loss, anxiety, etc.)

The character having to keep the news secret until they figure out what to do

Awkwardness with the child

The character having to reprioritize their life to make room for the child

Hearing rumors and misinformation about the situation

Getting a paternity test
Difficult conversations with the ex
Friends and family thinking less of the character

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Being burdened with new financial obligations the character can't afford
Friction between the character and their current spouse over the situation
Having to make big changes to build a relationship with the child
(relocating, changing jobs, etc.)
An affair being exposed
Having to renew a relationship with a toxic ex
The character's other children resenting the newcomer
The character knowing the child isn't theirs but being unable to prove it
The child having disabilities that the character feels unequipped to handle
The child "dropping the bomb" out of revenge (not because they want a relationship)
Not being able to gain the child's forgiveness or connect with them
The character welcoming the child only to have the mother take him or her away again
Building a loving relationship, then discovering the child is not theirs
The character (and the child) being caught up in a manipulative ex's scheme

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anxiety, Betrayed, Bitterness, Confusion, Contempt, Denial, Depressed, Disbelief, Humiliation, Hurt, Hysteria, Insecurity, Intimidated, Overwhelmed, Regret, Remorse, Resentment, Shock, Skepticism, Vulnerability

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Wrestling with distractions and negative thoughts
Regretting the life choices that created the situation
The character doubting their ability to parent the child
The character knowing they should tell their spouse about the child but being afraid to do so
Doubting that the child is even theirs
Not knowing what to do; being paralyzed by indecision
Slipping into denial despite adequate proof

Wanting to be a parent but being terrified of repeating the past due to a dysfunctional upbringing

Being tempted to justify a decision to not be involved in the child's life

Being riddled with shame or self-loathing due to not pursuing a relationship with the child

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Callous, Childish, Confrontational, Controlling, Cruel, Cynical, Defensive, Dishonest, Hostile, Irresponsible, Judgmental, Lazy, Prejudiced, Resentful, Selfish, Sleazy, Tactless, Vindictive, Volatile

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: The mantle of parenting may require the character to change their life in significant ways, including a sacrifice of certain personal dreams or passion pursuits.

Esteem and Recognition: If your character is someone others look to because of their moral integrity, the discovery that a child was produced through an affair or a one-night stand could greatly damage their position with others.

Love and Belonging: Depending on the circumstances, the character may end up being judged, rejected, or vilified by loved ones. Introducing a new, unknown child into the mix could also create relationship friction with current family members.

Safety and Security: The character's financial and emotional stability could be at risk if they're not equipped to handle such a drastic life change.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Calm, Centered, Confident, Empathetic, Funny, Generous, Gentle, Honorable, Hospitable, Humble, Mature, Nurturing, Optimistic, Protective, Resourceful, Responsible, Spiritual, Supportive, Thrifty

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Forming a healthy relationship with the child

Healing a prior relationship with an ex

Having a second chance to become a parent

Gaining a family member (if the character previously had none)

The situation forcing the character to mature, take responsibility, and put others first

The character determining to become a fit parent (by overcoming hoarding behaviors, dealing with an addiction, seeking help for a bipolar condition, etc.)

Being able to drastically improve the life of the child

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GETTING IN A CAR ACCIDENT

NOTES

A car accident can generate minor inconveniences, a devastating loss of life, and everything in between. The complexity multiplies if the character is responsible for the crash, so we've explored that option in the CAUSING A CAR ACCIDENT entry of Volume One. For additional ideas on how being in an accident might cause problems, read on.

EXAMPLES

Having an accident due to inclement weather (flooding, snowy conditions, etc.)

A car malfunction that happens at the worst time (the hood flying up and obstructing the driver's view, unresponsive brakes, an electrical short that sparks a fire, etc.)

Being hit by debris (a tree branch falling during a storm, equipment flying off a truck, etc.)

A tire blowout that causes the character's car to spin out of control

The character swerving to avoid hitting a pedestrian or animal and driving off the road

The character being hit by a reckless, inattentive, or drunk driver

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

The accident causing the character to be late

Friction with others who were inconvenienced by the character's lateness

Having to wait for the police or a tow truck to arrive

Dealing with someone who refuses to accept responsibility for the accident

A confrontational or impatient passenger making it more difficult for the character to work things out with the other driver

Working with a police officer who is biased, incompetent, or unsympathetic

Increased insurance premiums

Having to temporarily find other transportation

Having to pay for car repairs

The character's children being scared by the accident and needing reassurance
Discomfort from minor injuries, such as bruises or cuts and scrapes
The character's car being less reliable or comfortable due to incurred damage
Needing to find witnesses who can back up the character's version of events
Being blamed by a parent or spouse, who assume the character must have been responsible

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The character fleeing the scene to avoid police (because of an outstanding warrant, fearing deportation, etc.)
The other driver and their passengers lying about what happened to avoid blame
Being held responsible even though it wasn't the character's fault
The accident causing the character to miss a vital meeting
Being hit by someone with no insurance
Being sued by the other driver
The insurance company using a loophole to avoid paying for the accident
The character's car being totaled, leaving them with no transportation
A lengthy stay in the hospital when the character can't afford to miss work
The character being unable to continue in their current job due to their injuries
Incurring extensive medical bills
Developing chronic pain
Suffering lifelong or life-altering injuries
Someone being killed in the accident

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anguish, Annoyance, Anticipation, Anxiety, Appalled, Apprehension, Devastation, Disappointment, Discouraged, Doubt, Dread, Fear, Flustered, Frustration, Horror, Impatience, Intimidated, Panic, Powerlessness, Resignation, Shock

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Feeling guilty even though it wasn't the character's fault
The character being made to doubt the truth about what happened

Difficulty accepting the changes that have occurred from the accident (decreased mobility, having to take public transportation because of a totaled car, etc.)

Feeling anger and rage toward the responsible person

Feeling let down by the insurance industry and not knowing what to do about it

Getting stuck; not being able to move past the accident

Becoming obsessed with the *what ifs*

Struggling with PTSD or a driving phobia in the aftermath

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Addictive, Confrontational, Disrespectful, Impatient, Impulsive, Know-It-All, Martyr, Morbid, Obsessive, Oversensitive, Paranoid, Reckless, Resentful, Uncooperative, Vindictive

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: Injuries or mental challenges arising from a serious car accident can end certain dreams, forcing the character to pivot to something else. This can be hard to accept.

Esteem and Recognition: A character who is physically marred or disabled after an accident may worry about what others think of them.

Safety and Security: A significant accident can cause the character to feel unsafe or especially vulnerable while driving. Financial difficulties arising from the crash can also trigger changes in their living circumstances that may affect their sense of security.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Appreciative, Bold, Calm, Centered, Diplomatic, Objective, Observant, Optimistic, Wise

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

The character being blamed for the accident but being vindicated by evidence on their dashcam

Being less inclined to take the important things for granted

Recognizing how unimportant material possessions are

Having to get a new car and being able to upgrade to one the character has always wanted

A serious illness or condition being discovered from tests run in the aftermath of the accident

The character winning a financial windfall in a lawsuit against their car manufacturer

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HAVING A MISCARRIAGE

EXAMPLES

The character miscarrying soon after discovering she's pregnant

Losing a twin or triplet in utero

Losing a baby and having to induce labor to deliver it

Miscarrying after a long struggle with infertility

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having to tell people about the miscarriage

People asking prying or awkward questions

Having to go about life as if nothing had happened (if no one knew about the pregnancy)

A sibling or best friend getting pregnant at the time of the miscarriage

People offering well-meaning but unhelpful advice: *You'll have better luck next time*, or, *Everything happens for a reason*

Having to miss work to recover

Needing to take time off from work or school to process everything but being unable to do so

Needing to avoid pregnant friends for a while

The character feeling pressured to try again before they're ready

The character wanting to try again before their partner is ready

Having to pack up or return baby gifts

Money being wasted in the unsuccessful attempt to have a child

Miscarrying in a public place

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Miscarrying alone, with no support

The character being blamed for the miscarriage

The character giving up on ever having a family

The miscarriage requiring a lengthy hospital stay and hefty medical bills

The character and their spouse or significant other separating in the aftermath

Lacking the financial resources to go through another round of fertility treatments

An aging character despairing of ever being able to have a baby

The mother or father slipping into depression

The mother's life being endangered in the process

The miscarriage becoming an unresolved emotional wound for the character

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anguish, Bitterness, Defeat, Denial, Depressed, Despair, Desperation, Determination, Devastation, Disappointment, Disbelief, Discouraged, Doubt, Embarrassment, Grief, Guilt, Jealousy, Loneliness, Longing, Powerlessness, Relief, Resignation, Self-Pity, Vulnerability

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character feeling as if they're responsible for the miscarriage

Not wanting to be jealous or resentful of a friend's pregnancy but not knowing how to stop those feelings

The character wrestling with their faith

Struggling with the knowledge that others will be happy that the pregnancy has ended

The character not knowing how to answer a young son or daughter's questions about what happened

Wanting to try again but being afraid to do so

Wondering if the miscarriage is a sign that they shouldn't be a parent

Feeling stuck in the grieving process

Constantly being reminded of the pain (by TV commercials, friends' pregnancy announcements, an empty nursery, etc.)

Resenting a partner or spouse who doesn't seem upset enough by the miscarriage

Being relieved that the pregnancy has ended, and feeling guilty about it

The character feeling responsible because they had wished the unwanted pregnancy away

Being reminded repeatedly of the miscarriage (on the day of a canceled shower, the baby's due date, the birthday every year, etc.)

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Controlling, Cynical, Impulsive, Irrational, Jealous, Martyr, Nervous,

Obsessive, Pessimistic, Self-Destructive, Superstitious, Worrywart

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A character who has always wanted a family and has trouble producing one may begin to feel that their dreams are out of reach.

Esteem and Recognition: A character whose value and sense of worth are tied up in their role as a parent may compare themselves to people who have achieved those milestones and find themselves lacking.

Love and Belonging: Miscarriage and infertility are enormous stressors that can become a wedge between partners who are already struggling emotionally.

Safety and Security: This need can be impacted if a miscarriage creates mental health issues for either parent.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Centered, Confident, Easygoing, Objective, Optimistic, Persistent, Spiritual

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Recognizing the importance of self-care in the aftermath

The character and their partner growing closer during the healing process

The character learning that they're not alone in their pain

Recognizing the benefit of therapy in healing

The character receiving help or support when they expected judgment

Seeking to increase support for or awareness of this common issue

The end of an unwanted pregnancy giving the character a second lease on life

The character realizing their dream through adoption

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HAVING A PANIC ATTACK

NOTES

A panic attack is a sudden feeling of extreme fear caused by a wounding event, stressful life change, or triggers within the character's environment that remind them of past trauma. They also can come on with no apparent danger or cause. The body's response to real and perceived danger is powerful, resulting in extreme physical reactions that are instinctive and hard to control. Attacks can occur in isolation (from a specific circumstance) or they can be recurrent, as part of a panic disorder. Either way, these attacks are so terrifying, they can trigger a fear of having more of them—especially in public, where the character is exposed.

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Being unable to think clearly

Feeling disconnected from reality

Needing to make a quick exit to someplace private

Uncomfortable physical responses, such as an accelerated heartbeat, sweating, trembling, nausea, and shortness of breath

Difficulty walking and navigating because of dizziness

Having to hide the panic from others

The character worrying about what others will think if they find out about the attacks

Not wanting to be seen as weak or fearful

Being embarrassed by an attack that comes on in public

The character calling an ambulance because they believe they're having a heart attack

A costly medical bill after being treated for a suspected heart attack

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Feeling overwhelmed by the fear

Being too embarrassed to seek help

Never knowing when the next attack might come

Enduring the attacks alone despite loved ones being willing and able to help
Missing out on healthy opportunities because the character is so afraid of another attack

Being criticized by others who have no experience with mental health issues

Struggling to succeed at work or school

Difficulty following through on responsibilities

Not having money for therapy (especially if those services aren't covered by insurance)

The character losing their autonomy and becoming dependent on others

Having an attack during a job interview, before a tryout, during a date, or another time when the character needs to be at their best

An attack coming on in the presence of an enemy who will take advantage of the opportunity

Fear of another attack leading to a phobia (of driving, being away from home, etc.)

Panic attacks increasing in frequency or severity

Frequent attacks turning into a panic disorder

Abusing drugs or alcohol as a means of escape

Becoming depressed

Having suicidal thoughts

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anguish, Anxiety, Apprehension, Bitterness, Depressed, Despair, Desperation, Dread, Emasculated, Embarrassment, Fear, Horror, Humiliation, Hysteria, Overwhelmed, Panic, Paranoia, Powerlessness, Shame, Tormented, Unease, Vulnerability

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES (INNER CONFLICT)

Not wanting others to witness the attack but not wanting to endure it alone

Knowing the fear is irrational but being unable to stop it

The character not being able to trust their own brain (because it triggers an extreme fear reaction when there's nothing to be afraid of)

The character fearing that they're losing their mind

The character wrestling with guilt or shame over being unable to handle their responsibilities

Feeling guilt or shame for tying up a hospital bed (if they believed they were experiencing a heart attack)

Wanting to be honest about this condition with children to normalize it, but not wanting to frighten them

A desire to pursue certain interests but being too afraid to do so

Wanting to visit certain locations but avoiding them for fear of triggering another attack

Wanting to be social and make friends but fearing that others will find out about the character's mental state

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Addictive, Controlling, Inflexible, Inhibited, Insecure, Macho, Nervous, Perfectionist, Self-Destructive, Uncommunicative, Uncooperative, Withdrawn, Worrywart

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS:

Self-Actualization: An important moment ruined by a panic attack can lead the character to not take chances and always go the safe route, leading to a half-life of unfulfilled dreams.

Esteem and Recognition: It's embarrassing to have a panic attack in front of others, especially people the character wants to impress.

Love and Belonging: Someone who experiences frequent attacks may prefer being alone to being with others. The enforced solitude can result in a character who feels deeply disconnected from everyone around them.

Safety and Security: Whether the fear is real or perceived, a character in the throes of a panic attack feels fundamentally unsafe.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Alert, Analytical, Objective, Optimistic, Perceptive, Persistent, Proactive, Resourceful, Spiritual, Trusting, Uninhibited

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Recognizing the signs of an attack and being able to take action before they occur in the future

Finding new strength from having endured the attack and come out the other side

Seeking help and being able to deal with the attacks, reduce their frequency, or even stop having them altogether

Being able to better empathize with others who struggle with panic attacks

Learning to live a full life even with a panic disorder

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HAVING TO LEAVE SOMEONE BEHIND

NOTES

There are many unfortunate times in life where a character must make a choice that results in leaving someone behind. The fallout in this scenario will depend on many factors. This entry will focus on a situation in which the character doing the leaving has no choice in the matter.

EXAMPLES

Being in a life-or-death situation and having to leave someone who is injured

Escaping from a cult or kidnapper and leaving other victims behind

Escaping a dangerous homeland alone because there isn't enough money to take the whole family

Fleeing a natural disaster and leaving a friend behind because they were unwilling to leave

Facing an impossible decision that requires choosing between loved ones (Sophie's Choice)

Leaving a dangerous area on the last transport out that doesn't have space for everyone

Running away from an abusive home without taking younger siblings or children

An injured ally refusing to go on (because they're a detriment), forcing the character to leave them

Retreating soldiers having to leave their wounded behind

Being conscripted into military service and leaving a spouse and children to go to war

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Inconveniences arising from not being able to do what the person left behind was responsible for: starting a fire, navigating the stars, hunting, bartering, talking their way out of trouble, etc.

Missing the one who was left behind
A loss of the person's financial assets
No longer being able to use the person's network to get advice, financial support, intel, etc.
Having no one to keep watch, share the workload, help forage, etc.
The character having to change their plans because the abandoned person is no longer there
No longer being able to go to that person for advice or to strategize
Difficulty sleeping or eating

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Having to explain what happened to the abandoned person's family
Having to convince unhappy allies to also leave the person behind
Being blamed by others who disagreed with the decision
Discovering that leaving was the wrong choice and having to live with it
Having to continue to lead others while battling guilt and shame
Suffering night terrors and other PTSD symptoms from leaving the person behind
The abandoned person surviving and refusing to forgive the character for leaving them
The character learning that the abandoned party suffered terribly on their own (they were caught by an enemy, tortured, struggled through a serious illness alone, etc.)
The abandoned party dying
The character abandoning the person for their own survival, then dying anyway

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anguish, Defensiveness, Depressed, Despair, Devastation, Discouraged, Doubt, Dread, Grief, Guilt, Horror, Loneliness, Overwhelmed, Panic, Powerlessness, Regret, Remorse, Resignation, Sadness, Self-Loathing, Shame, Tormented

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Being overcome with regret and remorse
Obsessively running through other decisions that could have been made
Suffering from survivor's guilt

Wrestling with the temptation to go back, even if it's obviously not the right thing to do

Cycling through relief (for being able to escape) and shame (for feeling relieved)

The character not being able to forgive themselves

The character doubting their instincts and decisions

The character second-guessing their motives—especially if there was animosity with the person who was left behind

Needing to grieve but not being able to do so

Struggling to hold it together in front of other people

The character needing to profess confidence in the decision despite their own doubts

Developing a fear of leading

Having to lie to others (saying the person is already dead, for instance) to keep them from attempting a rescue mission that will end in disaster

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Addictive, Callous, Cowardly, Cynical, Defensive, Indecisive, Insecure, Morbid, Reckless, Self-Destructive, Withdrawn, Worrywart

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: If the character is crippled by guilt, doubt, or self-loathing, they may become mired in those feelings, unable to move toward their dreams and passions.

Esteem and Recognition: A character having to make this horrific decision could easily struggle with feelings about their own worth and whether they deserve forgiveness.

Safety and Security: A mental health struggle arising in the aftermath could undermine the character's sense of security.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Analytical, Centered, Decisive, Focused, Objective, Proactive, Responsible, Wise

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

The character or others being saved because of the sacrifice

In hindsight, realizing that as hard as the decision was, it was the right choice

Being forgiven by the abandoned party's loved ones

The character being able to forgive him or herself

The character determining to live a life worthy of the other person's sacrifice

Making sure the other's sacrifice is known and they are honored for it

Using the experience to educate others about the human cost of larger conflicts so the situation won't be repeated

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HAVING TO MOVE

EXAMPLES

Relocating for work

Moving because of financial constraints

Moving due to a separation or divorce

Evolving community dynamics precipitating a move to a safer place

Relocating to a place offering specialized care, such as a retirement home or medical facility

The character's building being condemned or becoming a safety concern

Being evicted

Relocating so the character can better support a struggling family member

Having to flee (to escape enemies, avoid being caught by police, get away from a violent ex, etc.)

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having to use free time to pack

Dealing with children who are angry about the move

A bank account hit that puts a strain on the moving budget

Prepping to put a house up for sale and discovering that extensive repairs are needed

Having to leave the house at inconvenient times for showings

Having to downsize and sell precious items

Having to reschedule appointments, holidays, or other commitments

Difficult goodbyes that must be made to friends and neighbors

Having to switch schools

An increased commute

Having to change jobs

A time-sensitive move that will leave people in the lurch—e.g., quitting work without notice

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Moving to save a rocky relationship only to have it end anyway

The kids hating their new school or being bullied by local kids
Hating the new job (or being unable to find one)
Discovering that the new place is riddled with problems (leaky pipes, a pest infestation, etc.)
Realizing the new neighborhood is unsafe or in some way undesirable—e.g., because there's a crack house around the corner or a factory being built nearby
Discovering the seniors' home is not a safe, caring place (subpar food, overworked or ambivalent caregivers, few social activities, mix-ups with medications, etc.)
Learning that a criminal lives next door
Being unable to keep up with the new mortgage
Experiencing a medical crisis and not having anyone nearby to lean on for support
Not being able to shake an enemy and being forced to move again

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Apprehension, Conflicted, Defeat, Determination, Disappointment, Frustration, Guilt, Homesickness, Hopefulness, Loneliness, Nostalgia, Uncertainty, Vulnerability, Worry

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Worrying that the move equates to quitting, and feeling like a failure
The character feeling guilty for moving away from loved ones or people who needed them
Second-guessing the decision to move
Struggling with self-esteem issues (if the move was a downgrade)
Feeling anxiety about the changes
Worrying over how the kids are dealing with the transition
Wrestling with homesickness
Dissatisfaction with the new house or location
Feeling isolated due to being removed from family and friends
Worrying about the future
Being unable to shake the feeling that their past will catch up with them

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:
Controlling, Disorganized, Forgetful, Grumpy, Impatient, Materialistic,

Melodramatic, Oversensitive, Pessimistic, Possessive, Prejudiced, Scatterbrained, Temperamental, Uncooperative, Volatile

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Esteem and Recognition: If the character's situation is worsened by the forced relocation or the circumstances leading up to the move sabotaged their self-esteem, they will struggle in this area.

Love and Belonging: It's not always easy to acclimate to a new location, and connecting with others is more difficult for certain kinds of people. If the character becomes detached and lonely, they may feel like they don't belong and never will.

Safety and Security: The character's security could be threatened in certain situations, such as having to relocate to an unsafe neighborhood or moving into a building that's claimed by a kingpin who requires payment in return for their protection.

Physiological Needs: If the character is fleeing someone dangerous or is in a witness protection program and the wrong people discover their location, the situation could end in death.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Cautious, Focused, Extroverted, Nature-Focused, Nurturing, Observant, Responsible, Sentimental, Thrifty

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Recognizing that change and overcoming adversity is part of life

Discovering new friendships and opportunities in the new location

Letting go of the pain associated with the old home and situation

Gaining a fresh perspective on life

Feeling more independent and life-capable

Being pleasantly surprised with the new situation (because the neighbors are nicer, the climate is better, the kids have found new activities, etc.)

Starting over with people who have no preconceived opinions or judgments about the character

Realizing that certain friends weren't healthy to be around and life is better without them

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LOSING A CHILD IN A PUBLIC PLACE

NOTES

Losing a child in a crowded area is every parent's worst nightmare. Amusement parks, grocery stores, malls, public pools and beaches, a busy urban street...that feeling of panic as the brain jumps to the worst-case scenario is nothing anyone wants to experience—whether the misplaced child is the character's own or one in their charge.

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Dropping everything to focus on the search
Bystanders judging the character for losing their charge
Having to drag other children around in the search
Being burdened with bags
Having to search in an unfamiliar area
Rushing to find a security guard or store manager to make an announcement
Not knowing the language
Overreacting in an embarrassing way
Anxiety symptoms (scattered thinking, dizziness, etc.) making the search harder
Having to rapidly explain the situation to others so they can help with the search
The character snapping at the people they're with
Poor judgment from having to make quick choices in the moment

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The child needing critical medical care (medication, a surgery scheduled for the next day, etc.)
The character breaking down emotionally and being unable to continue the search
An extreme reaction that traumatizes other children in the character's charge

External circumstances making the situation more difficult (inclement weather, a disaster making it hard to contact authorities, etc.)

Someone else in the character's party needing extra attention during the search

Verbally abusing the authorities or other people who are trying to help

Harshly blaming someone else (a spouse, a teen child who was supposed to be watching the younger one, etc.), creating a rift that may never heal

Physical issues from prolonged adrenaline (if the child isn't found right away)

Responding in a way that makes authorities suspicious

Recalling details incorrectly, making it more difficult to find the child

Accusing the wrong person for the child's abduction

The character having a panic attack, a stroke, or another serious mental or physical response

The child being abducted

The child's body being recovered

Never finding the child

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anguish, Annoyance, Anxiety, Despair, Desperation, Determination, Devastation, Embarrassment, Fear, Frustration, Guilt, Horror, Hysteria, Nervousness, Overwhelmed, Panic, Shame, Shock, Terror, Tormented, Unease, Vulnerability

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character taking on blame despite it not being their fault

Being angry at the child while recognizing that's not fair

Fighting to stay positive and not assume the worst

Wrestling internally with panic while needing to maintain a calm exterior for others

Being paralyzed—not knowing what to do in the moment

Cycling rapidly through a range of emotions and not know what to do with them

The character questioning their memory and the details about what happened

Being consumed by the need to do something but knowing it's in the police's hands

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Antisocial, Callous, Controlling, Disrespectful, Evasive, Impatient, Impulsive, Inattentive, Irrational, Melodramatic, Nervous, Paranoid, Possessive, Scatterbrained, Self-Destructive, Uncooperative, Volatile, Worrywart

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: If the child goes missing for an extended period, the character's perception of themselves as a good parent (or grandparent, big sister, etc.) will fall apart. The character will also not be able to focus on anything but the recovery of the child, and all other meaningful goals and passions will be put on hold.

Esteem and Recognition: A character in this situation will always feel at least partly to blame, which will seed doubt in their own mind as to their capability and trustworthiness. Other people who find the character at fault will also think less of them.

Love and Belonging: Depending on the response of the child's other parent (or parents if the character is not the child's mother or father), important relationships could be damaged beyond repair, leaving the character feeling unsupported and unloved.

Safety and Security: Even if the child is found safe and sound, the experience may linger with the character, removing the sense of security they once had.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Analytical, Bold, Calm, Cooperative, Courteous, Efficient, Focused, Observant, Optimistic, Persistent, Resourceful

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Quickly finding the child unharmed

Being able to find and save the child from an abductor

The character being more proactive in the future to keep from repeating the experience

Camaraderie forged with those who played a part in the search

A criminal being caught and kept from hurting anyone else

Vowing not to take a single moment with the child for granted

The character being less judgmental of other parents

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NOT ACHIEVING A COVETED GOAL

EXAMPLES

Not making a professional sports team
The character being passed over for their dream job
Being unable to have children
The character not being accepted to their dream university
Losing an election
Failing to make a relationship work
Taking second-place in an elite competition or contest
Not being accepted into an invitation-only group
Flunking out of college before a degree could be earned
The character's business failing
Being unable to make amends

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having to adjust plans and expectations
Losing the financial investment involved
Being dissatisfied with whatever comes next
Embarrassment
Having to explain the loss to others
Believing that the time spent pursuing the goal was wasted
Shouldering the weight of other people's disappointment
Envy others who were able to achieve the goal
Awkwardness around friends who got what the character wanted
The character changing their habits to avoid people or events related to the pursuit
Dealing with well-meaning but unhelpful comments from others: *It just wasn't meant to be*, or, *Something better will come along*

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Losing the joy the character once experienced from a beloved passion or hobby

The character becoming reluctant to dream big or take risks
Becoming apathetic; underachieving
The character losing their sense of identity (because it was tied to the goal)
The character blaming God and losing their faith
Developing crushing self-doubt and a loss of worth that derails future goals
Superficial partners leaving the character once they realize they'll never be famous, rich, etc.
Holding to an unrealistic idea of success that is impossible to achieve
Choosing to take the goal by force
Being unable to pivot to something else
Self-destructing and developing an addiction or embracing unhealthy relationships to cope
Developing an emotional wound
Developing a panic or anxiety disorder
Falling into depression

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Acceptance, Anger, Anguish, Betrayed, Bitterness, Confusion, Defeat, Defensiveness, Denial, Depressed, Despair, Determination, Devastation, Disillusionment, Dissatisfaction, Doubt, Embarrassment, Grief, Guilt, Insecurity, Longing, Panic

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Wrestling with self-doubt and insecurity
Obsessing over what might have been or what the character could have done differently
Fighting bitterness
Feeling at fault for letting others down
Battling denial; refusing to move on when it's time to do so
Being unable to let go of the dream
Needing to grieve but feeling like it shouldn't be necessary or such a big deal
The character feeling guilty, as if they have squandered the sacrifices of others
Believing this was their one shot, and they will never be able to secure happiness again
Wanting to move forward but not knowing how

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Apathetic, Cynical, Foolish, Insecure, Irrational, Jealous, Obsessive, Perfectionist, Resentful, Self-Destructive, Vindictive, Withdrawn

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A character whose happiness and identity are tied to their goal will have difficulty finding contentment with anything less.

Esteem and Recognition: If a goal requires a certain aptitude or level of talent, losing out will cause the character to doubt their own abilities, impacting their self-esteem. Similarly, if others use the character's talent as a measure of their value, those people may lose respect for them.

Love and Belonging: If friends or family criticize the character or turn against them because of their inability to achieve the goal, the character's sense of belonging will be threatened.

Safety and Security: If the goal was tied to their ability to be financially secure, healthy, or safe, until they find a new way to achieve the same end, this need will not be met.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Ambitious, Appreciative, Centered, Confident, Disciplined, Humble, Industrious, Optimistic, Persistent, Talented, Uninhibited

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

The character recognizing an area of weakness and seeking to eradicate it

The character reevaluating their definition of success

Finding another way to participate in the coveted activity without having to be the best (coaching a sport, teaching music lessons, becoming a reporter or commentator, etc.)

Discovering fulfillment through slowing down and doing less

The character realizing that their worth isn't measured by their giftedness

Being able to pivot to another goal that gets them excited

Realizing that success is not a metric of personal value

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RENT BEING RAISED

EXAMPLES

A planned rent increase looming in the near future

Receiving notice of an unexpected rent increase

A roommate or significant other moving out, no longer paying their share of housing costs

Having to move to a location where rent costs are significantly higher

Being charged (by parents, grandparents, a neighbor, etc.) after previously living rent-free

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Confrontations with the landlord

Friction with a partner over finances

Having to make excuses or lie to buy time for finding the extra money

Having to search for a new house or apartment

Working overtime to make more money

Being forced to curtail spending (giving up a morning latte, biking instead of driving, etc.)

Having to give up solitude and take in roommates

Struggling to find a suitable roommate

Needing to temporarily crash at a friend's home

Having to sell possessions to raise cash fast

Having to ask loved ones for a loan

Dealing with family members who are unhappy that a move will be necessary

Having to get a second (or third) job

Moving to a less convenient location, such as one that's farther from work or the kids' school

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Children experiencing stress over parents being unable to pay bills or keep their home

Hours being scaled back at work, making things worse
Taking in a roommate who isn't a good fit, and discovering they're a nightmare to live with
Moving in with a significant other faster than is wise
Having to sacrifice a dream or lifelong goal to make ends meet—e.g., giving up a college scholarship and staying home to help the family financially
A divorce due to escalating relationship problems stemming from financial difficulties
Becoming controlling in other areas of life to make up for the sense of powerlessness
Moving to a less expensive but more dangerous neighborhood
Relationships falling apart between the character and those who refuse to help with rising costs (someone in the house who refuses to get a job, parents who won't float the character a loan, etc.)
A circumstance that escalates the situation, such as a job loss, pay cut, or unexpected expense
Turning to gambling or an illegal activity to raise funds
Being evicted
Becoming homeless

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anguish, Annoyance, Anxiety, Apprehension, Depressed, Despair, Desperation, Determination, Disbelief, Dread, Embarrassment, Fear, Frustration, Humiliation, Overwhelmed, Panic, Powerlessness, Self-Pity, Shame, Shock, Worry, Worthlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character resenting the new home and not being able to settle in
Struggling with self-worth over not being able to provide for their family or themselves
Resenting siblings who don't have money struggles, then being ashamed for feeling that way
Feeling powerless
Struggling with feelings of anger or rage against the person responsible for the rent hike
The character becoming dissatisfied with the way their life has changed
Wrestling with defeatism; feeling like things will never get better

The character incessantly worrying over what will happen to them or their loved ones

The character being tempted to cross moral lines to increase their income

Feeling resentment toward others in the home who will not or cannot financially contribute

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Compulsive, Confrontational, Disorganized, Disrespectful, Evasive, Grumpy, Hostile, Impatient, Inattentive, Irresponsible, Materialistic, Melodramatic, Obsessive, Resentful, Spoiled, Worrywart

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Esteem and Recognition: If a character downsizes or moves to a less desirable neighborhood, they may see this as a step backward and worry over what others will think.

Love and Belonging: Starting over in a new community without friends can lead to loneliness and a lack of belonging. Financial difficulties can also cause conflict between the character and their partner, weakening that bond.

Safety and Security: Moving to a sketchy neighborhood can create security and safety issues for the character and their family.

Physiological Needs: A character who loses their home will struggle to meet their basic needs. If their performance declines at work as a result, their livelihood could also become threatened.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Adventurous, Analytical, Cautious, Centered, Courageous, Disciplined, Easygoing, Industrious, Mature, Optimistic, Organized, Proactive, Resourceful, Responsible, Sensible

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

The character negotiating a compromise with the landlord that both parties can live with

Falling in love with a new roommate

A character thriving in a new home or neighborhood

Learning to plan ahead financially

Being content with a simpler, less materialistic life

Out of necessity, becoming more financially savvy

Reducing life stress because downsizing means the character can set money

aside for emergencies

Discovering the benefits of living with others instead of alone

A parent's decision to charge rent pushing the character to leave home and start making an independent future for themselves

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THE DEATH OF A PET

NOTES

Pets provide so much encouragement, love, and comfort that their loss can be a huge blow—especially when it's unexpected or carries an element of guilt. Tack this debilitating event onto the end of a string of minor conflicts, and it can be the proverbial final straw that pushes a character over the edge.

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having to gently tell a child the family pet has died

Needing to explain the role of death to young children who have never experienced loss

Helping family members grieve

Needing to do something with all the pet products in the house because looking at them causes too much pain

Having to make final arrangements (if the pet is going to be cremated, preserved through taxidermy, etc.)

Retrieving the ashes for burial and reexperiencing the loss again

Having to explain the death after the fact (when the vet's office calls about a previously scheduled appointment, to neighbors who ask about the pet's absence, etc.)

Seeing a pet that looks similar to the character's and being reminded of him or her

Having to get used to new routines that don't involve the pet (going for walks alone, sleeping by oneself, etc.)

Being criticized by others for not getting over the loss quickly enough

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The character adopting a new pet before they're ready

A well-meaning loved one buying a replacement pet before the family is ready for one

Being unable to adopt another pet because the character was partly to blame for the death of the first one

Family members needing opposing things to heal (one person wanting to get a new pet and the other being unable to do so)

The character's children struggling with the pet's passing

Losing a support pet and not being able to function without it

Being unfairly blamed by a grieving family member

Racking up a huge debt in surgery costs and tests

The death being part of a criminal investigation that requires the character to keep revisiting the details

The pet dying on or near the anniversary of another loss, such as a parent's death, a miscarriage, or the finalization of a divorce

The pet dying in the same way as an important loved one

The pet dying in a gruesome or violent way, and the character being unable to move past it

Remaining pets pining away for their friend

The loss compounding an existing mental health issue, making the character emotionally volatile and increasing the danger of self-harm

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anguish, Bitterness, Denial, Depressed, Despair, Devastation, Disbelief, Discouragement, Dread, Grief, Guilt, Loneliness, Longing, Nostalgia, Overwhelmed, Remorse, Sadness, Shock

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Regretting not doing more to save the pet

Blaming oneself (legitimately or not) for the death

Feeling shame or guilt for not being able to afford treatments that might have lengthened the pet's life

Second-guessing decisions to put the pet through painful procedures that ended up being unsuccessful

Being torn over the decision to lie about the pet's death (telling the kids the dog ran away or went to live on a farm) to spare them heartache

Wanting another pet but being afraid to experience grief again

Experiencing a lack of closure (if the character never got a chance to say goodbye)

Wanting to give in to grief but needing to be stoic for children or other struggling family members
Being unable to forgive a family member for the part they played (even accidentally) in the pet's death
Wanting another pet but being unable to afford one
Getting stuck in the grieving process

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Insecure, Irrational, Martyr, Melodramatic, Needy, Nervous, Withdrawn

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Esteem and Recognition: The character's self-worth will be lessened if they regret certain decisions, such as not spending enough time with the pet while it was alive or being unable to pursue an expensive treatment.

Love and Belonging: Someone who is disconnected from other people but has a strong bond with an animal may suffer even more when that pet is gone, feeling as if they have no one.

Safety and Security: The loss of a pet that also provided security in a dangerous area may result in the family feeling less safe.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Affectionate, Appreciative, Easygoing, Empathetic, Extroverted, Hospitable, Independent, Nurturing, Objective, Optimistic, Sentimental, Socially Aware

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Remembering the good times

The character recognizing the good they did in nurturing and caring for their pet

Deciding to donate to an animal charity in the pet's memory

Adopting another pet in need of a loving family

Recognizing that the love and companionship of a pet is worth the risk of loss

Accepting that it's normal to grieve the loss; being comfortable moving through that process

The character setting aside their fears or grief to take in a pet in need and finding it therapeutic

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Power Struggles

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BEING ARRESTED

EXAMPLES

The character being taken into custody by law enforcement (local, state, federal, customs and border protection, etc.)

A private citizen accosting the character and turning them over to law enforcement

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Not being able to get in touch with a lawyer or family members right away

Embarrassment or humiliation arising from a public arrest

Being intoxicated during the arrest

Being interrogated

The character's car being impounded

Becoming the subject of rumors and speculation

Relationship friction due to the arrest and its fallout

Having to pay for legal representation

Being separated from loved ones

Not being able to afford a lawyer

Going through substance withdrawal while imprisoned

The character's driver license being revoked

Having to deal with press inquiries and coverage

The character being placed on leave at their job

Being denied bail

Not having anyone who can afford bail or who is willing to bail them out

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Resisting arrest

Confessing to a crime without a lawyer present

Injuring or killing someone before or during the arrest

Becoming seriously injured at the hands of law enforcement

Developing a criminal record

Being kicked out of school or vocational training
The character's reputation being destroyed by the arrest
Losing their job or being unable to find a job
Losing custody of a child
Being disowned by friends and family members
Being targeted by people who want the character to stay silent
Not having access to medical or mental health care
Being framed
Being found guilty and sentenced to prison
Being assaulted in jail
Being killed while awaiting trial

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Agitation, Anxiety, Betrayed, Defeat, Defensiveness, Defiant, Depressed, Emasculated, Fear, Guilt, Homesick, Impatience, Loneliness, Powerlessness, Regret, Resentment, Self-Loathing, Self-Pity, Shame, Uncertainty, Vengeful, Vulnerability, Worthlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Suffering post-traumatic stress disorder from the arrest
Struggling with isolation and loneliness while awaiting trial
The character being unable to forgive themselves for choices that led to the arrest
Blaming others and harboring resentment
Feeling helpless and powerless
The character being unable to stop the arrest from playing over and over in their head
Being unable to disassociate themselves from the arrest
Feeling guilty for letting loved ones down
The character questioning their judgment
Feeling stuck in a negative pattern of behavior
Wanting to offer information in exchange for a lighter sentence but knowing it's not safe to do so
The character wanting to express their true feelings but not wanting to show vulnerability
Being tormented by stories the character has heard about what happens to people in jail

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Cocky, Confrontational, Controlling, Disrespectful, Evasive, Hostile, Impulsive, Irrational, Manipulative, Prejudiced, Pretentious, Rebellious, Reckless, Uncooperative, Verbose, Violent, Volatile

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: When freedom is taken from a character, so is their opportunity to pursue achievements or follow dreams. This need can only be met once a new meaningful goal is set.

Esteem and Recognition: A regretful character may feel as though they're not deserving of certain things, such as forgiveness, trust, or a second chance.

Love and Belonging: Friends and family can shun a character who has been arrested, leaving them without support. As well, an incarcerated character may have difficulty maintaining deep and healthy relationships, resulting in an ongoing unmet need.

Safety and Security: Being arrested will remove the character's autonomy. The unpredictability of being held against their will can also lead to increased anxiety and fear.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Calm, Cautious, Charming, Cooperative, Courteous, Diplomatic, Disciplined, Discreet, Easygoing, Friendly, Honest, Just, Obedient, Optimistic, Patient, Patriotic, Persuasive, Resourceful, Trusting

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Being released without being charged

Successfully bringing the real perpetrator to justice

The character turning their life around for the better

The character reevaluating their life choices

Becoming an advocate for at-risk individuals

Taking advantage of vocational and educational opportunities while in prison

The character developing a new appreciation for people who supported them through the ordeal

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BEING BULLIED

NOTES: Bullying behaviors and reactions will differ between youths and adults. Options for both are included here.

EXAMPLES

Being bullied at school, work, or another location frequented by the character

Being targeted online by either a known person or a stranger

A family member mistreating the character inside the home

Being threatened by an organization or its agents to toe the line or face the consequences

Being bullied due to an imbalance of power—between a guard and prisoner, for example

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having to pretend that the bully isn't bothersome

The character rearranging their schedule or route to avoid the bully

Not being believed by a confidant or trusted authority figure

The character peeing their pants because they're afraid to use the school restroom

A friend or family member knowing about the bullying and not doing anything to stop it

Having to stand up to the bully

Experiencing weight changes or physical illness from the stress

Being unable to focus on school, work, or important activities

Receiving poor grades or a bad performance review

The character having to hide their true identity to avoid the offender

The character being completely on their own in a situation where no one wants to get involved

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Having to give up something of importance to avoid the bully (school, play, work, etc.)

Needing to change classes, schools, jobs, etc.

Becoming physically injured by the offender

The bully increasing the intensity of their attacks

The bully recruiting others to make the character's life miserable

The character's reputation being slandered

The character fighting back and being punished with a suspension, expulsion, or an arrest

Developing anger issues that damage other relationships

Using drugs or alcohol to cope with the mistreatment

Repeating the bully's behavior toward someone else

Developing a serious anxiety disorder

Suffering a nervous breakdown

Attempting suicide to escape the pain

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anxiety, Conflicted, Contempt, Defeat, Depressed, Despair, Desperation, Dread, Fear, Hatred, Humiliation, Hurt, Insecurity, Intimidated, Loneliness, Powerlessness, Self-Loathing, Shame, Tormented, Vengeful, Vulnerability, Worthlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character suffering from lowered self-esteem and self-worth

Doubting the severity of the situation

Debating whether or not to tell someone

Having anxiety over going to school, work, or the place where the bullying occurs

Questioning whether the bullying is deserved

Fearing retaliation by the bully or authority figures

Experiencing depression and anxiety

Becoming fixated on revenge

Wanting to seek help but fearing being perceived as weak

Feeling betrayed by those allowing the bullying to take place

Becoming disenchanted (if the bully is protected by the authorities)

Doubting that the situation will ever get better

The character feeling trapped by a bully they can't avoid, such as a family member or teacher

Debating whether or not to walk away from something important, like school, a great job, or a beloved activity

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Addictive, Confrontational, Cowardly, Evasive, Gullible, Impulsive, Insecure, Irrational, Obsessive, Paranoid, Uncommunicative, Vindictive, Violent, Volatile, Weak-Willed, Withdrawn

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: If the bully is blocking the achievement of a goal or making the character question the value of that pursuit, the character may give up on that dream.

Esteem and Recognition: The harmful emotional, psychological, and possibly physical effects of bullying can damage a character's self-esteem, leaving them feeling weak and ineffective. If they are unable to stop it, others may start viewing the character through that lens, too.

Love and Belonging: Bullying can lead to isolation and mistrust, making it difficult for the character to open themselves up to others and build meaningful relationships.

Safety and Security: This need will become threatened for a character who is always looking over their shoulder and has no safe places to go.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Calm, Centered, Confident, Courageous, Decisive, Diplomatic, Empathetic, Friendly, Gentle, Happy, Just, Kind, Merciful, Objective, Optimistic, Perceptive, Persistent, Proactive, Resourceful, Socially Aware, Spiritual

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Finding an ally, therapist, or friend who helps the character successfully navigate the bullying

Avoiding an escalation in the situation by directly dealing with it

The character realizing the power of using their voice

Peers rejecting bullying (and the perpetrator), making it clear that such behavior is unacceptable

Breaking a chain of toxic behavior before the character passes it forward

Becoming a mentor to others who have been bullied, helping them regain their personal power

The character preventing the bully from victimizing them further or hurting others

Renewed faith in a system of authority that puts an end to the treatment

The bully having an epiphany about their own behaviors

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BEING FALSELY ACCUSED

NOTES

Unlike [BEING FRAMED](#), where the character is set up by the perpetrator, a character can be falsely accused by a victim, witness, rival, mistaken family member, or literally anyone. The following are just a few of the behaviors and activities a character could be accused of.

EXAMPLES

Bullying

Lying

Physical or sexual assault

Having an affair

Stalking someone or invading their privacy

Cheating (on an exam, in a competition, etc.)

Criminal activity

Racism, sexism, or other discriminatory beliefs and actions

Taking sides or choosing favorites in a conflict

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having to mount a defense (gathering evidence, witnesses, hiring a lawyer, etc.)

Being questioned by others

Being scrutinized by friends or family members

The character having to defend their actions to others, firmly rejecting the claim

Being placed on leave from their job

Being abandoned by fair-weather friends

A significant other asking for space, moving out, or separating from the character

Dealing with public scorn

Being monitored and judged

The character's freedoms or access being restricted

Being hounded by the media
Developing stress-induced insomnia

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The character losing their job or being unable to get hired
The character's family being ostracized
The character's marriage falling apart
Needing to move or change jobs to avoid the accuser or regain anonymity
Being found guilty by the public—even after exoneration
Losing important relationships in the wake of the accusations
Stalking the accuser
Retaliating against the accuser
The character falsifying or destroying evidence to clear their name
Engaging in harmful behaviors to cope (self-harming, abusing drugs or alcohol, etc.)
The character being convicted of a crime they did not commit
Falling into severe depression
The character becoming so despondent and hopeless they take their own life

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anxiety, Betrayed, Bitterness, Defensiveness, Defiant, Depressed, Disillusionment, Embarrassment, Fear, Hatred, Humiliation, Intimidated, Loneliness, Paranoia, Powerlessness, Reluctance, Suspicion, Uncertainty, Vengeful, Vindicated, Vulnerability

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character resenting having to prove their innocence
Considering whether or not to retaliate
The character feeling like no one really knows them
Wanting to force the accuser to confess but being afraid it would play into their hands
The character becoming consumed with clearing their name
Second-guessing the choices that might have led to the false accusations
Anxiety and worry over the outcome
The character questioning their judgment and who to trust
Feeling powerless over the situation
Experiencing disillusionment from being perceived as guilty until proven innocent

Fighting anger when the accuser is believed based on their word alone

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Cocky, Confrontational, Controlling, Dishonest, Hostile, Impulsive, Irrational, Manipulative, Obsessive, Paranoid, Pessimistic, Resentful, Suspicious, Uncooperative, Unethical, Vindictive, Violent

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A character may become so disillusioned by the justice system, society, or humanity in general, that it steals their desire to pursue meaningful goals.

Esteem and Recognition: When friends believe the accusations, the character might wonder if anyone actually knows who they truly are. They may also feel their character is being unfairly called into question.

Love and Belonging: The character may find their support circle quickly narrowing when others create distance or cut themselves off socially.

Safety and Security: False accusations can lead to insecurity for the character—with good reason, as these can be accompanied by threats, attacks, and other terrorizing acts.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Cautious, Centered, Cooperative, Diplomatic, Empathetic, Honest, Honorable, Just, Loyal, Objective, Observant, Optimistic, Patient, Persuasive, Professional, Resourceful, Responsible, Sensible, Spiritual

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Learning to set boundaries and be cautious in who to trust

Exposing the accuser as a liar

Being compensated for damages

Experiencing the efficacy of the justice system

Finding greater satisfaction in a new job, relationship, or location

Learning not to rush to judgment

Becoming an advocate for others who are falsely accused

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BEING PRESSURED BY FAMILY

EXAMPLES

Being pressured to change a relationship status by getting married, ending a friendship, etc.

A parent or grandparent pushing the character to have children

Family compelling the character to attend a particular school or pursue a career path

Being pressured financially (to make a purchase, save, invest in a sibling's venture, etc.)

Being expected to participate in social gatherings and attend religious services as a family

Being told to keep a secret or tell a lie to protect a family member

The family staging an intervention for the character

Being coerced into participating in an illegal family activity or helping cover one up

Loved ones advising the character to hide their true identity because they won't be accepted for it

Being pressured to live in a particular place (close to family or near family holdings)

Being compelled to continue the legacy of a family business (a ranch, the Mafia, etc.)

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

The character breaking up with someone they like

Having to hide a relationship from family members

Only dating people who have been vetted and approved

Having to join a club or take up an activity because the family wants the character to

Applying to a school or for a job the character has no interest in

The character being surrounded by family (when they'd prefer space)

Always asking permission instead of being able to make independent decisions

Having to mentally prepare an argument for anything the family might take issue with

The character having to monitor what they say and to whom

Always giving in to keep the peace

Having to attend therapy, counseling, or rehabilitation at the family's request

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The character getting married or having a child before they're ready

Marrying the wrong person

Having to relocate

A meaningful relationship ending for the wrong reasons

Rebelling in unhealthy ways (dropping out of school, dating someone because the character knows the family will hate him or her, etc.)

Taking a role in the family's illegal business

Sharing the family's secret with an unreliable outsider

The character needing to hide their true identity

Getting arrested

Purposefully self-destructing publicly to punish a controlling family's reputation

Turning to toxic substances or self-harm to manage the stress

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anguish, Anxiety, Betrayed, Bitterness, Conflicted, Confusion, Contempt, Defeat, Depressed, Doubt, Empathy, Frustration, Guilt, Hatred, Hurt, Inadequate, Insecurity, Longing, Powerlessness, Resentment, Unappreciated, Worthlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Feeling torn about betraying the family

The character compromising their morals, then struggling with questions of right and wrong

Being forced to choose between two things that matter

The character not trusting their own judgment

Being unhappy about keeping secrets, but knowing it's necessary to maintain autonomy

The character feeling torn between meeting their own needs and serving the collective good

Struggling with how to put themselves and their own desires first
Feeling as though love within the family is conditional
Experiencing guilt for betraying or being disloyal to the family
The character fighting their true identity
Experiencing anxiety or depression
Resenting the family

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Cowardly, Dishonest, Disloyal, Disrespectful, Foolish, Gullible, Indecisive, Insecure, Rebellious, Resentful, Selfish, Stubborn, Subservient, Uncommunicative, Uncooperative, Weak-Willed

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A character who sacrifices their true calling to please family will ultimately end up unfulfilled.

Esteem and Recognition: If their family doesn't approve of their choices, the character may feel like they're not good enough. Recognition may also be inaccessible if loved ones refuse to acknowledge impressive accomplishments that weren't part of their preferred path for the character.

Love and Belonging: A character will likely be able to overlook occasional meddling by family members. But if those interferences become controlling and pervasive, the character may have to deliver an ultimatum or cut ties and go their own way.

Safety and Security: If the family is involved in something illegal, this could present a danger to the character.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE:

Affectionate, Ambitious, Cautious, Centered, Confident, Courteous, Decisive, Diplomatic, Empathetic, Focused, Gentle, Honest, Honorable, Independent, Industrious, Just, Kind, Loyal, Mature, Objective, Responsible

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

The character learning to adhere to their own beliefs despite the interference of others

Inspiring others to resist pressure

Helping family members see that loyalty is earned through respect and isn't automatically bestowed by blood ties, tradition, or anything else

Breaking unhealthy patterns in the family dynamic

Changing the minds of loved ones

Realizing that love was behind the family's actions

Achieving sobriety or improved health due to the family's positive pressure

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BEING PRESSURED TO CONFORM

EXAMPLES

Being pressured to look a certain way to fit in
The character's political beliefs being ridiculed
The character being pressured to conform in their sexuality
The character's religious views being attacked
Having to act a certain way or maintain certain ideas to impress influencers
Being pressured to observe specific practices and rituals
A sociopath or psychopath needing to pretend to be like other people to retain their freedom

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Needing to lie
Being polite when the character doesn't feel like it
Having to cater to certain people or make them feel important
Arguing with others about their unreasonable expectations
Being ridiculed by others
Being criticized for not measuring up
The character needing to convince others that their viewpoint isn't a threat
Spending money to fit in (buying memberships, the right kind of car, a nice house, etc.)
Having to adopt expected practices
Not being able to pursue personal interests or talents
Having to make excuses for minimal enthusiasm, failing to participate, or lackluster efforts
The character getting caught doing something they shouldn't and having to talk their way out of it

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The character losing control and exploding, revealing their true thoughts and alliances

A double life being exposed
Being disowned by family and losing their support and influence
Being ostracized or cast out by friends
Irresponsible spending leading to bankruptcy
Receiving threats
Being blackmailed
Experiencing bullying, harassment, or discrimination
Losing their job
The character's loved ones being threatened
The character's secret becoming known
Having to hide or suppress their identity
Relying on toxic substances or self-destructive behaviors
Running away from home
Being forced into a brainwashing program
Committing suicide

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anguish, Anxiety, Betrayed, Bitterness, Conflicted, Defensiveness, Depressed, Despair, Dissatisfaction, Envy, Guilt, Inadequate, Intimidated, Loneliness, Longing, Paranoia, Powerlessness, Resentment, Self-Loathing, Shame, Vulnerability, Worthlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Feeling different from everyone else
The character being confused by who they are vs. how others see them
Being hurt by a lack of acceptance (especially from those close to the character)
A loss of self-esteem leading to self-loathing or hatred
The character worrying about their safety (if their secret beliefs would be considered dangerous)
The character loving their family and friends but also hating their closed-mindedness
The character becoming obsessed with fitting in or changing themselves
Not wanting to hurt loved ones but recognizing the character will one day have to go their own way
Knowing that suppressing personal beliefs is costing the character health and happiness

Feeling as though love comes with conditions
Being disillusioned by religions that profess godliness but are filled with judgment and intolerance

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Antisocial, Dishonest, Disloyal, Evasive, Gullible, Ignorant, Insecure, Needy, Oversensitive, Prejudiced, Resentful, Self-Destructive, Subservient, Timid, Uncommunicative, Weak-Willed

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: If the character's true identity is linked to their talents and they feel the need to hide those strengths to avoid ridicule, they will be unable to live in their full identity.

Esteem and Recognition: The character being told that they don't meet the approval of others will result in a loss of self-esteem.

Love and Belonging: Finding intimacy in relationships will be nearly impossible if the character is pressured to be someone they are not.

Safety and Security: Characters who don't fit within society's norms may be threatened or targeted by others, and their personal safety will be compromised.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Centered, Confident, Courageous, Courteous, Decisive, Diplomatic, Empathetic, Honest, Honorable, Independent, Mature, Objective, Perceptive, Sensible, Socially Aware, Supportive, Tolerant

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

The character committing to loving themselves regardless of what others think

Demonstrating a positive self-image for others

Inspiring others to embrace their true selves

Widening the perspectives of those who initially criticized the character

The character finding their voice

Becoming an advocate for others who are receiving pressure to conform

Challenging restrictive beliefs and bringing about necessary change and inclusion

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BEING SABOTAGED

EXAMPLES

Past secrets being made public by a competitor
A work or school project being destroyed or tampered with
A physical attack sidelining the character
Theft of the character's work or ideas
The destruction of a machine, facility, or system by an activist group
The public being influenced against the character through lies or manipulation
Deliberate underachieving and poor performance by coworkers or employees
Important supplies being purposely rerouted and lost
Official documents being destroyed
The media only reporting negative information (and ignoring anything positive) about a character, organization, or issue
The distribution of counterfeit correspondence meant to discredit the sender
Being victimized via deep fake technology
An ally being won over by the enemy or taken out of the game altogether
Being set up to fail

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Public opinion turning against the character
Lost revenue from having to pay for new supplies, repairs, labor, etc.
Having to regroup after a setback
Having to start over
Needing to think creatively to overcome new challenges (find a new supplier, try another tactic, hunt for evidence, sway public opinion, etc.)
Expending energy and time on dispelling rumors instead of on important work
Decreased responsibilities and opportunities, such as being demoted or removed from a project
Having to calm nervous stakeholders who are impacted by the sabotage

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The character's reputation being irreparably ruined

Losing a vital asset or resource

Losing a pivotal ally, influencer, or business connection

Getting fired

The character being unable to accomplish their original objective (bringing down a corrupt organization, righting a societal wrong, etc.)

A class-action lawsuit being filed against the character or their company

Loved ones turning against the character because they're tired of the drama

Family members being harassed or attacked

The enemy taking or destroying something that can't be replaced, such as an original idea, a recipe or formula, or someone's life

The character being physically harmed by a saboteur

Discovering that someone within the character's inner circle is helping the enemy

Being arrested for something the character didn't do

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anxiety, Apprehension, Betrayed, Bitterness, Defeat, Defensiveness, Despair, Desperation, Determination, Devastation, Disbelief, Discouragement, Disillusionment, Fear, Humiliation, Hurt, Indignation, Insecurity, Intimidation, Paranoia

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Shock and disillusionment that someone would stoop so low

Worrying about what will come next and who will be hurt by it

Worrying that others have believed the rumors and think badly of the character

Anger clouding the character's judgment

Not knowing who to trust

Feeling broken by this turn of events

Struggling with feelings of disempowerment

Engaging in fantasies of hurting the responsible party, yet knowing it's unhealthy to do so

Knowing fear is making them hesitate, and feeling cowardly for it

Feeling disheartened by people who distance themselves to avoid fallout

Being tempted to cross a moral line to defeat the saboteur

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Cowardly, Cynical, Gullible, Martyr, Melodramatic, Nervous, Oversensitive, Paranoid, Reckless, Resentful, Sleazy, Timid, Vain, Vindictive

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: When the sabotage damages something tied to the character's life work (especially if it took a long time to build, design, or create), the blow could be crushing. Rather than start over, the character may choose to give up.

Esteem and Recognition: If the sabotage isn't exposed, the character's failure may appear to be the character's fault. This misconception can cause others to believe they're incapable, unethical, or irresponsible, resulting in a loss of esteem.

Love and Belonging: If a romantic relationship is sabotaged—perhaps when a "friend" tells lies to encourage a breakup—the character may become bereft at the loss of two relationships. Knowing that someone they trusted is to blame will make it hard for them to lower their shield and let people get close again.

Safety and Security: A character who is blamed for a high-profile or far-reaching failure could be placed in jeopardy by an enraged public.

Physiological Needs: Some cases of sabotage can lead to the loss of human life, either purposely or inadvertently.

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Increased resiliency

The character being able to identify the untrustworthy people in their life

Renewed determination to accomplish what was originally intended

The character seeing where they were too trusting or naive, and making changes for the future

Out-of-the-box thinking forcing the character to come up with better ideas or methods

The character seeing the sabotage as confirmation that they're on the right path

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BEING SUED

EXAMPLES

Getting sued over an unpaid invoice
A wrongful death lawsuit being leveled against the character
Being sued for compensation over damages
Getting involved in a divorce or custody dispute
Being sued for breaching a contract or warranty
Getting sued for libel, slander, discrimination, or harassment
Becoming embroiled in a property dispute
Getting sued for product liability
Being sued for malpractice

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

The character having to be careful about what they say so their words can't be used against them
Making a public statement to address the filing (if it's a high-profile lawsuit)
Needing to obtain evidence or witnesses in their favor
Having to hire a lawyer and file paperwork
Hiring someone to investigate the plaintiff and the validity of their case
Fielding questions from friends or family members about the lawsuit
Incurring costs—from missing work or paying for childcare—from attending court
Having to do damage control to protect their reputation
Making lifestyle changes to afford legal fees
Needing to pay medical bills or other damages for an injured person
Having to compromise to reach an agreement
Needing to publicly apologize

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Ignoring the complaint and summons, which leads to more legal trouble
A plaintiff dying of their injuries, deepening the repercussions

Failing to negotiate with the plaintiff, and the case going to court
More plaintiffs coming forward to launch independent lawsuits
A class-action lawsuit being filed
Being represented by an inept lawyer
Evidence being discovered that damages the character's case
Getting caught lying under oath or falsifying evidence
The character losing the case despite being innocent
The character having their wages garnished or being unable to pay a judgment fee
The character losing their license to practice
Having to close or sell their business
Losing a significant other or custody of a child
Having assets seized
Becoming imprisoned as part of the legal sentence
Turning to toxic behaviors as a means of escape

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anxiety, Betrayed, Contempt, Defeat, Defensiveness, Defiant, Denial, Depressed, Desperation, Embarrassment, Fear, Impatience, Intimidated, Overwhelmed, Powerlessness, Regret, Resentment, Uncertainty, Vengeful, Vulnerability

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Experiencing anxiety over the outcome of the legal battle
Regretting choices that made the character vulnerable to the lawsuit
Considering whether to countersue the plaintiff
Frustration at being prosecuted when the character was doing their best—
e.g., a doctor treating a car accident patient who died from their injuries,
then being sued by family members
Feeling personally judged or attacked as a result of the lawsuit
Struggling to see a way out of the mess
Worrying about finances and how to avoid bankruptcy
Resentment toward others who played a part but weren't targeted in the lawsuit
Believing there's a political reason behind the lawsuit but being unable to prove it
The character feeling guilty for putting their family through difficult times

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Apathetic, Cocky, Disorganized, Hostile, Impatient, Irresponsible, Manipulative, Prejudiced, Stingy, Stubborn, Uncommunicative, Uncooperative, Unethical, Unintelligent, Verbose, Vindictive

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A character who is being sued will likely need to divert their resources away from self-actualization and toward self-preservation.

Esteem and Recognition: Being sued will inevitably impact the character's reputation as their name becomes entangled with the lawsuit—particularly if the case is drawn out interminably or attracts media attention.

Love and Belonging: Depending on what the lawsuit is about, friends and family members may abandon the character, leaving him to battle the legal system on his own. This betrayal won't easily be forgotten.

Safety and Security: The character's financial well-being may be jeopardized by legal fees and court findings.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Calm, Cautious, Centered, Cooperative, Courteous, Diplomatic, Empathetic, Honest, Honorable, Just, Obedient, Objective, Optimistic, Organized, Patient, Persuasive, Proactive, Resourceful, Responsible, Sensible, Wise

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

The lawsuit being thrown out when the character proves they weren't culpable

The character learning to protect themselves and their assets better

Taking preventative measures to avoid future lawsuits

Winning a countersuit

Avoiding a larger lawsuit or multiple lawsuits

Learning to compromise

The character taking responsibility for their actions

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CLASHING BELIEFS

EXAMPLES

Having political views that are oppositional to someone else's

Clashing religiously with another person

The character and their spouse having divergent parenting styles

Being teamed with someone whose work ethic is vastly different from the character's

The character's moral code clashing with another person's

Living with someone who has different priorities about work, leisure time, family, etc.

The character's civil liberties conflicting with a governing body's actions

The character's outlook on vaccinations and medical intervention diverging from the culture's

The character trying to work with someone who has a drastically different perspective

A parent and child having disparate education priorities

Being conflicted over state and moral responsibilities

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

The character being judged (for how they parent, their politics, not going to church, etc.)

The character being told they're wrong

Being teased

Avoiding topics of conversation around certain people

The character having to tolerate digs about their views to avoid arguments

Other people trying to push their ideas onto the character

The character being pressured to change their beliefs

Needing to lie about a particular view to keep the peace

Having to compromise to avoid strife

Getting into fights or arguments

Inadvertently offending someone

The character being denied access to opportunities or information because of their beliefs

Not being invited to social gatherings

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Being passed over in favor of someone less qualified who shares the decision-maker's beliefs

The character losing their job

A marriage failing because the parties are too far apart on certain topics

Being accused of intolerance or hate

Experiencing harassment (property damage, pranks, sabotage, etc.) meant to push the character out of a community

The character having to hide their whereabouts or activities

Becoming estranged from friends or family

The character being coerced into changing their beliefs

A partner with extremist views passing them on to the character's children

Clashing beliefs escalating to violence

Someone being killed for their beliefs

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anguish, Anxiety, Betrayed, Bitterness, Conflicted, Contempt, Defensiveness, Determination, Disappointment, Disbelief, Dread, Flustered, Frustration, Hatred, Intimidated, Irritation, Obsessed, Resentment, Shame, Smugness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character feeling torn about keeping up a facade and hiding their beliefs

Questioning deeply-held beliefs

Feeling isolated, shunned, or depressed

Having an identity crisis

Feeling invalidated or devalued

Feeling guilty about a relationship falling apart because the parties couldn't meet in the middle

The character feeling alone, lacking community or support

The character fearing for their safety

The character considering cutting ties with someone who espouses dangerous beliefs

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Confrontational, Controlling, Defensive, Disrespectful, Fanatical, Hostile, Hypocritical, Ignorant, Inflexible, Judgmental, Know-It-All, Manipulative, Oversensitive, Prejudiced, Pushy, Uncooperative

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: When a character's deepest core beliefs are threatened, they will sacrifice other meaningful ideas and goals to protect them.

Esteem and Recognition: Being challenged over their beliefs may lead a character to doubt themselves. If the character is ridiculed and treated harshly, their self-worth may be diminished.

Love and Belonging: The character's connectedness to others will be threatened if they concede their position to maintain a relationship (albeit a weakened one) or break things off due to irreconcilable differences.

Safety and Security: When contentious ideas escalate to heated fights and physical altercations, the character may no longer feel safe around those who oppose their views.

Physiological Needs: In extreme cases, differing belief systems can lead to war, violence, and death.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Cautious, Centered, Cooperative, Courteous, Diplomatic, Discreet, Empathetic, Honorable, Independent, Just, Kind, Loyal, Mature, Merciful, Objective, Persuasive, Socially Aware, Supportive, Tolerant

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Learning restraint and social awareness

Finding common ground with someone holding an opposing set of beliefs

The character learning about different beliefs and widening their perspective

The character educating themselves on their own belief system

Becoming more involved in volunteerism or philanthropy

The character testing their beliefs and becoming more grounded in them

Making room for positive beliefs and becoming a better person for it

Finding satisfaction in a new job or social circle that better aligns with the character's values

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EXPERIENCING DISCRIMINATION

NOTES

Discrimination can be defined as mistreatment due to an element of the character's identity or their identification with a certain group of people. It may be based on a multitude of factors, including age, race, intellectual ability, family status, gender, sexuality, religion, or physical ability.

The line between discrimination and harassment is blurry and very often will be determined by the specific context of the situation, but discrimination tends to be more generalized, with the character being treated a certain way because of a specific identifier. For scenarios where your character is being personally targeted (oftentimes, repeatedly) based on these factors, see [EXPERIENCING HARASSMENT](#).

EXAMPLES

The character being denied a place to practice their religion

Not being offered a job because of a discriminating factor

Receiving lower pay or unequal benefits at work

Not being taken seriously in the workplace

Not being given equal access to housing, education, training, or another advantage

Being interrogated about a purchase that other consumers wouldn't be questioned about

Not being able to marry or adopt a child

Being profiled by members of the public or by the authorities

Being excluded from clubs, memberships, and certain careers

Being denied financial support (a loan, scholarship, sponsorship, etc.) that anyone else can access

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

The character having to hide aspects of their life

Needing to convince others of their value

Housing or job choices being limited by a discriminatory factor

Having to find alternative means of transportation
Dealing with judgmental looks or comments from others
The character having to pretend they don't notice the discrimination
Not being given the same responsibilities or perks in the workplace
Being stereotyped by others
Dealing with ignorant questions
The character having to educate others about their race, sexuality, gender, etc.
Having to point out a double standard and fight for equal status
Struggling to achieve financial stability

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Having to sue someone
Publicly accusing a person or entity of discrimination without evidence, and being punished
A private or secret discriminatory factor being revealed
Getting into an argument or fight
Seeking revenge against the discriminatory person
Experiencing bullying, threats, or violence
The character being denied the ability to marry, adopt a child, or expand their family
Being denied critical medical or mental health care
Being held without cause or trial
Self-medicating to cope with anxiety or depression and developing an addiction
Attempting or committing suicide

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anguish, Anxiety, Bitterness, Defeat, Defensiveness, Depressed, Desperation, Disbelief, Discouraged, Disillusionment, Frustration, Humiliation, Hurt, Inadequate, Insecurity, Intimidated, Powerlessness, Resentment, Vulnerability, Worthlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Becoming isolated and depressed
The character questioning their self-worth
Feeling torn about speaking up—wanting to, but fearing it will only make things worse

Feeling helpless for not being able to protect loved ones from discrimination
Wondering if they will ever be accepted for who they are
Feeling pressured to fit in
Resenting people who have never faced discrimination
Resenting those who could be an ally but won't step in and help
The character being enraged when others minimize or dismiss the discrimination

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Antisocial, Cowardly, Dishonest, Disrespectful, Hostile, Inhibited, Insecure, Nervous, Prejudiced, Resentful, Subservient, Timid, Uncommunicative, Vindictive, Violent, Volatile, Weak-Willed, Withdrawn

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A character may be forced to live below their potential if they lack the same opportunities as everyone else.

Esteem and Recognition: Not being accepted based on a random factor may cause the character to question their own worth.

Love and Belonging: The character may struggle to connect with people who can't relate to their lived experience. As well, other characters may not pursue a deeper relationship with the character due to bias or the fear they will be similarly labeled and mistreated.

Safety and Security: Access to jobs, safe housing, and medical care may be diminished because of discrimination. This kind of mistreatment will also increase the character's vulnerability, making them feel unsafe around certain people or in specific situations.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Centered, Courageous, Courteous, Diplomatic, Friendly, Honorable, Persistent, Professional, Resourceful, Responsible, Socially Aware

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Impacting culture by educating people on personal differences

Helping secure safer environments for others (at work, school, public spaces, etc.)

Exposing harmful practices or bad actors in influential positions to bring about change

Self-advocating and receiving equal benefits and opportunities

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EXPERIENCING HARASSMENT

NOTES

Harassment occurs when a character is personally and repeatedly targeted due to their race, gender, religion, political views, or another identifier.

While discrimination involves mistreatment based on the same factors, harassment takes things a step further, with the character being picked out individually. The mistreatment can be a one-time event or repeated over and over by the same offender.

EXAMPLES

Being touched inappropriately or physically assaulted by someone

Threats, rumors, or personal information about the character being spread online

Being threatened or intimidated by a peer, coworker, coach, or supervisor

The character repeatedly being teased or mocked (about their accent, femininity, intelligence, financial standing, etc.)

Being on the receiving end of offensive jokes, derogatory statements, names, slurs, or epithets

The character being shown offensive pictures or objects without their consent

A person in a position of power placing unfair demands or expectations on the character

The character being questioned about aspects of their personal life they're not comfortable discussing

Being stalked

Being offered a quid pro quo arrangement in which the character must do certain things to receive advantages—perks that will be denied if they don't comply

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Putting up with the behavior so the character can gather evidence and build a case

Needing to document or file a complaint
Having to confront the harasser
Needing to find ways to avoid the harasser
Dealing with gossip and public attention
Having awkward encounters with others who fear being accused of harassment
Being threatened by the harasser or their supporters
Trying to befriend the harasser
Having to report to someone who has an existing relationship with the harasser
Being placed on professional leave while the harassment is investigated
Having to find another job, school, or place for an activity

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Being kicked out of school or a valued activity
The character losing their job
Not being believed, or the accusations being unfounded
The harasser accusing the character of negative behavior to deflect attention
Losing friends or family who do not believe the accusations
Having to file a legal claim
The character's reputation being falsely smeared
The situation going public and the character being dragged into the spotlight
The offender getting away with it because of their power or influence
Being targeted with violence

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anxiety, Appalled, Conflicted, Contempt, Defensiveness, Disbelief, Disillusionment, Dread, Embarrassment, Flustered, Hatred, Insecurity, Intimidated, Paranoia, Powerlessness, Resentment, Shame, Tormented, Vulnerability, Worthlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character questioning if they're experiencing harassment or just being overly sensitive
Gaslighting causing the character to doubt what they know to be true
Fearing retribution
Experiencing shame, low self-esteem, and depression

Feeling helpless because the offender has all the power (a teacher, boss, coach, trainer, etc.)

Being pressured by others to remain silent

Seeing no end to the situation

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Addictive, Apathetic, Cowardly, Dishonest, Foolish, Gossipy, Gullible, Hypocritical, Inhibited, Insecure, Nervous, Oversensitive, Paranoid, Sleazy, Subservient, Uncommunicative, Vain, Weak-Willed

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: Being harassed may lead the character to being limited at work or school. They may be so focused on avoiding attention that they decline opportunities that would make them successful.

Esteem and Recognition: Repeated threats and intimidation would negatively impact a character's sense of self-worth. Over time, harassment can deplete a character's strength and influence the way they see themselves.

Love and Belonging: A character who doesn't know who they can trust or what the consequences for talking about the situation will be may withdraw from intimate relationships in the hostile environment.

Safety and Security: Because harassment is repeated and intimidating, the character may have no sense of safety in their daily life. School and work may become places the character dreads, where they feel isolated and fearful.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Calm, Cautious, Centered, Courageous, Courteous, Diplomatic, Friendly, Honest, Honorable, Just, Objective, Persistent, Proactive, Professional, Protective, Resourceful, Responsible, Sensible, Socially Aware

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Protecting others from harassment

Discovering allies who are willing to defend the victim or bear witness to the harassment

Having an increased sense of agency

Reforming a harasser

The character setting clear boundaries for themselves and others

Inspiring others to speak up about being harassed
Recognizing harassment and intervening on someone else's behalf

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FORCED ATTENDANCE

EXAMPLES

Attending a funeral, wedding, or religious service because it's expected
Having to participate in a meeting, training, holiday gathering, or other work function

Being required to attend anger management, rehabilitation, or another court-ordered program

Having to attend school or vocational training

Attending mandatory therapy, marriage counseling, or another mental health-related session

Having to attend Lamaze or parenting classes

Being forced to complete driver's education

Having to attend a parent-teacher conference or a meeting with school administration

Needing to attend a family or school reunion

Being required to appear for jury duty

Having to check in with a parole officer

Being subpoenaed or given a court-appointed appearance date

Having to attend church services

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having to arrange childcare and possibly pet care

Incurring travel, lodging, and other costs to attend the event

Challenges regarding dietary needs (if the character has unusual allergies or intolerances)

Lost earnings from missing work

Putting off other plans or missing an important event

Having to put up with things the character doesn't like or finds annoying, such as long speeches, team-building exercises, or sugar-hyper kids at a family birthday party

Needing to adjust to the cultural norms of an event

Getting into an argument about politics, religion, etc.

A belligerent character being reprimanded for their behavior
Becoming intoxicated at the event
Insulting someone
Being caught gossiping or talking trash about someone at the event
Failing to dress appropriately for the occasion
Having to pay fees or tuition associated with the requirement
The character running into someone they don't wish to see
Dealing with unlikeable participants or trainers

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The character acting like a jerk at the event because they don't want to be there
Showing up but being belligerent, abrasive, or abusive
Getting drunk and doing something incriminating (having a fling, using illegal drugs, etc.)
Getting into a fight with the person responsible for the forced attendance
Purposely doing something at the event to sabotage it
Missing a parole appointment or other critical appointment that was scheduled at the same time
Being away from home when an emergency or disaster occurs

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Agitation, Annoyance, Anticipation, Anxiety, Apprehension, Contempt, Defiant, Dread, Embarrassment, Guilt, Hatred, Humiliation, Insecurity, Overwhelmed, Paranoia, Powerlessness, Remorse, Resentment, Self-Pity, Smugness, Vulnerability

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Resenting the person or people forcing the character to attend
Being tempted to rebel, either to express true feelings or get back at the responsible party
Being embarrassed by a family member or another attendee's behavior
The character feeling like they must hide their true identity or some other secret
Negative past feelings surfacing
Feeling defensive or put on the spot
Anxiety over attending the event
The character having to hide their animosity about attending

Being plagued by negative emotions related to the event's outcome
Dealing with temptation related to illegal substances, romantic interests, etc. at the event
Feeling misunderstood or that the character's feelings are not validated
Impatience (at how long the event is taking, at the people the character must interact with, etc.)

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Addictive, Antisocial, Childish, Confrontational, Controlling, Disrespectful, Gossipy, Impulsive, Insecure, Nervous, Rebellious, Reckless, Resentful, Selfish, Tactless, Uncooperative, Verbose, Workaholic

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: If a character is being legally monitored and their freedoms are repressed, they may be unable to pursue certain goals for fear of repercussions.

Love and Belonging: In a family where a pattern of forced attendance is part of the package, the character may resent having to choose between their own wishes and the expectations of others. This growing bitterness can weaken those relationships.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE:

Adventurous, Cooperative, Courteous, Easygoing, Enthusiastic, Extroverted, Friendly, Funny, Happy, Mature, Obedient, Patient, Proper, Responsible, Sensible, Socially Aware, Supportive, Unselfish

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

The character discovering a benefit from the event—e.g., meeting a new business contact

The character achieving personal growth

Trying something new and enjoying the experience

The character equipping themselves with knowledge, skills, or resources

The character expanding their comfort zone

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MISALIGNED GOALS

EXAMPLES

One character wanting to have a baby while their partner doesn't

A marriage proposal that doesn't end well

One character wanting to right a wrong while the other seeks to maintain the status quo

One character pursuing growth and improvement while the other just wants to coast

A protagonist being romantically interested in someone who doesn't feel the same way

Business executives who have different goals for their company

One business partner having altruistic goals while the other is only out for profit

Acquaintances entering into conversation with different goals—e.g., one wants to be heard and affirmed while the other wants to dominate the exchange

A parent wanting to protect or control a child who is pursuing autonomy

One teen pursuing a friendship so they can cash in on the other's popularity or connections

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Misunderstandings arising from incorrect assumptions

Having to adjust expectations

Tension in the relationship

Friction causing the two parties to avoid one another

Making small concessions to try to work things out

Attempting to distract the other from their goal so they'll move on from it

Softening the truth (or lying) to avoid saying something that will lead to conflict

Making assumptions about the other person based on their goals—they don't want kids so they must be selfish, their assertive business tactics mean they're aggressive and domineering, etc.

Delaying choices that would lead to improvements (forward-thinking business decisions, self-actualization, etc.)

Wasting time fixing the little things (because the character doesn't see the bigger problem)

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The character backing down even though their goal was the correct one for them

Both parties digging in their heels, resulting in a stalemate

Avoiding the issue to keep the peace, allowing it to fester and grow

The character pushing their agenda and damaging their reputation or driving the person away

Being blocked by the other person from doing what's right or best

The character determining to get their own way regardless of what it takes

Being manipulated, undermined, or sabotaged by the other party to further their goal

The conflict turning personal and irrevocably damaging the relationship

A relationship being categorized by friction and conflict

Slipping into roles (the frugal executive, the controlling parent, etc.) that stymie growth

Not recognizing that goals are misaligned, and getting mired in the related conflicts

Giving in on something big (like having children) and experiencing lifelong regret

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Annoyance, Bitterness, Conflicted, Confusion, Contempt, Defensiveness, Determination, Disappointment, Disbelief, Dissatisfaction, Doubt, Frustration, Hurt, Impatience, Intimidation, Powerlessness, Reluctance, Remorse, Resentment

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Growing frustration

Feeling personally slighted or invalidated

Resenting the other party

The character feeling limited or unable to reach their full potential

Wanting to be right rather than being open to a differing viewpoint

Questioning the relationship's fit

Wanting to quit or leave to end the friction but knowing that's not the answer

The character giving in and suffering a crisis of confidence

Being conflicted about the right path forward (seeing potential in both goals)

Wanting two things but knowing one must be sacrificed for the other

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Confrontational, Controlling, Greedy, Gullible, Indecisive, Know-It-All, Manipulative, Melodramatic, Resentful, Selfish, Stubborn

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A character may have two meaningful goals and be in a situation where they must sacrifice one (becoming a mother) for the other (marrying a man who doesn't want children). Whatever they choose, they may feel that a piece of their destiny is missing, leading to lifelong unfulfillment.

Love and Belonging: Uneven balances of power between a parent and child can create relationship friction and a weakening of their bond. As well, if a couple are not on the same page regarding certain goals (to move across the country, never have children, travel widely, etc.) it could threaten the stability of the relationship.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE:

Affectionate, Enthusiastic, Honorable, Idealistic, Introverted, Obedient, Philosophical, Private, Trusting

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Becoming more open to new or challenging ideas

Learning how to compromise in a healthy way

Recognizing what's important and what doesn't need to be fought over

A character who is used to getting their way learning to give in

Valuing people over plans or processes

Recognizing that the other party complements the character's weaknesses

Learning how to work with the other party and defuse conflict

Discovering someone else's deeper needs and motivations

Utilizing a third party (such as a therapist) to reach a compromise

Recognizing the relationship isn't working and taking the steps to end it

amicably

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NEPOTISM OR FAVORITISM

EXAMPLES

A parent favoring one child over the other

The coach's nephew getting the most court time

The office suck-up being given an important or lucrative client

A teacher doting on her "chosen few," giving those students special duties and roles

One child getting a larger inheritance than another

A negligent coworker escaping consequences because he's the boss's golf buddy

Being expected to overlook certain things for a preferential client

A parent being quick to believe her children over her stepchildren

Unlike the rest of the team, the star athlete is never reprimanded for showing up late

One university department escaping cutbacks that other departments are subject to

A coveted political position being awarded to a relative with no experience

A contract bid being won by someone close to the client

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having to bite back comments that will only start an argument

Speaking up about the issue and being labeled a troublemaker

Morale in the workplace slowly declining

Being sucked into university politics

Being unable to enjoy family functions due to drama

The character's workload increasing because a favored employee is incompetent or lazy

Dealing with a child's hurt feelings over a sense of unfairness

Competitiveness turning into a personal rivalry

The character trying to one-up a favored teammate to prove their personal worth

Friction between siblings who are treated differently

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

A family business going under because the wrong people had been put in charge

The character calling out favoritism at a family reunion, ruining the event

Speaking out against the favored party and being sabotaged by them

Talking to the wrong person about the nepotism and being punished for it

Calling out unequal treatment and being shut down by people who benefit from the favored one's influence and power

The work environment becoming so toxic that the character quits their job

Becoming stuck professionally, unable to advance

A blended family being unable to function as a unit

Lifelong sibling rivalry

Broken family relationships

The character giving up on a meaningful goal because they feel they can't beat the system

The character responding in a way that compromises their ethics (avenging themselves on the party, spreading rumors about them, etc.)

Becoming apathetic and underachieving, believing there's no point in putting in extra effort

Developing a negative outlook on life

Believing that love is conditional and tied to achievement

Sabotaging the other party to balance the scales and being negatively changed as a result

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Agitation, Anger, Betrayed, Bitterness, Contempt, Defiance, Desperation, Determination, Disappointment, Disillusionment, Frustration, Indignation, Insecurity, Jealousy, Neglected, Paranoia, Powerlessness, Rage, Resentment, Resignation, Schadenfreude, Unappreciated, Uncertainty

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

A deeply embedded sense of unfairness becoming an obsession for the character

Struggling with jealousy, resentment, or even rage

Uncertainty over whether the nepotism is real or imagined

Being tempted to suck up to the boss to receive the same benefits as someone else

Self-doubt setting in as the character wonders if their inability to advance is their own fault

Wrestling with feelings of low self-worth

The character worrying about being viewed as jealous if they voice concerns

Becoming jaded and seeing favoritism where it doesn't exist

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Catty, Childish, Controlling, Devious, Hypocritical, Inhibited, Insecure, Martyr, Needy, Paranoid

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: Nepotism that keeps the character from advancing can make them feel like their big dreams are out of reach.

Esteem and Recognition: Others who don't know about the favoritism may assume the character is less skilled or not as hardworking and doesn't deserve advancement.

Love and Belonging: One of the most destructive places for nepotism is within family relationships. When a character is consistently overlooked or minimized, they may feel unsupported and become uncomfortable with vulnerability.

Safety and Security: Being trapped in an unfair and toxic community can wear on the character's mental state, potentially affecting their health.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE:

Ambitious, Bold, Idealistic, Independent, Just, Patient, Proactive

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Helping the offender understand how it feels to be treated differently when there should be equality

Speaking out against wrongdoing and discovering others who feel the same way, gaining support

Using the nepotism as a personal motivator to excel without help or favoritism

Recognizing the unfairness of nepotism and resolving never to be guilty of it

Developing a highly attuned sense of fairness and applying it to every situation and relationship

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Losing an Advantage

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A COMPETITOR SHOWING UP

NOTES

While rivalry abounds in every aspect of life, romantic competition is a bit more specialized. For help in this area, reference A ROMANTIC COMPETITOR ENTERING THE SCENE, which can be found in Volume One.

EXAMPLES

A talented coworker joining the team

An up-and-coming business moving in that will compete with the character's own

Someone new hanging out with the character's group of friends

Someone competing for resources (a gold panner setting up a claim close by, a factory drawing large amounts of water from a river, an influx of hunters making game scarce, etc.)

Being upstaged by someone—a spouse's estranged, deadbeat son or a successful, attention-loving cousin—who shows up and steals the family's time, energy, and focus

A political competitor joining the race (for mayor, vying for a job, to head a committee, etc.)

A talented upstart competing with the character for a cherished role (as the lead in a play, the team captain, for a promotion, etc.)

Another candidate putting their name in for tenure at a university

Another group or organization vying for government funding

Student hopefuls applying for limited spots at the character's preferred university

The character ending up in a bidding war (for a house, someone's business or their goodwill, etc.)

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Being ignored or forgotten temporarily while the focus is on the new person

Having to jump through new hoops to accommodate the competition

Being the only one who sees the competitor in a negative light
The character being thrown off their game due to emotional turmoil caused by the threat
People or resources (that maybe the character took for granted) becoming less available
Having to call in a favor for help or to gain an advantage
The character being forced to show someone around and explain the rules
Being caught off guard and having to scramble to catch up
Having to be welcoming and upbeat when the character doesn't want to
Having to hide anger, frustration or hurt that would cast the character in a bad light

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Discovering the competitor has advantages the character cannot match
Discovering the competition is flouting the law or doing damage but being unable to prove it
Going up against a competitor who plays dirty
Losing to the competitor
The character calling out the competitor and losing esteem in the eyes of others
A smear campaign stealing the character's prestige, clout, or support
Losing out on a job, raise, promotion, etc.
Being set up by the competitor
Being blackmailed and forced to drop out of the race by the competitor
The character crossing a moral line that they come to regret
Being called out or cast out (by family, a social group, or an organization) for over-competitiveness and rash behavior
The character discovering the competition is unstable, and fearing for their own safety

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Admiration, Agitation, Anxiety, Bitterness, Conflicted, Contempt, Defensiveness, Determination, Humbled, Inadequacy, Intimidation, Jealousy, Nervousness, Panic, Resentment, Schadenfreude, Self-Pity, Stunned, Uncertainty, Vulnerability, Worry

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Wanting to play dirty because the competition is doing so

Believing in capitalism, yet resenting a newcomer who forces competitiveness

The character wanting to win because of their loyalty and dedication, but knowing the competition is more skilled or suitable

Feeling angry about having to compete when others don't have the same pressure

Becoming obsessed with getting rid of the competitor

Knowing the competitor is manipulating others but not being able to prove it

Admiring the competitor and wishing they were an ally instead

Struggling with jealousy

Loving a family member but resenting their support of the competitor

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Catty, Childish, Cocky, Macho, Needy, Oversensitive, Possessive, Reckless, Resentful, Self-Destructive, Spoiled, Vain, Vindictive, Violent, Volatile

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A character who shifts their focus from the overall goal to beating the competition may lose sight of who they are and what they believe in.

Esteem and Recognition: There are many ways a character in this situation can lose the respect of their peers—if they end up getting beaten, resort to questionable methods, or are deliberately smeared by the competition, for instance.

Love and Belonging: A character who must win at all costs may sideline the important relationships in their life, leading to conflict and distance with those people.

Safety and Security: When it comes to getting what they want, not all people play by the rules. If the stakes are high enough, a character going against someone who needs to win at all costs can end up getting hurt.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE:

Ambitious, Centered, Confident, Disciplined, Objective, Patient, Persistent, Persuasive, Proactive, Talented

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

The character having an epiphany (about why being chosen or winning is important) that helps them move past an old hurt or shift focus to healthier pursuits

The character being forced to work harder and discover their innermost strengths

The character's creativity or ingenuity in the competition being noticed by the right people

Discovering which supporters are true, and cutting ties with negative or distracting people

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A PLACE OF SAFETY BEING COMPROMISED

EXAMPLES

The character's home address being discovered by a threatening person or entity

A child's safe place (a treehouse, playground, park, or school) being vandalized

A safe house being discovered by nefarious actors

A neutral space in a conflict becoming compromised

Rioters occupying roads and public areas

The character discovering that their home, car, or office has been bugged

The character experiencing threatening or violent behavior in their home

The character learning that a child predator is working at their kids' school

A gunman entering a church or other public gathering place

Being monitored at work or home by someone who is a threat

Someone the character knows entering their group therapy session

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having to pretend nothing is wrong to keep a threat from escalating

Needing to find a new place of safety

Having to file documentation with law enforcement or a legal representative

Needing to restore the place to safety

Being interviewed by law enforcement

The character having to censor what they say or do

Not being able to carry out previous engagements

Having to increase security around a home

Having to seek help from someone who will expect something in return

Being unable to tell anyone about the threat (because the risk is still present or ongoing)

Suffering minor injuries

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Inadvertently sharing sensitive information in a place that has been bugged
Experiencing threats or violence in the place of safety
Ignoring the danger and returning to the location
Being forced to return to the place
Wanting to move but not being able to afford a new place
Seeking protection from authorities who turn out to be corrupt or inept
Becoming paralyzed by mistrust and struggling to feel safe anywhere
Seeking revenge on those responsible for the safety breach
Buying a weapon for protection and a loved one being injured with it
(because it wasn't secured, the character didn't know how to use it, etc.)
Ignoring the threat (or believing it can be handled) and a loved one being hurt
Developing a panic disorder

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Agitation, Anger, Anxiety, Concern, Defiant, Devastation, Disappointment, Disbelief, Disillusionment, Fear, Frustration, Homesick, Insecurity, Intimidated, Paranoia, Powerlessness, Reluctance, Resentment, Suspicion, Unease, Vengeful, Vulnerability

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Being afraid to return to the place
Struggling to know how much to tell loved ones
Wondering if the breach was random or the character was personally targeted
Feeling paranoid, as if the character is always under scrutiny
Suffering post-traumatic stress associated with the loss of safety
Questioning whether to confront the perpetrator
The character's moral code being challenged
Feeling distrust toward others
Knowing the perpetrator and considering bringing legal charges against them
Resenting authorities who don't seem to be doing much to restore the place of safety
Wanting to keep a child safe but not wanting to limit them by being too overprotective

Second-guessing decisions and actions about safety

The character struggling over whether to listen to their intuition or if they're being paranoid

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Apathetic, Cocky, Confrontational, Controlling, Dishonest, Disloyal, Foolish, Ignorant, Impulsive, Inattentive, Inflexible, Irrational, Nervous, Obsessive, Paranoid, Reckless, Suspicious, Verbose, Vindictive

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Esteem and Recognition: A character may feel like a failure if they were unable to protect a safe space for themselves or others.

Love and Belonging: A character whose trust was violated may withdraw from close relationships.

Safety and Security: An attack on the character's place of security can leave them feeling physically, psychologically, and emotionally unsafe.

Physiological Needs: If the character is displaced, they may be unable to meet their basic needs.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Alert, Analytical, Cautious, Courageous, Diplomatic, Discreet, Easygoing, Efficient, Industrious, Intelligent, Just, Objective, Observant, Patient, Patriotic, Perceptive, Private, Resourceful, Socially Aware

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Finding an improved safe space

The character learning to better protect themselves and others

Becoming more aware of the signs of danger beforehand

Learning to be flexible

The character facing and overcoming their fears

The character more carefully choosing who they let into their lives

Asking more questions about safety before choosing a school, neighborhood, place of work, etc.

Pursuing the perpetrator and bringing them to justice

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BEING CAST OUT OF A GROUP

EXAMPLES

- Being kicked out of a church or religious organization
- The character becoming estranged from loved ones
- Losing a professional accreditation or standing
- Getting barred from a social media platform
- Being pushed out of a social circle
- Being disinvited from an organized activity
- The character losing their place on a sports team
- Being removed from a committee or board
- Being told to leave a commune or community

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

- Having to give up a title or trappings, such as a special parking spot
- Having to return items tied to the group (an access card, keys, etc.)
- Having to hide a range of emotions—possibly shame, humiliation, or anger
- Needing to confront the group
- Losing friends within the organization when leadership requires a clean break from the character
- Changing routines to avoid members of the group
- Being pumped for information by family, friends, or people who feed off drama
- The character having no control over what is being said within the group about their departure
- Needing to make new social or professional connections
- Handling rumors about what happened
- Lying about the events that led to the falling out

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

- Being accused of bad behavior during the exit (stealing information, destroying property, etc.)
- The character's reputation being sullied

Sensitive secrets getting out
Publicly bashing the group and drawing more attention to the situation
Becoming embroiled in a legal fight
Losing a job or being kicked out of school
Becoming estranged from loved ones who are still in the group
Threatening, blackmailing, or attacking the group
The group determining to ruin the character
Being targeted with threats, blackmail, and violence
The group turning their animosity toward the character's loved ones, too
Being cast out and made defenseless against a larger threat

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anxiety, Betrayed, Bitterness, Confusion, Defeat, Depressed, Devastation, Disbelief, Embarrassment, Hatred, Humiliation, Hurt, Inadequate, Intimidated, Loneliness, Powerlessness, Stunned, Unappreciated, Vengeful, Vulnerability

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Being unable to let go of what happened
Feeling betrayed
Becoming obsessed with bringing the group down
Missing the friendships with individual group members
Feeling directionless; not knowing where to go or what to do
Considering compromising their morals to rejoin the group
The character hating themselves for yearning to still belong
Being worried about family members or friends still caught in the group's spell
Fixating on what led to being cast out
Feelings of paranoia and vulnerability
The character questioning their ability to exist outside of the group
The character questioning their faith
Replaying the sacrifices they've made for the group and feeling utterly disillusioned

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Childish, Cocky, Confrontational, Controlling, Disloyal, Gossipy, Hostile, Humorless, Hypocritical, Ignorant, Insecure, Manipulative, Nagging, Needy, Obsessive, Resentful, Suspicious, Unethical, Vindictive

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A character who is shunned from a religious organization may become disillusioned, questioning their purpose, their place in the world, and their connection to a higher power.

Esteem and Recognition: A character who is cast out of a group may question their strength away from the community in which they once belonged.

Love and Belonging: Losing connectivity with others can shake a character emotionally and psychologically as they quickly shift from being part of a group to being alone.

Safety and Security: If their association with the group provided protection (physical safety, immunity, an untouchable social status, etc.), being forced out will remove those protections, exposing the character to threats and dangers.

Physiological Needs: If the group helped provide primary needs, the character may struggle to obtain them outside of that support system.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Adventurous, Centered, Confident, Cooperative, Creative, Diplomatic, Friendly, Independent, Industrious, Objective, Optimistic, Patient, Persistent, Proactive, Resourceful, Socially Aware, Spiritual

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

The character learning to see themselves differently and respect others' viewpoints

Exchanging a toxic environment for a healthier one

Realizing that actions have consequences

Finding independence apart from an organization, and growing as a result

The character gaining perspective on appropriate levels of give and take

Learning to give and receive forgiveness

Becoming more free-thinking and open-minded

Starting a new group to replace the old one and finding more fulfillment in it

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HAVING TO LEAVE ONE'S HOME OR HOMELAND

EXAMPLES

Fleeing to safety and stability amid a political, humanitarian, or economic crisis

Marrying someone who lives far away

Being sold, kidnapped, or trafficked

Attending a school away from home

Accepting a distant job opportunity

Pursuing diplomatic or missionary work

A natural disaster making the character's home or homeland unlivable

Having to seek critical medical care in another location

Receiving serious and credible threats that push the character to start over elsewhere

Relocating to take care of an ill family member

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Getting used to a new routine

Having to learn a new language

Needing to establish new relationships

Having to find a new form of employment

Getting lost

Having a different socioeconomic or social status than before

The character's children having to change school

Having to leave belongings behind

Not knowing cultural norms for the new location

Not being able to attend school because the new situation doesn't allow it

Unintentionally offending someone

Having to find housing

Needing to leave a pet behind

The character's professional credentials not being recognized in the new location

Having to find new businesses or service providers

Being cut off from support

Not knowing who to trust just yet (or feeling there's no one to trust)

Being unable to communicate with those left behind

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Having to illegally move to a new country because a legal transfer was denied

The character being treated differently based on gender, sex, or sexual orientation

Not being able to find employment

Naively trusting the wrong person

Being scammed by someone posing as a benevolent individual

Being unable to return to see loved ones

Having less access to critical health care

Needing to leave loved ones behind

Having religious beliefs that could get the character killed in the new location

Being hunted down by bad people from the character's previous location

Feeling unsafe and terrorized because danger is present

Becoming a victim in a trafficking scheme

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anxiety, Bitterness, Conflicted, Depressed, Disappointment, Discouraged, Dread, Fear, Frustration, Guilt, Homesick, Insecurity, Intimidated, Loneliness, Longing, Overwhelmed, Regret, Resentment, Self-Pity, Shock, Smugness, Unease, Vulnerability

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Experiencing paranoia over having to return home (if danger was the reason the character left)

Struggling with culture shock

Suffering with homesickness

Resenting a loved one who may have wanted or needed the move

Being forced to leave others behind but feeling guilty about it

Feeling anxious about outings and social interactions in the new location

The character being fearful for their well-being and personal safety
Feeling torn between identities and cultures
Struggling with isolation or displacement

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Antisocial, Controlling, Disrespectful, Foolish, Gullible, Hostile, Ignorant, Impatient, Inflexible, Inhibited, Prejudiced, Spoiled, Tactless, Timid, Uncommunicative, Weak-Willed, Withdrawn, Worrywart

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Esteem and Recognition: Because status and recognition can be geographically and culturally dependent, the character may suffer blows to their self-esteem after leaving home.

Love and Belonging: Leaving one's home or homeland often means leaving family behind. A character in this situation may yearn for their loved ones while struggling to build new relationships.

Safety and Security: Outside of a known home or homeland, the character will have to identify new resources to achieve safety and security. Their health, personal security, and employment may suffer because of the change.

Physiological Needs: Being dislocated will negatively impact the character's ability to meet basic needs, causing them to go without food, water, shelter, or rest for a prolonged period of time and putting them in mortal danger.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Adventurous, Centered, Confident, Curious, Diplomatic, Easygoing, Empathetic, Enthusiastic, Extroverted, Friendly, Industrious, Observant, Patient, Resourceful, Socially Aware, Spontaneous, Tolerant

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

The character discovering their strengths and ability to withstand dramatic change

Finding a home that better suits their needs

Widening their perspective in terms of culture and social dynamics

Gaining access to better resources, such as education, food, and jobs

Forming new relationships

Finding a new appreciation for their own culture

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LACKING AN IMPORTANT RESOURCE

EXAMPLES

Not having food or water
Being without shelter or protection
Not having critical medication or medical supplies
Lacking the currency used in the local area
Not having a means of transportation
Having no way of communicating with others
Having no antidote for a poison
Having no leverage or anything to negotiate with
Being unable to make rent
Needing a key, access card, or code to gain entry to a place of safety
Needing someone with a specific skill set—a hacker or weapons expert—to defuse a crisis
Losing important documents that identify the character or provide protection for them

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Needing to find the resource or a suitable substitute
Having to borrow from someone else
Needing to abandon other pursuits to obtain the necessary items
Competing with others for the resource
Having to take another person's portion to survive
Becoming weak or ill from going without
Having to relocate to find the resource
Losing sleep
Having to beg for help
The danger increasing
A window of opportunity closing
Having to deal with profiteering due to resource scarcity

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Being taken advantage of and ending up in a worse situation

Having to trade another asset to get the resource

Obtaining the item by means of a personal sacrifice (the character's freedom, promising to leave their homeland, giving up a romantic pursuit, etc.)

Using an unsafe or toxic alternative

Getting lost in pursuit of the resource

Not being able to afford critical supplies

Sacrificing a loved one to get the asset

Turning to harmful substances to escape reality

Being forced to work off a debt in exchange for the resource (being trafficked or enslaved, forced to work in a labor camp, etc.)

Stealing the resource and being pursued, caught, jailed, etc.

Attacking or killing someone else to get it

The character becoming seriously ill or dying

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anxiety, Concern, Defeat, Despair, Desperation, Discouraged, Emasculated, Embarrassment, Envy, Fear, Homesick, Humbled, Humiliation, Inadequate, Insecurity, Obsessed, Overwhelmed, Panic, Powerlessness, Self-Pity, Uncertainty, Vulnerability

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Wanting to stay with loved ones but needing to leave them to pursue the resource

Feeling like a failure for not being able to obtain critical supplies

Obsessing over satisfying the need

The character considering compromising their morals to obtain the resource

Panicking about potential outcomes

Feeling torn about meeting their needs over someone else's

Desperate circumstances changing the character into someone they don't like

The character needing to humble themselves to obtain help, and not wanting to do it

Needing to give up something of sentimental value to get the basic resource

Feeling unfairly judged by others who aren't facing the same hardship

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Addictive, Antisocial, Devious, Dishonest, Disloyal, Foolish, Gullible, Impatient, Impulsive, Inhibited, Insecure, Lazy, Obsessive, Pessimistic, Reckless, Spoiled, Timid, Uncommunicative, Unethical, Weak-Willed

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Esteem and Recognition: A character who is unable to provide for themselves or others might experience a severe drop in self-esteem, feeling like a failure (even if it's not their fault).

Love and Belonging: The character may isolate themselves out of shame or a need to keep their situation private.

Safety and Security: Without necessary resources, the character's personal health and safety will be negatively impacted. They may resort to dangerous behaviors to meet those needs, putting themselves at risk.

Physiological Needs: Without basic resources, the character may become seriously ill or die.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Alert, Calm, Centered, Disciplined, Focused, Independent, Industrious, Observant, Optimistic, Patient, Persistent, Proactive, Resourceful, Responsible, Sensible, Simple, Socially Aware, Spiritual, Thrifty

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Learning to be better prepared

Becoming more creative and industrious

Building meaningful relationships within the new group

Learning to ask for and accept support from others

Becoming more generous with those in need

Turning the experience into a philanthropic endeavor

Becoming less materialistic

Realizing it's time to move on and seek a better life elsewhere

Accepting, in hindsight, that the decision to separate was the right one

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LOSING A KEY WITNESS

EXAMPLES

A witness to a crime becoming incapacitated or dying

Learning information about a promising witness that makes them unsuitable (a criminal record, a penchant for lying, a bias that will taint their testimony, etc.)

A witness refusing to come forward because it will get them into trouble with a spouse or parent

A sibling declining to get involved because they have a reputation to protect

Failing to get contact information from a pedestrian who witnessed an accident

A witness being intimidated into backing out of a case

Mitigating circumstances that will make a witness seem unreliable to a jury

A judge ruling that a child witness cannot provide testimony

A witness being deemed mentally unfit for court

A witness abruptly changing their testimony

A witness disappearing without warning

A coworker refusing to testify because they've been told by the boss to stay out of it

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Pleading with someone to step up and say something

Making promises to secure someone's help

Having to hunt down evidence of wrongdoing

Talking to anyone who might have seen something

Missing work or school to collect evidence

Seeking out people who may have recorded what happened on their phones

Asking nearby businesses if they have surveillance video

Pleading with police to investigate certain people or locations

Needing to find another witness

Having to build a stronger defense

The character needing to testify on their own behalf

Filing a legal appeal
Asking for a continuance

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Finding a new witness who isn't credible
The character being unable to disprove false accusations
Needing to hire legal representation beyond their financial means
Having to pay for repairs or other bills related to the incident
Developing a negative reputation
Being demoted at work
Being isolated when family members believe the other party's version of events
The character needing to relocate because their reputation is ruined by false accusations
Charges being dismissed and the criminal targeting the character or their family in retribution
A hostile environment being created by coworkers who believe a lie about the character
Losing a trial and facing jail time or another severe penalty
Being threatened or abused
A killer being set free and hurting more people
RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anxiety, Betrayed, Bitterness, Concern, Despair, Desperation, Devastation, Disbelief, Discouraged, Frustration, Grief, Guilt, Hatred, Intimidated, Panic, Paranoia, Powerlessness, Skepticism, Suspicion, Uncertainty, Vengeful, Vulnerability

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Feeling unsupported by people the character thought they could trust
Feeling insulted that their integrity is being questioned
Anxiety over the outcome of a trial or investigation
The character worrying that they're putting other witnesses and loved ones at risk
Experiencing paranoia; feeling targeted
Wrestling with feelings of helplessness and defeat
Feeling betrayed by someone the character thought supported them
Experiencing guilt over pressuring the witness to get involved
Worrying that the guilty party will go free and hurt more people

The character being disillusioned by the lack of support from a company, church, or organization

Being frustrated that people can game the system and get away with it

Being at the mercy of a powerful and corrupt system, and not being able to do anything about it

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Apathetic, Cocky, Controlling, Disloyal, Impatient, Impulsive, Irrational, Manipulative, Nervous, Obsessive, Paranoid, Pessimistic, Resentful, Suspicious, Unethical, Vindictive

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Esteem and Recognition: If the loss of a key witness will kill the case—particularly when a lot of effort was invested to secure them—the character may question their own power to reach a positive outcome.

Love and Belonging: If the key witness is a friend or family member who refuses to step up, that relationship will be challenged as the character sees there are limits to what that person will do.

Safety and Security: If the key witness was lost due to threats, intimidation, or violence, the character may feel that their own safety and that of their loved ones is at risk.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Calm, Centered, Charming, Confident, Diplomatic, Focused, Just, Mature, Objective, Observant, Optimistic, Patient, Persistent, Persuasive, Proactive, Resourceful, Responsible, Spiritual, Trusting

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

A new witness being found who is credible and able to turn the tide in the case

Reaching a successful legal or investigative outcome without the key witness

The character's sense of honor being strengthened by doing the right thing in difficult times

The character discovering who their true supporters are

Becoming involved in philanthropic work that aids those in legal trouble

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LOSING A VITAL ITEM

EXAMPLES

Not having a map or compass in an outdoor environment
Losing a phone or laptop
A family heirloom being misplaced
The character losing their passport or birth certificate, a relative's will, or other documentation
Losing necessary medication, a medical device, or a prosthetic
Not having a plug adapter for international travel
Losing car keys or a security card for work
A police badge and gun being stolen from a locker
An airline losing the character's luggage
Losing critical resources in an outdoor environment (a water purifier, fire starter, knife, etc.)
A key piece of evidence in a criminal investigation being misfiled
A wallet, credit card, or purse being stolen
Losing a portable energy source

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Needing to search for what has been lost
Wasting time notifying security personnel
Needing to file documentation for an insurance claim
Having to tell a friend, family member, or employer about the loss
Needing to notify banks and creditors
Having to borrow the item from someone else
Changing or canceling travel plans
Having to scramble for a replacement or workaround
Needing to summon help (a locksmith, technician, etc.)
Not being able to use their phone, computer, or another electronic device
Developing a reputation for being irresponsible
Lying about what happened
Being reprimanded for the loss

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Becoming lost in an outdoor environment or an unknown area

Being held liable for what was lost

Being detained by law enforcement due to a lack of documentation

Having to barter something of importance to address the loss

Not being able to communicate with others in an emergency

Getting caught lying about the item's whereabouts

Rushing to remedy the situation and ending up with a substandard or deficient replacement

The thief using the item to access sensitive information or secure areas

Someone committing a crime with the item, which is traced back to the character

Being extorted to get the item back

Being injured or killed without the vital item

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Agitation, Annoyance, Anxiety, Defensiveness, Denial, Despair, Desperation, Devastation, Disbelief, Dread, Embarrassment, Fear, Flustered, Frustration, Guilt, Humbled, Obsessed, Overwhelmed, Panic, Powerlessness, Remorse, Uncertainty, Vulnerability

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Feeling panicked, worrying with each passing minute that a stolen item is further from reach

Becoming obsessed with finding the item

Blaming someone else for the loss

Catastrophizing about what can go wrong

Indulging in self-blame over the loss

Being tempted to compromise their morals to regain or replace the item

Struggling with embarrassment and shame

Questioning whether or not to tell others about losing the item

Feeling responsible for what will happen if the item falls into an unethical person's hands

Feeling guilty when others suffer from the loss

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Controlling, Defensive, Dishonest, Disorganized, Evasive, Forgetful,

Inattentive, Irresponsible, Materialistic, Obsessive, Paranoid, Perfectionist, Possessive, Reckless, Scatterbrained, Stingy, Suspicious, Unethical

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Esteem and Recognition: The character's sense of self-worth will diminish with the loss of an important item—not only because they feel responsible (whether self-blame is deserved or not) but because they believe others will see them as incompetent.

Love and Belonging: Colleagues may not want to associate with the character and loved ones may be disappointed or angry, causing distance in these relationships.

Safety and Security: The loss of a vital resource that impacts the character's safety will make them vulnerable, creating a lack of security.

Physiological Needs: If the item directly impacts the character's survival, they may be unable to meet basic needs and find themselves in a perilous situation.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Calm, Cooperative, Focused, Honest, Humble, Industrious, Innocent, Just, Loyal, Mature, Meticulous, Nature-Focused, Optimistic, Organized, Patient, Persistent, Proactive, Resourceful, Responsible

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Regaining the item through negotiation or the intervention of a third party
A stranger finding the item and giving it to authorities so it can be returned to its owner

Developing improved organizational habits

Having a contingency plan

The loss helping the character identify an area of dependency that must be addressed

Asking for help and receiving it

Learning to be honest and take responsibility for mistakes

Receiving mercy and extending it to others

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LOSING ACCESS TO SOMEONE IMPORTANT

EXAMPLES

An informant being killed

An important resource (a lawyer, doctor, therapist, etc.) moving across the country

Having to end a relationship because of competing interests

The character losing custody of their child

Someone important becoming incarcerated

A friendship ending

Someone being out of reach (they're deployed at sea, in a coma, etc.) with vital information

A third party controlling the character's communication with the person

A star employee or moneymaker leaving the character's business to start their own

Someone the character admires or idolizes getting a restraining order against them

A loved one going missing

The character's ex kidnapping their child and disappearing with them

A mentor falling ill when the character desperately needs advice and guidance

Losing an ally

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Feeling adrift or directionless

Struggling with making decisions independently

Having to figure out a workaround or backup plan

Needing the person's permission to access a building, documents, etc.

Needing to go through the other party's belongings to find information

Having to find a new professional (a lawyer, doctor, therapist, etc.)

Needing to find updated information for a lost contact

Having to sneak around to see the other person
Needing to visit them in jail
Experiencing a disruption in services or the ability to work
Losing resources that the person provided
Having no one to ask for advice
Unfinished business with the person leaving the character in limbo

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The character's last exchange with this person being an ugly one
Losing emotional support or critical medical care
Asking someone else for advice and being steered wrong
An intelligence source being tortured, arrested, or killed
Important information being lost (the location of a will, a family member's location, etc.)
The person's last wishes not being known
Making an independent decision without guidance and something awful happening
Breaking and entering a restricted space to gain access to the person
Cyberstalking the person and getting caught
Violating a restraining order
Acting in desperation (kidnapping the child from an ex, responding violently, etc.)
The character never seeing their child again
Someone dying because the person or information they held couldn't be accessed

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Annoyance, Anxiety, Betrayed, Bitterness, Conflicted, Confusion, Defiant, Denial, Depressed, Desperation, Devastation, Disappointment, Disbelief, Frustration, Hurt, Obsessed, Powerlessness, Regret, Resentment, Unappreciated, Vengeful

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Worrying about the person's well-being or safety
Resenting the people or organizations that are keeping the person beyond reach
Having to choose between competing interests

Finding it hard to make decisions independently
Worrying about making mistakes
Experiencing anxiety and depression
Being unable to move on due to unfinished business with the other person
Struggling with unrequited love (if the character had unresolved feelings for the person)
Feeling judged or unfairly punished

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Addictive, Antisocial, Controlling, Disloyal, Hostile, Ignorant, Impulsive, Irrational, Needy, Obsessive, Possessive, Pushy, Rebellious, Reckless, Resentful, Uncooperative, Unethical, Vindictive, Violent

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A character who loses access to a professional mentor or someone with key knowledge may feel paralyzed about how to move forward on their own.

Love and Belonging: If the character was emotionally involved with the person, they may feel disconnected, isolated, and misunderstood without them.

Safety and Security: Building a meaningful and trusting relationship takes time and courage, and when that person is taken away, the character must start over with someone new. This can leave them feeling insecure and uncertain, especially if trust was broken.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Ambitious, Charming, Confident, Creative, Diplomatic, Disciplined, Easygoing, Extroverted, Flirtatious, Friendly, Industrious, Patient, Persistent, Persuasive, Proactive, Resourceful, Socially Aware

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Finding a relationship that is better than the one that was lost
Learning to adapt to change; becoming more self-reliant
Valuing existing relationships more than before
Becoming a more reliable contact for others
Learning to create contingency plans
Determining not to hold back with people; being open about what the character thinks and feels

Regaining access to the other person

Reconnecting with the person and achieving closure by saying things that need to be said, apologizing, being honest about feelings, or making a declaration

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LOSING ACCESS TO SOMETHING IMPORTANT

EXAMPLES

Being unable to access a resource, database, or password-protected application
The character's finances being frozen
Communication channels becoming inaccessible
Not being able to open a safe or vault
Losing access to a key, cipher, or translation code
Not being able to access roads or critical travel routes
The character's utilities being shut off
A car or boat being repossessed
Losing access to camera footage or critical evidence
Being locked out of a social media account
The character losing access to their home or office because it's an active crime scene
A credit card being locked
A character's backup file being corrupted, resulting in lost work or information

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Discovering someone has reset a critical password
Having to search a site for customer support or contact information
Having to contact a site's administrators for access
The character being unable to monitor their finances or pay bills remotely
Needing to create a backup plan
Being unable to pay for a lunch because a credit card is rejected
Having to find an alternate route or mode of transportation
Having to ask someone for help
Needing to borrow a replacement item from someone else
Being unable to get to personal belongings

Needing to request a new password, key, identification card, etc.

Having to ask to see a manager or someone in authority

Redeveloping a cipher, translation code, key, etc.

Establishing communication in a different, less convenient way

Wasting time while waiting for access to be re-established

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Regaining access to a lock box, storage locker, or building and discovering something missing

Being unable to turn the utilities back on

Losing access to crucial information or intelligence

Discovering that accounts have been accessed and personal information has been stolen

Bank accounts being emptied

The character's identity being stolen

Being unable to regain access to a social account because the administrators are unresponsive

Sneaking past a blockade and being caught

Getting arrested for breaking into an area that's closed to the public

Getting caught attempting to hack into a system

The situation escalating when the character resorts to intimidation or threats

Trespassing on private property to retrieve what was lost

Not being able to pay for critical needs

Breaking the boundaries of a communication arrangement

Being fired for losing the access and creating a security issue or for responding irresponsibly

Someone else being fired because they got caught breaking rules to help the character

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Agitation, Anxiety, Betrayed, Conflicted, Defeat, Defiant, Desperation, Disbelief, Discouraged, Flustered, Frustration, Impatience, Nervousness, Obsessed, Overwhelmed, Panic, Paranoia, Powerlessness, Suspicion, Vengeful, Vulnerability, Worry

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Feeling set up to fail

Being angry at people who take advantage

The character questioning their ability to handle life's ups and downs
The character being tempted to compromise their morals
Using questionable methods to regain what was lost and feeling conflicted about it
Experiencing vulnerability and a loss of control
The character not knowing whether or not they should ask for help
Becoming jaded at the world

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Cocky, Confrontational, Controlling, Devious, Disorganized, Hostile, Impatient, Impulsive, Inflexible, Irrational, Irresponsible, Manipulative, Obsessive, Paranoid, Perfectionist, Temperamental

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: If the lost resource is necessary for the character to reach their goal, they may be unable to achieve success.

Esteem and Recognition: A character who feels at fault for the loss could view it as a personal failing. Others may agree and resist trusting the character with important tasks in the future.

Safety and Security: When something so important can easily be lost or taken, it may create feelings of vulnerability that are hard to shake.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Ambitious, Calm, Confident, Cooperative, Creative, Diplomatic, Extroverted, Focused, Friendly, Industrious, Intelligent, Meticulous, Organized, Patient, Persistent, Persuasive, Proactive, Resourceful

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Regaining access and finding that no harm has been done
Feeling a sense of pride in accomplishing a task without the important resource
The character learning to secure their assets better moving forward
Becoming more adaptable
Appreciating someone who went the extra mile, and resolving to do the same for others

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LOSING AN ALLY

EXAMPLES

A neighbor removing their name from a complaint they helped the character lodge with the city

A coworker who helped influence a difficult boss quitting

Losing an influential voice for funding at the university where the character works

The character's co-council removing themselves from a case

Losing a connection at an influential newspaper or law enforcement office

A detective who supplied crucial information being kicked off a case

A business partner or co-founder deciding to leave the company

A friend who was a constant source of support and encouragement passing away

A spouse reversing their stance on a parenting issue and pitting themselves against the character

A sibling losing their resolve and giving in to family pressure

A political peer crossing the aisle to join another party

A teammate being traded to another sports team

Losing a talented assistant in an office shuffle

A coworker being offered a too-good-to-turn-down job at another company

A fair-weather friend changing social groups when the character becomes less popular at school

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having more work than one person can handle

Taking on new responsibilities

Having to find alternative sources of information

No longer being in the loop

Losing confidence in the mission or goal

Having no one to talk to about a specific problem or challenge

Losing the person's connections and skills

Missing the friendship

Having to keep up the spirits of those who remain
Having to act confident to put on a show of strength
Having no one to safely share misgivings and doubts with
Having to hide disappointment and act happy for the ally in their new opportunity
Needing to build new alliances

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The ally being replaced by someone with inferior skills or experience
The loss of a tempering influence making the workplace environment unbearable
Friends and family ganging up on the character to change their mind
Important relationships being damaged beyond repair
The city bearing down on a lone homeowner to sell their property, making punitive threats
Rebel forces falling apart because of infighting among the leadership
An important government alliance failing when the involved parties can't find common ground
A marriage ending because one spouse feels alone and unsupported
A criminal going free because the opposition's legal team was in disarray
A worthy cause collapsing because there's not enough support for change

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anxiety, Apprehension, Conflicted, Defeat, Defiant, Depressed, Determination, Devastation, Disappointment, Grief, Humbled, Inadequate, Loneliness, Neglected, Nostalgia, Overwhelmed, Powerlessness, Remorse, Resentment

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Feeling devastated but being unable to show it
Doubting the strength of the relationship (because the ally chose to leave)
Being happy for the ally in their new opportunity but sad to lose them as an asset
Worrying about how to move forward without the ally
Being tempted to give up or give in (and feeling shame for those feelings)
Needing to replace the person but feeling disloyal for doing so
Resenting the ally and feeling betrayed by their desertion
Doubting the reasons given for the ally's departure; wondering if it was

personal

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Apathetic, Callous, Catty, Confrontational, Controlling, Disloyal, Disorganized, Hostile, Insecure, Manipulative, Needy, Perfectionist, Pessimistic, Possessive, Reckless, Resentful, Tactless, Ungrateful, Verbose

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Esteem and Recognition: If the ally was someone who propped up the character's confidence and self-belief, losing them may trigger self-doubt instead.

Love and Belonging: Losing an ally within the family can be especially devastating, causing a sense of betrayal. The sense of being backstabbed could make it difficult for the character to forgive, and the relationship may never be the same.

Safety and Security: The loss of an ally who provided protection and security for the character will result in them feeling exposed.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Appreciative, Calm, Charming, Confident, Extroverted, Honorable, Idealistic, Independent, Inspirational, Intelligent, Loyal, Optimistic, Organized, Passionate, Patient, Persistent, Persuasive, Resourceful

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Refusing to let the loss keep the character from doing what's right

Finding new allies who believe as the character does

Refusing to quit, and being rewarded with a win that inspires others

Making new connections and enjoying the exchange of help, advice, and support

The character discovering they have the strength to lead and persevere

Overcoming personal doubts about the person's choice to move on

Setting boundaries with certain family members so the character isn't overly dependent on them

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LOSING ONE'S FUNDING

EXAMPLES

A non-profit organization losing their primary donor
A student's scholarship or grant being suspended
Financing for the character's business drying up or being withdrawn
Being cut off from family support
Welfare, alimony, or child support disbursements ceasing
Being forced into conservatorship
Losing research or project funding
Halting a construction project due to insufficient financing
A charity project not raising enough support for it to continue
A religious mission losing its funding
A community grant being suspended because of an economic downturn
A large political donor ceasing to support a campaign

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having to make budget cuts
Needing to borrow money from family
Having to move back home
Needing to take out a loan
Being delayed in academic studies or a project advancement
Having to fundraise or find a new donor
Postponing a new business development or project
Halting a residential construction project mid-build
Being unable to expand and hire in a struggling economy
Having to cut back on the scope of a charitable program or walk back projects
A business's share prices dropping
Being blamed for the loss

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Having to lay workers off

Being financially cut off from friends and family
Developing a bad credit history
Defaulting on loans and obligations that force others into hard times
Having to end a charitable program
Being forced to abandon an academic degree
Being evicted for not paying rent
Being sued for failing to meet certain obligations
A company going under
The loss causing the character to give up a dream
Compromising safety standards to cut costs and keep a project alive
Turning to morally questionable means of raising cash
Turning to toxic substances or addictive behaviors

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anguish, Anxiety, Betrayed, Defeat, Denial, Depressed, Despair, Desperation, Devastation, Disappointment, Frustration, Grief, Humbled, Inadequate, Overwhelmed, Panic, Powerlessness, Resignation, Shame, Uncertainty, Worthlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Questioning choices that led to the situation
Feeling like a failure for being unable to see the endeavor through
Considering a moral compromise to make up for financial losses—
accepting a donation from a shady benefactor or partnering with someone
rumored to be a criminal
Experiencing shame for relying on others and letting people down
Feeling inadequate
Worrying about what others think
Becoming depressed over the loss of their project, business, scholarship,
etc.
Experiencing uncertainty over their next move
The character regretting overextending themselves and taking risks

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Addictive, Controlling, Extravagant, Frivolous, Ignorant, Impatient, Impulsive, Indecisive, Inflexible, Irresponsible, Know-It-All, Perfectionist, Possessive, Pushy, Resentful, Self-Destructive, Workaholic

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: Losing funding tied to schooling, a project, or the character's passion may derail them in their pursuit of self-actualization.

Esteem and Recognition: The character may feel like a failure if the path they were on suddenly collapses due to lost funding. Their reputation could also become negatively associated with the setback.

Love and Belonging: Turning to family for a financial rescue can strain those relationships, especially if the character has been irresponsible in the past or loved ones resent being put in such a position.

Safety and Security: If funding dries up, an individual, business, or charitable organization may become financially unstable.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Ambitious, Bold, Centered, Confident, Decisive, Disciplined, Focused, Imaginative, Independent, Industrious, Intelligent, Optimistic, Passionate, Patient, Persistent, Persuasive, Proactive, Resourceful

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Finding allies in unexpected ways

Generating replacement funds through creative means

The character's commitment to a project being tested and reaffirmed

Finding increased happiness in a different job, school, or project

Discovering a community of people who are willing to help (crowdfunding)

Taking early action and avoiding a financial disaster

Learning and applying financial lessons for future needs

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RULES CHANGING TO ONE'S DISADVANTAGE

EXAMPLES

Participation requirements (weight, height, drug testing, etc.) shifting for a competitive sport

The interest rate of a loan going up

The requirements for professional accreditation changing

A contract or lease being updated to include new costs or stricter terms

Membership requirements becoming more stringent

Work policies being altered (promotion requirements, scheduling expectations, etc.)

The character's child custody arrangement changing against their will

A grading system being tweaked

A significant other wanting to change the way the relationship operates

A loved one updating their legal will or trust to include other beneficiaries

School entry requirements being made more difficult

New laws being passed that restrict the character's freedom to marry, vote, travel, become a citizen, have autonomy over their own body, etc.

A loosening of the rules allowing new competitors to flood a marketplace

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Wasting time navigating new processes or filing more documents

Needing to pay more money than under the previous rules

Losing a perk

Seeing a benefit shrink and having to decide whether it's still worthwhile

A decreased chance of promotion

No longer being qualified to compete in a competition

Rising taxes or fees resulting in less overall pay

An increased risk for certain transgressions

Having to change preparations for a test, career path, or entry into a school

Being fined for failing to follow updated rules

Needing to find another place of leisure or worship
Having to find another source of income
Losing an established social circle
Trying to appeal the change

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Being unaware of the change in rules and losing out on an irreplaceable experience
Having less access to an important person because of the new situation
Being denied a professional license or acceptance into a program
Being deported
Having to relocate
Needing to change jobs or schools
A job offer being rescinded
Being left out of a will
Separating or divorcing due to irreconcilable differences
Needing to default on a debt or file bankruptcy
The character's credit being ruined
Needing to borrow money at a dangerously high interest rate
Becoming incarcerated for not following new rules

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Annoyance, Anxiety, Defeat, Denial, Disappointment, Disbelief, Discouraged, Disillusionment, Fear, Flustered, Frustration, Inadequate, Insecurity, Irritation, Overwhelmed, Powerlessness, Resentment, Unappreciated, Uncertainty, Vulnerability

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Trying to determine whether now's the time to move to a new company that offers better benefits
The character being tempted to fabricate their qualifications
Feeling under-qualified or disrespected
Wanting to be honest but knowing the character won't get what they want if they do
Feeling like the odds are against them
Resenting the group gaining an advantage at the character's expense
Considering whether or not to challenge the change
Feeling targeted by the change despite knowing it's not personal

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Cocky, Controlling, Dishonest, Disorganized, Disrespectful, Inattentive, Indecisive, Inflexible, Lazy, Manipulative, Perfectionist, Pretentious, Pushy, Resentful, Spoiled, Uncooperative, Unethical, Workaholic

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A rule change at work or school can create new challenges which must be overcome. This could delay the character's achievement of a meaningful goal or encourage them to give it up completely.

Esteem and Recognition: A loosening of requirements may open the playing field to less-qualified competition, leaving the character to feel like their former accomplishments and prestige are now meaningless.

Love and Belonging: A character may lose their place in any social setting if they no longer meet admission requirements.

Safety and Security: A rule change may lead to the character losing things of value, such as a job, property, or access to health care.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Ambitious, Cooperative, Decisive, Efficient, Focused, Honest, Honorable, Industrious, Just, Meticulous, Obedient, Organized, Persistent, Proactive, Professional, Resourceful, Responsible, Studious

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

The character being forced to apply themselves, and growing as a result
Discovering new activities, jobs, schools, etc.

Receiving training or schooling that opens their eyes to interests they wouldn't have discovered

Successfully advocating for the return to previous rules

Finding a mentor who can help them achieve higher standards

Using the increased competition as motivation to achieve more in the workplace, in a sport, etc.

Becoming more adaptable and proactive so changing requirements or rules are less of a stressor

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RUNNING OUT OF CRITICAL SUPPLIES

EXAMPLES

Having no access to clean water

Running out of gasoline in the middle of nowhere

Running out of medication

The character firing their last bullet during a battle

Experiencing a food shortage in a time of crisis

Having no more emergency supplies to distribute (blankets, rations, vaccines, etc.)

Running out of surgical supplies in a field hospital

Having no seeds to plant

The character having no feed for their animals

Running out of wood, coal, oil, or other fuel for heat

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Discomfort from hunger, weakness, or thirst

Wounds going untreated

Pain resulting from a lack of treatment

The psychological distress of anxiety, fear, and dread

The character agreeing to an uncertain arrangement so they can get what they need now in exchange for a future favor

Having to think of temporary solutions that are less than ideal

Having to lie or hide information so people don't panic

Going without personally so others have what they need

Having to beg for help

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

A key provider abandoning the group and striking out on their own

Having to give up something of importance to survive (power, security, freedom, etc.)

Seeking help and becoming lost, stranded, or injured

The character having to do something they're unsuited for or inexperienced in—e.g., performing emergency surgery with no medical training

A physical condition worsening

Disorientation or weakness leading to a serious injury or mistake

Acting rashly and doing something dangerous (drinking contaminated water, getting caught stealing, etc.)

Being captured in battle

Being forced to surrender

Compromising morals to survive, such as killing the weak to preserve resources or resorting to cannibalism

The character having to sell an organ on the black market to provide for their family

Losing body parts to frostbite or gangrene

Death

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anguish, Anxiety, Defeat, Despair, Desperation, Determination, Fear, Frustration, Empathy, Gratitude, Guilt, Overwhelmed, Powerlessness, Regret, Resentment, Self-Pity

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character feeling like a failure because they couldn't save someone

Guilt for worrying about their own needs when everyone is suffering

Considering ways to secure necessities when doing so means others will go without

Lying to others to stave off panic, yet feeling that they're entitled to the truth

Weighing the moral cost of leaving a group in need if doing so will make it easier for the character to survive

Jealousy toward people who have enough

Wondering if it's okay to break the law when survival is at stake

Wanting to obey the laws but feeling abandoned by the people who made them

Shame and self-loathing at having to beg or suffer mistreatment to secure what's needed

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Addictive, Confrontational, Controlling, Cynical, Disloyal, Extravagant,

Frivolous, Gullible, Haughty, Pessimistic, Possessive, Resentful, Selfish, Spoiled, Ungrateful, Whiny, Worrywart

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A hyper-focus on gathering and holding onto supplies could consume the character, forcing them to divert energy from goals that would be personally rewarding and satisfying.

Esteem and Recognition: A character may feel "less than" if they are unable to provide for themselves and their loved ones.

Love and Belonging: In a survival situation, the character may be forced to choose who will receive supplies and who won't. This could test those relationships as people are divided into groups of the most important (say, family members) and the expendable (neighbors and friends).

Safety and Security: Running out of supplies could put the character at risk in a multitude of ways. Running out of a basic resource, such as firewood or fuel, is an obvious problem, but other security issues can arise if the supplies come with an extra measure of protection. For instance, if the character's resources maintained an alliance with someone influential, that relationship and its benefits will disappear when the resources are gone.

Physiological Needs: A life could be endangered if the wrong resource goes scarce or missing, such as a diabetic character running out of insulin.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE:

Disciplined, Easygoing, Generous, Hospitable, Idealistic, Kind, Loyal, Obedient, Trusting

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Finding someone willing to trade for what the character needs

Becoming better at managing resources in the future

People in the community coming together to navigate the difficult experience

The character coming up with a creative solution or innovation to circumvent the problem

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SOMETHING IMPORTANT BEING STOLEN

EXAMPLES

Someone stealing the character's identity

Thieves targeting the character's finances (cash, credit cards, bank accounts, etc.)

A personal journal or diary being taken

Someone stealing the character's medication

The character being robbed of something valuable, such as jewelry, artwork, or a car

An item with sentimental value being stolen (a picture, gift, heirloom, keepsake, etc.)

An important electronic device being taken (phone, computer, camera, etc.)

Someone stealing sensitive information that was entrusted to the character

A wallet being pickpocketed

A thief taking the character's access card to a secure area of a building

Family property—land, resources, or mineral wealth—being redistributed because of a legal loophole or shady bank dealings

A child's innocence being taken

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Filing a police report

Having to replace the stolen item

Having to cancel cards or change passwords

Needing to file documentation with an insurance company or financial institution

Having to tell a friend, family member, or employer about the theft

The character needing to clear their name or credit record

Having to testify in court

The character needing to improve their security measures

Having to review security footage

Having to confront a known and suspected culprit
Having to go to the police station to identify a subject
Canceling travel plans
Having to report potential damages to a business or boss

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The stolen item equating to lost evidence in an important legal matter
Losing the public's trust for not protecting something so important
Losing the trust of a loved one
Family abandoning the character for being taken advantage of
Having to file for bankruptcy
Being retargeted by the thieves
Sensitive information being used against the character
Being fired (if the stolen object is related to the character's work)
Being put on probation for using poor judgment or failing to prevent the theft
Strategic plans being compromised in a corporate theft
Being wrongfully accused of the theft or crime
Experiencing trauma from the theft
Going after the thief in a way that makes the character criminally liable
Accusing the wrong person, effectively killing the relationship
The wrong person being found guilty of the theft
People being hurt or killed when key information, such as a witness's location or the name of an undercover operative, is delivered into the wrong hands

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anticipation, Anxiety, Betrayed, Depressed, Desperation, Devastation, Disbelief, Disillusionment, Embarrassment, Fear, Grief, Insecurity, Longing, Obsessed, Paranoia, Powerlessness, Self-Pity, Shock, Suspicion, Unease, Vengeful, Vulnerability

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character feeling uncertain about their ability to protect items, information, or people
Becoming paranoid or suspicious of close colleagues

Developing an irrational or unhealthy anxiety
Directing anger inward for being duped or not being more alert
Being asked to cover up the theft by an employer, interested party, etc.
Thinking about not reporting the theft because someone close to the character is involved
Considering an egregious path to get back what was stolen
Assuming responsibility for the theft, whether it's warranted or not

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Confrontational, Controlling, Cynical, Dishonest, Foolish, Forgetful, Gullible, Inattentive, Irrational, Materialistic, Obsessive, Paranoid, Prejudiced, Resentful, Scatterbrained, Suspicious, Unethical, Vindictive

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Esteem and Recognition: A character who is targeted by a thief may feel weak or like a failure in the aftermath.

Love and Belonging: If the perpetrator was a known entity, the character may develop trust issues, choosing instead to withdraw from others to protect themselves and the things that matter to them.

Safety and Security: Because the character was targeted, the safety of the character and their loved ones, along with the security of their belongings, may be called into question.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Alert, Calm, Cautious, Centered, Discreet, Humble, Industrious, Just, Merciful, Objective, Observant, Optimistic, Organized, Patient, Perceptive, Persistent, Protective, Resourceful, Responsible

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

A successful investigation ending with the return of the stolen item
The character improving security protocols in their environment
Others learning from the experience and being proactive
Replacing something old with something better
Investigation of the theft resulting in discovery of someone responsible for even greater crimes

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Ego-Related Conflicts

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AN UNEXPECTED LOSS OF PRESTIGE OR WEALTH

EXAMPLES

Losing an elected office and position

A character becoming penniless (from a stock market crash, bad investment, robbery, etc.)

A business owner declaring bankruptcy and losing their company

An upper-level employee being demoted to a lesser position

Being stripped of a royal title or elite status

A respected member of society moving to a new culture where their privilege is not recognized

Being swindled out of wealth by an online scam artist

A wealthy or well-known character being convicted of a crime

An elite status being rescinded for bad behavior or because the character is embroiled in a scandal

Being excluded from a social circle and its trappings (connections, invites to A-list events, etc.)

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Embarrassment or humiliation

Having to tell friends and family about the change in circumstance

No longer having assistants or staff for daily activities, such as driving, cleaning, or cooking

Being rejected by friends

Being forced to find a new home

The character taking a job beneath their skill level or stature

Having to make new friends

Being denied entry to favorite events or clubs

Having special memberships revoked

Becoming the topic of gossip

Struggling to learn budgeting and planning skills

The character's wardrobe being inappropriate for their new lifestyle
Lying to people, pretending nothing has changed
Difficulty giving up frivolous extravagances
Having to learn the social or cultural norms in a new environment
Fair-weather friends distancing themselves from the character
A natural parting of the ways with people the character no longer has anything in common with

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Loss of emotional or financial support from the family
The character racking up debt to maintain a lifestyle they can no longer afford
The character's kids struggling to adapt to a new school or neighborhood
Adopting elaborate conspiracy theories to explain what happened
An enemy launching a smear campaign to further destroy the character's reputation
Becoming the target of a media witch hunt
Declaring bankruptcy
Not being able to find a job
Lashing out in retaliation and spilling secrets about former associates
Seeking revenge against whoever orchestrated the loss
Stress creating mental health challenges
Being alienated from children, a spouse, or extended family
Being sent to prison (if the character was involved in illegal activity)
Turning to alcohol or drugs
Engaging in questionable or illegal activities (gambling, stealing, etc.) to recoup the lost wealth
Becoming suicidal

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anxiety, Confusion, Depressed, Despair, Devastation, Disappointment, Emasculated, Embarrassment, Fear, Grief, Humbled, Humiliation, Inadequate, Panic, Powerlessness, Regret, Resentment, Resignation, Self-Pity, Shame, Shock, Worthlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character sinking into depression, self-blame, and feelings of worthlessness

Becoming envious of and obsessed with the lives of wealthy peers and colleagues

The character struggling to accept their new circumstances

Knowing someone is responsible for the turn of events but not being able to prove it

Mixed feelings toward friends who aren't as supportive as the character would like

The character's thoughts turning increasingly negative

Struggling to find a new self-identity

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Addictive, Childish, Cocky, Extravagant, Frivolous, Fussy, Greedy, Grumpy, Haughty, Ignorant, Impatient, Lazy, Macho, Paranoid, Pretentious, Self-Indulgent, Selfish, Spoiled, Suspicious, Vain, Whiny

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: This character will have to invest time and energy into stabilizing their financial situation and supporting loved ones during the difficult transition, leaving little time for passion pursuits. And until they have navigated the stages of grief, it's unlikely they'll be able to focus on higher goals.

Esteem and Recognition: A character's ego will suffer in this situation, and they may lose the admiration and esteem of many in their circle when their status changes.

Love and Belonging: Characters suffering a loss like this will often be ousted from social circles or peer groups, causing them to lose their place of belonging.

Safety and Security: A character who has lost their wealth will be forced to live without the security systems and personnel that gave them their sense of safety and well-being.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Ambitious, Appreciative, Calm, Centered, Courageous, Creative, Easygoing, Happy, Imaginative, Industrious, Intelligent, Mature, Optimistic, Patient, Persistent, Resourceful, Responsible, Spiritual, Thrifty

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Finding solace in a simpler lifestyle

The character spending more time with family and becoming closer to their loved ones

Discovering a new vocation that is incredibly fulfilling

The character recognizing that their biases toward people with less money are unfounded

Finding partnerships with people the character would never have encountered without a change of status

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BEING CUT FROM A TEAM

NOTES

This entry explores being cut from a competitive team. For other similar scenarios, see [BEING CAST OUT OF A GROUP](#).

EXAMPLES

A character not being chosen to represent their school at a debate competition

A middle school athlete not making a school team (volleyball, wrestling, basketball, etc.)

A professional player's contract not being renewed

A pro golfer suffering a devastating injury that ends their career

A gymnast underperforming and not qualifying for the Olympics

An athlete being disqualified from competing for taking performance enhancers

Being kicked off a team for cheating or unsportsmanlike behavior

Being ousted from a robotics team for getting into a heated fight with the other members

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

The character not understanding why they were cut or didn't make the team

Losing social connections with teammates

Facing teasing or ridicule from former teammates or fans

Having to confront the coach for an explanation

Joining a new team that's less competitive and below the character's skill level

Filing a complaint against the organization in an attempt to be reinstated

Being at loose ends, not knowing what to do with the extra time without practices or competitions

Losing income from sponsorship or endorsements

Missing out on a year of development as the character waits for the next opportunity to try out

The character's ego being knocked down a notch or two
Missing out on travel or large competition opportunities offered to members of the team
Having to stop wearing clothing or other items associated with the team
Having to attend events as a spectator instead of a team member

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The character lying to friends and family, not sharing that they've been cut
Apologizing or asking for forgiveness from the team and being rebuffed
The character finding out they were cut because of the coach's personal grudge or bias
Doubling down on workouts and strength training for the next tryout, then suffering an injury
The character losing their primary source of income (in the case of professional athletes)
Finding a new group to replace the old one and falling in with the wrong crowd
The character giving up on their passion, believing they don't have what it takes
Missing an opportunity to be seen by a scout or agent
Losing a college scholarship and having to drop out
The character turning to performance enhancing drugs to up their game
The character not learning from their mistake and being destined to repeat it

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Bitterness, Contempt, Defeat, Depressed, Devastation, Disappointment, Discouraged, Doubt, Emasculated, Embarrassment, Fear, Frustration, Grief, Humbled, Humiliation, Inadequate, Jealousy, Self-Pity, Shame, Shock, Vengeful, Worthlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Missing the social part of being on the team even while harboring anger over what happened
Being angry at teammates who were involved in the character being cut
Feeling as if all the sacrifices and hard work were a waste of time
Struggling when people who were less qualified made the team
Wrestling with depression, feelings of inadequacy, or worthlessness

Harboring a grudge against a coach that turns to deep-seated bitterness
Experiencing jealousy toward players who made the team
Wanting a second chance but being afraid to ask for it
Being unable to let go of the unfairness of the situation
The character losing their sense of self, which was wrapped up in their identity as part of the team

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Addictive, Catty, Childish, Cocky, Confrontational, Defensive, Dishonest, Disrespectful, Hostile, Jealous, Macho, Melodramatic, Resentful, Selfish, Spoiled, Vain, Withdrawn

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: If being a member of the team provided great fulfillment for the character, being cut could stymie their ability to become fully realized.

Esteem and Recognition: A character who is cut from a team may experience feelings of inadequacy and humiliation. They also could be looked down on by others who think the character isn't quite as good as they claimed to be.

Love and Belonging: Being a member of a team can provide a social network and sense of belonging, and the character may feel this absence when they're cut.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Calm, Centered, Confident, Courageous, Creative, Easygoing, Happy, Humble, Mature, Optimistic, Persistent, Sensible, Talented, Tolerant

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Becoming a coach for a team of younger, promising athletes

Discovering a new sport or art form that is more fulfilling

Joining a new team that isn't as aggressive or competitive, and enjoying it more

The character discovering that they don't miss the stress of competition

Switching sports and learning a new skill

The character taking responsibility for their actions and recognizing that the right choice was made

Having more time for socializing, school friendships, and new activities
Stepping away from a sport the character was being pushed to participate in
Separating from a toxic team or coach and gaining higher esteem and self-worth

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BEING DISCREDITED

EXAMPLES

A coach or authority figure being exposed for abusing minors in their charge
A lawyer being disbarred
A member of the clergy losing the respect of their congregation
The character being blackballed for their political or religious beliefs
The character's reputation being deliberately attacked in a smear campaign
A doctor being found guilty of malpractice
A business owner or prominent politician going to jail for fraud
Public backlash against a celebrity for their actions or beliefs
The character getting caught lying or passing along misinformation

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Losing support of friends, family, or fans
Experiencing discomfort when facing coworkers or former supporters
The character having to defend their reputation in endless meetings or discovery sessions
Having to make a public statement
Dealing with snide remarks or criticism from coworkers or strangers
The character not accepting responsibility for their actions
Having to apologize to people who were hurt by the character's actions
The character trying to place blame on others for their own actions
Facing disciplinary actions (fines, suspensions, etc.)
Having to shut down social media accounts for damage control purposes
Not having a ready defense and saying something that doesn't help the character's case

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The character losing their job and means of livelihood
The character not able to accept their change in stature
The character's spouse or children being targeted by the media, too

Enduring a trial that drags on for years
Nobody believing the character's claims of innocence
The character's marriage ending
Having to pay steep fines
Having to assume a new name and identity to escape the controversy
Being the target of an angry social media campaign or mass demonstration
Getting caught lying about the ordeal when applying for a new job, signing an affidavit, etc.
Continuing to practice despite being legally forbidden to do so (a doctor practicing without a license, a lawyer taking cases after being disbarred, etc.)
The character plotting revenge against their oppressors
Family members being made guilty by association for sharing the character's name
People being dramatically impacted by the character's misbehavior or ineptitude (a patient dying, someone being victimized, etc.)
Turning to numbing substances to assuage guilt
Adult children rejecting the character
Being found guilty (legally or in the court of public opinion) despite being innocent
Going to jail

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anguish, Anxiety, Bitterness, Defensiveness, Disbelief, Emasculated, Embarrassment, Guilt, Humbled, Humiliation, Hurt, Loneliness, Powerlessness, Rage, Regret, Remorse, Resignation, Sadness, Self-Pity, Shame, Vengeful, Worthlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Experiencing embarrassment or shame
The character being crippled by guilt over their actions
The character struggling to accept the disciplinary measures because they believed their actions were justified
The character playing events over and over in their mind and wishing for a second chance
Being innocent but not being able to prove it
Wanting revenge against the responsible party
Feeling disillusioned that one mistake has caused everyone to forget all the

good the character has done

The character believing it was a setup but not knowing who or why

Their self-image, beliefs, or faith being challenged in the ordeal

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Addictive, Callous, Cocky, Confrontational, Cowardly, Defensive, Evil, Haughty, Irrational, Irresponsible, Martyr, Paranoid, Pessimistic, Prejudiced, Pretentious, Resentful, Uncooperative, Unethical

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: If it took the character a lot of time and effort to reach the position they were removed from, they may find themselves at loose ends, stalled in their pursuit of self-actualization.

Esteem and Recognition: A discredited character will not only lose their position but the esteem and recognition that went with it.

Love and Belonging: If a character in this situation loses the support of friends, family, or colleagues, they will feel abandoned to face the consequences of their actions alone.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Calm, Charming, Confident, Cooperative, Courageous, Courteous, Honest, Honorable, Humble, Innocent, Just, Kind, Loyal, Mature, Passionate, Professional, Proper, Responsible, Spiritual

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Evidence being discovered that exonerates the character

Finding a new friend or ally in the process

The character stepping up and taking full responsibility for their actions

Their actions spawning a new law or rule to protect the public

The character having a spiritual awakening and atoning for their behavior

The character becoming an advocate for ethical behavior in their field

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BEING EXCLUDED

EXAMPLES

Not being invited to an anticipated event (a birthday party, gala, wedding, etc.)

A best friend spending time with a new love interest instead of the character

An ex's friends taking their side and disassociating from the character

Being an outsider in a community that embraces a different lifestyle (outdoor enthusiasts, vegan, swingers, doomsday preppers, nudists, a religious sect, etc.)

A character being excommunicated from a religion they identify with

Being denied access to a social club or community—due to economic status, ethnic background, or education level, for instance

Being denied membership to a fraternity, gang, secret society, or other organization

Marrying into a family and being treated like an outsider

Moving to a new school or community and being excluded socially

Decisions being made by other team members or coworkers behind the character's back

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Being viewed as a third wheel by peers

The character going out of their way to try to fit in

Awkward conversations when the character runs into members of the excluding group

A loss of status

Having to attend events where the character knows they won't be treated as well as everyone else

Having to build a new community or event to replace the exclusionary one

Finding it hard to focus because of hurt feelings

Having no one to make special plans with

Having too much time on their hands

Time spent searching for new social groups, communities, or religions to fill the void

Unhealthy coping (eating when lonely or rejecting good people who try to include the character, for example), creating new problems

Having to suck up to the group to be included

Wasted time spent trying to find out why the exclusion is happening

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Never finding a supportive, welcoming group

The character's children suffering from also being excluded

The character falling into depression, not wanting to engage in any social activities

Suffering a loss of self-esteem; internalizing the exclusion

The level of exclusion escalating as people involved choose sides

Losing friends who are included in groups the character can't gain access to

Striving to establish a rival group but being unable to do so, experiencing more failure

The character changing their personality or values to gain acceptance

The character making a public scene, embarrassing themselves and others

Going to extremes to bring down the group

Becoming so obsessed with being accepted by the group that existing friends are alienated

Becoming overly enamored with people in the group (stalking them, etc.)

The exclusion escalating to bullying or violence

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anguish, Anxiety, Betrayed, Bitterness, Depressed, Despair, Devastation, Disappointment, Disillusionment, Emasculated, Embarrassment, Envy, Frustration, Resentment, Resignation, Sadness, Scorn, Self-Loathing, Self-Pity, Shame, Unappreciated

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Intense feelings of jealousy or envy toward members of the group

The character doubting that they are worthy of acceptance

The character wanting to be part of the group despite knowing the group wouldn't be good for them

Knowing the character is going too far to gain acceptance but feeling compelled to do so anyway

The character questioning their purpose in life
Secretly rejoicing when others are also excluded, then feeling bad about it

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Addictive, Confrontational, Cowardly, Cruel, Cynical, Defensive, Gossipy, Impatient, Jealous, Macho, Martyr, Melodramatic, Oversensitive, Resentful, Worrywart

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: If a character becomes obsessed with being accepted by a group, they may sacrifice their own desires and passions—the things that bring them joy.

Esteem and Recognition: When someone is excluded by others, that person will automatically wonder what's wrong with them and why they aren't "good enough." This can cause their self-esteem to plummet, making them question their own worth.

Love and Belonging: A character without an inner circle of caring and supporting loved ones will suffer from having no one to navigate life with.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Centered, Confident, Courageous, Courteous, Easygoing, Friendly, Funny, Happy, Independent, Persistent, Socially Aware, Tolerant, Uninhibited, Whimsical

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Time spent alone resulting in the character knowing and appreciating themselves more

Discovering a personal deficit that is prompting exclusion (such as a lack of training or knowledge, or a tendency to be manipulative) and correcting it, achieving self-growth

Having a greater appreciation for the loving people in the character's life

Finding other friends who are a better fit

Recognizing that the issue is with the group rather than something being wrong with the character

The character realizing that it's better to be alone than to be with people who treat them badly

Becoming attuned to people who are being excluded, and taking steps to include them

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BEING LIED TO

EXAMPLES

Dating someone and discovering they've been dishonest (about their job, marital status, religion, criminal record, financial situation, etc.)

A teenage son or daughter lying about their whereabouts

An employee calling in sick when they're fine

Befriending someone, then learning that their identity is false

The character's spouse lying about their spending habits

A friend lying about why they need to cancel their plans with the character

Students making up reasons for not completing their schoolwork

A family member denying they broke a valuable item

A rival passing along erroneous information that puts the character at a disadvantage

A politician or government official being dishonest about their past, beliefs, or intentions

A parent lying to the character (about their adoption, unknown half-siblings, etc.)

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Suspecting the other person of dishonesty but not having any proof

The character having to control their reaction when they know they're being lied to

Having to discipline the lying party

Having to sleuth around to uncover the truth

Hurt feelings or embarrassment

Friction in the relationship

Mutual friends covering for the person who lied

Not knowing who to trust in a company or organization

Frustration at being kept in the dark

Being unable to act immediately on information (slowing things down)

Ignoring the behavior to avoid confrontation, and it happening again

The character believing the lies they've been told

Not knowing when the person is telling the truth
Telling other people about the situation and creating dissension in the character's social group

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Discovering this lie wasn't the first and that the deception has been going on for some time

Living in denial; blindly believing the liar

Always assuming the other person is lying, even when they're not

A valuable relationship being irrevocably broken

Overreacting and saying things that damage the friendship beyond repair

The lies resulting in devastating effects (being swindled out of money, implicated in the other person's illegal activities, etc.)

The character unknowingly repeating a lie to others and ruining their credibility

Unknowingly acting on a lie and someone being hurt

The character retaliating by exposing the liar in an over-the-top fashion and creating a spectacle Making big decisions based on the false information

The character not being able to forgive the dishonest friend or family member

The character blackmailing the other person to keep their lies secret

Having to sue the other person or file charges (because their lies are criminal in nature)

Discussing the situation with loved ones who take the liar's side

Assuming that people aren't being straightforward, that everyone lies

Becoming overly confrontational

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Agitation, Amusement, Anger, Anguish, Betrayed, Bitterness, Contempt, Defeat, Denial, Devastation, Disappointment, Disgust, Disillusionment, Frustration, Humiliation, Hurt, Powerlessness, Pride, Rage, Resentment, Self-Pity, Shame, Shock, Wariness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Grappling with why the person felt the need to lie

Waffling over whether to expose the liar or do nothing

Not knowing when people are lying or telling the truth

The character doubting themselves: *Did they really say that?* or, *I probably misunderstood*

Not confronting the other person, then feeling weak, like a pushover

Trying to forgive the deceit because the friendship, job, or mission is bigger than the lie

Seeing the red flags in hindsight and feeling stupid for being taken in

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Confrontational, Controlling, Fanatical, Foolish, Gossipy, Grumpy, Gullible, Humorless, Hypocritical, Ignorant, Inattentive, Judgmental, Know-It-All, Melodramatic, Oversensitive, Paranoid, Unintelligent

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Esteem and Recognition: Being lied to can make the character feel gullible, weak, or disrespected, causing them to doubt themselves. Likewise, people who know the character was lied to may think less of them, especially if it was obvious and they believe the character should have picked up on it.

Love and Belonging: Dishonesty breaks trust, fundamentally weakening the bonds between people. If a character was lied to by someone they deeply respected, they may have difficulty trusting others and can end up with no one to confide in.

Safety and Security: There are many ways a lie can make a character feel less safe, such as it resulting in the character being scammed, assaulted, or contracting an STD.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Alert, Analytical, Bold, Calm, Cautious, Centered, Confident, Courageous, Curious, Diplomatic, Honest, Intelligent, Just, Mature, Perceptive, Professional, Sensible, Tolerant, Wise

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Discovering a friend's true nature and cutting ties before further harm is done

Calling out the liar and being able to protect others from him or her

The character becoming a more honest person in the aftermath

Publicizing the truth about a lie so others will have the correct information

Recognizing the signs of dishonesty in others

Learning the right way to confront a liar so it can be done effectively in the future

The character discovering that they have a knack for research or rooting out the truth

Discovering fraud or treachery and submitting evidence to police so the offender can be charged

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BEING MICROMANAGED

EXAMPLES

A boss needing to review everything the character does

Every decision being questioned by someone in authority

A spouse controlling the character's schedule

Volunteering to do a home-improvement job for someone who has to oversee everything

Being married to a professional who micromanages the character at home (a chef being hyper-critical in the kitchen, a therapist psychoanalyzing the character, etc.)

Having to justify decisions the character should be able to make on their own

Being given a job that is taken over by someone who thinks they can do it better

A parent not allowing their child to make age-appropriate decisions

The character not being allowed to use the methods that work best for them

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having to redo a perfectly good project multiple times before it's approved

Frequent arguments over how to do something

The character wanting to get away from the person doing the micromanaging

The character's boundaries with a coworker being breached

Work progressing at a slow pace

Lack of job satisfaction

The interfering party claiming or sharing credit for the character's success

The character going out of their way to avoid the individual

Criticism causing the character to procrastinate

The character making more mistakes due to stress and fear

Having to hide things from a friend so they don't interfere

Always needing to be ready with answers for everything

Having to work long hours to finish a job to the boss's satisfaction
The character going over the boss's head to complain and being reprimanded for it
Marital stress due to a lack of trust or privacy

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Becoming complacent or apathetic, letting the micromanager make all the decisions

The character becoming a perfectionist to avoid criticism

Soaring costs arising from inefficiency and work having to be redone

The character not feeling comfortable in their own home

A strained relationship between parent and child

Being stuck in a toxic work environment

Quitting a job or contract without another one lined up

Losing interest in work and forming bad habits (calling in sick, taking extended lunches, slacking during work hours, etc.)

The character turning down promising opportunities because the micromanager is involved

The character's marriage falling apart

Not doing anything until the stress reaches a boiling point and the character responds in a detrimental way

Becoming paralyzed with indecision

Becoming a micromanager of others

The character losing their joy (at work, with their spouse, etc.)

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Agitation, Annoyance, Anxiety, Bitterness, Defensiveness, Discouraged, Dissatisfaction, Doubt, Dread, Fear, Flustered, Frustration, Humbled, Irritation, Resentment, Resignation, Self-Pity, Unappreciated, Uncertainty, Unease, Worthlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character doubting their own capability

Wanting to avoid conflict but feeling like the problem is reaching a boiling point

Feeling smothered by a know-it-all in-law but not wanting it to impact the marriage

Wanting to stand up to the micromanaging boss but fearing repercussions

The character mentally reviewing various choices and not knowing what to do

Choosing not to rock the boat but growing in resentment and bitterness

Weighing whether to cut ties with someone because they won't change

The character recognizing that the micromanager produces better results while resenting their methods

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Apathetic, Childish, Cocky, Confrontational, Cowardly, Defensive, Grumpy, Haughty, Inflexible, Know-It-All, Lazy, Macho, Nervous, Oversensitive, Perfectionist, Resentful, Stubborn, Workaholic

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: Being micromanaged at work can lead to low job satisfaction. This is especially problematic if the position is one the character has worked hard to earn.

Esteem and Recognition: Constant criticism can seed self-doubt and cause the character to feel undervalued and unappreciated.

Love and Belonging: Micromanagement from loved ones will often encourage the character to pull away, creating distance in those important relationships.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Ambitious, Analytical, Appreciative, Bold, Confident, Cooperative, Disciplined, Easygoing, Enthusiastic, Happy, Humble, Industrious, Meticulous, Obedient, Patient, Persuasive, Professional

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Acknowledging that the micromanager's involvement caught a critical error before it was too late

Recognizing that certain aspects of the critical person's process are beneficial, and adopting them

The character standing up for themselves, earning more freedom and respect

Pushing back and creating healthy boundaries

Bringing the micromanager's methods to light, resulting in a happier environment

Being sensitive to micromanaging techniques and resolving not to use them with others

The character recognizing their own talents and values so the criticism isn't internalized

Looking for another job and finding one that offers more trust and autonomy

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BEING PHYSICALLY MARRED BEFORE AN IMPORTANT EVENT

NOTES

No one wants to be overshadowed by their physical shortcomings. This is especially true when the character is put on display or needs to make a good impression.

EXAMPLES

Acne breaking out on prom day

The character getting a bad haircut the day before a family photo shoot

An allergic reaction causing the character's face to swell prior to a press conference

Getting a black eye the day before meeting a significant other's parents

Breaking a leg a few days before being a bridesmaid in a friend's wedding

Contracting pink eye before a coveted job interview

Suffering abrasions in a car accident on the way to meet with a social worker or parole officer

Losing a tooth before a first date

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having to reschedule the event

Taking longer than normal to prepare and being late

Being teased by friends

Figuring out how to hide the disfigurement (with makeup, new clothes, sunglasses, etc.)

Having to see a doctor for the injuries

Having to repeatedly explain what happened (possibly reliving an embarrassing moment)

Lying to others about what caused the deformity

Trying to act like everything's normal

Discomfort from people looking and staring

Being hyperaware of the deformity, making it hard to concentrate

Nervousness from the disfigurement causing the character to perform poorly
Fielding awkward questions from people at the big event
Dealing with public gossip and criticism (if the event was publicized)
Physical discomfort
Becoming part of the rumor mill
The injuries affecting the character's physical ability to do well
Being fuzzy from medication
The accident or resulting injuries stealing preparation time for an important event

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Trying a home remedy that makes things worse
Pictures of the character's appearance going viral
The event being canceled without an option to reschedule
People making incorrect assumptions about what happened to the character
The character experiencing a serious side effect from medication
The character's appearance playing a part in the event's unfavorable outcome (not getting the job, potential in-laws not approving, etc.)
Being unable to complete the event due to the pain
The character's lies about what happened being found out and made public
The character blaming a bad outcome on their appearance when it had nothing to do with it
Having a panic or anxiety attack during the event
The disfigurement becoming permanent

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anguish, Anxiety, Apprehension, Depressed, Despair, Desperation, Devastation, Disappointment, Embarrassment, Frustration, Grief, Humbled, Humiliation, Longing, Neglected, Panic, Paranoia, Rage, Self-Loathing, Self-Pity, Shame, Unease

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character blaming themselves for the disfigurement
Wanting to come up with an excuse to bail on the event and feeling shallow for feeling that way
Assuming that things will go terribly and obsessing over the worst-case scenario

Being terrified of attending the event but feeling like they have no choice
Second-guessing whatever decision is made
Being sidelined by self-pity
Dreading an upcoming event that should be joyful; not wanting to feel that way but being unable to feel differently

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Childish, Cocky, Cowardly, Grumpy, Humorless, Insecure, Jealous, Macho, Martyr, Materialistic, Melodramatic, Needy, Nervous, Paranoid, Perfectionist, Prejudiced, Pretentious, Self-Destructive, Vain

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: If the event is one the character is passionate about or has long pursued, it being canceled, postponed, or ruined may cause them to give up on it altogether.

Esteem and Recognition: A character who is treated differently after the disfigurement or looked at with pity may result in them pitying and feeling sorry for themselves. If the character's good looks are tied to their self-worth, a situation like this could be especially damaging.

Love and Belonging: A character who is embarrassed by their appearance may avoid others, becoming isolated.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Calm, Centered, Charming, Confident, Courageous, Creative, Easygoing, Extroverted, Flamboyant, Funny, Happy, Humble, Inspirational, Mature, Optimistic, Quirky, Resourceful, Spiritual, Spunky, Witty

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

The character succeeding despite their physical appearance, growing in confidence

The character being able to fully enjoy the event, realizing that sheer will and perseverance can carry them through times of uncertainty

The character learning who their true friends are

Resolving to be more careful before important events in the future

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EXPERIENCING A CRISIS OF SELF-DOUBT

NOTES

Self-doubt is difficult to deal with at the best of times. But when it strikes during high-stress events or moments when decisiveness and quick thinking are imperative, the stakes go up dramatically. To complicate matters, consider adding a healthy dose of insecurity to the following scenarios.

EXAMPLES

As the character is getting ready to propose

When they're trying something new (auditioning for a play, starting an internship, etc.)

When the character is thrust into unexpected or reluctant leadership

Before taking a dangerous step, such as jumping out of a plane or running into a burning building

While participating in a heist, kidnapping, or assassination

When delivering an important speech

While lying their way out of a situation

When others are relying on the character

Before the character's first big challenge (as a team captain, in a promising relationship, etc.)

When it's important to speak up or take action—e.g., to right a wrong

When impressing someone is vital

In a split-second-decision situation

When someone's life is on the line

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Giving in to procrastination or indecision and losing valuable time

Anxiety escalating, making it hard to focus

Needing to find a place to safely calm down

Seeking out reassurance from someone else before going ahead

Delaying, and missing an opportunity

Someone else stepping in to take charge
A competitor gaining an advantage
Missing the perfect moment
Creating the seed of doubt in others (about the character's abilities, leadership, commitment, etc.)
Never getting a chance to say something to someone important
Disappointing others

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Being caught in a lie
Failing to save someone's life
Making the wrong decision in the moment
Letting doubt win and giving up important leverage
The character ignoring their gut and being swayed away from what's right
Losing to a competitor
Wrongs continuing to be perpetrated because the character didn't act
Being on the cusp of greatness, then giving up
Failing to bring about a meaningful change
Becoming a follower instead of a leader
Being ruled by fear in future situations
The character engaging in self-sabotage as a subconscious way of getting out of the situation

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anguish, Anxiety, Conflicted, Defeat, Despair, Desperation, Devastation, Disappointment, Discouragement, Disillusionment, Doubt, Dread, Fear, Frustration, Inadequacy, Longing, Overwhelmed, Panic, Powerlessness, Self-Loathing

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Feeling paralyzed by past failures
The character wanting to give up but knowing others are counting on them
Wrestling with questions of right and wrong
The character believing that they're incapable or flawed
Worrying that an inner weakness will always keep them from greatness
Being too easily influenced by other people's viewpoints (because the character doubts their own)

Hearing multiple perspectives and seeing value in them all, making decision-making difficult
Feeling pressured by others to do things their way
Not being able to commit or move forward because the stakes are just too high
Seeing others who are confident and bold and resenting them

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Apathetic, Childish, Cowardly, Defensive, Evasive, Flaky, Gullible, Impatient, Impulsive, Indecisive, Inhibited, Insecure, Nervous, Oversensitive, Perfectionist, Timid, Weak-Willed

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: If doubt encourages the character to procrastinate, quit, or settle for second best, they may never achieve the things that will truly make them happy.

Esteem and Recognition: Self-doubt is an insidious seed that, if it isn't rooted out, will spread and grow to the point that the character will no longer like or respect the person they have become.

Love and Belonging: Self-doubt will cause a character to lose confidence in who they are. If they believe they will only disappoint others, a fear of being rejected for being weak may keep them from taking chances that would build happy and fulfilling relationships with others.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Ambitious, Bold, Confident, Decisive, Diplomatic, Disciplined, Enthusiastic, Honorable, Objective, Passionate, Patient, Persistent, Responsible, Uninhibited, Wise

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Following through and discovering inner strength
Pushing through self-doubt and gaining clarity in the moment to know what needs to be done
Determining to never again let doubt and fear have the upper hand
Hesitating long enough to fully examine the situation, thereby avoiding a terrible mistake
Overcoming self-doubt and making a decision that has enormous positive results

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FACING A CHALLENGE BEYOND ONE'S SKILL OR KNOWLEDGE

EXAMPLES

Having to lead in a life-or-death situation
Delivering a baby without medical help
Surviving a natural disaster
Treating a wound or performing emergency surgery
Navigating the wilderness when lost
Troubleshooting a vehicle breakdown
Escaping from abductors or pursuers
Talking someone through a mental crisis
Stealing a car or breaking into a building out of necessity
Lacking a specific skill (hot-wiring a car, knowledge of explosives, musicality, self-defense, swift-footedness, writing, etc.) needed to achieve a goal
Raising a child alone
Being the sole caregiver for someone with special needs
Traversing hostile territory on foreign soil
Earning an education with a significant learning disability
Being put in charge of a work project the character isn't qualified to do
Being set up to fail

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having to put other plans or needs on hold
Not having what they need on hand
Scrambling to find tools, medical supplies, a witness, information, etc. that will help
Shakiness from nerves or an adrenaline rush
Needing time to think and not having it
Learning that friends or allies don't have faith in the character
Being uncomfortable with the task at hand

Suffering an injury while trying to navigate the situation
Making a political misstep
The character overestimating their abilities and publicly looking like a fool

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Freezing up and failing to address the challenge, leading to disaster
Failing to see a risk until it's too late, resulting in painful fallout
Failing because the character overestimated their abilities or underestimated the problem
Self-doubt causing a failure to act and a negative outcome
Taking bad advice out of fear and things go from bad to worse
The character knowing they're incapable but pressing forward for the wrong reasons (to impress someone, to outdo a competitor, to avoid having to admit ineptitude, etc.)
Abdicating responsibility and later regretting it
Acting despite a lack of knowledge and it leading to unforeseen consequences
Being sued or targeted for revenge by family members of the one who was hurt
Being deserted by allies who doubt the character's abilities
Making a mistake that hurts or kills someone

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anxiety, Apprehension, Desperation, Determination, Doubt, Dread, Flustered, Frustration, Inadequacy, Nervousness, Overwhelmed, Panic, Uncertainty, Vulnerability

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Struggling with moral questions, such as having to break the law for the right reason
Combating instinctive fight-flight-or-freeze responses
The character struggling in hindsight with what they should have anticipated, said, or done
The character blaming themselves for lacking the necessary knowledge or skill
Fearing failure and wanting to give up even though it will hurt and disappoint loved ones
Managing PTSD symptoms from being placed under such strain

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Apathetic, Disorganized, Flaky, Indecisive, Insecure, Irresponsible, Nervous, Perfectionist, Scatterbrained, Timid, Weak-Willed, Whiny

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A character who struggles with perfectionism or doesn't deal well with failure may give up their dream rather than face more stressful events in the future.

Esteem and Recognition: Someone who is unable to perform well under pressure may do damage to their reputation.

Love and Belonging: A character who fails in a life-or-death situation could have difficulty forgiving themselves. This can easily lead to a feeling of unworthiness that causes them to keep others at arm's length.

Safety and Security: If the character's inability to perform results in harm or injury to them or others, their safety and sense of security could definitely be undermined.

Physiological Needs: In many scenarios, the character's inability to succeed in a given area could realistically end in someone's death.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE:

Ambitious, Analytical, Bold, Calm, Confident, Courageous, Creative, Decisive, Focused, Honorable, Industrious, Meticulous, Observant, Persistent, Resourceful, Responsible, Studious, Talented

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Learning they're more capable than they previously believed

Feeling good at stepping up or helping when it was needed most

The character realizing they can lead others

Seeing mistakes as an opportunity to learn

Seeing the situation as proof of their willingness to stick out their neck when necessary

Having a bigger appreciation for life, its advantages, and the people in it

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HAVING TO RELY ON OTHERS

EXAMPLES

A parent in a health crisis—such as suffering a stroke or struggling with dementia—having to move in with grown children

The character becoming dependent on their spouse after suffering brain damage in a car accident

Requiring live-in support from caretakers due to a physical or mental health issue, such as cerebral palsy, muscular dystrophy, or Down syndrome

An illegal immigrant without working papers relying on friends and family for support

An orphaned character being taken in by an older sibling or relative

An unemployed character having to frequently borrow money from family members

A fugitive or persecuted character being hidden by friends until the danger passes

Losing everything and having to rely on the kindness of others

Being sick and unable to contribute to the family or community supporting the character

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Chafing from having to follow someone else's rules

Adapting to a caregiver's schedule

Struggling with certain restrictions (which may or may not be necessary)

Not getting along with an assigned caregiver

The character having to find work that will accommodate their disability

No longer being involved in decision-making processes

Frequent doctor appointments or medical procedures

The character's love interest not being welcome in the caregiver's home

Family feuds over how to best care for the character

Power struggles arising when the character becomes obstinate or acts out

Lack of privacy

Having to rely on others for information

Being monitored or watched (if the character is a flight risk or is used to being independent)

Becoming forgetful and confused in a new home

Added expenses causing friction between the character and whoever is helping them

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Caretakers having to postpone vacations, school, or work opportunities to look after the character

The character developing a sense of entitlement—expecting caretakers to cater to them

Being neglected and provided with limited activities or social outlets

Being treated like a prisoner with no rights

The character's condition worsening

The character not trusting their caregiver to make sound decisions

A character who wants to leave being held against their will

Facing deportation

Caregivers making life-or-death decisions for the character when they're not equipped to do so

An unethical caretaker gaining total control of the character's money, care, and assets

Family members using a power of attorney to squander the character's life savings

Being physically or emotionally abused in the new environment

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anguish, Anxiety, Betrayed, Bitterness, Confusion, Defeat, Defiant, Denial, Depressed, Despair, Fear, Frustration, Guilt, Humbled, Humiliation, Loneliness, Neglected, Panic, Powerlessness, Pride, Self-Pity, Shame, Vulnerability, Worthlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Struggling with loss of independence and control

Suffering crippling anxiety over all the changes and new situations

Flip-flopping between feeling grateful and bitter toward a host or caregiver

Guilt over keeping others from living their dreams

Feeling "less than" because of a lack of autonomy or inability to do things others can do

Wanting to voice concerns over treatment but feeling guilty about doing so
A mistreated character feeling guilty for not being "properly" grateful to their caregiver

Wanting to contribute but not being able or allowed to do so

Experiencing shame over not contributing to a household or community

The character feeling unseen and overlooked

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Childish, Confrontational, Controlling, Fussy, Grumpy, Inflexible, Martyr, Nosy, Oversensitive, Paranoid, Temperamental, Uncommunicative, Uncooperative, Ungrateful, Violent, Volatile, Whiny

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A character in this situation could feel guilty for holding caregivers back and for wanting more than their basic needs. This can hinder their ability to grow and go after what they really want in life.

Esteem and Recognition: If a character has to depend on others for their physical, emotional, or financial care, their ego could take a hit, impacting their confidence and the way they view themselves.

Love and Belonging: A character who must live with people they don't get along with will experience a lessened sense of love and belonging.

Safety and Security: A character who must rely on others for protection and basic provisions may live in a constant state of uncertainty about whether their needs will be met.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Affectionate, Alert, Appreciative, Calm, Cooperative, Courageous, Easygoing, Humble, Inspirational, Spiritual, Tolerant, Trusting, Unselfish, Witty

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Getting involved and finding fulfillment with a charity that supports the character's condition

Building lasting relationships with the caregivers

Being given time to heal or plan next steps so the character has a better chance of success

An isolated character becoming part of a family

Learning that there is no shame or weakness in receiving help

Finding meaningful ways to contribute

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HAVING TO STAY BEHIND

NOTES

This entry is about a character who has to stay behind while others move forward, and it covers both voluntary and involuntary scenarios. For information from the viewpoint of the people moving on, see **HAVING TO LEAVE SOMEONE BEHIND**.

EXAMPLES

Missing a family vacation to deal with an emergency plumbing issue

The character getting sick and missing out on a holiday get together

Getting injured on a hike and being left behind while others go for help

A spouse taking a job in a different city and the character staying behind to sell the family home

A character having to work during the biggest event of the year (a party, gala, concert, etc.)

Missing an overseas trip to care for a sick, elderly parent

A student falling behind and being held back in school

Someone not being accepted to college while all of their friends are

The character watching their friends join an elite group that he or she can't be part of

Being the only person in a group of friends to not make a coveted sports team

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having to be self-sufficient in situations they are unfamiliar with

Dealing with boredom due to circumstantial limits

Losing money that was spent on the missed event

Friction arising in a long-distance relationship

Being bedridden or confined to the house and going stir-crazy

Missing the friends or family who left

The character being consumed with self-pity

The character haunting social media to catch a glimpse of what they're missing
Having to communicate via phone or text messaging
Learning to do activities solo (foraging, cooking, hunting, security checks, etc.)
Not knowing when others will return and so being unable to make plans
Jumping at every sound, thinking it's a loved one coming home
Having to find ways to stay busy to avoid worrying

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The wait dragging into weeks or months
The character not hearing anything from those who left
Ending a relationship or marriage due to distance
The character's friends moving on emotionally and relationally, leaving them behind in every way
Running out of resources
The character playing the martyr, expecting praise and attention for staying behind
Assuaging boredom through unhealthy means (drinking heavily, overeating, etc.)
The character blaming others for their misfortune
The character acting irresponsibly or making poor decisions while on their own (hosting wild parties, staying up late, not going to school or work, etc.)
A natural disaster or political crisis occurring while the character is separated from their family
Encountering danger while waiting

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anguish, Annoyance, Anxiety, Betrayed, Bitterness, Confusion, Contempt, Curiosity, Depressed, Desire, Despair, Disappointment, Embarrassment, Frustration, Hurt, Impatience, Jealousy, Loneliness, Longing, Neglected, Self-Pity, Unappreciated, Wistful

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Struggling with intense jealousy and resentment, even if the character stayed behind voluntarily
Daydreaming about the fun they'd be having if they hadn't stayed behind
The character wishing they could change the circumstances

Fighting self-pity, apathy, or depression

Worry for others causing the character's mind to travel to the worst-case scenario

Wanting to go after the person or party despite having promised to stay put

Alternating between resentment toward the person responsible and guilt for blaming them

Being tempted to shirk responsibility and follow the rest of the party

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Addictive, Childish, Cynical, Hostile, Humorless, Impatient, Inflexible, Irresponsible, Jealous, Martyr, Melodramatic, Needy, Nervous, Reckless, Resentful, Rowdy, Self-Indulgent, Spoiled, Withdrawn, Workaholic

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: If a character's decision to stay behind turns into a long-term situation where they become a sole caregiver to others, they may not be able to pursue educational or vocational opportunities.

Esteem and Recognition: Even if the decision is voluntary, the sense of being left behind could leave the character feeling discarded, as if they and their contributions don't matter.

Love and Belonging: If staying behind means being separated from family and loved ones, the character may struggle, especially if they have no one else to draw support from.

Safety and Security: Mental health issues associated with being left behind can deplete the character's sense of security if they are not addressed.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Calm, Centered, Confident, Cooperative, Easygoing, Empathetic, Flamboyant, Honorable, Humble, Independent, Introverted, Loyal, Mature, Patient, Pensive, Private, Resourceful, Responsible, Unselfish

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Taking the time alone to do something the character wouldn't normally be able to do

Being able to get a lot done without other people around

Finding ways to keep in touch with long-distance loved ones and deepen those relationships

Accomplishing something meaningful through the sacrifice
Growing in resiliency from pushing through boredom, uncertainty, or fear
Becoming more independent and self-sufficient
Gaining an opportunity to step out of the shadow of others and find their own path forward

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LEARNING THAT ONE WAS ADOPTED

EXAMPLES

A forgetful elderly family member referencing the adoption during a conversation

A parent spilling this secret to an adult child in a moment of anger

A birth parent contacting the character out of the blue, wanting to meet

A character meeting their doppelgänger and finding out they are siblings who've never met

Completing a DNA online registry and getting wildly different results from family members

Finding adoption papers when cleaning out a deceased parent's attic

A young character overhearing adults whispering about the adoption

Being contacted by a lawyer about a class-action lawsuit against the adoption agency

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Being derailed by hurt feelings and betrayal

Having to make complicated decisions

Arguments with the character's adoptive parents

Having to keep the news secret from important people until the character knows what to do

The character's image of their background being shattered

Having to do research and file paperwork to gain information

The character realizing they know nothing about their medical history

Feeling disconnected from adoptive family members

The character meeting their birth parents and not liking them

A birth parent or sibling wanting a relationship while the character does not (or vice versa)

The character being pressured by adoptive family members not to find their birth parents

Awkwardness when adoptive and birth family members are together
Additional expenses for hiring a lawyer or private detective

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

An already contentious relationship with an adoptive sibling being made worse by the news
The character learning they belong to a culture or religion that's at odds with their beliefs
Holding a grudge against adoptive parents for lying
The character being unable to donate blood or organs to an adoptive family member in need
The character's pursuit of their birth family causing a rift with adoptive loved ones
Bad feelings causing the character to pull away from their birth family
A young character rebelling against their adoptive parents' rules and authority
The character feeling as if they don't belong anywhere
Friends or family treating the character differently after finding out about the adoption
The character going to extreme lengths to locate their birth parents (going into debt, being fired for too many absences, blowing off family members, etc.)
The character finding their birth parent, making contact, and being rejected again
The character losing a grandparent's inheritance because of their uncertain parentage
The character discovering something shameful or horrifying about their family history
A young character acting out as a result of confusion, uncertainty, and emotional upheaval

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anxiety, Apprehension, Betrayed, Confusion, Curiosity, Despair, Devastation, Disbelief, Disillusionment, Grief, Humiliation, Hurt, Insecurity, Jealousy, Loneliness, Shock, Stunned, Surprise, Suspicion, Uncertainty, Unease, Vulnerability

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Feeling unmoored, as if everything the character has known must be recalibrated
Trying to decide if they should contact their birth parents
Struggling with feelings of resentment toward their adoptive parents for lying to them
Fantasizing about what life would have been like with a different family
Feeling duped and gullible; seeing clues that seem obvious now but were missed for years
Wanting to contact the birth parents but being afraid of experiencing rejection again
Wanting to forget about the birth family but being unable to do so
Struggling to adapt to all the new changes and realizations
Wondering what other information the adoptive parents have withheld from the character
The character wavering between wanting to embrace their birth culture and not wanting to seem unappreciative or disloyal to adoptive family members

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Addictive, Childish, Confrontational, Disloyal, Disrespectful, Insecure, Irrational, Jealous, Martyr, Melodramatic, Needy, Oversensitive, Resentful, Selfish, Spoiled, Suspicious, Ungrateful, Withdrawn

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: Roots, culture, and history are part of a character's identity. When those foundational aspects change, it can change the character and disrupt their dreams and passions, which may no longer excite them.

Esteem and Recognition: A character who took great pride in their ancestry or family name may struggle when they learn they weren't born into it—especially if their birth heritage is one they deem to be less prestigious.

Love and Belonging: A character who feels lied to about their birth may find it hard to trust their parents or siblings. This can also taint their other relationships with mistrust.

Safety and Security: A character who becomes obsessed with finding or being accepted by their birth family may go to dangerous lengths to achieve

their goals—bankrupting themselves, pulling away from loving adoptive family members, losing their job, etc.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Appreciative, Calm, Centered, Confident, Courageous, Easygoing, Happy, Loyal, Mature, Optimistic, Spiritual, Tolerant, Traditional, Trusting, Unselfish

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

The character experiencing relief because they never fit in with their adoptive family

Forging a fulfilling relationship with a second family

The birth family providing a place of belonging for a character who is alone in the world

A character who experienced neglect or abuse connecting with a loving birth family

Making a decision about whether or not to pursue their birth family and feeling good about it

Learning about the circumstances of the adoption and gaining a sense of closure

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NEEDING TO BORROW MONEY

EXAMPLES

A character realizing they've lost their credit card and having to ask their date to pay

The character losing their job and needing help with monthly expenses

An unexpected expense (having to replace a car, a medical emergency, etc.) making it impossible for the character to make ends meet

The character needing someone to bail them out of jail because they can't afford it

A young adult character borrowing money from parents so they can buy a house or start a business

The character asking family for a loan when they've mismanaged their finances

An addict borrowing money under false pretenses to fund their addiction

A character who is living beyond their means trying to borrow money from family members

Needing to acquire money quickly to pay someone off—to keep a secret from coming to light, for instance

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Inconveniences associated with being short on finances

Being embarrassed

Disagreements between the character and their significant other about borrowing the money

The character having to admit to others that they're in this situation

Time spent planning out the conversation so it can be successful

Having to lie about what the loan is for

Having to approach someone the character knows is going to be difficult

Having to approach someone toxic the character has cut ties with

Things becoming awkward between the character and the person they're approaching

Knowing that the loan will come with strings attached

Filling out paperwork (if the character is borrowing from a bank)
The character having to suck up to someone they don't like or respect

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The relationship ending due to bad feelings on either side
Borrowing money from someone nefarious, such as a loan shark
Putting up something for collateral that the character can't afford to lose
Something unexpected happening that makes it impossible for the character to pay the loan back
The loaner using the situation to gain power over the character
Desperation causing the character to agree to a bad arrangement (paying too much in interest, crossing a moral line in exchange for the money, etc.)
Using questionable means (manipulation, blackmail, force, etc.) to get the loan
Choosing not to borrow the money and foregoing a necessity (medical treatment, educational services for a child, etc.)

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anxiety, Apprehension, Bitterness, Concern, Conflicted, Defensiveness, Desperation, Determination, Disappointment, Disillusionment, Dread, Emasculated, Embarrassment, Flustered, Insecurity, Jealousy, Reluctance, Self-Pity, Shame

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Knowing the money is necessary but being too proud to ask for it from someone else
The character worrying about what will happen if they can't get the money
Being jealous of people who don't have financial troubles
The character being overcome with guilt for poor decisions that created the situation
Feeling entitled, as if the person with the money owes it to the character (because the other party is wealthy, they've mistreated the character in the past, etc.)
Refusing to accept responsibility for the financial situation and becoming defensive when it's mentioned
Considering using manipulation to sway the other party
The character wrestling with moral questions about what they're willing to do to obtain the money

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Cocky, Controlling, Defensive, Disorganized, Disrespectful, Frivolous, Haughty, Irresponsible, Manipulative, Pushy, Self-Indulgent, Selfish, Stingy, Uncooperative, Unethical

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS:

Self-Actualization: If the character's dream requires money they don't have, their ability to live their fullest life will be contingent upon them being willing to ask someone else for the funds.

Esteem and Recognition: A character who has to ask someone to help them provide for themselves and their family may begin to feel inadequate and experience a lowered self-esteem.

Love and Belonging: Borrowing and lending money can be tricky between friends and loved ones and could stress those important relationships—especially if this isn't the first time the character has asked for financial assistance.

Safety and Security: If the money is needed to provide security (such as enabling the character to hold onto their apartment, move to a safer community, or cover veterinary services for a dog that keeps the family safe), not securing those finances could impact their safety.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Analytical, Appreciative, Charming, Cooperative, Courteous, Diplomatic, Disciplined, Honorable, Kind, Persuasive, Responsible, Sensible, Thrifty, Unselfish, Wise

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Successfully borrowing money from a friend while keeping that relationship intact

Learning to craft an argument or proposal in a way that maximizes the chance of success

The character learning how to manage their finances better so they can avoid having to ask for money in the future

Not securing the money and using out-of-the-box thinking to make ends meet without a loan

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NOT BEING TAKEN SERIOUSLY

EXAMPLES

The character being passed over for a job due to their age or lack of experience

Being denied an apprenticeship based on looks, attire, a lack of pedigree, a disability, etc.

The character offering ideas in a meeting and being ignored

The character asking out their dream date who laughs it off, thinking it's a joke

Parents discouraging the character's dream because they think it'll go nowhere

A spouse not supporting the character's desire to run their own business

Family members viewing the character's passion (writing, art, breeding dogs, etc.) as a silly hobby

Being told that a career, membership, or opportunity is out of reach for the character

Volunteering for a leadership role and being blown off

Participating in a conversation and being patronized or dismissed

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Losing face in front of others

Having to swallow pride and try again (because the ends justify the means)

Having to listen to "do this, not that" speeches by those who think they know better

Feeling let down by loved ones but being unable to show it (or the family drama will get worse)

Trying to increase credibility by taking up serious interests they're not passionate about

Having to suck up to the people in charge

Getting into frequent arguments with snide or dismissive family and friends

Having to lie (about their age, experience, talents, wealth) to be taken seriously

The character going to extra efforts to prove their capability
Having to work harder and longer than others
Having to find a proxy to share their ideas so people consider them
Dealing with condescension from employers
Being put in charge of jobs that are below the character's ability level
Financial investments to improve appearances (buying a new wardrobe, taking a course, etc.)
Having to suck up to the people in charge
Not being given the same opportunities as friends, family members, or coworkers

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The character losing faith in their own abilities
Giving up on a dream
Becoming risk-averse and missing out on opportunities
The character working too hard and burning out
Living a life that isn't fulfilling
Believing what others say or perceive about the character
Becoming jaded; the character believing they'll always be stuck in their current situation
A relationship becoming toxic or dysfunctional because of the disrespect or friction
A close friendship ending
Important projects suffering because they're being led by someone less competent
Slipping into apathy; no longer contributing
Being given a chance and blowing it
Being falsely welcomed and then sabotaged as a warning to others to stay in their lane
Plotting revenge or sabotage against the offenders
Trying to game the system (lying, cheating, falsifying documents, etc.) and being caught

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anxiety, Defeat, Defensiveness, Desire, Disappointment, Discouraged, Doubt, Emasculated, Embarrassment, Frustration, Hurt, Inadequate, Indifference, Insecurity, Longing, Resentment, Self-Pity, Shame, Unappreciated, Worthlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Not knowing for sure if the character was being slighted (because the other person was purposely vague or passive-aggressive in their belittlement)

The character replaying a rejection over and over in their mind, beating themselves up over it

The character worrying about being judged when they meet new people

Struggling with depression or anxiety

Wondering if what people say is true

Trying to control a deep anger stemming from oppression and/or unfair judgment

The character wanting to try for a promising opportunity but fearing possible rejection

Having to choose between the hard road (changing minds) or the easier one (moving on)

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Antisocial, Childish, Confrontational, Cruel, Cynical, Defensive, Disrespectful, Fanatical, Flaky, Foolish, Forgetful, Irresponsible, Jealous, Know-It-All, Macho, Materialistic, Melodramatic, Pushy

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A character who faces an uphill battle to be taken seriously needs internal drivers to sustain them through hardship. If they lack these, they will eventually give up their higher calling or dream.

Esteem and Recognition: Characters in this position are perceived by peers as being incapable, unreliable, unrealistic, or foolish. If the character lets these judgments affect their level of self-worth, it will change how they view themselves.

Love and Belonging: If a loved one or family member doesn't take the character's pursuits seriously, it can leave cracks in the relationship that may be difficult to fix.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Bold, Cautious, Centered, Charming, Confident, Cooperative, Courageous, Funny, Happy, Honest, Humble, Imaginative, Independent, Mature, Meticulous, Passionate, Patient, Persistent, Professional, Tolerant, Witty

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Strengthening self-belief and refusing to let others diminish it

The character starting their own endeavor and experiencing success

Seizing opportunities for growth and becoming more well-rounded

Cutting ties with toxic friends or family members

Calling the other person out and beginning a dialogue that results in positive change

The character recognizing how they played into the misperception and taking steps to change

The character increasing their knowledge or experience and benefiting from it

Fighting to prove people wrong, and succeeding

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ONE'S AUTHORITY BEING THREATENED

EXAMPLES

A police officer getting spit on by a detainee
The head of a country hearing rumors of a coup
A parent being consistently challenged by a strong-willed or disobedient child
A sports captain feeling threatened by a talented and popular team member
A boss whose employee goes over their head to complain about them
A religious leader's behavior or beliefs being challenged by their parishioners
A military officer's command being threatened by soldiers going rogue
A referee losing control of a game they're officiating
A teacher being continually disrespected by their students

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Embarrassment and emasculation being on display
Not being sure who is loyal and who isn't
The character yelling or using threats to try to regain control
Having to discipline a disobedient child or teen
Enduring backtalk, snide remarks, and sarcasm
No one showing up to the character's meetings
Having to make concessions to keep problems from escalating
Having to navigate tricky politics to get things done
Dealing with propaganda produced by the opposition (attacks in social media, false information being distributed, etc.)
The character constantly having to defend and justify their actions
Being extra careful with information and protocol so nothing can be used against them
Time spent countering rumors and false information
Not being able to enforce rules

The character overthinking every decision they make

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

An angry outburst leading to unprofessional responses, making the character part of the problem

Becoming so defensive the character refuses to entertain good suggestions from others

The character resorting to bribery or other unethical methods to hold onto their followers

Arguments escalating to violence (among teams, inmates, parishioners, etc.)

The character treating their subordinates poorly

The character losing the financial backing of their followers

Ongoing friction affecting the character's ability to lead during an emergency, resulting in someone's death

The character losing their leadership title or position

Being passed over for future opportunities due to a lack of support

Being fired

Quitting, leaving an important organization without a leader

The character taking drastic action to defend their position (military action, firing employees, etc.)

Punishing non-supporters with blackballing, financial penalties, or jail time

The character giving up and settling into apathy and underachieving in their role

Giving in to a usurper who isn't competent or qualified to lead

The character protecting their authority with weapons or force

War breaking out over a perceived weakness in a country's leadership

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anxiety, Betrayed, Bitterness, Defensiveness, Denial, Depressed, Desperation, Emasculated, Embarrassment, Fear, Frustration, Humbled, Humiliation, Inadequate, Nervousness, Paranoia, Powerlessness, Pride, Unappreciated, Worthlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Waffling between wanting to be in charge and not wanting the stress

Questioning themselves (whether they have what it takes to hold their position)

Grappling with doing what's right versus doing what's popular

Longing for things to go back to how they used to be
The character second-guessing their decisions and leadership style
Not knowing if the adversary's claims are justified or they're simply a power play by a rival
The character knowing their ego is influencing their decisions but feeling powerless to change

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Callous, Catty, Childish, Cocky, Controlling, Cruel, Dishonest, Evil, Greedy, Hostile, Impatient, Inflexible, Insecure, Irrational, Macho, Manipulative, Martyr, Paranoid, Prejudiced, Rebellious, Reckless

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Esteem and Recognition: A character whose authority is questioned has lost some of the respect of those reporting to him or her. This kind of blow to the ego can be hard to take, causing them to look inward and question their worth.

Love and Belonging: If a character has sacrificed for people in their care and, in return, is shown disloyalty and a lack of appreciation, their sense of duty may be overtaken by bitterness.

Safety and Security: Depending on the circumstances, a character being forcibly removed from a political position (as the head of a government, per se), may be physically threatened and no longer be safe.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Calm, Cautious, Centered, Charming, Confident, Diplomatic, Friendly, Honorable, Humble, Inspirational, Intelligent, Just, Kind, Merciful, Passionate, Patriotic, Persuasive, Socially Aware, Unselfish, Wise

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Stepping down from a position that had become lackluster, stressful, or overwhelming

Developing new skills and improving as a leader

The conversation highlighting flaws in the overall system that can then be addressed

Identifying rivals or troublemakers who need to be dealt with

Unexpected supporters coming to the character's defense

The character deciding how much abuse they're willing to take and when it's time to exit

Leaving a toxic situation for one in which the character's contributions are appreciated

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PUBLIC HUMILIATION

EXAMPLES

Infidelity being made public (through a sign on the lawn, a billboard ad, or on social media)

Private letters, images, or videos being shared online

Being negatively singled out in front of peers

Being ridiculed by family or friends at a group event

Dirty laundry being aired publicly

An explosive secret—drug use, sexual fetishes, criminal behavior—coming out

The character being put on the spot when they're unprepared or at a disadvantage

Being unfairly targeted and humiliated by enemies seeking to diminish the character's esteem

The character having to do something they believe is beneath them due to their status, age, etc.

Serving a punishment that puts a transgression on display—e.g., a bullying character being forced by a parent to hold a sign on a street corner that announces their behavior

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Friends and connections distancing themselves, leaving the character to handle the fallout alone

The rumor mill spinning, adding to the drama

Not knowing who to trust

Having to repeatedly explain what happened

The character changing their routine to avoid being harassed or ridiculed

Having to give up beloved activities or hobbies to maintain privacy

Feeling trapped at home by reporters or protestors

Other members of the character's family being inconvenienced or harassed

Having to pay for legal advice

The character's words being twisted by the media to fit a news-worthy narrative

Feeling watched

Past actions being dragged into the spotlight and examined

Having a membership or award revoked

Feeling uncomfortable around others because of their judgment

Being unwelcome at a club, event, or establishment

Being threatened or harassed

Being bullied or targeted online

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Being scrutinized to the point that other secrets come to light

The character's marriage breaking down

Being abandoned by family, friends, or employers

Losing important allies

Being falsely blamed or scapegoated

Being accused of a crime

Losing key support or funding

Losing a job

The character's business folding

The character having to change their identity or relocate their family to avoid scrutiny

Family members being caught in the crossfire and having their lives ruined

Being innocent of an accusation but having no proof

Having to give up a dream

Being incarcerated or put on a watch list

Developing PTSD, an anxiety disorder, or another condition

Turning to drugs or alcohol to cope with everything

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anguish, Anxiety, Betrayed, Bitterness, Defensiveness, Despair, Devastation, Disbelief, Disillusionment, Dread, Emasculation, Fear, Grief, Guilt, Regret, Remorse, Resentment, Self-Pity, Shame, Tormented, Unappreciated, Vulnerability, Worthlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character vacillating between blaming themselves (for making a mistake that set the ball rolling) or the person who broke the story

Getting bogged down in self-pity
Feeling both regret and relief about the truth coming out
Wanting to be a person of integrity but also desiring revenge
Indecision over moving on (and regaining freedom and privacy) versus fighting for justice
Feeling betrayed by a friend, yet being glad to finally know their true colors
Struggling with embarrassment, guilt, and/or shame
Desperately wanting to shrug off what people think but still caring deeply about it

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Addictive, Compulsive, Confrontational, Cruel, Evil, Gullible, Inhibited, Insecure, Martyr, Needy, Oversensitive, Paranoid, Perfectionist, Rebellious, Reckless, Self-Destructive, Vindictive, Violent

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Esteem and Recognition: Public humiliation will absolutely crater the character's self-esteem and the way others view him or her.

Love and Belonging: Not every person in the character's circle will stand by them through this experience. A loss of those support members can add another blow, making it more difficult for them to cope.

Safety and Security: In the pile-on nature of internet culture, a juicy story will often gain momentum online. If the offense was serious enough or the story is picked up by those with an axe to grind, the character and their family may become targeted in real life.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Centered, Diplomatic, Honest, Honorable, Patient, Persistent, Persuasive, Proactive, Wise

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Acknowledging the truth behind a long-kept secret, taking responsibility, and making amends

The character cutting toxic forces from their life

The act of hitting rock bottom leading to change and growth

Becoming less concerned with what other people think

Working to bring down those who unfairly target others with the intent to ruin their lives

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TELLING THE TRUTH BUT NOT BEING BELIEVED

EXAMPLES

A child being blamed for something their sibling did

An innocent person being convicted of a crime they didn't commit

Backing up a friend's story or alibi and being accused of covering up for them

Reporting a serious crime (burglary, assault, murder, etc.) that isn't investigated seriously

A character calling the police so often that they're dismissed when there's a real emergency

The character sharing their harassment story with someone who suggests they misread the situation

Being accused of infidelity and the character's denials not being believed

Being assaulted, then being punished as the aggressor instead of being protected

Being accused of an infraction and not being believed because the people in charge have set up the character as a scapegoat

Presenting facts that go against popular sentiment and being accused of spreading misinformation

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

The character having to plead their case

Trying to find a witness to what happened

Having to ask people who don't want to get involved to step up and share what they know

Getting shut out of a social group

Being publicly accused of lying

Dealing with behind-the-back gossiping and whispering

Time spent gathering research and evidence

The character losing a contest or game they should have won

The character having to ask friends or family to vouch for their trustworthiness

Becoming increasingly cynical

A friend or coworker taking the character's side and experiencing backlash

Being right but not being good at arguing or debating

Friends and family getting tired of hearing the character vent about the situation

The character taking a simple misunderstanding personally

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Crying wolf so many times that no help comes when the character needs it

The character's self-image being undermined

Forcing friends or family to choose sides

Creating an irreparable schism with a significant other

The character becoming obsessed with proving they're right

The character carrying a grudge against their accuser

Not opening up to anyone about anything because they fear they won't be believed again

Developing a reputation for being untrustworthy

The character blowing up in anger and reinforcing other people's ideas about them

The offense being put on the character's permanent record

The character laying the blame on others to detract suspicion from themselves

Losing a professional designation (as a doctor, lawyer, government official, etc.)

Being forced to make amends (reimbursing missing money, replacing a broken object, etc.)

Being sent to jail

Giving in, and a horrible injustice going unpunished

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Agitation, Anger, Anxiety, Betrayed, Bitterness, Contempt, Defensiveness, Desperation, Disillusionment, Emasculated, Embarrassment, Frustration, Grief, Humiliation, Hurt, Insecurity, Irritation, Obsessed, Powerlessness, Self-Pity, Shock, Unease

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The unfairness and betrayal causing deep resentment the character can't get over

Running arguments over and over in their mind

Wanting to lash out at the accuser but knowing it will make things worse

The character starting to doubt their own story

The character wanting to get out of the toxic situation but not wanting to rock the boat

Wanting revenge

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Cocky, Confrontational, Dishonest, Grumpy, Haughty, Hostile, Irrational, Macho, Martyr, Melodramatic, Oversensitive, Paranoid, Perfectionist, Selfish, Spoiled, Stubborn, Unethical, Whiny, Worrywart

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A character in this position will have a number of vital needs being attacked, such as their sense of belonging, their esteem, and possibly their safety. Actualization will have to take a back seat until the other more critical issues are resolved.

Esteem and Recognition: The character's credibility, reputation, and ego will take a hit as people assume the worst about them.

Love and Belonging: This situation is especially damaging when the people who don't believe the character are loved ones and close friends who should have their back.

Safety and Security: If the truth is a threat to influential, ego-driven, or volatile people, the character may become a target simply from trying to be honest.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Calm, Cautious, Centered, Charming, Confident, Courageous, Diplomatic, Honest, Honorable, Humble, Idealistic, Mature, Objective, Observant, Optimistic, Persuasive, Resourceful, Spiritual, Tolerant, Unselfish

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

The character finding allies in unlikely places

Gaining perspective through loyalty, seeing which relationships are solid and which are not

Gaining clarity about the accuser's character, and cutting ties

Triumphing through persistence, and bringing the truth to light
Taking heart in having done the right thing despite the difficulties
Finding a newfound passion for advocacy, helping others have a voice
Recognizing the value of trustworthiness and striving to become a more honest person

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Dangers and Threats

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A DANGEROUS CROSSING

EXAMPLES

Crossing a rope bridge that's fallen into disrepair

Traversing unstable ground (due to a mudslide, loose rocks, a steep grade, etc.)

Wading or swimming across a river with a strong current

Driving over a partly flooded road

Navigating unseen hazards (a minefield, a snow-covered crevasse, pockets of radiation, etc.)

Sneaking across a guarded or patrolled area

Traveling through a predator's territory

Enduring rough seas and storms on an ocean voyage

Crossing a desert or other desolate location where resources are sparse

Moving through a booby-trapped room

Walking a precarious path in the dark

Escaping an oppressive and dangerous region where leaving is not allowed

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having to travel light and leave behind anything unessential

Poor planning resulting in the trip taking longer than anticipated

Needing to move quickly; having to push on when rest is needed

Leaving behind loved ones so they'll be safe

Being on edge, alert for danger

Suffering scrapes and bruises from having to move quickly

People questioning the character's leadership choices

Needing to blend in and having difficulty doing so

Navigational challenges (traveling at night, driving without headlights, etc.)

Having to wait until it's safe (for a guard to move on, a hazard to be dismantled, etc.)

Losing something during the crossing and being unable to go back for it

Traveling with companions that make it harder to move undetected (babies, sick people, etc.)

Picking up more people along the way
Members of the character's party not getting along

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Realizing the crossing was a mistake but being unable to turn back
Discovering new dangers the character didn't foresee and couldn't have planned for
Sustaining an injury and being far from help
Mental and physical ailments arising from prolonged stress (insomnia, anxiety, heart palpitations, etc.)
The group having to split up when it's important to stay together
Having to leave an injured party member behind
Discovering a betrayal (someone working against the good of the group)
Suffering an accident that makes travel nearly impossible
Having to decide who to save (because saving everyone isn't an option)
The character being seen and chased
Being trapped with nowhere to hide
Making a choice that gets someone killed
A party member being taken captive
Being captured or killed

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Agitation, Anguish, Anxiety, Apprehension, Concern, Conflicted, Confusion, Connectedness, Defeat, Defiant, Desperation, Determination, Dread, Fear, Frustration, Guilt, Hopefulness, Horror, Impatience, Inadequate, Overwhelmed, Regret, Relief

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Realizing that not everyone will make it and not knowing what to do about it
The character having to hide their worries and fears to keep the group's spirits up
Disagreeing with the leader's decisions but not wanting the responsibility of leadership
Struggling to weigh the needs of the many versus the needs of the few
Suffering from survivor's guilt (if others have lost their lives)
The character second-guessing their choices (especially when things don't go well or a lot is at stake)

The character being tempted to strike out on their own because they'll have better luck alone

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Confrontational, Cowardly, Disloyal, Foolish, Gullible, Hostile, Impatient, Impulsive, Inattentive, Indecisive, Nervous, Perfectionist, Pessimistic, Reckless, Timid, Uncommunicative, Uncooperative

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Esteem and Recognition: If the character is in charge and makes a mistake, this could cast doubt on their judgment and ability to lead, damaging their esteem.

Love and Belonging: At some point, the character may have to put the good of the group above their personal connections. This could damage key relationships—especially if those involved see the situation differently.

Safety and Security: A dangerous crossing, by nature, puts safety and security at risk.

Physiological Needs: If the character is unable to meet basic food, water, and shelter needs, this crossing could have fatal consequences.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Alert, Bold, Calm, Cautious, Decisive, Disciplined, Intelligent, Observant, Patient, Proactive, Wise

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Gaining something that was desperately needed

Securing safety for themselves and others

Proving loyalty to the group (if it was in question before)

Being able to let go of a past mistake because the crossing somehow balanced the scales

Discovering inner strength and hope that will help them through the challenges ahead

Building trust and strengthening alliances during the crossing

The character regaining respect that was lost (from themselves or someone else)

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A HOUSE FIRE

NOTES

This entry can be adapted to suit different types of residential locations, such as an apartment, house, vacation home, trailer, or even a motorhome.

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Poor visibility

Labored breathing

Rushing to find children, pets, or others in the household

Indecision over whether to fight the fire or run, costing valuable seconds

Wasting time looking for a phone to call 911

Smoke damage (even if the fire was small and quickly contained)

A secondary condition that makes fighting the fire harder (living far from a fire department, extreme weather that creates a delay in response, explosive materials on-site, etc.)

Losing cherished items before the fire is contained

Injuries due to rushing (a fall on the stairs, bruises, scrapes, etc.)

Burns or blisters

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Being unable to find children or pets in the house

Escaping and discovering that someone is unaccounted for

The character losing their home and prized possessions

Irreplaceable items of historical or personal value being destroyed

Being unable to recoup the loss due to not having home or fire insurance

Discovering that the insurance wasn't kept up to date or the company has recently gone bankrupt

Important evidence being destroyed that would have proven the character's innocence in a crime

The fire spreading to other homes or buildings

High winds turning the fire into a conflagration that destroys everything in its path

Losing a beloved pet to the fire
Sustaining injuries that lead to lifelong health issues and trauma
The character discovering they were responsible for starting the fire
A firefighter dying in the line of duty
Someone reentering the burning building and not making it back out
Someone perishing in the fire

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anguish, Despair, Desperation, Devastation, Gratitude, Grief, Guilt, Overwhelmed, Panic, Powerlessness, Regret, Relief, Resignation, Shock, Uncertainty

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Indecision over whether to fight the fire or flee
Being unable to locate a pet and weighing the decision to leave it to its fate
The character escaping to safety when others have not, and considering risking themselves to help
Having to make a choice about who to save
Suffering from survivor's guilt in the aftermath
The character being riddled with guilt because they were partially or fully responsible for the fire
Indulging in self-blame for not doing something differently (checking to make sure a child's heater was off before going to bed, not grabbing a valuable heirloom on the way out, etc.)
Being unable to forgive the responsible party, causing friction in the relationship
Wrestling with anger and rage over what happened

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Addictive, Cocky, Compulsive, Cowardly, Flaky, Frivolous, Impulsive, Inattentive, Irresponsible, Macho, Materialistic, Reckless, Self-Destructive

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: If the character's life work or irreplaceable materials tied to it are lost to fire, it could prevent them from realizing a dream.

Love and Belonging: If loved ones are lost to the fire, this will create a painful void. Relations with living relatives will also be strained if they blame the character for the loss of a beloved pet or family home.

Esteem and Recognition: A character who is responsible for a catastrophe like this—especially if it results in loss of life—will think poorly of themselves, possibly struggling with self-pity, shame, and self-loathing.

Safety and Security: This type of threat will endanger the character's safety (and potentially that of others they care about).

Physiological Needs: A fire jeopardizes the lives of those who face it. Even if they survive, it may leave them without shelter, which could continue to put them at risk.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE:

Appreciative, Courageous, Decisive, Observant, Proactive, Protective, Resourceful, Responsible, Unselfish, Witty

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Everyone escaping unharmed

The fire being contained and the house being saved

A community coming together to help and support those who lost their home

Gaining a new perspective on what's important and what isn't

The experience helping the character let go of their materialistic tendencies

Others learning from the experience, making property improvements to reduce danger in their own homes

The character being instrumental in saving a life, thereby regaining lost self-worth

A trauma attached to the house going up in flames with it, creating a cathartic situation that gives the character a chance to start over

The insurance money enabling the character to achieve a dream of buying a bigger house or moving to a different neighborhood

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A LOVED ONE BEING PUT IN HARM'S WAY

EXAMPLES

Family members being at home during a break-in or burglary

A loved one taking on a dangerous job (rescuing someone who's fallen through the ice, fighting a fire, delivering medical supplies to a remote location, etc.)

The character's partner being targeted by a controlling, vengeful ex

Children being in a building where there's a fire, active shooter, or other threat

A loved one being used as a human shield

A family member being taken hostage

Being out with family and running into someone violent

Discovering there's a sex offender working at a child's school

Someone the character cares about agreeing to meet with criminals (to pay a ransom, pick up contraband for a delivery, pay a bribe, etc.)

The character's family being targeted by criminals to dissuade them from testifying

Being exposed to a virus at a work lab and unknowingly bringing it home

Family members living in an area where war has broken out

A tsunami, earthquake, or other natural disaster striking the place where the character's grown children live

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Being unable to focus on anything but worry

Dropping everything to concentrate on the threat

Engaging the police (filing a report, being questioned, etc.)

Wanting more information but not getting it

Staying near a phone, computer, or location in hopes the loved one makes contact

Fielding phone calls from concerned family and friends
Having to put on a brave face around family (especially if children are present)
Having to deal with reporters camped in front of the character's house
Not being able to get in touch with the endangered party
Disagreeing with a spouse or parent about how the situation should be handled
Having to pay a lawyer, bodyguards, or someone else

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Not being taken seriously by authorities
Getting into a car accident due to rushing, distraction, or anxiety
Discovering the loved one's been singled out and the danger has increased —e.g., a terrorist pulling a spouse out of a group of hostages to threaten them if demands are not met
Draining all financial resources to get the loved one home safely, and the attempt failing
Discovering that someone involved is being protected because of their political connections
Learning about a cover-up
Attempting a rescue and being captured
Police giving up because there's an impasse, the criminals have escaped, or the loved one has gone missing
The loved one being caught in friendly fire
The loved one being injured or killed

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anguish, Anxiety, Concern, Desperation, Disbelief, Dread, Guilt, Horror, Hysteria, Panic, Powerlessness, Rage, Regret, Relief, Tormented, Unease, Worry

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Extreme anxiety that pushes the character's thoughts to examine the worst-case scenario
Feeling helpless and powerless (especially if a possible resolution is still far off)
The character knowing they sound hysterical and unhinged, yet being unable to gain control over their emotions

A crisis of faith; questioning how God let this happen
Self-blame (irrational or not) for not preventing the danger
The character replaying the last interaction with their loved one, regretting what was said or not said
Wishing someone else had been targeted or taken, then feeling guilt for feeling that way
Wanting to self-medicate to ease stress and feeling guilty or weak for wanting it
Fantasizing about causing pain and suffering to the one responsible despite believing such violence is morally wrong

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Addictive, Confrontational, Impulsive, Morbid, Pessimistic, Selfish, Ungrateful, Violent, Worrywart

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A character in this situation will devote all their time, energy, and emotions to dealing with the threat, putting aside their own desires and interests.

Esteem and Recognition: If the character feels responsible for the threat to their loved one, it may eat away at their self-worth.

Love and Belonging: Family members are not always kind when a mutual loved one is at risk. They may blame the character, even if it isn't their fault, fracturing the relationship.

Safety and Security: A character may put themselves at risk, even foolishly, out of desperation to see their loved one safe.

Physiological Needs: If the character involves themselves too deeply in the effort to save their loved one, they could be captured and killed.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Calm, Cooperative, Courageous, Disciplined, Meticulous, Objective, Observant, Optimistic, Protective, Resourceful

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

The loved one being rescued or returning home unscathed

A peaceful resolution that leaves the loved one unharmed

Discovering the loved one was somewhere else during the crisis and was

never in danger

The bonds of a relationship strengthening over the course of the ordeal

The character letting go of things that don't really matter so they can
commit without reservation to the loved one upon their safe return

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A MECHANICAL MALFUNCTION

EXAMPLES

A vehicle breaking down
A cell phone battery exploding, rendering the phone useless (or a hazard)
A tool that breaks when it's needed most
An access panel shorting out
Life-saving equipment failing in an emergency
A boat motor dying or running out of fuel in the middle of a trip
A parachute failing to open
A clip breaking while the character is mountain climbing
Landing gear that doesn't open
A gun jamming
An elevator breaking down while the character is on it
A subway train stalling on the tracks
The power grid failing
A business's computer system crashing

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

A project or mission being delayed or put on hold
Arriving late to the destination
Other people being inconvenienced by the character's tardiness
Having to ask someone for assistance
The failure causing the character embarrassment (because they're responsible)
Having to make a detour or find another way of achieving a goal
Having to think quickly
Wasting time to secure a replacement
Spending money on repairs
Having to find a stopgap solution or rig a replacement that doesn't function as well
Being stranded until help arrives
Being stuck with strangers

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Being in an emergency situation and not having the tools or resources to fix the malfunction

Rushing a fix and damaging the item further

Having to sacrifice something meaningful and irreplaceable to secure a repair

The malfunction imperiling many people (who are in a plane, in a submarine, underground, etc.)

Being unable to save someone's life

Losing access to an opportunity that could have changed the character's fate

Losing a mode of transportation, way of communicating, or a piece of leverage that will undermine a rescue or result in someone's death

Failing to achieve a goal when the stakes are high

Being forced to pursue an option that isn't as good and carries greater risk

Being overpowered or overtaken when a mechanism fails

A dangerous situation arising while the character is vulnerable

Being held responsible (and being sued, fired, or attacked)

The malfunction injuring or killing someone

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Annoyance, Confusion, Desperation, Frustration, Panic, Powerlessness, Stunned, Uncertainty, Unease, Worry

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Feeling shame and inadequacy for not foreseeing the situation

Struggling with the burden of responsibility when the cost is high

Feeling like a failure for being unable to fix the problem (even if it's not their fault)

The malfunction forcing the character to make a hard choice (between goals, things they need, people they can save, their life or another's, etc.)

Wondering if sabotage was a factor, and not knowing who to trust

Wanting to act quickly to fix the problem but knowing that caution and patience are needed

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Hostile, Impatient, Impulsive, Know-It-All, Melodramatic, Perfectionist, Scatterbrained

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: Sometimes all the proverbial stars must line up to achieve a life goal. If a significant malfunction happens during a specific occurrence (like the passing of a comet or a once-a-century portal opening) that the character needs to take advantage of, it might mean the end of their dream.

Esteem and Recognition: When something goes wrong on the character's watch, they could believe others value them less (whether this is true or not).

Safety and Security: A malfunction in the wrong place or at the wrong time can cause injuries.

Physiological Needs: A piece of equipment doesn't need to be dangerous to kill someone. Simple things, like a broken inhaler or cell phone, can spell disaster for someone when they're needed most.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Analytical, Creative, Disciplined, Industrious, Persistent, Proactive, Resourceful, Talented, Thrifty, Wise

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Opposing groups setting aside their differences to work together and fix the problem

Ingenuity revealing a workaround that saves the day

Finding someone with the right knowledge or skills to address the malfunction

The delay thwarting a plan that, had it proceeded, would have led to disaster

Recognizing the need to care for things and be prepared, which will help the character down the road, when the stakes are higher

The malfunction creating an opportunity for the character to rectify a past mistake, thereby regaining their esteem and worth

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A NATURAL DISASTER

EXAMPLES

A flood
A tsunami
Severe thunderstorms
An earthquake
A tornado
A hurricane or tropical storm
Severe winter storms
A mudslide
An avalanche
Wildfires that threaten the character's safety
A sinkhole
A volcanic eruption
An impending asteroid strike

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

The character having to fortify their home by sandbagging against floods, adding storm shutters, turning off the gas, etc.
Clogged roads caused by evacuations
A vacation being cut short
Having to evacuate the area
Having to escape in a hurry, leaving behind belongings
Flight delays and grounded planes
Being relocated to a shelter
Stubborn family members who ignore or dismiss the threat
Finding a place for animals to weather the storm
Supply and demand issues cropping up (fuel shortages, empty grocery shelves, etc.) as people prepare

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Having to abandon someone who refuses to evacuate
Having nowhere to go because the shelters are full
Being victimized by criminal opportunists
A cataclysmic event happening with no time for the character to prepare
Having to flee at a moment's notice
Being forced to leave behind animals to fend for themselves
Becoming separated from family members
Being unable to evacuate (being in a critical care ward, on a cruise ship, on an oil rig, etc.)
The government refusing to offer aid
Not having the help, resources, or shelter to weather the event
Power outages and breakdowns in emergency services making the aftermath more dangerous than the event itself
Losing a home, livelihood, or business to the event
Being injured or falling critically ill
Losing a family member or friend

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anxiety, Confusion, Desperation, Determination, Devastation, Disbelief, Dread, Fear, Fearlessness, Horror, Insecurity, Powerlessness, Shock, Vulnerability

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Struggling internally over questions of right and wrong when survival is at stake
The character agonizing over being separated from family and worrying that they've failed as a parent, spouse, etc.
Feeling irrationally to blame for the danger—because they insisted on the family road trip and ended up in the path of a tornado, for example
Indecision over staying with the group or leaving (because being alone gives the character better odds)
Dealing with the emotional trauma of failing to save someone's life
Being terrified by the situation but having to keep it together for the kids

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Disorganized, Impatient, Irresponsible, Materialistic, Melodramatic, Reckless, Scatterbrained, Weak-Willed

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Esteem and Recognition: An emergency can highlight your character's coping skills and leadership—which can be a problem if they're not up to snuff. A poor performance in this circumstance could change how people view the character and how they see themselves.

Love and Belonging: If the character was unable to save or protect a loved one, others may blame them, creating a wedge in those relationships.

Safety and Security: An unavoidable natural disaster has the power to compromise your character's safety.

Physiological Needs: Natural disasters can not only put the character's life at risk, they can also make it difficult for them to survive in the aftermath.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Calm, Cautious, Cooperative, Focused, Observant, Persistent, Persuasive, Proactive, Protective, Resourceful, Responsible, Sensible, Spiritual, Thrifty, Unselfish, Wise

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

The event not being as severe as predicted

Finding shelter, resources, or aid that keep the character and their family safe

The event miraculously sparing the family's home, business, or property

A family that was fractured coming together through shared adversity

Taking initiative beforehand to prepare, so the character and their loved ones have what they need to survive

The event taking out an enemy or threat that was capable of doing even greater damage

Gaining a new perspective about what's important, and making changes that lead to greater fulfillment in the future

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A THREATENING CRIMINAL BEING SET FREE

EXAMPLES

Someone getting off on a technicality
A criminal being released on bail while awaiting their trial
An incarcerated person being paroled
A prisoner breaking out of jail
A violent person being granted immunity in exchange for their testimony
A suspect being released due to a lack of evidence
The criminal being pardoned by someone in power
The criminal procuring a new identity and evading authorities

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having to chase down information from lawyers or detectives
Filing for a restraining order
The character having to change their routine to avoid predictability
Being set off by little things; the stress getting to the character
Disagreements with loved ones who resent the increased security and decreased freedom
Insomnia and anxiety
Being unable to focus on work or other responsibilities
Worry stealing the character's joy
Having to invest in security purchases (getting a dog, changing the locks, installing lights and an alarm, hiring a bodyguard, buying a taser, etc.)
Keeping family members close to minimize their risk
Needing to leave home for a period of time
Being placed under police surveillance
Being put into protective custody

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Being threatened in some way (receiving an ominous email, being sent an email with surveillance video of the character's child, silent phone calls

meant to intimidate, etc.)

The character discovering their home has been broken into by the criminal

A loved one being terrorized or roughed up

Other witnesses in the case disappearing or having "accidents"

A hitman finding the character's safe house

The character having to take on an assumed identity and leave their life behind

A loved one being used as leverage—e.g., a brother is kidnapped and will be killed if the character testifies, or a parent's business will be torched if a police statement isn't retracted

Developing a panic disorder or other anxiety-related condition

The criminal re-victimizing the character a second time

Being captured or killed by the criminal

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anxiety, Betrayed, Defeat, Desperation, Determination, Disappointment, Disbelief, Disillusionment, Dread, Fear, Frustration, Hysteria, Overwhelmed, Powerlessness, Rage, Resentment, Shock, Suspicion, Tormented, Vengeful, Worry

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Uncertainty about the severity of the threat; the character wondering if they're being paranoid

Wanting to warn others about the potential danger (coworkers, extended family, etc.) but not wanting to worry them unnecessarily

Feeling responsible for the safety of loved ones but being unequipped to protect them against this threat

Moral questions about killing someone to protect the lives of others

Anger and resentment at a justice system that allows someone like that to go free

Wanting to give in and not testify, and feeling cowardly for doing so

The character being changed by anger, fear, and anxiety and struggling to reconcile who they are with who they were

Struggling with moral outrage (if the offender was able to gain freedom because they have power or money)

Feeling unsafe, and knowing this won't change until the person is put away for good

Worrying the police or FBI will use them as bait to draw the offender out

Not knowing which threats are real or imagined

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Confrontational, Flaky, Foolish, Impulsive, Macho, Martyr, Obsessive, Reckless, Self-Destructive, Violent, Volatile

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Esteem and Recognition: If the character worked to put the criminal behind bars, they might see the criminal's freedom as a personal failure, especially if it results in danger to themselves or loved ones.

Love and Belonging: If the criminal wants revenge or is desperate enough to use threats and violence to dissuade the character from testifying, their loved ones may become targets.

Safety and Security: Some criminals will do anything to hold onto their freedom, even if it means destroying someone else's sense of security.

Physiological Needs: If the end game is to take the character out, their life is at risk whether police are involved or not.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Calm, Cautious, Courteous, Discreet, Observant, Private, Proactive, Protective, Resourceful, Wise

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

New evidence resulting in an arrest

A new witness or evidence that renders the character's testimony unnecessary, removing the danger

The character using anger and a need for justice to strengthen their own resolve

Learning new skills and strategies that increase the character's safety over time

Being protected by police until the person is caught

The criminal being killed, giving the character closure and opening the door to healing

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A WAY OF LIFE BEING THREATENED

EXAMPLES

Technological advances making the character's career obsolete

A border town being threatened by a neighboring nation seeking to expand its territory

Living close to a growing or worsening threat, such as an active volcano or nuclear reactor

Corporations buying up land and transforming it to suit their purposes

The character's children or grandchildren not wanting to continue a long-term family business

Financial debt resulting in the loss of family property

Human settlements encroaching on land owned by indigenous groups

Being displaced by conquerors or landowners

Popular culture changing and clashing with the character's personal ideals or beliefs

Government overreach stealing its citizens' freedom and autonomy

Rural living becoming increasingly difficult (because of threats from marauders, a natural disaster destroying their ability to be autonomous, climate change factors, a recession, etc.)

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Disruptions to the character's routine

Environmental changes (such as increased noise, being surrounded by people, etc.)

Having to change to adapt

Increased costs due to price hikes or the need to financially support others

Having less privacy

Having to share resources with others

New rules or regulations being enacted that restrict the character in some way

The character being forced to learn something new (a language, technology, new methods, etc.) to stay employed, keep what they have, or provide for

their family

Dealing with an increased military presence

Living with fewer resources and creature comforts

The character having to hide their true allegiances

Arguments with family members over what to do next or how to respond to the threat

Having to talk hot-headed loved ones out of impulsive responses that will cause further harm

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Running out of a vital resource

Being caught in the middle of violent clashes

Being overregulated and forced to obey laws or conditions that are illogical or unfair

Being squeezed out of an industry by bigger companies, neighbors with deeper pockets, or technology that makes the character's products and skills obsolete

Enduring a hostile takeover

Violence forcing the character and people they care about to flee

Suffering abuse or discrimination

Meeting with the opposition and realizing the threat has been engineered by those in authority but not being able to convince others

Being forcibly relocated or imprisoned by those in charge

Underestimating the threat to disastrous result

Losing a loved one in a skirmish

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Betrayed, Bitterness, Conflicted, Contempt, Defeat, Defiant, Disillusionment, Fear, Frustration, Hurt, Inadequate, Nostalgia, Powerlessness, Remorse, Unappreciated, Uncertainty, Worry, Worthlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

A loss of esteem that causes the character to question their self-worth

Feeling betrayed by a company, government, or supposed allies

Reeling at a sudden loss of cultural identity (due to being displaced)

Navigating the stages of grief

Being fearful of change, yet knowing it can lead to good things
The character seeing new opportunities for their family but resenting that it comes at a forced cost
Struggling with harmful desires that don't match the character's core values (wanting to see others experience hardship, a need for revenge, etc.)

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Confrontational, Controlling, Evil, Impulsive, Insecure, Irrational, Martyr, Materialistic, Melodramatic, Rebellious

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: When displacement or a character's way of life changes, it can cause them to question their identity and place in the world.

Esteem and Recognition: Working hard and becoming proficient at a trade only to have a machine come along and do it faster and better...that's a huge blow to the ego.

Love and Belonging: When different groups fight over the same land or commodity, anger and biases can arise. If family members disagree about who or what is a threat, it can cause relationship tension.

Safety and Security: A character who feels (justly or unjustly) that their way of life is in jeopardy can easily turn on the perceived threat. If this situation escalates to conflict or violence, the character or their loved ones could end up hurt.

Physiological Needs: If a character is displaced, they could lose their home, land—everything.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Centered, Creative, Independent, Industrious, Nature-Focused, Nurturing, Objective, Proactive, Professional, Protective, Resourceful, Sensible, Spiritual, Thrifty, Tolerant, Uninhibited

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Taking a stand and driving back unwanted developments, competitors, or threats

Discovering one's fears of displacement were unfounded

Learning that a group in the area is not malicious and only want to live in harmony

Adopting a new technology or way of doing things that ends up making life easier

Coming together with others in the same situation and leveraging group strengths

Pivoting to something new—such as a career or relocation—that the character wanted but thought would never happen

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BEING ASSAULTED BY A STRANGER

NOTES: An assault will naturally erode safety and control for the character, making this a physically and emotionally painful event. Not only will the attack itself be difficult, but so will the aftereffects, so keep this in mind when employing this conflict.

EXAMPLES

Being mugged

Being assaulted by someone who is delusional or on drugs

Being attacked and tortured in a case of mistaken identity

Experiencing a sexual assault

Becoming the target of a hate crime

An attempt to stop a burglary or home invasion turning violent

Being forced by sadistic captors into conflict with someone else

Being targeted as part of a hazing or ritual induction activity

Standing up for someone who is being brutalized and becoming the attacker's new target

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Disorientation by the suddenness of the attack and aftereffects of shock

Sustaining minor injuries (a black eye, bruises, sore muscles, scrapes, etc.)

Having to explain what happened to others

Feeling vulnerable and exposed and having to mask it

Being humiliated if friends or loved ones witnessed the attack

The attack preceding an important event (a college scholarship interview, the character's wedding, etc.), when physical signs of the assault are still visible

Possessions being broken in the scuffle

Clothing being ruined

A purse or wallet being taken

Having to file a police report

Difficulty recalling the details in the aftermath

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Suffering a panic attack
Sustaining a serious physical wound
Being sexually assaulted
Being taken (and the abuse continuing)
A false accusation of inciting the attack (victim blaming)
Being unable to find help in the aftermath
The attacker going free or not being caught
The assault being recorded and shared online
The attacker using information stolen during the attack to cause serious trouble (stealing the character's identity, using their credit card to purchase items, learning where they live, etc.)
The attacker being caught but power and connections keep them from facing consequences
Mental distress significantly impacting the character's life—e.g., because they're afraid to leave home or become overprotective of their children
The character becoming obsessed with tracking down the stranger and avenging themselves

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Confusion, Contempt, Disbelief, Disgust, Emasculated, Fear, Hatred, Humiliation, Hurt, Insecurity, Panic, Powerlessness, Rage, Shock, Terror, Vengeful

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character feeling unsafe and fearful for their life
Confusion in the moment, followed by mental scrambling to deescalate the situation
Panic taking over
Disbelief that the assault is happening
Wanting to fight back but knowing it will make things worse or won't be effective
Feeling vulnerable
Worrying afterward about the safety of loved ones
Suffering from flashbacks and PTSD
Desiring justice but not wanting to relive the ordeal
Trying to forget the assault but being unable to do so

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Disrespectful, Foolish, Hostile, Macho, Reckless, Self-Destructive

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: In a severe attack, the character may experience a long road of recovery. Scars on the inside can steal the joy they once found pursuing meaningful goals and living life to the fullest. If they were attacked in a hate crime, the assault on their identity will make moving forward especially difficult.

Esteem and Recognition: A character may find it hard to shake the feeling of powerlessness that comes with an assault. They may also irrationally blame themselves for the outcome. An emotional wound like this can level their self-worth.

Love and Belonging: After an attack (especially a sexual assault) the character may find it difficult to be vulnerable with others. This can impact their relationships.

Safety and Security: A character's sense of security is taken away in an attack like this. The severity (and randomness of it) will influence how hard it will be to regain this need.

Physiological Needs: A physical attack can absolutely endanger the character's life.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Centered, Confident, Diplomatic, Disciplined, Innocent, Obedient, Objective, Persuasive, Proactive, Tolerant, Witty

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

The character taking up self-defense so they feel better equipped to deal with future threats

Growing in empathy and providing support for others who have experienced an attack

Fighting back and feeling empowered for being victorious

Escaping without injury

Friends coming to the character's defense, generating increased loyalty and closeness

The attacker being caught and convicted

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BEING ASSIGNED A DANGEROUS TASK

EXAMPLES

Having to clean up bodily fluids, toxic waste, radioactive materials, etc.
Mediating a dispute between dangerous people (criminals, mob henchmen, etc.)
Having to capture an injured animal
Crossing treacherous territory to deliver supplies
Gathering incriminating intelligence from an enemy
Participating in a dangerous military assignment
Serving jury duty in a trial where tampering and juror intimidation are likely
Having to apprehend or escort a violent criminal
Searching for survivors or remains at a recent disaster site, where conditions are dangerous
Executing or assassinating someone
Carrying out a risky medical procedure
Having to reprimand a volatile and violent employee
Having to protect a family who have been targeted by ruthless people

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Procrastinating, and the situation worsening in the meantime
Not taking the job seriously enough, and the danger increasing
The character shirking their responsibility so someone else has to take over
Having to make arrangements for loved ones in case things go badly
Friction with family members who don't want the character in harm's way
Facing fear, anxiety, and pressure
Key details being left out, making the task more difficult
Not having the supplies or equipment needed to effectively carry out this task

Dealing with ailments brought on by stress (nausea, stomach pain, loss of appetite, etc.)

Preparing to take on the task only to have it postponed

Worrying about not knowing what to say or having the right answers

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Refusing to do the task and facing repercussions

Failing to remain objective; becoming emotionally involved

Rushing to get the job over with, and botching it

An unpleasant task dragging out interminably

Unknowingly being a pawn in a powerful person's game

Superiors not having the character's back, hanging them out to dry

The task being too big for the character to handle and so they do not succeed

The character failing in their mission, and other people suffering because of it

Failure resulting in the character being demoted, fired, or denied future opportunities

Developing PTSD from an emotionally traumatizing task

An innocent party being caught in the crossfire

Someone being critically injured or dying

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anguish, Annoyance, Anxiety, Defiance, Disappointment, Dread, Fear, Frustration, Inadequacy, Irritation, Overwhelmed, Panic, Reluctance, Resentment, Resignation, Self-Pity, Suspicion, Worry

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Wanting to refuse the task but not wanting to face the consequences

The character doubting their ability to handle the task

Being excited by the task and struggling to remain patient while they prepare

Finding it hard to compartmentalize their emotions so they can carry out their duty

The character being asked to do something that goes against their moral beliefs

The character suspecting that all is not as it seems but not being able to prove it

Being tempted to treat the involved parties with disrespect or unnecessary physical force

The character second-guessing their decisions afterward

Knowing they're not supposed to question orders but being plagued with uncertainty about them

Needing to make arrangements for loved ones (in case things go wrong) but not wanting to alarm them

Denying the truth about the situation

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Childish, Confrontational, Cruel, Disrespectful, Haughty, Impatient, Irresponsible, Lazy, Nervous, Pessimistic, Rebellious, Selfish, Spoiled, Stubborn, Tactless, Temperamental, Uncooperative

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A character who allows fear to keep them from doing what's right or employs abhorrent methods to accomplish the task will find themselves questioning their identity and values.

Esteem and Recognition: A character experiencing doubt and insecurity about their ability to carry out their duty will find it even harder to get the job done.

Love and Belonging: If the character is asked to do something that's morally questionable, they may refuse, which can strain the relationship between them and the one making the request.

Safety and Security: A dangerous assignment will inherently undermine the character's sense of security—in the midst of the job but also in the aftermath, as they struggle to cope with what went down or continue to worry about their safety.

Physiological Needs: Dangerous tasks can lead to a loss of life.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Ambitious, Appreciative, Bold, Confident, Cooperative, Diplomatic, Easygoing, Enthusiastic, Focused, Honorable, Humble, Industrious, Obedient, Responsible, Sensible, Simple, Unselfish

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Intervening in time to save someone's life

Completing the job and procuring valuable information or resources

Fulfilling a role that others aren't suited to handle

Neutralizing someone who would wreak havoc or hurt others

The character taking pride in knowing they pushed through adversity and did what was right

Increased fortitude making it easier to make the right decision next time

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BEING CUT OFF FROM HELP

EXAMPLES

Being isolated in a remote location

Having no way to easily resupply food, water, medicine, etc.

Being injured or becoming sick without a way to contact others for help

A fire, flood, or enemy cutting the character off from allies

The character losing their ability to communicate with others (losing internet service, their phone breaking, losing power and being unable to charge their devices, etc.)

Being trapped in an elevator or cave-in

Being captured and imprisoned by enemy forces with no hope of rescue

The character being stranded in a remote location—e.g., marooned on an island or stuck in the mountains after a plane crash

Being caught behind enemy lines

Being separated from people who would intervene (an abuser isolating their spouse from friends or a royal family member being "kept safe" during a succession or coup)

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Personal discomfort—being too hot, cold, wet, exposed, etc.

Having limited supplies

Being unable to see well (if lighting is an issue)

Lacking supplies to tend to injuries or minimize pain

Having to procure vital resources

Being forced to travel by foot

Navigating debris and hazards

Not knowing what the dangers are in the area

Conditions that make navigation difficult (not having access to a GPS, fog making it impossible to see the stars, snipers monitoring a border, etc.)

Having to keep others calm (if the character is trapped with other people)

Arguments over what to do and how to get help

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Running out of resources and having no way to replenish them

Sustaining a debilitating injury

No one knowing where the character is (and so they don't know where to look)

Having to travel a long distance to reach help under less-than-ideal conditions

Having a finite amount of oxygen

Being inadequately dressed for the conditions (not having a coat in freezing temperatures, wearing shoes unsuited for travel, etc.)

A danger developing that makes staying put precarious, such as a predator showing up or the structure where the character is sheltering becoming unstable

Being tracked and hunted

Having a serious health condition that requires monitoring (the character is pregnant, requires timed medication doses, is prone to seizures, etc.)

Being unable to think clearly—due to an injury or lack of sleep, for instance

Discovering someone in the group is a threat to everyone's safety

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Acceptance, Anxiety, Apprehension, Bitterness, Concern, Confidence, Despair, Desperation, Determination, Homesick, Hopefulness, Humbled, Inadequate, Inspired, Loneliness, Nervousness, Overwhelmed, Powerlessness, Resignation

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Having doubts about the leader's plan but not having a better idea

Feeling uncertain about the chances of survival but needing to keep everyone's spirits up

Self-blame for being stuck in this predicament (even if there was nothing the character could do)

Beating themselves up for a failing (not preparing for the emergency, not telling anyone where they were going, not keeping a vital medical item with them, etc.)

Being torn over staying put or keeping moving

Vacillating between self-preservation and doing what's best for the group

Fears cropping up (of enclosed spaces, being abandoned, etc.)

Being tempted to give up

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Disorganized, Extravagant, Flaky, Frivolous, Irresponsible, Needy, Reckless, Scatterbrained, Self-Destructive

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Esteem and Recognition: A character who thinks poorly of themselves may not perform well under pressure. Failing when it matters most—especially if doing so impacts others—could further erode their self-worth.

Safety and Security: An isolated character could be in big trouble if the route to safety is dangerous or they have been injured and need medical assistance.

Physiological Needs: Depending on the environment and resources available in a survival situation, the character's life could hang in the balance.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Calm, Cautious, Confident, Disciplined, Independent, Industrious, Meticulous, Proactive, Protective, Resourceful, Responsible, Sensible, Simple, Spiritual, Supportive, Thrifty, Tolerant, Unselfish, Wise

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Being rescued

Surviving the ordeal by taking the initiative to find help

The character discovering their own resilience and grit

Being able to access old skills, knowledge, and abilities that help the group survive

Viewing the circumstance as an opportunity to gain inner strength

The character gaining confidence from being able to survive completely through their own efforts

Being able to help others along the way

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BEING EXPOSED TO AN ALLERGEN

EXAMPLES

Ingesting an allergen (shellfish, peanuts, strawberries, gluten, etc.)

Touching an allergen (latex, a certain type of fabric, a cosmetic ingredient, etc.)

Exposure to a chemical toxin

Being stung by a wasp

The character being caught out in the sun when they have a photosensitivity condition (such as Lupus)

Being bitten and injected with venom

The character being administered medication they don't know they're allergic to

Experiencing a serious plant allergy from touching oils or breathing in pollen or spores

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Itchiness and discomfort

Scratchiness in the throat

Feeling hot and dizzy

Weakness and fever

Labored breathing

Nausea

Hives and swelling

Having to self-diagnose to understand what's happening

Worry and mental stress

Having to procure medication to relieve the symptoms

Being temporarily disfigured by the allergen's effects

Having to be transported to a hospital

Missing work or school

Not being able to attend an anticipated event, such as a concert or birthday party

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

A breathing condition worsening

Being alone when the exposure and reaction happens

Being unconscious when the reaction happens

Having no phone, vehicle, or way to get help

A language barrier that makes communication with others difficult

The attack happening at a dangerous time (while the character is driving, when they're home alone with small children, etc.)

Not having an inhaler or medicine to help

The situation resulting in the character missing a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity, such as their own award ceremony or a trip they've spent years saving up for

Experiencing anaphylaxis

Having a seizure

Being far from a hospital

Lapsing into unconsciousness

The heart stopping

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anxiety, Denial, Despair, Desperation, Fear, Hysteria, Impatience, Overwhelmed, Panic, Powerlessness, Stunned, Terror, Tormented, Vulnerability

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Trying (and failing) to rein in panic

Mentally comparing the attack to other close calls to judge the severity

Anguish and fear of dying

Self-blame for not being prepared (if this was a known danger)

Wanting to get help but not wanting to be an alarmist

Worry over what others think causing the character to procrastinate in getting help

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Disorganized, Foolish, Forgetful, Impulsive, Inattentive, Irresponsible,

Melodramatic, Morbid, Paranoid, Reckless, Uncommunicative, Ungrateful,

Whiny, Worrywart

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: The character's fulfillment can be threatened if a newfound allergy will keep them from pursuing a passion or dream job.

Esteem and Recognition: If your character doesn't take their allergy seriously and suffers a severe reaction, they might worry that others will think they're irresponsible, scatterbrained, or foolish. They might also think these things about themselves.

Love and Belonging: A close friend who is unaware of the allergy may accuse the character of being melodramatic and attention-seeking. When the truth is revealed afterward, the character might find it hard to forgive that person for their callous attitude.

Safety and Security: Allergic reactions can be serious and require medical intervention.

Physiological Needs: People die frequently from severe allergic reactions, making this a conflict that can be deadly for your character.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Calm, Cooperative, Disciplined, Obedient, Observant, Optimistic, Organized, Patient, Proactive, Resourceful

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Being able to ride out the episode

Discovering someone nearby with the proper medication and using it to subdue the symptoms

Finding someone who knows what's happening and what to do

Reaching the hospital in time

Surviving and resolving to be more prepared in the future

The situation alerting the character to an unknown allergy and enabling them to take preventive steps against future attacks

The character discovering a toxin within their environment and removing it

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BEING POISONED

NOTES

Poisonings can be deliberate or accidental. In either case, a character who doesn't know they've been poisoned may misdiagnose the symptoms, delaying the proper treatment and making the situation more dire.

EXAMPLES

Munchausen's syndrome (deliberately ingesting poisons and toxins to become ill and gain attention)

Munchausen's syndrome by proxy (being poisoned by someone else who then controls the character through ongoing care)

Being given something (in food, tea, etc.) by an enemy or rival to produce illness at a critical time

The character accidentally ingesting something that makes them sick

Becoming ill from eating improperly cooked food

Being exposed to a toxin in the environment

Suffering from high exposure to a substance like lead (in paints and beauty products) or asbestos (in insulation)

Being poisoned through exposure to radioactive materials

Overdosing on a toxic amount of medication, drugs, or alcohol

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Experiencing uncomfortable symptoms (dizziness, headaches, confusion, sweating, nausea, tremors, etc.)

Having to call in sick to work

Having to back out of commitments, promises, and responsibilities

Attending many doctor appointments

Enduring multiple tests to figure out what's going on

Stress and anxiety interfering with sleep

Suffering from exhaustion

Struggling with responsibilities at home and work

Difficulty with cognitive tasks
Being clumsy due to muscle weakness
Having a longer-than-anticipated recovery time

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The character not realizing they've been poisoned
Throwing up blood
Internal bleeding
Extreme pain
Knowing about the poisoning but falling unconscious before conveying this to doctors
Needing to be hospitalized
A long hospital stay resulting in crippling medical bills
A caregiver not being honest about the character's situation or symptoms (Munchausen's syndrome by proxy) and being allowed to continue in their role
A delayed diagnosis allowing the poison to do greater damage
Being unable to determine which poison is responsible
Determining the poison but discovering there is no cure
Death

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anxiety, Appalled, Betrayed, Concern, Desperation, Devastation, Disbelief, Disillusionment, Dread, Fear, Hysteria, Panic, Paranoia, Peacefulness, Powerlessness, Rage, Shock, Stunned, Suspicion, Terror, Tormented, Vengeful, Worry

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Discovering the poisoning but not knowing who did it (or who to trust)
Knowing who the poisoner is but being unable to communicate it
Fear of dying
Distress over putting family members through this trauma
Having life regrets when it's too late to do anything about them
The character feeling acute betrayal and hurt that someone they trusted poisoned them
Self-blame and self-directed anger if the character accidentally poisoned themselves

Hating the sensations of suffering but wanting the attention (Munchausen's syndrome)

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Disorganized, Impulsive, Insecure, Know-It-All, Melodramatic, Morbid, Scatterbrained, Weak-willed

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A character suffering long-term or crippling side effects from the poisoning may find it difficult to engage in the activities that bring them the most joy.

Esteem and Recognition: A character who suffers long-term harm from a poisoning that could have been avoided may come to loathe themselves and be overwhelmed with self-pity.

Love and Belonging: A victim of Munchausen's syndrome by proxy may develop severe trust issues, making it hard to have close relationships.

Safety and Security: A poisoned character may not know if they're going to live or die. They also may be uncertain about who they can trust, which will lead to them feeling distinctly unsafe.

Physiological Needs: If a character with Munchausen's syndrome goes too far, they can cause their own death.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Calm, Cautious, Courageous, Meticulous, Observant, Organized, Persistent, Persuasive, Proactive, Resourceful, Responsible

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Discovering the type of poison in time and receiving the antidote

The character getting to a hospital and having their stomach pumped so the damage is minimized

The character escaping an abusive caregiver so they can recover and start living a full life free of illness

The person responsible for the poisoning being incarcerated, giving the character some closure so they can move forward with healing

Healthcare professionals diagnosing the character with Munchausen's syndrome and getting them the appropriate help.

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BEING RECOGNIZED

EXAMPLES

A celebrity being mobbed by fans in public

A TV personality being recognized in compromising video footage

Committing a crime and being identified by a witness or an online sleuth

Someone noting the character's license plate as they flee a car accident

Getting pulled over by police and being seen by a relative or employer who is driving by

The character lying about their whereabouts, then being seen in the background of a news report

An attacker being identified by their victim

An undercover officer being recognized by a real-life connection

A character in witness protection running into an old acquaintance on vacation

The character being seen by a friend while trying to blend into a crowd and disappear

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Fandom being new to the character and so they don't know how to navigate it

The character's children being dragged into the limelight

Having to engage with fans enough to satisfy them

The character needing to make an excuse for their whereabouts

The character having to leave the area before others also recognize them

Having to ask (or beg) someone to not mention running into them

Needing to cut a visit or outing short because a cover is blown

Trying to pretend to be someone else: *Oh, I get mistaken for Henry Cavill all the time.*

The character denying that they are who they are

Fielding awkward questions from family members

Needing to avoid cameras and people with phones

Being forced to keep a low profile

Having to silence a witness without getting caught
The character needing to find out how much the person who recognized them knows

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

A blown cover ruining a police operation
The character being recognized while they're out on a date (and they're married to someone else)
Being caught with someone who will damage the character's reputation
A recording of the character engaging in an illicit activity (buying drugs, soliciting a prostitute, etc.) being posted online
The character's marriage imploding when footage of them and their lover is sent to their spouse
A hit being put out on a character when they are caught doing undercover work, selling state secrets, or colluding with an enemy
Losing a job because of a lie (calling in sick and then being seen at the casino, for example)
Destroying a career (as a politician, leader, CEO, etc.) because the character is now tied to a situation that represents a breach of public trust
Having to go into police protection
Becoming estranged from family after bad behavior is revealed
Being charged with a crime

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Amusement, Annoyance, Anxiety, Apprehension, Conflicted, Dread, Embarrassment, Euphoria, Flustered, Gratitude, Guilt, Happiness, Impatience, Irritation, Moody, Moved, Panic, Pleased, Pride, Resentment, Resignation, Validated, Valued, Wistful

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Trying to act like everything's fine when it's not
Stifling the desire to lash out (at the reporter, overeager fan, police officer, etc.)
The character scrambling to find a logical explanation for being where they are or whom they're with
Needing to ask the person not to share what they've seen in a way that won't arouse suspicion
The character feeling guilt for what they're hiding while being angry or

disappointed for getting caught

Knowing that using leverage to get the other person to keep silent is wrong, but doing it anyway

Internal panic over what will happen if word gets out

Fantasizing about what it would be like to live a normal life

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Callous, Disloyal, Disrespectful, Haughty, Hostile, Oversensitive, Self-Indulgent, Temperamental, Whiny

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: Celebrities might enjoy the limelight at first, but over time, they realize it carries a cost. This might cause them to question whether their dream career was worth it. If they have spent many years maintaining distinct personas for their private and professional lives, they may also encounter an identity crisis as they wonder who they really are.

Esteem and Recognition: A character caught in a shameful act can have their reputation ruined, and their career along with it.

Love and Belonging: If a character becomes an embarrassment to the family name, loved ones may abandon them to the mess they have created for themselves.

Safety and Security: A character who has wronged someone can become the target of retribution, and their safety will be put at risk.

Physiological Needs: If a character is caught doing something shameful or unlawful, it can ruin their entire life and render them an outcast. This could make it difficult for them to secure their basic survival needs.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE:

Appreciative, Charming, Confident, Courteous, Disciplined, Discreet, Flirtatious, Friendly, Funny, Generous, Patient

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

No longer having to keep a secret or live a double life

The event triggering something the character didn't have the courage to do (such as get a divorce)

The character deciding to embrace who they are and stop worrying about what others think

Leaving the limelight and focusing on having a normal, anonymously peaceful life

The act of being caught causing the character to seek help and deal with their problems in a healthier way

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BEING TARGETED BY A MONSTER OR SUPERNATURAL FORCE

EXAMPLES

Being haunted by a ghost

Being possessed by a demon

Being cursed by a jealous or mischievous witch

Being targeted by an immortal because the character's connection to a god makes them a threat

The character being targeted because of their involvement in a powerful prophecy

Being chosen as a siren's next victim

A formidable beast targeting the character because of his occupation as a monster hunter

Being hunted by a monster from another dimension

Being targeted for termination by a cyborg from the future

Having to escape a dinosaur, kraken, or dragon

Being attacked by a werewolf or vampire

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Not understanding exactly what's happening

Being unable to find things because they've been moved by an unseen force

Household disturbances interrupting the character's sleep

Children who are frightened and must be calmed down

Experiencing lost time

Not being able to clearly recall what happened during the attack (because of the magic involved or the character's memory being tampered with)

Not being able to tell anyone because no one would believe it

The character getting into trouble for what happens while they're under the entity's control

Enduring minor inconveniences from a curse (having to wear gloves to avoid touching people, needing to stay out of sunlight, etc.)

The character's possessions being destroyed in an attack
Having to spend time learning new skills, languages, and lore
Having to seek out special resources, weapons, or experts

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Living in terror
Experiencing excruciating physical pain
Never knowing when an attack is coming
Being intrinsically changed by the attacker (turned into a werewolf, made immortal, etc.)
The character not having control over their body or mind
The character having no say in their own destiny or future
Loved ones or family members being put in danger
Having to participate in abhorrent behavior (killing people, drinking blood, etc.)
Avoiding deep relationships with others to keep them safe
Having to carry the weight of the dark secret alone
Facing an enemy that is too powerful to defeat
Knowing that death is imminent
Losing family and friends who don't understand the character's behavior
Not knowing where to find help (or find those willing to help)
Being paralyzed by fear

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anguish, Anxiety, Appalled, Apprehension, Confusion, Defeat, Defiant, Denial, Depressed, Despair, Desperation, Embarrassment, Hatred, Horror, Hysteria, Loneliness, Panic, Powerlessness, Pride, Rage, Self-Loathing

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character wanting to be like everyone else and despising what makes them different
The character worrying that they've gone insane
Struggling to identify what's real and what's not
Worrying about what comes after death
Not wanting to die but recognizing death as the only way out
Wrestling with suicidal thoughts
Wanting to fight back but being afraid of the consequences

Struggling with feelings of powerlessness and despair

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Addictive, Cocky, Cynical, Melodramatic, Morbid, Nervous, Paranoid, Pessimistic, Self-Destructive, Subservient, Superstitious, Temperamental, Timid, Withdrawn, Worrywart

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: It's not possible for a character to reach their full potential when they're not in charge of their own destiny. If they're in mortal danger from their enemy, they may not even consider it worthwhile for them to pursue their passions.

Esteem and Recognition: A character in this situation is going to doubt herself and her own mind, resulting in lowered self-esteem.

Love and Belonging: Meaningful relationships will be difficult to create or maintain because of the secrets the character has to keep or not being believed when they do tell the truth.

Safety and Security: The character won't be safe while they remain a target from such a formidable foe.

Physiological Needs: It's very likely that the character could be killed in this situation.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Adventurous, Analytical, Courageous, Curious, Disciplined, Discreet, Industrious, Intelligent, Persistent, Resourceful, Sensible, Spiritual, Studious, Uninhibited

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Becoming more open-minded to things that the character didn't previously believe in

Putting things in perspective; not fussing over the small stuff

The character recognizing that if they can survive this, they can survive anything

Learning an important skill that will help them in the future

Using their knowledge and skills to help others who are targeted by these forces

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BEING TARGETED FOR REVENGE

EXAMPLES

A jury member or lawyer in a high-profile case being stalked by the family of the guilty party

Being targeted by the mob for not complying with their demands

An attempted assassination of a politician because of their beliefs or political platform

The character's life being destroyed by someone they hurt as a child

An athlete being attacked by a competitor they defeated

A student keying a teacher's car because of the grade they received

A police officer's family being targeted for the part he or she played in the killing of a suspect

An inmate being assaulted in prison because of the crime they committed (child abuse, kidnapping, etc.)

A lover purposely giving their partner an STD because the person cheated on them

A popular girl being targeted by a vindictive student wanting to take her down a peg

A victim of bullying targeting their harasser by staging an event to humiliate them

Speaking out against a bully and the abuser retaliating with increased mistreatment

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Not knowing when the attack will occur or what form it will take

Having to postpone events or outings

Time lost to worry and safeguarding practices

Limiting activities or movement that could leave them or their family exposed

The character having to change their schedule to avoid predictability

The character having to explain to their children what's going on

Friends and associates not wanting to be around the character because of the safety risk

The character's children chafing against increased rules and restrictions

Other people believing that the character is overreacting

Lodging a complaint, reporting a threat, or filing a restraining order

The character reading unpleasant things being said about them online

Assuming, at first, that no harm was intended (if the revenge was deliberately subtle or covert)

The character having to prove their innocence (if false accusations are involved)

The character having to meet with lawyers, police officers, and other fact-checkers

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Confronting the attacker directly and escalating the situation

The character not feeling safe leaving their house, becoming homebound

Being unable to do their job because the risk of returning to work is so high

An important project being put on hold that threatens to ruin all the character has worked for

Being physically wounded in an attack

Losing friends or family members who believe false claims against the character

The character's reputation suffering permanent damage

The character having to change their name or leave town to start a new life

The character's long-kept secret (the reason for the revenge) coming to light

Legal fees causing a financial disaster

The character's children suffering trauma

Developing PTSD or severe anxiety

Someone being killed

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anguish, Anxiety, Defensiveness, Disbelief, Dread, Fear, Hysteria, Insecurity, Intimidated, Nervousness, Overwhelmed, Panic, Paranoia, Powerlessness, Rage, Regret, Self-Pity, Shock, Tormented, Unease, Vulnerability, Wariness, Worry

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Not knowing how to respond

Wanting to tell someone what's happening but being afraid of making things worse

Constantly feeling unsafe

The character second-guessing actions they think triggered the revenge

The character feeling weak and struggling with lowered self-esteem

The character feeling victimized but also feeling like they deserve it (if the revenge is based on their bad behavior)

Wanting to get help, but knowing it means admitting guilt or exposing a closely guarded secret

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Confrontational, Controlling, Disrespectful, Impulsive, Inattentive, Melodramatic, Morbid, Nervous, Obsessive, Paranoid, Reckless, Worrywart

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: If the revenge focuses on damaging the character's skill or disrupting his passions and is successful, the character may no longer be able to pursue the things that make them truly happy.

Esteem and Recognition: A character whose reputation is attacked could lose the respect of others.

Love and Belonging: When a character is targeted for revenge, their loved ones can easily be at risk, too. If someone is exposed to drama or danger, this will strain their relationship with the character.

Safety and Security: Anytime a person is specifically targeted, they are made vulnerable—physically, emotionally, mentally, etc.

Physiological Needs: If the character suffers serious physical trauma in the attack, their life may be endangered.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Alert, Bold, Calm, Cautious, Confident, Courageous, Decisive, Diplomatic, Discreet, Independent, Observant, Optimistic, Persuasive, Proactive, Resourceful, Sensible, Uninhibited

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Finally seeing, without any doubt, that the offending person is an enemy and not a friend

Being able to out the threatening party, making others aware of their true nature

Family bonds being strengthened through the shared experience

Receiving support from an unexpected quarter

The threatening party being brought to justice

Being more careful that incendiary actions are not tied back to them (covering their tracks)

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BEING TRAPPED

EXAMPLES

Fleeing from an enemy and running into a dead-end
Being forced up a tree or into a crevice by a wild animal
Retreating to an interior bathroom to evade a home invader
Being surrounded by an enemy force
Getting caught in a dangerous weather or environmental situation
Getting caught in a lie with no way out but to tell the truth
Being forced to follow a life path that is unlivable or abhorrent
Being stuck in an abusive marriage—because the character can't leave their kids, for instance
Being required to make a choice when there are no winning options
Being unable to climb out of poverty
Being trapped by the bonds of addiction; feeling incapable of escaping
A cognitively sound character being stuck in a body that doesn't work

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Being forced to share the predicament with people the character can't stand
Having to formulate a plan of escape
Having very few resources to work with
The character's mobility being limited (because they're tied up, confined to a hospital bed, etc.)
Experiencing minor injuries from the ordeal
Having no one to turn to for help
Being trapped with other, more vulnerable people the character feels responsible for
The character's concerns or worries being minimized by others
Insomnia and mild physical ailments brought on by worry
A language barrier or injury that makes communication with other survivors difficult
Being unable to share their feelings of frustration

An unforeseen event (an injury, loss of a resource, etc.) disrupting the character's escape plan

Being trapped alone and having no one to strategize with

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Making a decision that makes the situation worse

Having an incompetent leader who wastes resources, making circumstances more dire

A cave-in that cuts the character off from others who are trapped

The character discovering they're trapped with a threat (a rabid animal, a cache of unstable dynamite, an opportunistic murderer, etc.)

Discovering time is running out and the place the character is trapped will soon become lethal

Trusting someone who ends up betraying the character

The character's physical condition deteriorating (due to a lack of resources, infection, dehydration, being unable to move, neglect, etc.)

Slipping into a pattern of negative, self-defeating thoughts

An ally or source of comfort being removed

Developing a mental health issue from the trauma (PTSD, anxiety, depression, etc.)

Giving up; surrendering to the situation or the person in charge

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Agitation, Anger, Anxiety, Bitterness, Defeat, Depressed, Desperation, Determination, Discouraged, Envy, Intimidated, Overwhelmed, Panic, Powerlessness, Resignation, Self-Pity, Shame, Tormented, Vulnerability, Worry, Worthlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character doubting their ability to escape or better their situation

Having difficulty maintaining hope after multiple failed escape attempts

Wanting to think positively but being consumed with negativity

Being paralyzed with indecision because the stakes are too high

The character blaming themselves for not being able to avoid or escape the situation

Envy others who are in a better place

Feeling abandoned by those who could fix the situation

The mind cycling through life regrets
Contemplating suicide as a last resort to escape agony

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Controlling, Fussy, Gullible, Impatient, Impulsive, Lazy, Macho, Self-Destructive, Subservient, Timid, Uncommunicative, Uncooperative, Unintelligent, Weak-Willed, Whiny

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A character stuck in undesirable or dangerous circumstances likely won't have the time or energy to pursue personal endeavors; either their efforts will be focused on escape or they'll be so overwhelmed by the feeling of captivity that pursuing a dream will seem futile.

Esteem and Recognition: Powerlessness is a common feeling for someone in this situation, eroding their confidence and belief in their abilities.

Love and Belonging: A character trapped alone (say, in a bunker after a chemical attack) will be isolated and have no one to bond with.

Safety and Security: A character living out this scenario is in a vulnerable state; given enough time, their mental or physical well-being will deteriorate.

Physiological Needs: Someone trapped in a life-or-death situation can easily find themselves in mortal peril if they can't escape or no one intervenes.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Alert, Ambitious, Analytical, Bold, Decisive, Disciplined, Discreet, Focused, Industrious, Optimistic, Patient, Persistent, Persuasive, Proactive, Resourceful

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Perseverance, persuasion, and flawless research enabling the character to change the mind of the person in power, thereby altering the course of their life

The character finding strength they didn't know they had
Discovering allies in unlikely places

Being unable to change their circumstances but learning to live in contentment and peace

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FACING A THREAT WHILE UNARMED

EXAMPLES

A police officer losing their firearm in a fight with a suspect
Having to fight off a kidnapper without a weapon
Being attacked by a bear or cougar while hiking
Being attacked by a shark during a dive
Being assaulted in a dark alley
A weaponless character facing down an armed home intruder
Being mugged at gunpoint
The character facing an assault while they're vulnerable (in the hospital following surgery, at home with a broken leg, while they're intoxicated, etc.)
A mild confrontation turning violent when the other party pulls a knife or gun

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Being caught off guard and so even more vulnerable
Clothing choices that put the character at a disadvantage (having to run in flipflops, the attack happening while they're in their pajamas or naked, etc.)
Not being able to pinpoint the attacker's location (because it's dark, the attacker is hiding, etc.)
Having to find a place to hide
The character struggling to silence their own rushed breathing so they can hear or hide
Needing to stay still in an uncomfortable position
Being with someone who is likely to make the situation worse (because they're impulsive, confrontational, macho, or foolish)
Needing to stay calm in a high-emotion situation
Being responsible for someone (a child or elderly parent) and needing to protect them, too

Being alone with no hope of aid from anyone else
Sustaining minor injuries in the attack (cuts, scrapes, a black eye, etc.)

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Being blamed by others for putting themselves at risk (if this is the case)
A place of security no longer feeling safe for the character
Surviving the attack but then having to battle the elements (freezing temperatures, a desert crossing, etc.)
Saying the wrong thing to the attacker and worsening the situation
A debilitating fear being triggered (of dogs, physical pain, torture, etc.) that paralyzes the character at the worst possible moment
A mitigating factor that makes it impossible for the character to defend themselves (being unable to shake off the effects of a drug, being weak from a surgery, etc.)
Fleeing and being caught by the attacker
Suffering from a lack of food, water, or sleep, for a prolonged period of time
Being robbed and stranded with no money
The character being kidnapped
Being left for dead in an isolated location
Sustaining a lifelong injury
Suffering from PTSD in the aftermath
Seeing someone else killed

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anxiety, Apprehension, Desperation, Determination, Dread, Emasculated, Embarrassment, Fear, Flustered, Horror, Hysteria, Intimidated, Nervousness, Overwhelmed, Panic, Powerlessness, Shock, Stunned, Unease, Vulnerability, Wariness, Worry

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The extreme stress causing a panic attack
The character being confused about whether they should stand and fight or run away
Feeling incapable of handling the situation
Wavering between options that are all high-risk
The vulnerability of others distracting the character and making it hard to focus

Difficulty thinking clearly and coming up with out-of-the-box solutions
Struggling with self-blame for being in the situation to begin with
The character's self-esteem being shattered because they couldn't protect themselves or others

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Compulsive, Confrontational, Disrespectful, Foolish, Impulsive, Indecisive, Melodramatic, Nervous, Reckless, Stubborn, Tactless, Volatile

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: If there is a long-term impact for the character following this event, they may be consumed by fear and worry, making it impossible for them to enjoy life and live it to the fullest.

Esteem and Recognition: A character who blames him or herself for the attack or its outcome can slip into a dangerous cycle of self-pity or self-loathing.

Love and Belonging: If loved ones were killed in the attack or blame the character for the outcome, the character will find himself without those supportive relationships when he needs them most.

Safety and Security: In the wake of an attack, the character may struggle to feel safe again.

Physiological Needs: Depending on the circumstances, it's possible that an event of this nature could result in loss of life.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Alert, Calm, Cautious, Centered, Cooperative, Courageous, Decisive, Diplomatic, Disciplined, Discreet, Observant, Persuasive, Proactive, Resourceful, Uninhibited, Unselfish, Wise

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Being able to neutralize, overcome, or escape the threat

Navigating the threat in a way that produces no long-term effects

Newfound confidence from being able to think rationally and survive the situation

A bond developing between the character and those who were involved in the attack

The attacker being brought to justice

The character making changes to keep a similar situation from recurring

The character learning to defend themselves to be better prepared in the future

The character sharing about their ordeal and educating others to help keep them safe

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HAVING TO HIDE OR ESCAPE DETECTION

NOTES

There are a number of scenarios your character could face that will require them to stay hidden from a threat. The following conflict options will provide ample opportunities for high tension and close calls when they need to fly under the radar.

EXAMPLES

Being hunted by a predator (animal or human)

Having to sneak through enemy territory during a war or occupation

Hiding from an intruder during a home invasion

Being targeted for capture or execution (because the character possesses magic, has certain physical characteristics, belongs to a particular race, is divergent, etc.)

Avoiding someone who has targeted the character because their role in a prophecy poses a threat

Having to enter the witness protection program to hide from formidable enemies

Evading security during a break-in, break-out, or other prohibited activity

Meeting up with a contact at an event that's being surveilled by an enemy's security personnel

Avoiding police (because the character has gone AWOL, is wanted for questioning, etc.)

Sneaking in (or out) after curfew

Needing to gain access to a lover's hotel room or apartment undetected

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Being stuck in an uncomfortable position or a small space

Having to be very quiet and still

Having to wait (for a shift change, a mark to fall asleep, etc.) before leaving a hiding place

Being separated from loved ones
Having no one else to depend on
Being a naturally clumsy or loud person
Having to wear an uncomfortable disguise
Having to keep a supply of unusual resources to maintain the disguise
Always having to be on the lookout for the enemy; not being able to relax
A loss of freedom (being confined to a room, a house, or specific location)
until it's safe to move
Nearly getting caught and having to lie, manipulate, or use threats to escape capture

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Being seen on a security camera and chased
Being injured or attacked by the enemy
The enemy capturing loved ones and using them as bait to flush out the character
Suffering a loss that makes hiding harder (running out of money, losing a place of shelter, etc.)
Having to hide with someone who can't easily escape detection (because they have a cognitive limitation, they're using crutches, etc.)
An ally losing their cool and drawing unwanted attention to the character
Trusting the wrong person and being betrayed
Suffering from stress and adrenaline overload in a prolonged situation
Getting caught in the act (of a burglary, a tryst with a married lover, espionage, etc.)
Others with the character being injured or killed

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anguish, Anxiety, Apprehension, Desperation, Determination, Discouraged, Dread, Fear, Impatience, Intimidated, Longing, Nervousness, Nostalgia, Panic, Paranoia, Powerlessness, Unease, Vulnerability, Worry

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Becoming paranoid
Struggling with exhaustion and an ongoing loss of freedom (if life has become a pattern of running and hiding from those who mean to do harm)
Trying to stay true to the mission or higher purpose as it gets harder to cope

The character being tempted to save him or herself and leave vulnerable allies behind

Struggling with guilt over loved ones who are manipulated or harmed to get to the character

Hating having to rely on others and put them in danger but knowing it's necessary

Being tempted to surrender and end the tormented waiting

Not knowing who to trust

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Compulsive, Confrontational, Controlling, Extravagant, Fussy, Impatient, Impulsive, Macho, Materialistic, Nervous, Paranoid, Reckless, Self-Indulgent, Selfish

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: Hiding isn't generally conducive to living your best and truest life, so until the threat has passed and the character can return to their normal world, most personal pursuits will have to be paused.

Esteem and Recognition: Friends and loved ones may think less of a character who goes into hiding instead of standing up and fighting. The character might also feel bad about having to flee or putting others in danger by not giving themselves up.

Love and Belonging: A character who's on the run or has to hide for a long time will likely do so on their own and will miss the attention and community of others.

Safety and Security: This need will obviously be vulnerable as long as the threat persists.

Physiological Needs: The character could end up paying the ultimate price if detection results in their injury or death.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE:

Adaptable, Adventurous, Alert, Calm, Cautious, Disciplined, Discreet, Easygoing, Imaginative, Independent, Meticulous, Patient, Persistent, Resourceful, Unselfish

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Recognizing that while fighting is one option, it's sometimes necessary to retreat and regroup

Buying time for allies to come on board or resources to arrive
Learning to appreciate the small things and be content with less
The character learning new skills that help them fly under the radar
Realizing that not everyone is the enemy, that there are good people in the world
Growing in confidence from making the right split-second decision in a tough situation
Mastering stoicism, and staying true to a higher purpose despite hardship

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HAVING TO MAKE A FINAL STAND

NOTES

Similar to [BEING TRAPPED](#) (with a character focused on escaping or changing their circumstance), this entry explores situations where they can't retreat and are forced to make a stand, even when success is impossible.

EXAMPLES

Soldiers having to keep enemy forces from crossing a boundary at all costs
Moral beliefs being threatened, triggering a need to uphold what's right no matter what the cost

The character standing up to forces beyond them to protect a vulnerable party (their child, a physically or mentally weak individual, a group of disenfranchised people, etc.)

A character being pursued to a physical barrier (such as a wall, cliff, or ocean), making fighting their way out the only option left

Being forced into a fight-or-die situation—e.g., gladiators in the arena

Making a final stand because the character is out of options

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having to compartmentalize emotion to focus on the task at hand

Having to quickly assess resources (in pockets, a combat pack, immediate surroundings, etc.)

Trying to find high ground or a defensive position

Setting up a barrier to slow the onslaught (if there's time)

Gathering weapons, setting traps, and creating a barricade if time allows

Getting one's group to inventory resources and distribute them

Not having a weapon, or having something that will do little good against the threat

Being unsuited for the task the character is about to face

Needing help, resources, or guidance, and having none of these things

Having multiple threats or enemies to contend with

Being injured or depleted of energy due to exhaustion

Having to push aside grief and fear to focus
Having little time to say the things that matter to someone important (or not having access to the person they want to say these things to)

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Asking for mercy for those in the character's care and being denied it
Needing to rally the troops through words and strength and failing to do so

Being paralyzed by fear and failing to act

The character wanting to sway the followers of their enemy by revealing truths kept from them, and being captured and gagged before this can happen

Being captured when, for the character, this is a dishonor

Facing an enemy who is deliberately cruel and wishes to prolong the character's agony

Being captured when it's a worse fate (being denied a swift end)

Refusing to break from a moral belief and being killed for it

Being the last one standing (experiencing the death of companions or loved ones)

Wanting to do as much damage as possible before dying and being cut down immediately

Breaking resolve and giving in

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anguish, Betrayed, Bitterness, Certainty, Defeat, Defiant, Despair, Desperation, Determination, Devastation, Disgust, Dread, Emasculated, Fear, Shame, Somberness, Terror, Tormented, Uncertainty, Vindicated, Vulnerability

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Feeling defeated but needing to project strength

Feeling love, respect, and admiration for those the character stands with and hating that their lives are about to come to an end

Trying to push back fear and terror with a burning conviction that whatever happens, the character stuck to their beliefs and stayed true to who they are, and that's meaningful

Trying to tamp down dread and focus on the mission

Thinking about what they are protecting (a way of life, a belief, people who need time to escape, etc.) in a mix of sorrow and resolve

The agony of unfinished business (if the character has any), and trying to reconcile with it
Fearing what will happen and hoping the end will come quickly
Wanting to surrender but knowing that's not an option
Being torn over becoming a captive, knowing that pain is coming yet also hope for escape

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Cocky, Cowardly, Dishonest, Disloyal, Flaky, Foolish, Gullible, Impatient, Indecisive, Inhibited, Needy, Pessimistic, Self-Destructive, Subservient, Timid, Unintelligent, Weak-Willed, Whiny

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Love and Belonging: If the character is captured, they will be kept from loved ones, leading to loneliness. And, if the character is a sole survivor, they may also feel adrift because the group they belonged to is no more.

Safety and Security: In this situation, personal safety and security is automatically sacrificed, whether the character is captured or killed.

Physiological Needs: Unfortunately, most "last stand" situations end with the character losing their life.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Bold, Calm, Cautious, Centered, Disciplined, Focused, Honorable, Inspirational, Loyal, Optimistic, Organized, Proactive, Socially Aware, Talented, Tolerant, Uninhibited, Unselfish

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Reinforcements showing up in time to change the outcome

Being able to hold out long enough that others in the character's care can escape

A larger battle being won elsewhere that leads to a ceasefire, saving the character

The character doing or saying something that causes the enemy forces to turn against their leader

Being left for dead and later rescued by an ally who helps the character recover

Being captured rather than killed and then escaping

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HAVING TO SPLIT UP FOR SAFETY

EXAMPLES

Splitting up to seek help for an injured person

One person fleeing a disaster or emergency site while another stays to help people

Separating to make it harder for pursuers

One person leaving a dangerous location while the other must stay for their job

Dividing up investigative personnel to find a culprit

Quarantining or self-isolating due to illness

Separating key personnel during high-risk activities

A group splitting up to increase the chances of a mission's success

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having limited communication

Needing to replicate resources for each party

Not having enough resources after dividing the parties

Having to travel on foot

Not speaking the local dialect

Having to come up with a cover story (in case the character is caught or questioned)

Missing the other person or people

Needing to convince others that the split is for the best

Being unsuited for the task at hand but having no choice

Losing something in flight that the character needs (a knife, extra medication, a map, etc.)

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The characters losing communication completely

Being unable to reconvene and having no backup plan

One person being captured

Suffering an injury that jeopardizes the mission or the character's safety

Getting lost
Running out of supplies
The character overestimating their skill set
Not being prepared for a natural disaster or severe weather event
Needing backup and not having it
The character realizing they are being hunted
Being unable to get past a checkpoint
Encountering an unexpected danger
Showing up at a meeting point and finding signs of a struggle or battle
Refusing to split up and paying the price
A member of the group being killed

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anguish, Apprehension, Conflicted, Desperation, Disbelief, Discouraged, Doubt, Fear, Hysteria, Inadequate, Intimidated, Loneliness, Overwhelmed, Panic, Paranoia, Powerlessness, Regret, Reluctance, Remorse, Uncertainty, Unease, Vulnerability, Worry

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Struggling to stay motivated when everything seems hopeless
The character doubting their ability to be independent
Regretting the decision to separate
The character questioning their own judgment or the judgment of others
Anxiety over the well-being of the other party
Handling the guilt of leaving someone behind
Being afraid of letting others down
Regretting decisions that led to the need to split
Trying to compartmentalize and push emotions aside to focus on what must be done
Feeling intense pressure to make the right choices in a high-stakes situation

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Cocky, Controlling, Cowardly, Disloyal, Impatient, Impulsive, Inattentive, Indecisive, Inflexible, Irrational, Irresponsible, Lazy, Needy, Nervous, Pessimistic, Reckless, Selfish, Uncooperative, Weak-Willed

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Esteem and Recognition: A character may doubt their ability to succeed apart from others, especially if they are separated from someone who

traditionally took care of them or handled certain tasks.

Love and Belonging: A character who is separated from the people who support and encourage them the most may feel alone and isolated, even when they're part of a group.

Safety and Security: Being alone may make a character more vulnerable, both internally and externally.

Physiological Needs: The character may lack or run out of basic resources because of a split. In survival situations, the character could also be exposed to extreme elements or situational dangers without proper supplies.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Alert, Calm, Cautious, Cooperative, Courageous, Independent, Industrious, Nature-Focused, Observant, Optimistic, Patient, Persistent, Proactive, Protective, Resourceful, Responsible, Sensible

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Being reunited

Finding help for someone in need of care

Evading a pursuer

Supporting someone who has a selfless and demanding job

Apprehending a suspect

Successfully sneaking through a dangerous area or avoiding opposing forces

Being rescued

The character discovering that they are stronger than they previously realized

The character learning from the experience so they can avoid the same situation in the future

Learning not to overestimate their skills or abilities

Becoming more proactive and risk-conscious

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WAR BREAKING OUT

NOTES

War is one of the most disastrous and destructive conflict scenarios, with ripples that spread far and wide. A character whose country is invaded will encounter all kinds of challenges whether they stay or try to flee. People actively involved in the fighting will face even more immediate dangers. War impacts many vital areas of need, making it a versatile conflict with lots of options.

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Arguing with friends and family who don't agree with the character about the political situation

Escalating fuel and grocery prices

Being confined to a certain area; not being able to travel

Increased bureaucracy for the most basic things (to travel, purchase certain items, etc.)

Products that used to be readily available becoming scarce

Raising children in an environment where things have changed for the worse

Having to hide unpopular beliefs for fear of retribution

Being separated from loved ones outside the war zone

Having to put on a positive front for others

The character having to leave their home to seek safety

Disagreements with family members about whether to fight or leave

Inconveniences caused by sharing space with others (in a group shelter, when housing refugees, being housed as a refugee, etc.)

Struggling to make ends meet financially

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Being caught in an airstrike or invasion

The character or a loved one sustaining serious physical injuries

The character not being able to shield their children from horrific events

A child being misled by propaganda and adopting beliefs that are loathsome to the character

The character's home being destroyed

The character being forced out of their home by enemy forces

Having to cross dangerous territory with vulnerable family members

Losing access to a critical resource, such as food or a necessary medication

Fighting in a battle against an overwhelming force

A soldier running out of ammunition or losing the ability to communicate when they need help

Foundational social structures breaking down, resulting in chaos (not having access to emergency services or medical care, phone service ceasing to work, electricity grids failing, etc.)

Being targeted by enemy forces (because of the character's race, occupation, political beliefs, etc.)

The character being forced to use their specialized skill set to help the enemy

Having to go into hiding to avoid persecution or death

Being betrayed by people the character trusted and turned over to the enemy

Becoming a prisoner of war

Losing a family member in the war

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anxiety, Appalled, Apprehension, Concern, Conflicted, Denial, Depressed, Despair, Desperation, Devastation, Disappointment, Disillusionment, Dread, Excitement, Fear, Frustration, Horror, Overwhelmed, Powerlessness, Shock, Uncertainty, Worry

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Hearing news and not knowing what to believe

Not knowing what to tell the children

Being upset about inconveniences and feeling guilty because others have it so much worse

Struggling to remain positive

Worrying about the future

Seeing injustice occurring but being afraid to intervene

Wanting to help others and not knowing how

Developing a mental health issue from the trauma, such as depression or PTSD

Facing questions that threaten the character's sense of right or wrong

Feeling shame or self-loathing for decisions the character was forced to make to survive

Struggling to navigate all the emotions that come with an ongoing traumatic situation

Fighting back resentment and despair because injustice is happening and no one seems to care

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Antisocial, Childish, Controlling, Cowardly, Cynical, Fanatical, Foolish, Ignorant, Indecisive, Inflexible, Materialistic, Morbid, Nervous, Reckless, Self-Destructive, Worriwart

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Esteem and Recognition: War is a polarizing situation that can bring out the worst in people. If the character's views or actions are seen as cowardly, inflammatory, or just plain wrong, they may lose the respect of others (and never be able to earn it back).

Love and Belonging: Fear of expressing true feelings and opinions can make the character feel isolated, even if they're surrounded by loved ones and friends.

Safety and Security: War is an inherently unsafe situation—meaning, the character is unlikely to feel secure for as long as it lasts.

Physiological Needs: A character who is fighting or living in a war zone could lose their life.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Adventurous, Appreciative, Bold, Calm, Cautious, Cooperative, Decisive, Diplomatic, Disciplined, Discreet, Honorable, Hospitable, Just, Optimistic, Patriotic, Pensive, Persistent, Proactive, Resourceful

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Being able to help someone in a desperate situation

Realizing that sacrifices are sometimes necessary to achieve a greater good

Being helped by strangers, and realizing that there are good people everywhere

Seeing a courageous act that inspires the character to be brave
The character recognizing that while they may not have control over their
circumstances, they can control their responses and attitude
Holding onto courage and hope even through dark times

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WITNESS INTIMIDATION

EXAMPLES

Witnessing a crime and being anonymously contacted with a warning to say nothing

Being intimidated into silence by thugs associated with the character's criminal ex

A whistleblower being sent incriminating sexual photos of himself as a warning to keep quiet

A teen who witnesses bullying being told that the same will happen to him if he talks

A student seeing their teacher in a compromising situation being told that it's up to them if they pass or fail

The prosecution's star witness learning that someone sinister was in his elderly mother's home

A jury member receiving photos of her children under surveillance, along with a threatening note

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Finding it hard to think straight

Feeling fearful and unsafe, even in their own home

Feeling watched and monitored

Having to hide the damning evidence (if it is being used as leverage)

Contacting friends and loved ones to make sure they are okay without raising alarms

Having to field questions about why the character is so quiet or seems distracted

Having to be on hand in case more incriminating mail or packages are delivered so they can be retrieved before family members discover the character's secrets

Having to decide whether to share the threat with police or hide it

Having to decide whether to testify or "remember things differently" to muddy the case

Everyone telling the character what he or she should do
Procrastinating and making the situation worse
Loved ones pressuring the character to make a certain decision
Suffering from insomnia, ulcers, high blood pressure, and other health issues
Being unable to focus on work or school
Distractibility and irritability causing issues with the character's spouse and children

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Not taking the threat seriously and a second reminder is sent (in the form of a random attack, a loved one being involved in a hit and run, or the character's home being broken into)
The character telling other people about what they witnessed, and them becoming targets as well
Another witness being killed by the same people who are threatening the character
Learning that the people the character trusted (the police, their boss, etc.) are part of the problem
A family member being taken and held to ensure cooperation
The character's children being terrified and living in fear
Having to go into hiding
The character sending his family away and discovering they never made it to their destination
Pressure being applied at a high level (a bank calling in a loan, sanctions on a business that are crippling) to encourage the character to refuse to testify or recant a statement
The character giving in to the pressure and changing their testimony
Not speaking out, and the aggressor goes on to hurt more people
Refusing to be deterred and being set up for a crime the character didn't commit
An assassination attempt
Being captured and killed to ensure permanent silence

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anguish, Anxiety, Betrayed, Defiant, Despair, Desperation, Disbelief, Disillusionment, Doubt, Dread,

Emasculated, Embarrassment, Fear, Flustered, Insecurity, Intimidated, Panic, Paranoia, Powerlessness, Regret, Self-Pity, Tormented

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Uncertainty over what to do

Vacillating between choices

Obsessing over the *Should Haves* and *What Ifs*

Knowing what's right but being too scared to do it

Wanting to tell someone what's happening but not wanting to endanger them

Searching for reasons to comply with the intimidators even though the character knows it's not the right thing to do

Worrying that speaking out will ruin the character's life for no purpose

The character fearing that if they give in to the demands, they'll never feel safe or be free

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Apathetic, Confrontational, Cowardly, Cynical, Foolish, Forgetful, Gullible, Needy, Nervous, Paranoid, Pessimistic, Self-Destructive, Subservient, Tactless, Volatile, Weak-Willed, Worrywart

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: An intimidated character's focus will narrow so they're looking at what's happening right now and the immediate consequences of their actions, leaving no time or energy for looking forward and pursuing meaningful interests.

Esteem and Recognition: If the character knows what's right but is too scared to do it, their image of themselves will be tarnished. Likewise, other people may think less of a character who doesn't make the "right" decisions.

Love and Belonging: Many characters in this situation won't speak to anyone about what they're going through because they're embarrassed or don't want to involve loved ones. This leaves them without much-needed emotional support.

Safety and Security: A measure of safety is always threatened in an intimidation situation—meaning, the character won't feel secure until the threat is removed.

Physiological Needs: In extreme cases, powerful and immoral individuals will go to any length to keep their secrets under wraps, including killing those who are privy to that information.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Bold, Calm, Cautious, Confident, Cooperative, Courageous, Decisive, Diplomatic, Discreet, Focused, Honorable, Independent, Inspirational, Just, Passionate, Patient, Persistent, Responsible, Uninhibited

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Gaining confidence from doing the right thing even though it seemed impossible

Being able to right a wrong

The character discovering they're not alone and joining forces with others to stop a threat

Becoming a role model for others

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Miscellaneous Challenges

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A FEAR OR PHOBIA REARING ITS HEAD

EXAMPLES

The character facing a new phobia that wasn't previously a problem
Someone accidentally triggering the character's fear
Being in a situation where the fear must be faced or someone else will suffer
The character suffering a regression when a fear they thought they had dealt with is triggered
An enemy or rival using the character's phobia against them
A phobia threatening the character at a time when they need to be at their best

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Being initially confused by the gut response, unsure of what's going on (especially if the character's phobia is an unusual one)
Being paralyzed in the moment, unable to move forward
Trying to hide the fear response from others
Lying about the situation to save face
Being teased
Making mistakes or poor decisions because of the fear
A spouse or partner thinking less of the character for their perceived lack of bravery
Suffering from nightmares or insomnia
Having to take inconvenient precautions to avoid the triggering object or event
The fear cropping up when the character is without their medication
Withdrawing socially to avoid embarrassment
Lashing out at others (misdirected emotions)

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The character's response resulting in physical injury (startling and falling down a flight of stairs, running away and being hit by a car, etc.)
Suffering extreme ridicule that damages their reputation
Losing a job because of poor performance, too many absences, etc.
Having to give up a valued hobby or pastime
Being limited at work when the character turns down good opportunities
The fear negatively impacting loved ones (a fear of intimacy causing problems in a marriage, fear of crowds making certain family outings impossible, etc.)
A friendship or romance falling apart because of the other person's lack of understanding
One fear leading to others
Resorting to unhealthy coping mechanisms
Giving in to the fear; allowing it to rule them
Being so traumatized by the event that it leads to PTSD, crippling anxiety, or paranoia

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anguish, Anxiety, Apprehension, Concern, Confusion, Defeat, Desperation, Disgust, Dread, Emasculated, Fear, Flustered, Horror, Humiliation, Hysteria, Intimidated, Overwhelmed, Panic, Paranoia, Powerlessness, Terror, Vulnerability

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character not wanting to be ruled by fear but still allowing it to limit them
The character questioning if they have the strength to face the phobia again
Struggling with feelings of despair
The character feeling responsible for an undesirable response, even if it was out of their control
The character questioning their sanity (if the fear leads to paranoia)
Knowing that a response isn't healthy but not knowing how else to react
The character blaming themselves for their fear
Feeling "less than" because other people aren't devastated by the character's fear
Retreating into themselves and shutting others out, even though they know this isn't healthy

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Cowardly, Gullible, Insecure, Irrational, Macho, Melodramatic, Nervous, Paranoid, Pessimistic, Self-Destructive, Superstitious, Weak-Willed, Worrywart

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A character dealing with a phobia will likely feel inhibited and unable to reach their full potential. Prolonged exposure to their fear coupled with an inability to cope could be crippling.

Esteem and Recognition: Failure to overcome the fear or to deal with it in a healthy manner could have negative impacts on the character's self-worth.

Love and Belonging: If the fear or phobia directly affects the character's interactions with others, and the people in the character's life are not understanding and compassionate, these bonds may break.

Safety and Security: Exposure to a phobia may jeopardize the character's sense of real or perceived safety.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Adventurous, Analytical, Bold, Calm, Cautious, Confident, Courageous, Creative, Intelligent, Observant, Optimistic, Perceptive, Proactive, Resourceful, Spiritual

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Overcoming the phobia a second time

Understanding what caused the phobia or fear to reemerge, making lifestyle changes, and prioritizing self-care to ensure it doesn't take over again

Finding a new and effective way of dealing with the fear

Becoming an inspiration to others

Changing a person's perception of someone living with phobias

Finding and connecting with others who have the same struggles

Realizing that even with the phobia, the character can live a full and happy life

The character succeeding in a difficult situation despite the fear, revealing new depths of courage and resiliency

Encountering others who share the same fear and the character realizing they're not alone

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A HEALTH ISSUE CROPPING UP

NOTES

This entry contains information related to acute or chronic illnesses, conditions, and other health concerns that arise at inconvenient times. It does not include health issues arising from injuries or other wounds. To explore those scenarios, check out [BEING INJURED](#).

EXAMPLES

Catching a cold or other minor virus from a coworker
The character's children bringing home an illness from school
Having to care for a sick loved one and being infected as a result
The character suffering a flare-up of a chronic condition
An ongoing condition creating new complications
Contracting an illness because the character isn't vaccinated or their vaccinations aren't up to date
The character discovering they have a hereditary condition shared with other family members

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Missing out on an event or family gathering
Being unable to perform daily tasks for a short period of time
Having no work sick days left
Infecting others
Having a dulled appearance due to the illness
Causing others to worry
Having to be taken care of by others
Not having healthcare or the financial means to see a doctor right away
Being fatigued for a long period of time
Having to rest often
Hating the feeling of vulnerability and weakness that comes with being sick
Fighting brain fog that comes with the illness
Having to work through the illness, despite feeling awful

Being reprimanded and sent home for going to work while sick
Feeling lonely while isolated
Other people viewing the character as frail or fragile (if they're sick often)
Others viewing the character as melodramatic or a hypochondriac

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

A minor health problem turning into a serious issue
Learning that the illness is a sign of something more serious
Known treatment options not working for the character
Having to be hospitalized
Having to file for bankruptcy due to extensive health bills
Being unable to continue working
Being permanently disabled from complications
A student missing so much school that they fail, lose a scholarship, or have to be held back
Developing a fear of germs and getting sick
An immune-compromised loved one catching the illness from the character
Being told that the illness is terminal

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Agitation, Anxiety, Concern, Defeat, Denial, Disappointment, Discouraged, Envy, Frustration, Impatience, Loneliness, Moody, Neglected, Overwhelmed, Powerlessness, Resignation, Sadness, Self-Pity, Somberness, Vulnerability, Wanderlust, Worry

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character blaming themselves for becoming ill
Frustration at not being able to perform properly at work or school
The sick character feeling guilty for not being able to care for other ill family members
The mind continually circling around to worst-case scenarios
Fearing that the diagnosis is worse than it actually is
The character wanting to be around others but knowing they should isolate
The character feeling guilt about not fulfilling their responsibilities and letting others down
Stressing over a growing to-do list
Being paranoid about future illnesses

Being tempted to lie about the severity of the illness to others (because the character wants to attend an event, they don't want people fussing, etc.)

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Controlling, Defensive, Grumpy, Humorless, Impatient, Irrational, Irresponsible, Melodramatic, Needy, Paranoid, Pessimistic, Stubborn, Uncooperative, Ungrateful, Vain, Whiny, Workaholic, Worrywart

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A character's full potential may go unrealized for the duration of the illness, making them feel incomplete or unhappy.

Love and Belonging: If a family member is resentful or begrudging about their caregiving duties, the character may begin to feel unwanted or unloved.

Physiological Needs: An illness can contribute to a lack of sleep, not eating or drinking enough, and perhaps an inability for the character to care for him or herself.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Appreciative, Centered, Cooperative, Funny, Gentle, Happy, Humble, Introverted, Obedient, Optimistic, Patient, Persistent, Proactive, Resourceful, Responsible, Sensible, Spiritual, Uninhibited

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Becoming aware of the health issue so future flare-ups can be predicted and prevented

Being able to take time off from work and rest

Gaining a better understanding of the condition and how to treat it

Getting temporary help for chores and other responsibilities

An introverted character making the most of a bad situation and enjoying alone time

The character's relationship with their caregiver improving

The character being able to indulge in a desired activity, such as reading or playing a video game

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A REPRESSED MEMORY RESURFACING

EXAMPLES

The character being triggered by something in their environment
Overhearing a discussion that leads to forgotten memories
Uncovering something unexpected during hypnotherapy
Experiencing a traumatic situation that awakens past memories
Finding mementos from the past that trigger a flood of unwanted memories

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Becoming emotional and anxious
Being confused by the sudden memories
Being distracted from work or school duties
Difficulty sleeping and eating
Experiencing a fight-flight-or freeze reaction and causing a scene
Remembering trauma that will impact other people
Still being in contact with people associated with the past event and having to interact with them
Underlying behaviors becoming worse (fear reactions) because the character now understands the reason for them
The character being frustrated about the holes in their memories
Feeling driven to investigate (researching news clips, going through family albums, etc.)
Asking questions of family members without raising suspicions
An increased financial burden from needing to see a therapist or go on medication

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The memory being so traumatic the character immediately shuts down (disengaging from work, forgetting to pick kids up from school, becoming unresponsive, etc.)
Becoming isolated and paranoid because of new trust issues

Telling a loved one the truth and being chastised as a liar or someone who is mistaken

The memory destroying a relationship with someone the character trusts

A family fracturing when a member's involvement in a past event is revealed

A family member being arrested or incarcerated for their past actions

The character prematurely confronting the person responsible and not achieving closure

A loved one learning the truth and enacting vengeance, leading to more problems

Being unable to achieve closure because the person who was responsible has died

Living in denial about the memory; choosing not to believe it or pretending it never happened

Turning to drugs or alcohol to numb the pain

Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD) derailing the character's life

Becoming depressed

Having suicidal thoughts

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anguish, Anxiety, Betrayed, Bitterness, Confusion, Depressed, Disgust, Disillusionment, Fear, Grief, Guilt, Hatred, Humiliation, Insecurity, Neglected, Overwhelmed, Panic, Paranoia, Self-Loathing, Shame, Terror, Tormented

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Struggling to hide the memory and act like nothing has changed

The character doubting their memories and what's real

Self-loathing and self-blame (often undeserved)

Feeling unsafe and not knowing how to fix it

Feeling like their life has derailed, like it no longer fits who they are

Wanting to move past what happened but being unable to

Struggling to decide what to tell others

Needing to share the burden with someone else but fearing the secret will change the way they view the character

Wanting to know the whole story about the past event but being terrified to learn more

Being grateful to know about the past event while also wishing the memory had never surfaced

Anger and resentment toward people involved who should have protected the character or made different choices

Religious disillusionment

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Addictive, Apathetic, Cowardly, Dishonest, Impulsive, Insecure, Irrational, Needy, Nervous, Paranoid, Reckless, Uncommunicative, Vindictive, Violent, Volatile

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: The surfacing of a painful memory could cause a crisis of self, causing the character to wonder who they really are or who they might have been had the event not happened.

Esteem and Recognition: When a memory resurfaces and becomes known, it reveals a vulnerability that the character cannot control. Knowing that others know what happened can cause the character to feel pitied which may make them feel weakened or insecure.

Love and Belonging: If loved ones were involved (causing harm or trying to keep the truth quiet), the character may choose to sever those relationships and struggle with trust issues moving forward.

Safety and Security: Some memories are more treacherous than others, involving parties who have a vested interest in keeping the truth buried. If your character was a witness to something illegal or immoral, it might be dangerous for them to reveal what they know.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Analytical, Centered, Cooperative, Courageous, Curious, Empathetic, Honest, Just, Mature, Objective, Optimistic, Perceptive, Persistent, Responsible, Sensible, Simple, Wise

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

The character acknowledging their past trauma and seeking help to work through it

Having an explanation for why they feel a certain way (when they're in a specific place, with a person, or doing an activity)

Experiencing relief from finding answers about a past event or situation

Recognizing that there's a reason for certain dysfunctional behaviors and addressing them

Being able to achieve closure when there was no hope of it before

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AN ANTICIPATED EVENT BEING CANCELED

EXAMPLES

A sporting event being canceled due to bad weather

A conference having to be rescheduled because the venue double-booked its events

A couple not being able to take a honeymoon because of a natural disaster in the area

A vacation not taking place because of a death in the family

Venue renovations delaying an event until further notice

A concert or rally being canceled because of a security breach

A pandemic causing a graduation ceremony to not take place

A benefit being canceled when the host falls ill or unexpectedly passes away

A wedding being called off at the last minute

Financial difficulties causing the character's retirement to be postponed indefinitely

A couple's golden anniversary party being canceled when one of them falls ill

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Being disappointed

Having to wait for the event to be rescheduled

Lamenting wasted time preparing for the event

The character taking out their frustrations on others

Scrambling to let other people in the character's party know about the cancelation

Losing money that was spent on flights or lodging

Time spent tracking expenses and making sure refunds are issued

Not being notified about the cancelation until the character arrives at the event

Having to find another way to pass the time
Having to break the news to excited children
The character trying to stay upbeat while traveling with angry or whiny companions
Having to reschedule and make new plans
Details being scarce, making it difficult to reschedule
Having to rely on distant friends or acquaintance for lodging

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The cause of the cancelation putting the character in critical danger (a terrorist attack, the building collapsing, a freak ice storm, etc.)
Being unprepared to stay overnight and having to find lodging when no rooms are available
Knowing this was the last chance the character or a loved one had to attend the event (because of a terminal illness, going to prison, etc.)
A canceled charity event resulting in beneficiaries not receiving funding
The character going on a social media tirade and damaging their reputation
Ranting and railing against the person or entity responsible for the cancelation and being blocked from attending future events
Missing out on a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Agitation, Anger, Anxiety, Betrayed, Bitterness, Confusion, Denial, Desperation, Disappointment, Disbelief, Dissatisfaction, Frustration, Impatience, Irritation, Moody, Neglected, Powerlessness, Rage, Regret, Remorse, Resentment, Self-Pity

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Uncertainty about where to go and what to do (if the character is stuck in an unfamiliar place)
Difficulty getting over the disappointment and moving on
Being upset about missing the event and feeling superficial and insensitive about it (because a death was the cause of the cancelation)
Being disappointed but also relieved (because the character had mixed feelings about going, is feuding with another event attendee, is looking forward to spending a quiet evening alone in a hotel, etc.)
Worrying that the cancelation is more than coincidence—because the character is marrying the wrong person, for instance

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Childish, Confrontational, Controlling, Cynical, Disrespectful, Haughty, Hostile, Inflexible, Irrational, Judgmental, Materialistic, Melodramatic, Resentful, Spoiled, Temperamental, Vindictive

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: If the event is closely connected to the character's goals or is a stepping-stone to realizing a dream, this setback will delay the character's fulfillment.

Love and Belonging: If the cancelation is prolonged and the event is the only opportunity for the character to be with loved ones, they may suffer from being unable to get together.

Safety and Security: The character's security may be threatened if they're stuck far from home without necessary resources or they get caught in the dangerous circumstances that caused the cancelation.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Adventurous, Calm, Charming, Creative, Diplomatic, Easygoing, Extroverted, Funny, Imaginative, Independent, Kind, Mature, Optimistic, Patient, Resourceful, Sensible, Spontaneous, Thrifty

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Getting to spend a day exploring new surroundings

The character having a day to themselves

Meeting locals and making new friends

The character having more time to prepare (if they played an important role in the event)

The character waiting patiently for the rescheduled event and benefiting from delayed gratification

An emergency arising that the character wouldn't have been able to pay for without the refunded money from their trip

The character avoiding something catastrophic that happened at the venue when they would have been there

The character and their family or travel buddies having plenty of downtime to bond

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AN UNEXPECTED CHANGE OF PLANS

EXAMPLES

A flight being delayed

The character's child getting sick and needing care

Bad weather forcing the character to postpone vacation plans

Learning that a parent has had a heart attack

Someone with whom the character has plans calling to cancel

Finding a stray animal on the roadside and needing to care for it

Going for a run and finding someone who has collapsed on the sidewalk

The character leaving for an anticipated date and discovering their car battery is dead

Construction causing a detour during a road trip

The character becoming ill while traveling

Witnessing a crime while going to meet a friend and having to report it and talk to the police

Getting injured at work and needing to go to the hospital

Going into labor prematurely

A routine doctor's visit resulting in emergency surgery

A merger at work that changes the character's responsibilities or does away with their position

A retiree being scammed out of their nest egg and having to go back to work

An unexpected divorce changing the entire trajectory of the character's future

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Missing an important meeting or appointment

Not having certain items that would help navigate the change of plans (access to a digital calendar, contact information for someone, a cell phone charger or spare change of clothing)

The delay causing other people to wait on the character
Having to reschedule
Missing a meal
Having to renege on a promise
Apologizing for not being able to follow through
The change causing tension with loved ones who are also inconvenienced
Having to fill out paperwork, file reports, or talk to officials
Appearing frazzled or disheveled to others
The character taking their frustration out on others and causing a scene
The character panicking and saying or doing something they later regret
Losing money in the form of non-refundable deposits
Having to give bad news (about a canceled trip, etc.) to children

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Losing a client
Not finding help in enough time
The unexpected event being the last straw for the character—e.g., an employee who has received multiple warnings for tardiness now getting fired for being late
The change in plans resulting in a cancelation that can't be rescheduled, such as a flight delay causing the character to miss a funeral
The change negatively affecting the character's loved ones
Lashing out at loved ones who have unintentionally caused the change in plans (a child who gets sick, a parent needing care, etc.)
Being so overstressed that this disruption causes a breakdown
Doing something rash in response (quitting a job, telling a spouse they want a divorce, walking out on a sibling who always needs to be rescued, etc.)

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Agitation, Anger, Annoyance, Bitterness, Disappointment, Disbelief, Dissatisfaction, Flustered, Frustration, Impatience, Irritation, Moody, Overwhelmed, Rage, Resentment, Sadness, Self-Pity, Shock, Vengeful, Vulnerability, Wariness, Worry

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Struggling to contain frustration and not take it out on others
Feeling overwhelmed and not knowing what to do
Contemplating the best way to deliver bad news to others

Not knowing how to mentally prepare for what's coming next
Feeling guilty for how the change affects others, even when it's not the character's fault

The character wasting mental time thinking about what they could have done differently

Becoming apathetic because burnout is closing in

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Apathetic, Confrontational, Controlling, Dishonest, Humorless, Impatient, Irrational, Irresponsible, Judgmental, Manipulative, Melodramatic, Selfish, Temperamental, Uncooperative, Vindictive, Violent

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: When the affected plans are vital to fulfilling a dream or doing something important for the character, being thwarted can leave them feeling unhappy and discontent.

Esteem and Recognition: If the character is responsible for the change of plan, others may view them differently, seeing them as irresponsible, flaky, or selfish.

Love and Belonging: This situation could lead to conflict in the character's relationships with others, particularly if they were already strained prior to the event.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Adventurous, Calm, Confident, Courageous, Creative, Decisive, Diplomatic, Easygoing, Empathetic, Gentle, Happy, Independent, Kind, Nurturing, Optimistic, Patient, Resourceful, Spontaneous, Tolerant

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Having extra downtime to relax

The character's absence from the anticipated event saving them from a catastrophic occurrence

Learning patience and resiliency that will help the character deal with future disappointments

Being forced to try something new and ending up with a better opportunity than the one that was missed

Being able to save or help someone

Recognizing the need to prepare better for unexpected contingencies in the future

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AN UNWANTED INTRUSION

NOTES

It's frustrating enough to be interrupted during a pleasant activity. It's especially annoying when the intruder is someone the character would rather not see. To complicate things for them, consider working an unwanted visitor into their day. For close encounters of the unpleasant romantic kind, see AN UNWANTED ROMANTIC ADVANCE in Volume One.

EXAMPLES

A religious proselytizer ringing the character's doorbell

A guest popping in at an inconvenient time—when the character is high or has planned a romantic interlude with their significant other, for instance

Being approached by an ex while on a date

Someone persistent and repugnant propositioning the character

An abusive or hurtful person from the character's past sending them a text

The character bumping into someone they're not on speaking terms with (because things ended badly between them)

Someone with a restraining order showing up at the character's home

An in-law visiting the character at their workplace

A friend dropping by the character's apartment while they're trying to work

A verbose family member calling the character on their one day off

The character being cornered by a charity coordinator who's always asking people to volunteer

An extended family member calling to ask the character for money

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having to be polite when they don't want to

The conversation feeling awkward

Having to endure an annoying person

The character trying to hide their true feelings

Having to think up excuses to end the contact as quickly as possible

Lying to the visitor to make them go away, then being found out
Trying to disengage with someone who can't read social cues
Feeling compelled to invite the person in
Being reprimanded by the boss about visitors during work hours
An anticipated activity being interrupted by the visitor
Being less productive because of the interruption
Being late (to a meeting, picking up the kids, to a date, etc.)
Being too brusque with someone the character will have to see again
Having to be rude because the other person won't listen or take a hint
Being embarrassed in front of a friend, date, or spouse

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Complaining about the unwanted contact to someone else, and word getting back to them
Trying to be nice or accommodating and being taken advantage of
A current relationship being jeopardized by the visitor's presence
Blowing up at the other person in public and making things worse
The character's sense of safety being stolen when an abusive person reenters their life
Letting someone in and realizing it was a ruse to gain access—e.g., to assault the character or victimize them in a home invasion
The character rejecting the person, who then seeks revenge or turns to stalking
The character letting a toxic person back into their life

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Agitation, Annoyance, Anxiety, Bitterness, Contempt, Disbelief, Dread, Flustered, Frustration, Guilt, Hatred, Humiliation, Insecurity, Intimidated, Irritation, Nervousness, Overwhelmed, Panic, Paranoia, Resentment, Suspicion, Unease, Vulnerability

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Fighting to stay calm and collected
The character wanting to say something they know they'll regret
Trying to be cordial but not friendly enough to encourage more contact
The character struggling to move past a grudge they hold against the person
Not knowing what to say or do to get rid of them
Feeling guilty for pushing them away or not wanting them around

The character feeling vulnerable or unsafe in their own home
Frustration and anger warring with a desire to be polite

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Apathetic, Catty, Confrontational, Defensive, Dishonest, Disrespectful, Evasive, Hostile, Hypocritical, Insecure, Judgmental, Manipulative, Melodramatic, Pessimistic, Resentful, Tactless, Vindictive

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: An unexpected visitor invading the character's space, particularly at an inconvenient time, can cause internal friction as the character struggles to balance their personal needs with serving the other person or keeping the peace.

Esteem and Recognition: Being reintroduced to someone who treated the character poorly or made her feel bad about herself can aggravate old feelings of low self-worth.

Love and Belonging: If the visitor is a family member or a mutual friend, an unkind response by the character may lead to tension with other loved ones.

Safety and Security: If the contact is threatening or has exhibited violence in the past, the character may rightly fear for their safety.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Appreciative, Centered, Charming, Confident, Courageous, Diplomatic, Gentle, Honest, Hospitable, Humble, Independent, Kind, Mature, Objective, Optimistic, Pensive, Perceptive, Sensible, Tolerant

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Rekindling a positive relationship

Taking advantage of an opportunity to mend the relationship

The character being intrinsically rewarded for sacrificing their personal desires and serving others

Practicing self-control and learning to respond to the person in a healthy way

Establishing healthy boundaries

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BEING CURSED

NOTES

This entry refers to circumstances in which the character has been bound to an intensely negative, long-lasting malediction. For a situation in which the character experiences the results of shorter, less serious sorcery, see [BEING PLACED UNDER A SPELL](#).

EXAMPLES

Being condemned to a premature death

Everything the character touches disintegrating

Being enslaved to a witch or sorcerer for all eternity

Being doomed to have all romantic relationships fail

The character being transformed into an animal and losing their humanity

Making a trade with a demon: something beneficial in exchange for the character's soul

Stealing an object that's cursed, bringing a lifetime of bad luck for the character

A provoked spirit haunting the character for the rest of their life

Disturbing sacred ground and suffering extreme illness or death

A curse that permanently changes the character's gender

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

The character not feeling like themselves

The character losing their appetite

The character having gaps in their memory and being unable to remember certain periods of time

Having to find a way to break the curse

Suffering a wound or scar from it

Having to hide the curse from others

Avoiding circumstances that would trigger the curse

Temporary physical ailments or afflictions related to the curse

Having nightmares

Never knowing when the demon, ghost, or responsible party will reappear
A precious heirloom being cursed or destroyed

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Being magically bound to a location and being unable to leave
The character distancing themselves from loved ones to protect them
Being unable to touch others without harming them
The character losing their job after not being able to perform
The character's appearance being permanently altered
The character's identity being affected
The character permanently losing one or more of their senses
The character knowing that their days are numbered
Being controlled by another entity
The character's bad luck impacting the people close to them
Seeing no way out
Losing all sense of empathy; becoming callous
The person who invoked the curse refusing to remove it
Being doomed not only in this life but in the next as well
Doing something while cursed that the character can't live with
Being responsible for hurting or killing someone

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anguish, Anxiety, Appalled, Betrayed, Bitterness, Defeat, Depressed, Despair, Desperation, Devastation, Disbelief, Discouraged, Grief, Guilt, Horror, Humiliation, Hysteria, Loneliness, Overwhelmed, Powerlessness, Rage, Regret, Resentment, Self-Pity

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character feeling as if they deserve this punishment
Struggling to maintain optimism
Feeling hopeless
Feeling like an outcast
Becoming emotionally overwhelmed by grief or panic
Considering taking their own life to save others
The character transferring the curse to someone and having to live with that choice

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Dishonest, Disloyal, Disrespectful, Foolish, Greedy, Hostile, Impulsive,

Irrational, Jealous, Pessimistic, Possessive, Reckless, Resentful, Self-Destructive, Selfish, Unethical, Ungrateful, Vindictive, Violent

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A debilitating curse will remove a character's freedom and impact their identity. The removal of these two things almost ensure that they will never feel fully actualized.

Esteem and Recognition: A character's reputation and sense of self-worth are at risk if others gain knowledge of the curse.

Love and Belonging: A character living under a curse may become ostracized, making it difficult for them to develop lasting relationships with others.

Safety and Security: The safety of the character and their loved ones can be at risk when the amenities they're used to are no longer available.

Physiological Needs: Factors such as sleep, sex, and homeostasis might be diminished if the curse is traumatic or isolating enough.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Appreciative, Calm, Centered, Cooperative, Disciplined, Discreet, Generous, Gentle, Happy, Honorable, Humble, Independent, Just, Kind, Loyal, Optimistic, Patient, Resourceful, Spiritual, Wise

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Finding a way to break the curse

Destroying the one who set the curse, thereby nullifying it

Gaining immortality (if the character is searching for such a thing)

Learning to make the most of the situation

The character finding contentment and peace with themselves

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BEING FORCED TO LEAD

EXAMPLES

Being next in line to take over a company when the owner dies
A life-or-death emergency arising where someone has to step up and take charge
Participating in a group project that no one else wants to lead
Being bullied into taking a position that no one else wants
Having to lead a military company behind enemy lines
Taking charge of a resistance group because no one else will
Having to take charge during a medical disaster
Being assigned as a project leader at work
Leading a sports team because if no one takes charge it will be disbanded
Being the only one qualified to lead in a certain area
Being indebted and being promised a monetary reward for leading and succeeding

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Facing criticism from others
Lacking necessary supplies or resources
Working with a group or team that is untrained, inexperienced, or apathetic
Having less time to do what the character wants
Dealing with the stress of responsibility
The character struggling to lead, resulting in people losing faith in him
Lacking certain vital skills (discipline, tact, math acumen, etc.)
Friction with friends who don't agree with how the character is leading
Personality differences making leadership difficult
People resisting the character's leadership for unfair reasons (because of age, gender, race, etc.)
Apathy or fear of failure causing the character to do as little as possible while leading
Someone in the party challenging the character's leadership

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Freezing at a critical moment

Experiencing a humiliating defeat

Being demoted and replaced by someone who is less capable

Making poor decisions that negatively affect others

The character's reputation being ruined by their poor leadership

The character's life being threatened if they don't comply

Not being able to find outside help or relief from the situation

Discovering someone is trying to sabotage the character's efforts

Realizing they've been set up to fail

The character losing the respect of others with unethical decisions
(practicing nepotism, using the company's assets to the character's
advantage, being discriminatory, etc.)

Being expected to lead when success is impossible

Someone in the character's charge dying

The character struggling with perfectionism and holding themselves to an
impossible standard

Facing a no-win situation

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anxiety, Apprehension, Concern, Confusion,
Denial, Desperation, Disbelief, Doubt, Dread, Horror, Inadequate,
Insecurity, Intimidated, Nervousness, Nostalgia, Overwhelmed, Reluctance,
Terror, Uncertainty, Vulnerability, Worry

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character doubting their ability to be successful

Second-guessing every decision

Struggling to find a way out of the situation

Wondering what might happen if the character simply refused to lead

Considering sabotaging the project to put an end to it

The character panicking and not thinking clearly

Facing indecision at a critical moment

The character losing faith in themselves

The character being too hard on themselves

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Callous, Cowardly, Cruel, Dishonest, Disloyal, Disorganized, Evasive,

Foolish, Greedy, Impatient, Impulsive, Indecisive, Irrational, Know-It-All, Lazy, Pretentious, Reckless, Unethical, Weak-Willed

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: As long as the character's main responsibility falls to attending others' needs, they may feel they'll never have a chance to focus on themselves and their own desires.

Esteem and Recognition: If the character exhibits poor leadership, their reputation could be jeopardized and they could lose the respect of their team.

Safety and Security: A character forced into a leadership position whose job is dependent upon their success may feel vulnerable, fearing that their livelihood will be threatened if they don't perform well.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Analytical, Bold, Confident, Courageous, Creative, Decisive, Diplomatic, Disciplined, Honest, Humble, Inspirational, Intelligent, Just, Kind, Loyal, Objective, Organized, Professional, Responsible, Wise

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Acquiring leadership skills that can be used in other situations

Tapping into other people's strengths to balance out the character's weaknesses and create a strong team

Leading others to safety or success

Learning which techniques work (and which ones don't) for effectively leading others

The character being commended for their actions or seen as a hero

Saving someone's life

Doing well and being promoted

Becoming more comfortable with leading

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BEING IN THE WRONG PLACE AT THE WRONG TIME

EXAMPLES

Heading down to the river to fish and seeing someone dump a dead body in the river

Being present when a crime occurs

Vacationing in an area when a natural disaster hits

Needing to keep a low profile and running into someone who could blow the character's cover

The character being caught up in a bar brawl and accidentally killing someone in self-defense

Riding a train that, in a freak accident, jumps the tracks

Spending the night at a relative's house when it catches fire

Crossing an intersection when another car has run a red light

Being picked up by a serial killer while hitchhiking

Boarding a plane that ends up being hijacked

Walking into a convenience store during a robbery

Returning a book to a prison library in time to see a fellow prisoner get shanked

Working with machinery when it malfunctions

Driving behind a construction truck when a wheelbarrow or other tool flies out of the back

Being struck by lightning

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Being startled in the moment

Having to make a split-second decision

Being unable to think or process what's happening

Misreading the situation

Watching other people for cues on how to respond, and losing precious time

Underestimating the danger
Having to gain someone's trust quickly
Having to talk their way out of trouble
Suffering minor injuries
Seeing other people get hurt
The character having to convince perpetrators that they saw nothing and don't want trouble
The character's motives or word being questioned
People doubting that the character wasn't involved or responsible in some way

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Being terrified into paralysis
Being wrongly accused of a crime
Being robbed, attacked, or taken advantage of
Having to witness terrible suffering or injustice
Having to work with others in the crisis who make the character's job more difficult (because they're unrealistic, refuse to cooperate, are immobile, etc.)
Having to make quick decisions with life-or-death consequences
The character's life being threatened because they saw or heard something they shouldn't have
Incurring a terrible financial burden from hiring a lawyer, paying for auto repairs, etc.
The lack of control creating debilitating anxiety and worry in the aftermath
Suffering trauma from the event
Getting severely injured
Someone being killed
Being killed to ensure silence

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anxiety, Appalled, Concern, Denial, Desperation, Disbelief, Dread, Embarrassment, Fear, Flustered, Guilt, Horror, Humiliation, Hysteria, Overwhelmed, Panic, Powerlessness, Shame, Stunned, Terror, Vulnerability, Wariness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Grappling with what could have been done differently
Contemplating the best way to get out of the situation

Struggling with intense fear
Contemplating whether to share information that could negatively impact others
Having no sense of power or control
The character doubting their ability to get through the situation
The character being filled with anger and rage that this has happened to them
Looking for someone to blame when the situation is no one's fault
The character struggling to forgive themselves for a response that had serious fallout or unintended consequences
Suffering a crisis of faith; wondering why God would have let this happen

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Confrontational, Cowardly, Foolish, Hostile, Ignorant, Indecisive, Irresponsible, Judgmental, Pushy, Rebellious, Reckless, Self-Destructive, Selfish, Stubborn, Uncooperative, Weak-Willed, Whiny

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Esteem and Recognition: How the character reacts in this situation will affect their view of themselves—their sense of capability and their ability to function under pressure.

Safety and Security: A character in a dangerous situation will not feel safe. The outcome of the situation can also create anxiety in the future, giving them a general sense of vulnerability and a lack of security.

Physiological Needs: It's not always possible to escape a high-risk situation in which the character has no control, making loss of life very likely.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Alert, Analytical, Calm, Centered, Courageous, Decisive, Focused, Intelligent, Introverted, Meticulous, Observant, Optimistic, Perceptive, Persistent, Proactive, Protective, Resourceful, Socially Aware, Spiritual

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

The character seeing what they could have done differently and making changes for the future

Mastering fear and navigating a dangerous situation safely

The character recognizing that there was nothing they could have done to avoid the situation or improve its outcome, and that knowledge enabling them to move on

The character learning to trust their gut

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BEING MISTAKEN FOR SOMEONE ELSE

EXAMPLES

Being mistaken for a celebrity or public figure

Someone propositioning the character because they think they're a prostitute

Being targeted for revenge by a person who thinks the character is someone who has hurt them

Someone talking to the character before realizing they're not who they thought they were

Closely resembling a criminal, sexual offender, or war criminal

The character being mistaken for a sibling

The character having a doppelgänger and constantly being confused with that person

Sharing a name with someone else and being mistaken for that person

Identity theft resulting in confusion over who the character is

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Being stared at

People hovering, pointing, and whispering

A lack of privacy

Being filmed without permission

Enduring awkward conversations

Being mistrusted until the truth is sorted out

Getting mobbed by fans

Constantly having to reply politely to people who ask if they're someone else

Dealing with people who believe the character's denials are an act and won't leave them alone

Having to leave a place to avoid being pestered

The character having to go through official channels to prove their identity

Displeasure and embarrassment over being mistaken for someone undesirable

Being questioned by police (if they are mistaken for a local criminal)

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Pent-up frustration causing the character to blow up, making things worse

Being falsely accused of a crime

The character having no proof or alibi to prove their innocence

Being accused of infidelity when their doppelgänger is spotted on a date with someone else

Receiving threats (because someone believes the character is someone else)

Being assaulted for actions taken by the character's likeness

The character's credit being ruined when their identity is stolen

Family and friends turning their back on the character, believing the lies

The actual wrongdoer seizing the opportunity and framing the character

Friends and loved ones being made guilty by association

The character's credibility being ruined, impacting their business or livelihood

Being taken and tortured by dangerous people

Loved ones being caught in the crossfire and killed

Being arrested

Losing faith in a justice system that could find an innocent person guilty

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Amazement, Anger, Anguish, Anxiety, Betrayed, Bitterness, Conflicted, Defensiveness, Desperation, Determination, Disbelief, Frustration, Horror, Nervousness, Overwhelmed, Paranoia, Powerlessness, Self-Pity, Stunned, Unease, Wariness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Being tempted to pretend to be the other person (because it would generate a positive experience) but knowing it would be wrong to do so

Going along with the mistaken identity, then regretting it when things get complicated

Liking the positive aspects of being mistaken for someone attractive or popular but disliking the negative aspects

Feeling betrayed by loved ones who doubt the character's word

Feeling anger toward friends for turning on the character, yet knowing that if the circumstances were reversed, the character probably would have done the same thing

The character not seeing the resemblance and wondering if the way they see themselves is different from what others see

The character being mistaken for someone unattractive and feeling insecure about their looks

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Confrontational, Controlling, Dishonest, Evasive, Gullible, Impulsive, Irresponsible, Paranoid, Self-Destructive, Uncooperative, Volatile

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: If the character's resemblance to a well-known person affects their reputation or impedes their ability to pursue a dream, they may become stuck, unable to find success.

Esteem and Recognition: If people think the character closely resembles a nefarious or loathsome person, their mental association between the two people can cause them to think less of the character.

Safety and Security: If the person the character is being mistaken for has powerful enemies, the character and their loved ones may be put in harm's way.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Calm, Diplomatic, Optimistic, Persuasive, Resourceful

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Finding a way to make the best of the annoying situation

Reaping benefits from the mistaken identity—bypassing lines at a concert or being treated as royalty

Regaining a newfound appreciation for a simple or ordinary life

Becoming an advocate for injustice and the falsely accused

Building close bonds with those who stayed true to the character throughout the ordeal

The character discovering who their friends really are (and getting rid of the dead weight)

Becoming aware of societal inequities and how some people are unfairly targeted (through prejudice, racism, etc.), and working to bring about change

Finding a way to change their appearance so similarities become lessened, regaining anonymity

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BEING PLACED UNDER A SPELL

NOTES

This entry pertains to relatively minor magical afflictions with a temporary or trivial result. For powerful maledictions with severe implications, see the entry [BEING CURSED](#).

EXAMPLES

A talent or skill being taken away, such as a dancer being bestowed with temporary clumsiness

Being slipped a love potion

A spell being used as a prank, such as a common word triggering the character to bray like a donkey, burst into song, or fall asleep

The character always tripping in the presence of certain people

Being able to understand animals or talk to the dead, and being followed around by them

Being unable to find or use a certain object

Never being able to reach a specific location

An aspect of the character's appearance shifting depending on their mood (hair changing color, the skin breaking out in spots, etc.)

Unfortunate things happening when the character sneezes

Being unable to speak of anything related to a prophecy, spell, or curse

Being temporarily turned into an animal or inanimate object

Only being able to speak in questions

Being made invisible

The character exchanging bodies with someone else for a predetermined amount of time

Being afflicted with a seemingly good spell that causes major problems, such as the Midas touch

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Embarrassment arising from things the character did while the spell was in effect

The character having no memory of what they did while ensorcelled
Something humiliating being recorded and shared with others
A relationship being strained because of the spell
The character not being believed when they explain that a spell caused their words or actions
The character's physical appearance being temporarily altered
Enduring teasing from those around them
Needing to find a way to break the spell
Not knowing who cast the spell or why
Not knowing the trigger for an ongoing spell; being uncertain as to when it will go into effect
A loss of control chafing at the character
Physical discomfort associated with the spell

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Feeling powerless and targeted
A relationship ending due to the character's change in behavior
Not being able to explain what's happening to loved ones (because the spell won't allow them to)
Feeling utterly alone because no one else is suffering in the same way
A magical feud breaking out between the character and the spellcaster, endangering others
A nonmagical character being unfairly targeted by a spellcaster, creating an imbalance of power
The spell's result making the character vulnerable to others
Losing an opportunity or important relationship that can't be regained or replaced
An error in the spell making the effects permanent
An emotional wound forming that causes severe trust issues and anxiety
The spell causing the character to do something unforgivable

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Agitation, Anger, Anxiety, Concern, Confusion, Denial, Desire, Desperation, Determination, Disillusionment, Embarrassment, Insecurity, Lust, Obsessed, Powerlessness, Regret, Remorse, Resentment, Vengeful, Vulnerability, Wariness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character not knowing about the spell and blaming themselves for their actions

The character struggling with embarrassment about their new appearance

The character thinking they're going crazy

Wanting help but being reluctant to tell others what's happening

Worrying that things will never get better

Self-loathing arising because the character was weak enough to be targeted and not strong enough to fix the situation

Wanting revenge but fearing what payback would look like

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Cocky, Compulsive, Dishonest, Disrespectful, Foolish, Humorless, Impatient, Irrational, Pessimistic, Reckless, Resentful, Self-Destructive, Temperamental, Timid, Uncooperative, Vindictive, Weak-Willed

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Esteem and Recognition: Experiencing any level of embarrassment or humiliation while under a spell could negatively impact the character's confidence and cause them to lose the respect of others.

Love and Belonging: It's very difficult to maintain healthy relationships when the character is unable or unwilling to be 100 percent honest. If the spell has lasting effects preventing them from being forthright, the character could lose the people they care about most.

Safety and Security: While the spell's effects might be minor, the character can suffer mental distress from embarrassment, not knowing when the spell will be triggered, and being victimized by a powerful being. All of this will cause the character to feel distinctly unsafe.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Adventurous, Analytical, Cautious, Creative, Efficient, Humble, Imaginative, Independent, Intelligent, Observant, Optimistic, Patient, Perceptive, Proactive, Resourceful, Sensible, Spiritual, Wise

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Once the spell is gone, being able to see humor in the situation

Being able to break the spell and defeat the enemy

Adapting to the effects of the spell and learning to live with them

No one witnessing the spell's effects

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BEING UNABLE TO FORGIVE ONESELF

EXAMPLES

Injuring someone in a car accident

Playing a part in ending a valued relationship

Abusing or neglecting someone in the character's care

Poor decisions causing the character to miss a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity

Making a decision that costs the character their family's life savings

Giving into temptation, with disastrous results (an affair ending the character's marriage, drug use killing their dream, etc.)

The character realizing that their parenting methods have caused irreparable damage to their child

Not being available for a friend during a crisis

Crossing moral lines to survive (in a time of war, when homeless, as a child, etc.)

Killing someone in self-defense

Missing signs of depression prior to a loved one's suicide

Not voicing suspicions about someone who later goes on a killing spree

Staying in a bad relationship because the character believes they deserve punishment

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having to apologize and knowing it's not enough

Needing to be truthful with family members even though it means reliving what the character did

Having to talk about the situation to officials

Being unable to focus on day-to-day tasks

Losing time at work to seek therapy

Trying to think of ways to rectify the situation or make amends

The character being especially hard on themselves, even in daily tasks

Others thinking less of the character for their actions
The character running into a person who was hurt by their actions and not knowing what to say
Having anxiety or nightmares
Loved ones misreading the situation, believing the character is feeling sorry for themselves

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The character's mental state making it difficult for them to focus on day-to-day things
Someone close to the character refusing to forgive them
Being unable to find a way to right a wrong
The fallout to others being greater than the character first realized
Being so self-conscious or embarrassed that the character refuses to leave their house
The character distancing themselves from loved ones because they feel unworthy
The character's marriage crumbling
Being sued
Being found guilty of a crime
Overcompensating for the past event in ways that put people off (becoming clingy, needing constant affirmation, being hyper-vigilant, etc.)
The character being treated like an outcast in their community
Adopting a self-destructive coping mechanism
The character punishing themselves in extreme ways (through starving, self-harming, etc.)
Never fully recovering from the event
Sinking into self-loathing or depression

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anguish, Anxiety, Appalled, Defeat, Depressed, Despair, Desperation, Devastation, Disgust, Doubt, Emasculated, Embarrassment, Envy, Frustration, Grief, Guilt, Inadequate, Loneliness, Remorse, Self-Loathing, Shame, Tormented, Worthlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Wanting to move on but being unable to
The character berating themselves, even if others have forgiven them

Struggling with what they could have done differently
Feeling responsible for the incident regardless of their guilt or innocence
Knowing they need to apologize but not having the courage to do so
The character believing that everyone is blaming and judging them
Feeling incompetent, untrustworthy, or defective in some way

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Addictive, Cowardly, Cruel, Cynical, Defensive, Dishonest, Evasive, Foolish, Hypocritical, Ignorant, Impulsive, Inattentive, Inflexible, Irrational, Jealous, Judgmental, Pretentious, Reckless, Self-Destructive

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A character struggling with self-blame may refuse to pursue a dream because deep down they believe they're not worthy of it.

Esteem and Recognition: A character in this situation will struggle with poor self-esteem that may progress to the point of self-loathing. Others may also blame the character and withhold forgiveness, causing an extreme void in this area.

Love and Belonging: Consequences of the character's actions and a lack of self-forgiveness can create a sense of no longer being worthy of love from others.

Safety and Security: The character's safety will be threatened if their self-blame pushes them to engage in harmful or risky behaviors.

Physiological Needs: If the character's self-hatred escalates, a person in this situation may consider ending their own life.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Appreciative, Centered, Confident, Disciplined, Gentle, Happy, Humble, Nature-Focused, Objective, Optimistic, Pensive, Philosophical, Responsible, Sensible, Spiritual, Uninhibited, Wise

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Forgiveness from others leading the character to forgive themselves
Recognizing that everyone—even the character—is worthy of forgiveness
Learning to deal with repressed emotions
Developing a stronger support group
Learning to communicate better with others
Finding peace through service, giving to others in need

Finding a hobby that helps the character manage their stress and negative thoughts

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CONTEMPLATING SUICIDE

Content may be triggering. Proceed with caution.

NOTES

Suicidal ideation can result from different types of trauma or mental health issues. It may also come about from a devastating loss, oppression, or other painful life battle. As it progresses, it becomes a source of serious conflict, largely in the form of internal strife. When people contemplate suicide, the weight of their suffering can feel insurmountable, so think carefully about a character's circumstances and how they view themselves before using this conflict.

If you've struggled personally in this area, please be aware this entry could be triggering. And if you find yourself in this situation now, know that we care about you and advise you to talk to someone. [Hotlines](#) are available in many countries.

WHAT THIS MIGHT LOOK LIKE ON THE OUTSIDE

Pulling away from others and withdrawing from family activities

Sleeping much more or less than usual

Long-lasting sadness or depression

Decreased interest in personal hygiene and self-care

Talking about feeling trapped, being a burden to others, and wanting to die

Noticeable wounds from cutting that are no longer being hidden

The character giving up activities or hobbies they once enjoyed

Reckless or harmful behaviors (drug use, unprotected sex, driving erratically, etc.)

Researching suicide methods

Giving away possessions

Making a suicide plan

Seeking help, therapy, or other preventive methods

Unsuccessful suicide attempts—real attempts or those meant to get help

The character appearing suddenly calmer or even happy (because a decision

has been made to free themselves of an unbearable burden)

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having to put on a happy face for others

Avoiding family members' questions and concerns

Having to hide strong emotional surges (anger, hopelessness, etc.)

Discomfort from physical pain (manifestations of emotional pain)

Hiding plans, supplies, and internet search histories from others

Being put on the spot when others express concern about the character's mental state

Difficulty finding joy in anything

Being forced to attend therapy, take medication, or undergo other preventive methods

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Feeling overwhelmed by psychological and/or physical pain

The character talking to someone about their mindset and not being taken seriously

Being given advice that makes things worse: *You're overreacting, Suicide isn't the answer*, etc.

Something big (or small) happening that pushes the character over the edge

Someone close to the character committing suicide, making it more real and achievable

Worsening depression

Suicidal ideation becoming chronic, never going away

Attempting suicide

Committing suicide

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anxiety, Conflicted, Defeat, Despair, Doubt, Dread, Hurt, Loneliness, Overwhelmed, Powerlessness, Self-Loathing, Shame, Tormented, Worthlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Fearing that life will never get better

Feeling like a burden for needing help and support

Inner thoughts reinforcing hopelessness and worthlessness that won't stop

Not wanting to have suicidal thoughts but not knowing how to stop them

Being unable to see the positives in life despite knowing they're there
Feeling incapable of coping with the big and small things
Struggling with the guilt of knowing who would be hurt if they go through with it
Wanting help but not wanting to be viewed as weak or defective
Refusing to admit that the suicidal thoughts are a problem
Knowing that suicide isn't the answer but desperately wanting to escape

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Addictive, Compulsive, Evasive, Morbid, Pessimistic, Reckless, Self-Destructive, Uncommunicative, Withdrawn

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A character who is considering suicide may feel that they have no purpose or hope. By necessity, their mental energy is focused on the day-to-day struggle to keep going.

Esteem and Recognition: A character in this situation could feel that they have no value or worth—to the point that they may believe a lie: that the world is better off without them.

Love and Belonging: A character struggling with suicide will often withdraw from others, leaving them isolated and without the support they desperately need.

Safety and Security: Suicidal thoughts can make the character feel vulnerable, and if their ability to cope narrows, the danger to themselves increases.

Physiological Needs: If circumstances do not change and the character does not get the help they need, the likelihood they may take their own life is high.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE:

Appreciative, Centered, Cooperative, Courageous, Creative, Generous, Honest, Objective, Optimistic, Socially Aware

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Finding someone to act as a sounding board who will be available when the thoughts get too loud

Finding a coping mechanism that helps push the dark thoughts away

Identifying a cause (mental health issues, an emotional wound, oppression, etc.) and seeking help

Finding purpose through an area of giftedness, ideology, charitable endeavor, or spirituality

Being able to recognize the signs in others and become a listening ear and wise counselor

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DISCOVERING A DEAD BODY

EXAMPLES

Hiking in the woods and stumbling across a corpse in the underbrush

Renovating a house and discovering remains hidden in the walls

Draining a lake and finding bones at the bottom

Providing housecleaning services and coming across body parts in the freezer

Finding a corpse in the trunk of a friend's car

Walking home at night and seeing a body in an alley

The character checking on a friend they haven't heard from in a while, only to find them deceased

Visiting an elderly neighbor and discovering their body in the house

Uncovering remains in the wreckage following a bombing, earthquake, or mass shooting

Being the first person on scene at a fatal car crash

Finding a corpse used in a gruesome ritual in a remote location

A soldier grabbing an injured buddy to carry them to safety and discovering they're already dead

Being first on scene at a homicide

Finding a boat adrift and everyone on board is dead

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Feeling unclean despite not making contact with the corpse

Vomiting at the discovery

Accidentally contaminating the crime scene

Having to speak to the police about what happened

The discovery hijacking the character's day, causing them to miss out on anticipated plans

No longer feeling safe in that location

Having to field questions from morbidly curious people

The character being rebuked because they handled the situation poorly

Suffering from insomnia

Feeling unsafe

Being questioned by the deceased's loved ones

Being hounded by reporters

The character's children being frightened by the experience

The character's house becoming part of the crime scene (if the remains were discovered there), forcing them to find temporary lodgings elsewhere

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The character being implicated in the crime (despite their innocence)

Developing post-traumatic stress or another long-term condition

The character becoming morbidly obsessed with death

The discovery exposing a secret that someone desperately wants to keep quiet

The responsible party threatening the character if they don't change their story or hide certain details

Becoming obsessed with the victim

The character's recall of the crime scene not matching police reports, suggesting foul play or a cover-up

A young character being unable to fully process what they've seen

The character discovering that they knew the deceased

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anguish, Anxiety, Appalled, Concern, Confusion, Curiosity, Denial, Desperation, Devastation, Disbelief, Disgust, Dread, Fear, Flustered, Horror, Hysteria, Insecurity, Overwhelmed, Panic, Paranoia, Shock, Stunned, Terror, Vulnerability

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Being paralyzed in the moment and not knowing the first step to take

The character's mind having difficulty accepting what the eyes are seeing

Fighting the urge to panic

The character not knowing how to describe what they've seen

The character feeling responsible for the deceased even though they couldn't have helped them

The character knowing they should report what they found but not wanting to get involved

Being unable to escape the mental images associated with the corpse

Being haunted by the victim's last moments and the way they died
The character becoming consumed with their own mortality
The character being afraid to sleep because of the images they see and the dreams they have
Being overwhelmed with emotions, fears, and questions
The feeling that their life has irrevocably changed

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Apathetic, Callous, Cowardly, Cruel, Dishonest, Disrespectful, Evil, Foolish, Gossipy, Insecure, Irresponsible, Judgmental, Morbid, Paranoid, Scatterbrained, Suspicious, Uncooperative, Unethical

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Esteem and Recognition: People in the community may look differently at the character if they don't believe her version of what happened or if she becomes inextricably associated with the appalling events.

Safety and Security: The character's safety could be threatened if the events surrounding the death pose a risk, such as a murderer coming after the character or the body hosting a contagion.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Alert, Analytical, Calm, Cautious, Cooperative, Courageous, Empathetic, Honorable, Innocent, Just, Kind, Mature, Merciful, Meticulous, Objective, Observant, Perceptive, Responsible, Spiritual, Uninhibited, Wise

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Helping the deceased's loved ones find closure
The character's discovery providing evidence that solves a cold case
Helping to capture a criminal before they strike again
Gaining a new appreciation for how precious life is
Being regarded as a hero in the community
Earning a monetary reward for finding a missing person
The character being praised for their level-headedness in an extraordinary situation

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EXPERIENCING MEMORY LOSS

EXAMPLES

Developing a chronic condition that leads to short-term memory loss
Sustaining a concussion that affects the memory
Experiencing a traumatic event that results in the suppression of memories
Growing older and struggling to recall past events
Getting an acute illness that temporarily affects the memory
Taking a drug that inhibits cognitive abilities
Being slipped a medication that makes the character forget things
Not sleeping for days on end, then being unable to recall details clearly
Struggling with mental health issues that impact the character's ability to recall events correctly
A high-stress situation clouding the character's memory and recall of details

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Losing credibility with others
Being pitied by others
The character's autonomy decreasing out of necessity
Getting frustrated when people claim things happened differently than the character remembers
Frequently misplacing items
Needing help with everyday tasks, such as cooking or tying shoes, because the character has forgotten how to do them
Having to give up a favorite hobby because the character can no longer remember the rules
Not recognizing that there's a problem
The sickening feeling when the character realizes they've already asked a question or had a conversation
The character losing their train of thought mid-sentence
Forgetting a deadline or appointment
Needing to have someone else drive them around for a while
The character forgetting their name or other important personal information

Not recognizing a loved one or friend

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The character permanently losing awareness of their own identity

Constantly feeling lost and confused

The character no longer being able to safely live on their own

The character no longer being able to perform their job

The character failing at school

The character having to trust others with the details of life (with health decisions, financial information, computer passwords, etc.)

Their driver license being revoked

Taking medication that helps the memory but makes the character feel awful

The character feeling abandoned because they've been put in a home or don't remember loved ones visiting

The character's loved ones pulling away because watching this deterioration is too painful

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Agitation, Anger, Bitterness, Confusion, Defensiveness, Denial, Depressed, Desperation, Disbelief, Discouraged, Disillusionment, Embarrassment, Frustration, Grief, Loneliness, Powerlessness, Self-Pity, Shame, Unappreciated, Worry, Worthlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Trying so hard to remember something and not being able to

Struggling to identify how much of the memory loss is normal and what's abnormal

The character convincing themselves that they don't have a memory issue, despite evidence

Wanting to continue with favorite activities but being frustrated by the new limitations

Being angry and struggling not to take it out on others

Feeling shameful about the condition

Worrying that the memory loss will progress

Diminished self-esteem from no longer being able to do something they were really good at

Resenting coddling or micromanaging family members yet recognizing the need for their support

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Catty, Childish, Controlling, Defensive, Disorganized, Forgetful, Fussy, Grumpy, Inflexible, Irrational, Oversensitive, Pessimistic, Reckless, Stubborn, Temperamental, Uncooperative, Ungrateful

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: It's difficult for a character to be fully realized when they're unable to do what makes them happy and can't remember important aspects of who they are and what's important to them.

Esteem and Recognition: A character struggling with an undiagnosed memory problem may be criticized for something that's beyond their control, causing them to internalize the issue.

Love and Belonging: If frustration over increased care causes family members to treat the character poorly, they may end up feeling abandoned and unloved.

Safety and Security: If the memory loss keeps the character from being able to perform basic tasks without supervision, it could create an unsafe environment for themselves and others.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Appreciative, Calm, Confident, Cooperative, Decisive, Disciplined, Funny, Happy, Honest, Humble, Kind, Mature, Optimistic, Organized, Persistent, Resourceful, Responsible, Sensible, Whimsical, Wise

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Becoming an inspiration for others who suffer from memory loss

Forgetting a painful experience

Gaining a more positive outlook on life and appreciating the small things

Growing closer to their caregivers

A family member moving closer so they can be with the character more often

Seeking help early and finding a treatment to reverse or halt the memory loss

Being a candidate for a drug trial and seeing their memory improve

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HAVING A CRISIS OF FAITH

EXAMPLES

The character finding out about deceptive practices at their place of worship

The character hearing arguments against their religious beliefs that make them question their faith

The character reaching a point in their maturity and growth where they begin to question what they've always been taught

Being cast out of a religious community for a transgression

Discovering ulterior motives or unforgivable flaws in a mentor

Seeing suffering in the world that can't be explained away

Struggling with a seemingly insurmountable addiction

Praying diligently for something that doesn't come to pass

A loved one dying unexpectedly

Being presented with a religious ideal that doesn't fit the character's belief system

Questioning inconsistencies in religious teachings in which certain ones have been discarded while others are held as absolute fact

Developing a terminal illness that steals all hope

Being the victim of a violent crime

Experiencing multiple miscarriages

The character's marriage falling apart, despite their best efforts

Experiencing progressive traumas, one after the other

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Asking questions but being shut down

Arguing with family members and friends who still embrace their faith

The character being judged by their religious community

Being pressured by others to make a certain decision about their faith

Slipping into negative behaviors to cope with the difficulties that caused the crisis

Having to reevaluate what's important and what should take priority

Looking for answers and struggling to find an unbiased source of information

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The character losing their sense of place in the world

Animosity between the character and their loved ones causing a rift

The character losing their core support system

No longer feeling welcome in a community

Searching for something to fill the void and being pulled into a cult

The character rejecting their faith for the wrong reasons (to rebel against parents, so they can embrace something unhealthy the faith condemns, etc.)

Making a hurried decision and regretting it later

Experiencing panic attacks brought on by the fear that everything they've known is a lie

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Betrayed, Bitterness, Conflicted, Confusion, Defeat, Depressed, Desperation, Devastation, Discouraged, Disillusionment, Doubt, Embarrassment, Frustration, Grief, Hurt, Insecurity, Loneliness, Regret, Resentment, Worthlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character reevaluating that part of their identity and questioning their life choices

Knowing they need to start anew but lacking the courage to do so

Wondering if their bad choices negate or outweigh their good ones

Struggling to find the strength to overcome the crisis

Wanting to talk to others about their struggle but being afraid of judgment

The character blaming others for their own shortcomings

Feeling like a failure for having doubts

Not knowing who to talk to

The character feeling like their entire identity and everything they know is crumbling

The character fearing for their eternal soul

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Apathetic, Compulsive, Cynical, Hypocritical, Ignorant, Impatient, Impulsive, Insecure, Know-It-All, Materialistic, Pessimistic, Prejudiced, Reckless, Self-Destructive, Stubborn, Unethical, Vain, Weak-Willed

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: If the character's faith defines who they are and their purpose in the world, the loss could shake their very foundation, bringing everything they've believed into question.

Esteem and Recognition: Guilt over questioning their faith may cause them to think badly about themselves. Other people within their spiritual community may also think less of the character for their doubts.

Love and Belonging: A character rejecting a faith that's an integral part of their community can lead to a loss of friendship and support, making them feel like they no longer belong.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Appreciative, Centered, Confident, Creative, Disciplined, Extroverted, Friendly, Funny, Generous, Humble, Independent, Intelligent, Mature, Objective, Optimistic, Patient, Pensive, Spiritual, Wise

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Gaining a new perspective

The character renewing their faith after losing it

Forming new friendships

Getting a fresh start in life

Resolving the crisis in a way that strengthens the character's faith

Serving as an inspiration to others struggling with the same thing

Embracing doubts and searching as a healthy part of the faith process

Recognizing that the problem isn't with faith but with the flawed organization or people who represent it, and seeking to elicit change

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HAVING TO BLINDLY TRUST SOMEONE

EXAMPLES

The character having to take an emergency trip and leave their pets with someone who has never watched them

Needing a doctor to perform a lifesaving but risky medical procedure

A vacationing character enlisting a local to give them a tour around an unfamiliar city

Working on an important project with a new team

Being referred to a new professional (a financial advisor, live-in nurse, nanny, etc.) when the one the character has always used retires

A kidnapped or trafficked character being offered help by a stranger

The character becoming ill in a foreign country and having to rely on strangers for care

Engaging in an illicit activity (buying drugs, hiring a hitman, selling stolen merchandise, etc.) and trusting that the other person isn't a cop

Being imprisoned and trusting that the guards will be fair and protect the character

Relying on strangers to smuggle the character out of a hostile area or hide them from authorities

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Trauma or fear clouding the character's judgment, making it difficult for them to decide what to do

An independent character having to accept help from others

Loved ones or co-conspirators disagreeing with the character's choice of who to trust

Having to relinquish control to someone else

The trusted person turning out to be incompetent, lazy, or not a good fit for the character

The person not working out, and the character having to waste more time and money finding a replacement

The character having to hold their tongue when the other person makes a decision they disagree with

Having to be comfortable with never having all the information

Asking questions the other person won't answer (because they have to keep a confidence, the truth would frighten the character, it's better if they don't know, etc.)

Having to pay for the other person's service and not knowing if the investment will pay off

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The character discovering that their trust has been misplaced

Learning that the other person wasn't completely honest about themselves

The character putting themselves completely in the other person's hands and missing obvious signs that something was off

The character risking all their money to acquire the person's services, and the gamble not paying off

Replacing a bad situation for a worse one

Being betrayed or set up

Being found by people the character was trying to avoid

Being arrested

Suffering physical abuse or harm

Others being harmed because the character chose to trust the wrong person

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Agitation, Anxiety, Apprehension, Betrayed, Bitterness, Concern, Conflicted, Defeat, Defiant, Desperation, Disillusionment, Doubt, Dread, Emasculated, Fear, Humiliation, Insecurity, Intimidated, Reluctance, Uncertainty, Unease, Vulnerability

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Struggling to give up control, even when it's the only way forward

A proud character struggling to ask others for assistance

Having doubts about the person but not knowing if they're warranted

The character trying to believe that most people are good so they can relax and focus their attention elsewhere

Deciding to trust another person, but worrying the whole time about what could go wrong

The character feeling as if their judgment is flawed and they can't trust their instincts

Struggling with shame and self-blame when the person turns out to be untrustworthy

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Childish, Controlling, Defensive, Dishonest, Foolish, Grumpy, Impatient, Insecure, Nagging, Needy, Pushy, Reckless, Resentful, Selfish, Stubborn, Uncooperative, Ungrateful, Violent, Whiny

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Esteem and Recognition: A character with a strong sense of self-reliance who highly values liberty may feel unsettled in this situation, believing they should have been able to take care of themselves.

Love and Belonging: If trusting an incompetent or duplicitous person has serious repercussions, the character may find themselves at odds with loved ones who blame them for not listening to them or engaging the wrong person.

Safety and Security: This need can quickly become threatened in a situation where the character's physical safety, mental stability, or freedom are on the line.

Physiological Needs: If the character is trusting a stranger with their life, the wrong choice could have dire consequences.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Adventurous, Alert, Appreciative, Calm, Confident, Courageous, Creative, Easygoing, Focused, Honest, Humble, Innocent, Intelligent, Observant, Perceptive, Resourceful, Trusting, Uninhibited, Wise

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

The person ending up being amazing—someone the character will work with for many years

The character's hope in humankind being renewed

Making it out of a life-threatening situation alive

Learning to give up control and trust others

The character learning to trust their gut instincts

Learning to distinguish trustworthy people from rascals
Being so appreciative of the person that the character becomes inspired to
do the same for others

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HAVING UNWANTED POWERS

EXAMPLES

Hearing other people's thoughts
Everything the character touches turning to dust
Seeing the deceased in spirit form
Having acute hearing that can't be shut off
Physically feeling others' pain
The character being able to grant other people's wishes (but not their own)
Being invisible
Having a fantastic singing voice, but only when the character is alone
Being immortal, even if the character has severe wounds
Smelling things more strongly than what is normal
Having visions of the future
Seeing how people are going to die
Spontaneously time-warping or teleporting without any control
Strong emotions affecting the weather
Being a powerful empath who senses every emotion
Being able to do something that other people wish to exploit

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Lacking the ability to control the power
Difficulty communicating with others
People asking insensitive questions
Repeatedly being asked for a demonstration
Breaking something or destroying it
Having physical ailments related to the power (headaches, ringing ears, nausea, etc.)
Not being able to sleep well
Feeling or being treated like an outcast
The character's senses being overloaded
Being treated like a spectacle by others
Friends and acquaintances being afraid of the character

Being gossiped about

People making assumptions about the character because of the power

Having to take uncomfortable or inconvenient precautions so the power isn't used accidentally (wearing earplugs, not being able to touch people,

having to avoid places with strong smells, etc.)

Needing to be hyperaware of triggers and avoid them

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Using the power to do something awful and not being able to undo it

Accidentally hurting a friend

Being avoided by everyone

Losing a significant other who doesn't know how to deal with the character's abilities

Using the power in anger against an enemy, and something terrible happening

Being completely isolated, with no friends or supporters

Being hunted by people who wish the character ill

Having no way to get rid of the power

The character accidentally destroying the world

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anguish, Anxiety, Appalled, Bitterness, Concern, Defeat, Despair, Desperation, Devastation, Envy, Frustration, Grief, Guilt, Humbled, Hysteria, Loneliness, Longing, Overwhelmed, Paranoia, Self-Loathing, Self-Pity, Shame, Tormented

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Wanting someone to talk to but being afraid of rejection or not being believed

Wanting to make the power stop but not knowing how

Trying to make friends but worrying about what others will think

Struggling to relate to others

Sinking into despair and negativity

The character struggling to contain their frustration so they won't take it out on others

The character feeling like they're unlovable

Being hyperaware of the power and how it could embarrass them or cause problems for others

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Controlling, Cruel, Cynical, Devious, Greedy, Hostile, Humorless, Impatient, Impulsive, Know-It-All, Manipulative, Mischievous, Nosy, Reckless, Self-Indulgent, Temperamental, Unethical, Vain, Vindictive

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: A power that makes the character's goals harder to reach will hinder them in achieving their full potential.

Esteem and Recognition: If the power a character has is harmful or embarrassing, this could lead to others judging them or avoiding them, damaging their self-esteem.

Love and Belonging: Having a power that makes the character different from everyone else can jeopardize their sense of place and belonging. It might also become something that others want to possess and control, meaning people may seek relationships with the intent to take advantage.

Safety and Security: Depending on the power, the character could endanger themselves without meaning to.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Bold, Charming, Confident, Creative, Disciplined, Discreet, Friendly, Funny, Generous, Imaginative, Industrious, Inspirational, Optimistic, Organized, Quirky, Resourceful, Talented, Uninhibited, Whimsical

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Finding a cure for the affliction or power

Learning to use the power to help someone

Using the power to entertain others or make money

Finding purpose in the power

Finding someone who is able to love the character unconditionally

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NEEDING TO CIRCUMVENT SECURITY

EXAMPLES

Needing to bypass security to get inside a bank
Being incarcerated and wanting to escape
Having to dodge security cameras to secretly meet a lover at a hotel
Needing to hack into a computer system to obtain information
A white-hat hacker needing to get past a security system to identify its flaws
Breaking into a compound to kidnap or free someone
Illegally crossing a border to another country
A hitman needing to get past a politician or celebrity's security detail
Avoiding security to break into a museum and steal an artifact
A character leaving their home without drawing the attention of police officers stationed outside
Military personnel having to evade enemies in hostile territory
Having to get something illegal past airport security
Students sneaking out of school without those in charge noticing
Having to guess a partner's passwords to investigate their online banking activity after money goes missing from shared accounts
An underage patron getting into a bar or nightclub without getting caught

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Creating a plan that has a lot of details
Securing schedules and blueprints
Trying to consider every possible contingency
Making sure they have enough time and privacy to get the work done
Having to secure questionable or difficult-to-obtain items without leaving a paper trail
Having to trust others for help

Having to create a cover story to tell parents, a spouse, or anyone else who isn't in on the plan
Hiring someone who turns out to be untrustworthy or inept
Something changing at the last minute, compromising the plan
The character being identified by someone when they're trying to fly under the radar
Setting off an alarm
Forgetting to take out a security camera before entering a room
Being stopped by authorities and having to lie convincingly

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The character getting caught and losing their job
Security and scrutiny increasing for the character once people recognize what they're up to
Having to go into hiding to elude capture
A deadline or timeline being moved up, causing the character to rush
Losing an important person in the operation at the last minute
Fumbling something in a way that suspicions are raised
Losing valuable leverage or the element of surprise
Getting caught
Being arrested
Being sent to jail
Being double-crossed by an accomplice
A failed attempt drawing the attention of a formidable enemy

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Annoyance, Anxiety, Apprehension, Concern, Conflicted, Confusion, Desperation, Discouraged, Doubt, Fear, Flustered, Frustration, Horror, Impatience, Intimidated, Irritation, Overwhelmed, Panic, Reluctance, Uncertainty, Vulnerability

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Being conflicted about committing a crime to protect themselves or their family
The character feeling guilty about what they're doing (but doing it anyway)
Needing to cross a moral line and wondering if the outcome is worth the cost
Struggling not to give in to fear, especially if the stakes are high

The character questioning their values and wondering who they're becoming

The character wondering if they have the necessary skills to pull off the job

The character hating what they must do but knowing if they don't, injustice will continue

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Cocky, Confrontational, Cowardly, Disorganized, Flaky, Foolish, Forgetful, Greedy, Impatient, Impulsive, Inattentive, Indecisive, Reckless, Stubborn, Unintelligent

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: If circumventing security is required for the character to achieve a dream or rise to a difficult challenge, failing in the endeavor could keep them from satisfaction and being all they could be.

Esteem and Recognition: Getting caught could not only make the character feel bad about themselves, it can ruin their reputation, compromising their future.

Love and Belonging: Friction with loved ones over the character's goal and motives can create tension in these relationships, fracturing them.

Safety and Security: If getting caught results in physical abuse, a ruined reputation, loss of liberty, or alienation by loved ones, the character won't feel secure until the job is finished.

Physiological Needs: Depending on the preparations that are required, the character might have to forgo sleep, food, and adequate shelter in the pursuit of their goal.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Alert, Analytical, Bold, Calm, Cautious, Charming, Confident, Courageous, Creative, Decisive, Discreet, Efficient, Focused, Intelligent, Meticulous, Observant, Organized, Patient, Perceptive, Persistent, Resourceful

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Getting what the character came for (money, information, freedom, satisfaction, etc.)

The character gaining confidence in their skills

Finding a network of capable people the character can work with in the future

The character being recognized or rewarded for their success

Learning what not to do next time

The character recognizing how far they will or won't go to reach their objective

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NEEDING TO INFILTRATE A GROUP

EXAMPLES

Working undercover to gather evidence against criminals

Needing medication or supplies from a hospital and having to feign an illness to obtain them

Posing as a daycare worker to gain access to children

Joining an opposing sports team to sabotage them

Hacking into a rival company's database to obtain information about their products

Joining an opponent's political campaign to discover their strategies

Gaining employment at a company with the intention of accessing information

Working with a celebrity so the character can rise to fame themselves

The character seeking to gain access to a secret club to increase their social status

Joining a cult to get a family member out of it

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having to come up with a plan of attack

Needing to build a careful persona before attempting to join the group

Having to study the group's beliefs and rituals to fit in

Others in the group being unfriendly or unwelcoming

Being rejected and having to try again

The character accessing the group easily but not being able to get what they need

The character having to lie about their motives, desires, values, past, etc.

Getting found out and ousted

Breaking character

Needing to change tactics

An insider becoming suspicious about the character

Lacking knowledge of the group's language, culture, practices, etc.

The character having some kind of evidence that could expose them if others discovered it
Not having the skills needed to remain part of the group
The character having to keep their true goal and motives secret from close friends and loved ones
Tension with family members who believe the character is abandoning their values (because the character can't tell them the truth)

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Getting caught in a lie
Getting caught and being prosecuted
Being recognized by someone who knows the character and questions their involvement with the group
The character failing and losing their job
Someone on the character's team leaking information and exposing them
Falling in love with someone in the group
The character being brainwashed and adopting the group's values
Being rejected by loved ones who can't accept what the character appears to be doing
A friend within the group figuring out what's happening, and the character having to decide what to do about them
Being killed

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anxiety, Apprehension, Concern, Conflicted, Defiant, Disillusionment, Doubt, Dread, Fear, Inadequate, Insecurity, Intimidated, Nervousness, Overwhelmed, Panic, Reluctance, Self-Pity, Suspicion, Unease, Vulnerability, Wariness, Worry

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character trying not to think about what will happen if they get caught
The character doubting their ability to blend in
Being tempted to do something unethical to maintain cover
The character pretending to care for people in the group even though they despise them
The character struggling, over time, to resist the group's ideology and beliefs

Getting so deep into their persona that the character loses sight of their true identity

The character questioning, as the situation drags out, if what they're doing is worthwhile

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Antisocial, Cocky, Controlling, Cowardly, Disorganized, Flaky, Foolish, Gullible, Impulsive, Indecisive, Nervous, Paranoid, Rebellious, Reckless, Scatterbrained, Temperamental, Unintelligent, Weak-Willed

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: If the character must engage in immoral activities or reject their talents and uniqueness to fit in, they may become frustrated from being unable to live as their true self.

Esteem and Recognition: A character who must stoop to undesirable levels to get what they want may begin to believe that they've lost their moorings and feel bad about themselves.

Love and Belonging: If the character is working undercover and is unable to explain themselves to others, close friends and loved ones may disagree with their choices, and those relationships can become strained.

Safety and Security: A character who is always looking over their shoulder to be sure they haven't been discovered will have very little security.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Alert, Analytical, Bold, Calm, Centered, Charming, Confident, Creative, Decisive, Disciplined, Discreet, Efficient, Focused, Intelligent, Meticulous, Observant, Organized, Patient, Perceptive, Persistent, Resourceful

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

Stopping a catastrophic event from happening

Getting promoted for being successful

Gaining new sympathy for a group of people

Developing unexpected friendships

Successfully making it out alive

Learning new skills or strategies for future missions

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NEEDING TO LIE CONVINCINGLY

EXAMPLES

Making up an alibi to evade arrest

A young character lying to a parent, teacher, or coach to avoid consequences

The character misleading their spouse to cover up an indiscretion

Hiding a secret that could be a reputation killer

Withholding information from a coworker or boss to avoid being fired

The character lying to protect their child

The character lying about their ideals or opinions that others would take issue with

Posing as someone in need to swindle others out of money

The character falsifying their age to purchase alcohol

Lying to a captor to gain an opportunity to escape

Traveling under a fake identity (having to answer to a different name, create and adhere to a convincing history, etc.)

The character exaggerating their financial status to obtain a vehicle or gain entry into a prestigious group

The character lying about their true feelings and intentions to a mark so they can build a relationship with them and gain access to money or other people

Fibbing to avoid hurting a friend's feelings

A politician or cult leader needing to hide their true motives and objectives from others

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Having no time to prepare and having to lie on the spot

The character stumbling over their words

Someone becoming suspicious

Difficulty remembering which lies have been told to whom

A hole in the character's story being exposed

Having to lie to loved ones to hide the character's initial lie

Temporarily losing the trust of a loved one
The character's reputation being weakened when others see them lying
Needing to convince a friend to back the character up
Worry keeping the character up at night
Suffering from minor physical ailments, such as stomach pains and loss of appetite

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

The character's body language giving away the lie
Being found out and losing the opportunity for personal gain
Being reprimanded for not telling the truth
An important relationship ending when the truth comes to light
Being arrested for lying to police or engaging in other criminal activity
Being sued
Being outsmarted by the person the character is lying to
Lying so well that it becomes easy for the character to be dishonest with others
Suffering dire consequences for not telling the truth only to learn that the situation wasn't one where lying was necessary
The character being blackballed for their dishonesty (not being able to get another job, losing sponsors and fans, etc.)

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anxiety, Appalled, Concern, Conflicted, Confusion, Contempt, Defensiveness, Denial, Desperation, Discouraged, Disillusionment, Doubt, Dread, Envy, Flustered, Frustration, Guilt, Hurt, Nervousness, Panic, Regret, Remorse, Self-Loathing, Shame

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Debating the morality of the lie (if it helps prevent someone from being hurt, for instance)
Wanting to do the right thing but fearing the consequences
Feeling guilty for lying but believing it's necessary
The character feeling guilty for doing something they know is wrong, but doing it anyway
The character wanting to brag about their duplicity but also wanting to keep a low profile
The character wondering if they should push their luck and lie again

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Catty, Childish, Cocky, Compulsive, Cowardly, Defensive, Disorganized, Forgetful, Greedy, Gullible, Hypocritical, Irrational, Jealous, Lazy, Nervous, Paranoid, Pessimistic, Suspicious, Unintelligent

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: If the character highly values honesty, they may begin to question their identity and values, and their sense of self will become threatened.

Esteem and Recognition: If the character is caught lying, their reputation and ego could both take a hit.

Love and Belonging: If the character is lying to someone important and that person finds out, that relationship could be broken beyond repair.

Safety and Security: If the character lies to the wrong person, they could end up in a situation that jeopardizes their security or the safety of people important to them.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Bold, Calm, Charming, Confident, Discreet, Efficient, Focused, Funny, Imaginative, Intelligent, Meticulous, Observant, Patient, Perceptive, Persuasive, Resourceful, Socially Aware, Sophisticated, Studious, Witty

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

The character gaining confidence in their ability to sway or persuade others

Getting a big payoff

The character achieving what they wanted

Escaping from a dire situation

Learning to lie convincingly without getting caught or suffering consequences

Deciding to reject dishonesty and become more persuasive instead

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NOT KNOWING WHAT ONE WANTS

EXAMPLES

The character frequently changing their college major because they can't decide on a career

A character feeling unfulfilled in a romantic relationship but not knowing why

A CEO requiring an employee to submit new ideas repeatedly, saying they'll know what they want when they see it

A character always breaking things off with romantic partners because they can't commit

A pregnant character debating whether or not to terminate their pregnancy

The character taking their business in too many directions because they can't settle on a specialty

A character waffling over a major life choice

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Pressure to make a decision (due to a looming time limit, a pushy loved one, competition, etc.)

Having to make decisions with partial information

Wasted time pursuing paths that don't pan out

Restless sleep or uneasy dreams

High expenses associated with frequently changing pursuits

Becoming a jack-of-all-trades, master of none

Having to continually retrain to learn new skills or information

Well-meaning relatives constantly asking the character about their future plans

Frustration from loved ones who have their own clear vision of the character's future

Saying yes to any opportunity

Shallow distractions and diversions dominating the character's days

The character lying to employers about their interest in a project to protect their livelihood

The character hating their job
Having to attend therapy to sort out their mixed feelings
Frustrating conversations with focused and decisive people who know their own path

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

Too many options overwhelming the character so they end up choosing nothing
Feeling stuck without a plan to move forward
The character letting others make the decisions for them
The character's decisions hurting a significant other
The character regretting their decisions
The character staying in a dead-end relationship or job because they don't know what else to do
Being passed over for a raise or promotion because the character's commitment is questioned
The character missing out on a great opportunity by sticking with what's familiar
Waiting so long that the worst comes to pass (a financial loss becomes unrecoverable, a spouse asks for a divorce, an opportunity is given to someone else, etc.)
The dissolution of the character's business or family
Deferring to other people's advice and being miserable with the outcome
People leaving the character because they are directionless and unmotivated
Living a life devoid of passion
Becoming depressed with how life is turning out

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Acceptance, Anguish, Anxiety, Apprehension, Conflicted, Confusion, Curiosity, Depressed, Despair, Dissatisfaction, Emasculated, Embarrassment, Envy, Guilt, Impatience, Jealousy, Overwhelmed, Self-Loathing, Shame, Uncertainty, Wanderlust

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

The character wondering if there's something wrong with them for not being able to decide
The character comparing themselves to their role models and finding themselves lacking

Struggling to weigh the pros and cons for options that look equally good or bad

Resenting other characters who know exactly what they want, then feeling like a jerk

The character feeling burdened by a family that was built before they knew what they wanted

The character knowing what they want but being too afraid to pursue it

The character putting on a frivolous persona to hide the truth, and hating themselves

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Addictive, Antisocial, Apathetic, Cowardly, Dishonest, Disloyal, Disorganized, Hypocritical, Ignorant, Impatient, Impulsive, Indecisive, Inhibited, Insecure, Irrational, Irresponsible, Jealous, Lazy, Perfectionist

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: Being fully realized means knowing what it takes to be fulfilled. This is difficult for a character who doesn't know what they want.

Esteem and Recognition: Friends or family members who view the character as flighty or wishy-washy will think less of them. This lack of respect can influence the way the character views him or herself.

Love and Belonging: Friends or family may become impatient with the character's lack of clear direction and at some point, abandon them if they feel their own futures are being held back.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE: Adaptable, Adventurous, Ambitious, Bold, Centered, Confident, Courageous, Creative, Decisive, Disciplined, Gentle, Happy, Imaginative, Independent, Industrious, Nature-Focused, Optimistic, Passionate

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

The character exploring many possibilities and finding their calling in life

Delaying major decisions until the character feels better equipped to choose

Learning to be content in the waiting

Discussing the situation with a wise friend or mentor and gaining valuable insight

The character trying many things and, in the process, learning what they don't want to do

A door closing and the character realizing it's okay because it's not what they truly wanted

The character removing sources of external pressure and expectation and discovering what they really want

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PHYSICAL EXHAUSTION

EXAMPLES

The character's body being pushed past its limits due to exertion

Being depleted due to poor nutrition or starvation

An illness that ravages the character's strength

Forced wakefulness that takes a physical toll

MINOR COMPLICATIONS

Clumsiness

Sustaining an injury, such as a cut or burn, from reacting too slowly

Dropping something of value and damaging it

Being unable to finish a task

The character's exhaustion endangering others

Poor decision-making that leads to mistakes

Making mistakes that require additional energy to correct—e.g., falling down a hill that must be re-climbed

The character becoming defensive when loved ones suggest taking a break or letting someone else take over

The character having to ask someone to take over when their strength is depleted

Having to rely on other people to pick up the slack

Getting into trouble for doing a job poorly

Lacking the energy to do things that bring the character joy

Having to cancel plans with friends and family because the character just can't follow through

Being forced into a prolonged recovery, creating a time crunch

POTENTIALLY DISASTROUS RESULTS

A long recovery due to collapse resulting in a missed timeline

Exhaustion depleting the character's immune system and leading to a serious illness

Suffering a serious fall or injury

Causing an accident that disfigures someone or causes their death—e.g., working a saw and cutting the hand of the person holding the board
Pushing the body past its limits and causing a permanent injury or lifelong chronic pain

The character injuring someone when their strength gives out

Being removed from a prestigious position of leadership because of a poor performance

Allowing someone else to take over temporarily, and them making the character's job much harder

The character being replaced by someone who is guaranteed to fail

Being unable to help or rescue someone in imminent danger

Loved ones whose advice to take it easy was ignored losing patience and confidence in the character

Others being put in harm's way when they have to rescue the character

RESULTING EMOTIONS: Anger, Anguish, Defeat, Defiance, Despair, Desperation, Determination, Dread, Emasculation, Embarrassment, Guilt, Humiliation, Inadequacy, Powerlessness, Regret, Resentment, Resignation, Self-Loathing, Self-Pity, Shame, Tormented, Unappreciated, Uncertainty, Vulnerability, Worthlessness

POSSIBLE INTERNAL STRUGGLES

Recognizing the signs of exhaustion but deciding to ignore them

The character wanting to care for themselves but worrying that they'll be letting others down if they do

The character doubting their ability to go on

Feeling insecure about being perceived as weak or unworthy by people who matter

The character comparing themselves to others who aren't struggling and finding themselves lacking

Wrestling with self-loathing and shame (if the situation happened because the character didn't take care of themselves, they were out of shape, etc.)

Being too proud to accept help despite knowing it's needed

Wanting help but being angry for needing it

NEGATIVE TRAITS THAT MAY WORSEN THE SITUATION:

Abrasive, Cocky, Grumpy, Haughty, Hostile, Irrational, Melodramatic,

Perfectionist, Pessimistic, Prejudiced, Resentful, Self-Destructive, Uncooperative, Ungrateful, Whiny

IMPACT ON BASIC NEEDS

Self-Actualization: Sleep is a basic survival necessity—meaning, it will take priority over anything else that isn't critical. In this situation, dreams, passions, and hobbies will be temporarily set aside until the need for rest is met.

Esteem and Recognition: Exhaustion will physically and mentally weaken a character, limiting what they're able to do. Others may see this as a weakness and think less of them. The character may certainly share that perception and experience lowered self-esteem.

Love and Belonging: A character who refuses to listen to wise and caring loved ones and continues pushing past healthy boundaries may strain those relationships.

Safety and Security: Exhaustion can cause clumsiness, slowed reaction times, and mental foggyiness, which often leads to injuries. Long-term fatigue can also induce illness. So there are many ways it might impact the character's safety and security.

POSITIVE TRAITS TO HELP THE CHARACTER COPE:

Adventurous, Ambitious, Courageous, Disciplined, Enthusiastic, Honorable, Industrious, Mature, Persistent, Sensible

POSITIVE OUTCOMES

The character recognizing the beginnings of exhaustion so they can stop before going too far

The character seeing that the physical struggle isn't their fault and doesn't warrant shame or embarrassment

Experiencing greater empathy for others in a similar situation

The character identifying and addressing a root cause for their reluctance to accept help

Being brought down a peg and realizing that weaknesses are universal to everyone

Recognizing that the people who tried to warn the character were doing so out of concern, not judgment

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APPENDIX A: GMC+S TRACKER

Track the Goal, Motivation, Conflict, plus Stakes for each primary character in your story by exploring **Plot** (Outer) and **Arc** (Inner) factors. Revisit the section on [*Conflict's Role in Storytelling: Shaping the Plot*](#) for more information.

CHARACTER
NAME:

Aragorn

STORY
ROLE:

Protagonist

Goal

PLOT

What does the character want to do or achieve?

To defeat Sauron and restore peace and harmony to Middle Earth, as was the case long ago

ARC

What must be resolved by growth, change, or a mindset shift?

To stop hiding and embrace his true destiny as the king of Gondor

Motivation

PLOT

Why do they want to achieve the plot goal?

To avoid Sauron's rule, which would cast Middle Earth into darkness and despair

ARC

Why do they need to make that internal change?

To prove his own strength and worth—and that of the human race

Conflict

PLOT

What is blocking them from achieving the story goal?

Sauron and his minions, as well as the ring's evil, which is slowly spreading and corrupting those associated with it

ARC

What is blocking them from internal change?

His worry that Isildur's weakness runs through his veins, that he's destined to repeat the mistakes of his ancestors

Stakes

PLOT

What's at stake if they fail to achieve the goal?

If he fails to defeat the enemy, Sauron will regain the ring and destroy Middle Earth, along with everything good in it.

ARC

What's at stake if they don't change?

If he doesn't embrace his destiny, he will have proved his greatest fear: that he's weak and lacks the strength to succeed where his forebears failed.

APPENDIX A: GMC+S TRACKER

CHARACTER
NAME: _____

STORY
ROLE: _____

Goal

PLOT

What does the character want to do or achieve?

ARC

What must be resolved by growth, change, or a mindset shift?

Motivation

PLOT

Why do they want to achieve the plot goal?

ARC

Why do they need to make that internal change?

Conflict

PLOT

What is blocking them from achieving the story goal?

ARC

What is blocking them from internal change?

Stakes

PLOT

What's at stake if they fail to achieve the goal?

ARC

What's at stake if they don't change?

Download additional copies of this template from the Writers Helping Writers [Build Your Toolkit](#) page.

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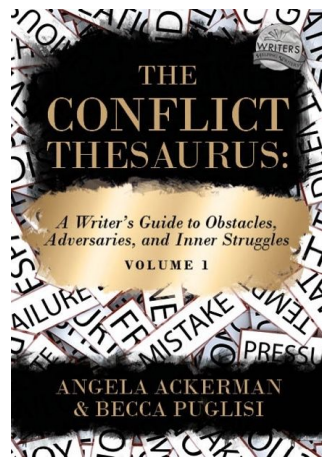
APPENDIX B: CLIMAX TROUBLESHOOTING

The climax is the apex of the story. Whether it involves a showdown between your protagonist and villain, clashing antagonistic forces, or star-crossed lovers, readers have been waiting for this moment to see what happens. If the big event is a disappointment, they'll feel let down. To help you get this scene right, we've provided a handy checklist of common problems with the climax and how to fix them.

PROBLEM	SOLUTION
RESOLVES TOO QUICKLY	Introduce more (meaningful and fitting) conflict to the scene, making it harder for the hero to win.
TAKES TOO LONG	Plan this scene carefully to keep it focused on what must be accomplished. In revision, remove unnecessary filler to keep the action crisp and concise.
AMBIGUOUS OUTCOME	Make it crystal clear who wins this battle. There must be an obvious winner and a clear loser.
TOO PREDICTABLE	Give the hero undermining doubts and weaknesses, ensuring success isn't guaranteed. And take a good look at your antagonist to be sure they're formidable enough.
NOT SIGNIFICANT ENOUGH	A win in the climax will result in the victor achieving their story goal, so make sure that's part of the package. This event should be the highest-stake moment in your story.
NO CHARACTER AGENCY	The character must win through their own strength, cunning, determination, etc. If a supernatural event or another character's intervention saves the day, the hero hasn't won. Give them back their agency by requiring them to succeed on their own merits.
INCOMPLETE CHARACTER ARC	The primary character must address their fatal flaw either prior to or during the climax because the lessons learned or growth achieved will be key to securing a victory. If they can't discard their biggest flaw or correct a specific deficiency, they will fail.

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THE CONFLICT THESAURUS, VOLUME 1

With so many conflict scenarios to explore, this topic just couldn't be contained to one book. Enter the first volume of *The Conflict Thesaurus*, which continues the exploration of conflict and how it will shape the plot and challenge your characters. There, you'll find information on internal conflict, employing specific challenges to encourage character growth, and how conflict should create choices and incur consequences that will impact your protagonist and storyline.

The entry portion of the first volume is similar to the second but contains different categories. This will provide you with more ways to craft psychological and physical struggles that will force your characters to dig deep to overcome them.

Together, both Conflict Thesaurus volumes offer valuable insight into conflict's role in storytelling, as well as providing a large spectrum of scenarios that will pressure and challenge your characters. Complete your set by picking up Volume 1.

RELATIONSHIP FRICTION

A Divorce or Breakup

A Child Wanting to Live with One's Ex

A Love Interest Taking Up with Someone Else

A Partner Being Unwilling to Commit

A Romance Being Stymied

A Romantic Competitor Entering the Scene

An Ex Interfering in One's Life

An Unwanted Romantic Advance

Being Betrayed or Abandoned by a Trusted Ally or Friend

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Together, both Conflict Thesaurus volumes offer valuable insight into conflict's role in storytelling, as well as providing a large spectrum of

scenarios that will pressure and challenge your characters. Complete your set by picking up Volume 1.

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RECOMMENDED RESOURCES

Like oil in an engine, conflict keeps your story chugging along. If you're looking to add to your knowledge of conflict and how it can contribute to character development and a strong story structure, consider the following writing guides.

The Conflict Thesaurus, A Writer's Guide to Obstacles, Adversaries, and Inner Struggles (Volume 1) is a primer on utilizing conflict to build tension and high stakes, challenge characters as they traverse their arcs, and keep readers emotionally invested from beginning to end. (Angela Ackerman and Becca Puglisi)

Conflict & Suspense is packed with everything you need to know to spice up your story, move your plot forward, and keep your readers turning pages. (James Scott Bell)

Understanding Conflict (and What it Really Means) is an easy-to-use guide filled with ideas on how to build and amplify conflict. (Janice Hardy)

Save the Cat: The Last Book on Screenwriting You'll Ever Need isn't just for screenwriters. This bestselling guide is a primer on storytelling in any form, packed with information on making your ideas more marketable and your story more satisfying. (Blake Snyder)

[The Conflict Thesaurus](#) at One Stop for Writers contains the entire collection of entries in one database, expanded to include even more information to make your story's conflict as powerful and dramatic as possible.

[The One Stop for Writers' Conflict Tutorial](#) is a quick and dirty manual on conflict and what it can do for your story and characters. It's a handy reference when you need a refresher on this important storytelling element.

[Formal](#) and [Informal](#) Scene Maps at One Stop for Writers allow you to plan and organize the scenes in your story to make sure they're doing what they need to do. With formal and informal maps at your disposal, you'll be able to record the conflict scenarios, stakes, character motivation, and emotions that will play a part in each scene.

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~ **James Scott Bell, best-selling author of *Deceived* and *Plot & Structure***

THE POSITIVE AND NEGATIVE TRAIT THESAURUSES

“In these brilliantly conceived, superbly organized and astonishingly thorough volumes, Angela Ackerman and Becca Puglisi have created an invaluable resource for writers and storytellers. Whether you are searching for new and unique ways to add and define characters, or brainstorming methods for revealing those characters without resorting to clichés, it is hard to imagine two more powerful tools for adding depth and dimension to your screenplays, novels or plays.”

~ **Michael Hauge, Hollywood script consultant and
author of *Writing Screenplays That Sell***

THE URBAN AND RURAL SETTING THESAURUSES

“The one thing I always appreciate about Ackerman and Puglisi's Thesauri series is how comprehensive they are. They never stop at just the obvious, and they always over-deliver. Their Setting Thesauri are no different, offering not just the obvious notes of the various settings they've covered but going into easy-to-miss details like smells and tastes. They

even offer to jumpstart the brainstorming with categories on potential sources of conflict.”

~ **K.M. Weiland**, best-selling author of *Creating Character Arcs* and *Structuring Your Novel*

THE EMOTIONAL WOUND THESAURUS

“This is far more than a brilliant, thorough, insightful, and unique thesaurus. This is the best primer on story—and what *really* hooks and holds readers—that I have ever read.”

~ **Lisa Cron**, TEDx Speaker and best-selling author of *Wired for Story* and *Story Genius*

THE OCCUPATION THESAURUS

“Each and every thesaurus these authors produce is spectacular. *The Occupation Thesaurus* is no different. Full of inspiration, teachings, and knowledge that are guaranteed to take your writing to the next level, it's a must. You need this book on your craft shelf.”

~ **Sacha Black**, best-selling author of fantasy and the *Better Writing* series

THE CONFLICT THESAURUS, VOLUME 1

“If characters drive the story, then conflict operates as the engine to every tale. Keeping this tenet in mind, writing experts Angela Ackerman and Becca Puglisi return with their most ambitious, hefty thesaurus yet, examining conflict in multiple dimensions and on multiple levels. Every writer should keep this volume handy as they work.”

~ **Ekta R. Garg**, editor and author of *The Truth About Elves*

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